Das Johannes-Evangelium
with Explanations of Rudolf Steiner

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Foreword

The Gospel of John has been taken from the fifth edition (2020) of the book Emil Bock, The New Testament: Translation in Its Original Form. The explanations by Rudolf Steiner consist solely of quotations and are placed between GA numbers, where NNN denotes the number of the Collected Works volume.

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1

1 In the primal beginning was the Word, and the Word was creative with God, and the Word was a divine being.
2 This was creative in the primal beginning with God.
3 Through it all things came into being, and nothing that has come into being came about apart from the Word.
4 In it was life, and the life was the light of humankind.
5 And the light shines into the darkness, but the darkness did not receive it.
6 There came a man sent by God; his name was John.
7 He came to bear witness. He was to testify to the light and thus awaken faith in every heart.
8 He was not himself the light; he was to be a witness to the light.
9 The true light, which illumines all people, was to come into the world.
10 It was in the world, for the world came into being through it, but the world did not recognize it.
11 It came to the human beings of the I, but they did not receive it.
12 Yet to all who received it, it gave the free power to become children of God—to those who trustingly take its power into themselves.
13 They do not receive their life from blood, nor from the will of the flesh, nor from human will; for they are born of God.
14 And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us. We beheld the revelation of its being: the revelation of the Father's only-begotten Son, filled with devotion and truth.
15 John bears witness to him and proclaims aloud: "This is the one of whom I said, 'He who comes after me was before me, for he is greater than I.'"
16 Out of his fullness we have all received grace upon grace.
17 The Law was given through Moses. Grace and truth came into being through Jesus Christ.
18 No human being has ever beheld the divine ground of the worlds with the eyes. The only-begotten Son, who was in the bosom of the Father of the worlds, became the guide to this vision.
19 This is John's testimony, when the Jews sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem to him with the question: "Who are you?"
20 He made his confession openly and without reserve. He confessed: "I am not the Christ."
21 Then they asked him: "Who are you, then? Are you Elijah?" He said: "I am not." "Are you the Prophet?" He answered: "No."
22 So they said to him: "Who are you? What are we to answer those who sent us? What do you say about yourself?"
23 He said: "I am the voice of one calling in the solitariness: 'Prepare the way for the Lord.' Thus the prophet Isaiah proclaimed."
24 Those who had been sent were Pharisees.

25 They asked him: “Why, then, do you baptize, if you are neither the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet?”
26 John answered: “I baptize with water. But already among you stands one whom you do not know,
27 the one who comes after me and yet was before me. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire. I am not worthy even to untie the strap of his sandal.”
28 This took place at Bethabara, beyond the lower Jordan, where John was baptizing.
29 The next day he saw Jesus coming toward him and said: “Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes upon himself the sin of the world.”
30 He is the one of whom I said: “After me comes one who was before me, for he is greater than I.”
31 I did not know him, but I came and baptized with water for this purpose: that the people of Israel might become able to experience the revelation of his being.
32 And John testified: “I saw the Spirit descend from heaven like a dove and remain joined to him as his higher being.”
33 I did not know him, but the one who sent me to baptize with water said to me: “The one on whom you see the Spirit descend and remain joined to him is the one who baptizes with the Holy Spirit.”
34 I have seen it, and so I testify that this is the Son of God.
35 The next day John was standing there again, with two of his disciples.
36 When he saw Jesus passing by, he said: “Behold, the Lamb of God.”
37 When the two disciples heard him say this, they followed Jesus.
38 Jesus turned and saw them following him, and said: “What are you seeking?” They answered: “Rabbi”—which means Teacher—“where are you staying?”
39 He said to them: “Come and see.” They came and saw where he was staying, and remained with him that day. It was about the tenth hour.
40 Andrew, the brother of Simon Peter, was one of the two who had followed Jesus at John’s word.
41 The first person he met was his brother Simon, and he said to him: “We have found the Messiah”—which means the Christ.
42 He brought him to Jesus. Jesus looked at him and said: “You are Simon, the son of Jonah. You shall be called Cephas”—which means Peter, the Rock.
43 The next day Jesus intended to set out for Galilee. He found Philip and said to him: “Follow me!”
44 Philip was from Bethsaida, the town of Andrew and Peter.
45 Philip found Nathanael and said to him: “We have found the one of whom Moses wrote in the Law and the prophets wrote: Jesus, the son of Joseph, from Nazareth.”
46 Nathanael said to him: “Can anything good come out of Nazareth?” Philip answered: “Come and see!”
47 When Jesus saw Nathanael coming toward him, he said of him: “Here is truly an Israelite; he has risen above all falsification.”
48 Nathanael said to him: “How do you know me?” Jesus answered: “Before Philip called you, when you were sitting under the fig tree, I saw you.”
49 Nathanael said to him: “Teacher, you are the Son of God; you are the guiding Spirit of Israel.”
50 Jesus replied: “Because I said to you, ‘I saw you under the fig tree,’ you have come to trust. You will experience greater things than these.”
51 And he said: “Truly, truly, I tell you: you will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending over the Son of Man.”

2

1 On the third day a wedding was celebrated in Cana of Galilee. The mother of Jesus was there,
2 and Jesus and his disciples had also been invited to the wedding feast.

3 When the wine ran short, the mother of Jesus said to him: “They have no more wine.”
4 And Jesus answered her: “Take heed of the power that weaves between you and me, O woman. My hour has not yet come.”
5 His mother said to the servants: “Do whatever he tells you.”
6 Six stone water jars stood there for the Jewish rites of purification. Each held two or three measures.
7 Jesus said to the servants: “Fill the jars with water.”
8 And they filled them to the brim. Then he said to them: “Now draw some out and take it to the steward of the feast.” And they took it to him.
9 The steward of the feast did not know where what had been served to him came from; only the servants who had drawn the water knew. When he tasted the water that had become wine, he called the bridegroom
10 and said to him: “Everyone usually serves the good wine first, and then the inferior wine when the guests have drunk their fill. But you have kept the good wine until now.”
11 Jesus performed this first beginning of his signs in Cana of Galilee. In this way he revealed the radiant power of light that was his being, and his disciples came to trust in him.
12 After this he went down to Capernaum, together with his mother, his brothers, and his disciples. They stayed there only a few days.
13 The Jewish Passover was approaching, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.
14 There in the Temple he found the merchants selling oxen, sheep, and doves, as well as the money changers sitting at their tables.
15 He made a whip out of cords and drove them all out of the Temple, along with the sheep and oxen. He scattered the money changers’ coins and overturned their tables.
16 To the sellers of doves he said: “Take these animals away, and do not turn my Father’s house into a marketplace!”
17 His disciples remembered the words of Scripture: “Zeal for your house consumes me.”
18 The Jews confronted him and asked: “What signs of higher power can you perform to prove that you have the right to act in this way?”
19 Jesus answered: “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up again.”
20 The Jews said: “This temple has been under construction for forty-six years, and you will raise it up in three days?”
21 But he had been speaking of the temple of his body.
22 Later, when he had risen from the dead, his disciples remembered these words and drew confidence in their faith from Scripture and from the word Jesus had spoken.
23 While he was in Jerusalem for the Passover feast, many came to trust in him as they saw him work through spiritual power.
24 But Jesus himself did not entrust himself to them, for he knew all people
25 and did not need anyone to testify to him about the nature of a human being. The inner life of each person lay open before his insight.

3

1 Now there was a man who belonged to the order of the Pharisees. His name was Nicodemus, and he held a high rank among the Jews.
2 He came to Jesus in the realm of night and said to him: “Teacher, we know that you have descended from the divine worlds as a great teacher, for no one can perform such deeds of the spirit as you do unless the divine world itself is at work in those deeds.”
3 Jesus answered: “Yes, I tell you: whoever is not born anew from the heights of the worlds cannot behold the kingdom of God.”

4 Nicodemus said to him: “How can a person be born when already old? Can one return to the mother’s womb and be born again?”
5 Jesus answered: “Yes, I tell you: whoever does not experience rebirth through the formative power symbolized by water and through the moving breath of the Spirit cannot gain access to the kingdom of God.”
6 What is born from the earthly element is itself earthly in nature; what is born from the breath of the Spirit is itself spirit in motion.
7 Do not be astonished that I said to you: You must be born anew from the heights.
8 The wind blows where it wills. You hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born from the breath of the Spirit.”
9 Nicodemus said: “How can one come to this?”
10 Jesus answered: “You are a teacher among the leaders of the people, and you do not know this?
11 Truly, I tell you: We speak of what we perceive, and we bear witness to what we have beheld. Yet you do not accept our testimony.
12 If I spoke to you about earthly things and you did not trust me, how will you trust me when I speak to you about heavenly things?
13 No one has ascended into the world of spirit who has not also descended from the world of spirit: the Son of Man, whose being belongs to the world of spirit.
14 Just as Moses lifted up the serpent in the solitariness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up,
15 so that everyone who feels his power in the heart may share in the timeless, higher life.
16 In this way the primal Father of the worlds showed his love for humankind: he gave them the Son born from him alone.
17 The Father did not send the Son into the world to judge humankind, but to save and heal them.
18 Whoever fills himself with the Son’s power is not brought before a judge. But whoever closes himself to that power is already judged, because he has no share in the being and power of the divine Son born from unity.
19 This is already the judgment of the world: the light has come into the world, yet people love darkness more than light and serve evil through their deeds.
20 Everyone who gives himself through his deeds to what is perishable becomes an adversary of the light. He does not turn toward the light, so that the true nature of his actions will not be revealed.
21 But whoever serves the true nature of things through his deeds comes toward the light. Through those deeds it becomes radiant and clear that they possess full reality in the realm of spirit.”
22 After this, Jesus and his disciples came into the land of Judea. He stayed there with them and baptized.
23 John was also baptizing; he was working at Aenon, near Salim, because there was much water there, and people came and were baptized.
24 John had not yet been thrown into prison.
25 A dispute arose between John’s disciples and the Jews about the way of purification.
26 They came to John and said to him: “Teacher, the one who came to you beyond the Jordan, to whom you bore witness—look, he is baptizing, and everyone is going to him.”
27 John answered: “No one can take authority upon himself unless it has been given to him from the higher world.
28 You yourselves can testify that I said: ‘I am not the Christ, but I have been sent ahead of him.’
29 The one who has the bride is the bridegroom. The bridegroom’s friend, who stands beside him and listens to him, rejoices greatly at the bridegroom’s voice. So this joy of mine is now fulfilled.
30 He must grow greater, but I must become less.
31 The one who comes from the heights of the worlds is above all others. The one who is of the earth is earthly in nature, and his words are bound to the earth. The one who comes from the worlds of spirit is above all others.

32 He bears witness to what he has seen and heard, but no one accepts his testimony.
33 Whoever accepts his testimony thereby confirms that God is truth.
34 For the one sent by God speaks words permeated by the Spirit. He does not dispense the spiritual in measured portions.
35 The Father loves the Son and has placed all being into his hand.
36 Whoever trusts himself to the Son has timeless life. Whoever does not trust the Son will not behold true life. The wrath of God remains upon him.

4

1 At that time Jesus became aware of the report circulating among the Pharisees that he was gaining and baptizing more disciples than John.
2 In reality, Jesus himself did not baptize; his disciples did.
3 Thereupon he left Judea and returned to Galilee.
4 On the way he had to pass through Samaria,
5 and he came to a Samaritan town called Sychar, near the land that Jacob had given to his son Joseph.
6 Jacob's well was there. Jesus was tired from the journey and sat down on the edge of the well. It was around noon.
7 A Samaritan woman came to draw water. Jesus said to her, "Give me a drink."
8 His disciples had gone into the town to buy what was needed for food.
9 The Samaritan woman said to him, "How can you, a Jew, ask me, a Samaritan woman, for a drink?" For Jews avoided all dealings with Samaritans.
10 Jesus answered, "If you knew something of the power God gives us, and knew the one who says to you, 'Give me a drink,' you would ask him, and he would give you the water of life."
11 She said to him, "Sir, you have nothing with which to draw, and the well is deep. Where will you get this living water?
12 Are you greater than our father Jacob, who gave us this well and drank from it himself, along with his sons and his herds?"
13 Jesus answered, "Everyone who drinks this water will thirst again.
14 But whoever drinks the water I give will have their thirst quenched for this age of the worlds. The water I give will become within them a spring of water flowing into true life through all cycles of time."
15 The woman said to him, "Sir, give me this water, so that I will never thirst again and will not have to come here to draw water."
16 He said to her, "Go, call your husband and then come back."
17 The woman answered, "I have no husband." Jesus said, "You are right in saying that you have no husband.
18 You have had five husbands, and the man you have now is not your husband. In this you have spoken truthfully."
19 The woman said to him, "Sir, I see now that you are a prophet.
20 Our fathers worshiped on this mountain, but you say that the place of worship is in Jerusalem alone."
21 Jesus answered, "Woman, trust my word: the time is coming when you will serve the Father neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem.
22 Your worship is directed toward a being who remains beyond your awareness. Our life of worship goes hand in hand with conscious knowledge. That is why the true salvation of humanity had to be prepared among the Jews.

23 The hour is coming—and is already here—when the true worshipers of God will serve the Father through the power of the Spirit and in the knowledge of truth. The Father seeks people who serve him in this way.
24 God is Spirit, and those who worship him must do so through the power of the Spirit and in the knowledge of truth."
25 The woman said to him, "I know that the Messiah is coming, the one called Christ. When he comes, he will proclaim everything to us."
26 Jesus said to her, "I am the I AM. As such, I am speaking to you."
27 Just then his disciples returned and were astonished that he was speaking with a woman. Yet no one asked, "What do you want from her?" or "Why are you speaking with her?"
28 Then the woman left her water jar, went into the town, and said to the people,
29 "Come and see a man who has interpreted my whole life and all that I have done for me. Could he be the Christ?"
30 So the people streamed out of the town toward him.
31 Meanwhile, his disciples urged him, "Teacher, eat!"
32 But he answered them, "I have food to sustain me that you do not know about."
33 The disciples said to one another, "Could someone have brought him something to eat?"
34 Jesus answered, "My food is to act according to the will of the one who sent me and to bring his work to completion.
35 Do you not say, 'In four months the harvest will come'? Look, I tell you: lift up your seeing souls! You will see the fields already shining white and ripe for harvest.
36 Already the reaper is receiving his reward and gathering fruit that bears within it the true, deathless life.
37 The one who sowed and the one who reaps are to rejoice together. This is the true meaning of the saying that one sows and another reaps.
38 I sent you to gather a harvest for which you did not labor. Others have done the work, and you have entered into their labor."
39 Many Samaritans from that town came to trust him because of the woman's testimony on his behalf: "He has interpreted my whole life and all that I have done for me."
40 When the Samaritans came to him, they asked him to stay with them. And he stayed there for two days.
41 Many more people came to trust him,
42 and they said to the woman, "Our trust no longer rests only on your word. We have now heard him ourselves, and we know that he truly is the Christ, the bringer of salvation for the whole world."
43 After the two days he continued on to Galilee.
44 Jesus himself had affirmed that a prophet is not honored in his own homeland.
45 When he arrived in Galilee, the Galileans welcomed him, for they had witnessed his deeds in Jerusalem, where they had gone for the Passover festival.
46 He came again to Cana in Galilee, where he had turned water into wine. There was a royal official there whose son lay ill in Capernaum.
47 When he heard that Jesus had come from Judea to Galilee, he went to him and begged him to come down and heal his son, who was already near death.
48 Jesus replied, "Unless you see signs and wonders, you do not trust."
49 The royal official said to him, "Lord, come down before my child dies."
50 Jesus said, "Go; your son is alive." The man trusted the word Jesus spoke to him and went on his way.
51 While he was still on the road, his servants met him with the news that his boy was alive.
52 He asked them at what hour the change had occurred, and they answered, "Yesterday, at the seventh hour, the fever left him."

53 Then the father recognized that it was the very hour when Jesus had said to him, “Your son is alive.” He and his whole household were filled with the power of that experience.
54 This was the second spiritual deed Jesus performed when he came from Judea to Galilee.

5

1 A Jewish festival was approaching, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.
2 In Jerusalem, by the Sheep Gate, there was a pool called Bethesda in Hebrew, with five colonnades for those who bathed there.
3 Many sick people lay there—blind people, lame people, and those with impaired limbs—waiting for the water to be stirred.
4 For at certain times an angel, with its power-being, descended into the pool, causing the water to surge. The first person to enter after the water surged was healed, whatever illness afflicted them.
5 Among the sick was a man who had suffered from his illness for thirty-eight years.
6 When Jesus saw him lying there and realized that he had been ill for so long, he said to him, “Do you will to become well?”
7 The sick man answered, “Sir, I have no one to carry me down into the pool when the water surges. And whenever I go there myself, someone else gets in ahead of me.”
8 Jesus said to him, “Rise, take up your pallet, and walk!”
9 At once the man became well, took up his pallet, and walked. Now that day was a Sabbath.
10 So the Jews said to the man who had been healed, “It is the Sabbath today, and you are not permitted to carry your bed.”
11 But he replied, “The man who made me well said to me, ‘Take up your pallet and walk.’”
12 They asked him, “Who is the man who said to you, ‘Take it up and walk’?”
13 The healed man did not know who it was. Jesus had slipped away from the crowd gathered at that place.
14 Later Jesus found him in the Temple and said to him, “See, you have become well. Do not sin any longer, so that an even heavier fate does not befall you!”
15 The man went away and told the Jews that it was Jesus who had healed him.
16–17 Jesus himself then came forward to meet them and said, “Until now, all activity has proceeded from the Father. From now on, however, the I who lives in me is at work.”
18 The Jews were all the more intent on killing him: now he had not only profaned the Sabbath, but had even called God his own Father and made himself equal with the Father.
19 Jesus came before them and said, “Truly, I tell you: the Son can do nothing on his own, except what he sees the Father doing. Whatever the Father does, the Son does likewise.
20 For the Father loves the Son and shows him all that he does, and he will show him even greater works, so that you will be filled with amazement.
21 For just as the Father raises the dead and leads them into life, so the Son also leads into life those through whom his will can work.
22 The Fatherly Ground of the World passes judgment on no one. Rather, he has entrusted all decisions of destiny to the Son.
23 All are to honor the Son just as they honor the Father. Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who sent him.
24 Truly, I tell you: whoever hears the word I speak and trusts the one who sent me has the life that extends through all cycles of time. They do not face the great judgment; they have already passed from death into life.
25 Truly, this is so: the time is coming—and is already here—when the dead will hear the call of the divine Son, and those who hear it will become bearers of true life.

26 Just as the Father carries the life of the world within his being, so he has also given the Son the power to carry the life of the world within his being.
27 And with this he has given him, who is also the Son of Man, authority to be Lord of destiny among human beings.
28 Do not be astonished: the time is already coming when all who lie in the tombs will hear his call.
29 Those who have done good will come forth and find true life through resurrection; those whose deeds were without worth will pass through resurrection into an enduring trial.
30 My I can do nothing on its own. I judge according to what I perceive in the spiritual realm, and my judgment is just. For I seek not to fulfill my own will, but the will of the one who sent me.
31 If I were to appear only as a witness for myself, my testimony would have no real force.
32 But there is another who bears witness for me, and I know that the testimony he gives on my behalf is fully real.
33 You sent messengers to John, and he gave valid testimony.
34 But human testimony is not enough for me, for I want you to find the way to salvation through my word.
35 He was the burning and shining light, and all you wanted was to feel comfortable in that light for a while.
36 I have testimony weightier than John's. The works whose completion the Fatherly Ground of the World entrusted to me—the works I perform—testify on my behalf that the Father has sent me.
37 And so the Father who sent me himself bears witness for me. You have never heard his voice or seen his form;
38 the Word of the World that comes from him does not dwell in your souls, because you do not open your hearts to the one he has sent.
39 Search the holy Scriptures. You believe, after all, that in them you possess the power of eternal life. They are the ones that testify about me.
40 But your will does not lead you to me, and therefore it does not lead you to the place where you can find true life.
41 I do not rely on human opinion.
42 I have recognized for myself that there is no love of God in your souls.
43 I have come in my Father's name, and you do not receive me. If another comes in his own name, you will receive him.
44 How can you come to faith while you cling to the human honors you exchange among yourselves, instead of striving toward the luminous image of your higher being, which can be found only in the divine world?
45 Do not think that I will accuse you before the Father. Your accuser is Moses, on whom you place your hope.
46 If you truly trusted Moses, you would trust me too, for he wrote about me.
47 If you do not trust his writings, how will you trust my words?

6

1 After this, Jesus went far away to the Sea of Galilee, near Tiberias.
2 A great multitude followed him because they had seen what he did for the sick through spiritual power.
3 Jesus went up a mountain and sat down there with his disciples.
4 The Passover, the Jewish festival, was drawing near.
5 When Jesus lifted his soul to behold the Spirit, he saw a great crowd coming toward him. He said to Philip, "Where can we buy bread for them to eat?"

6 He asked this to test him; he himself knew what he was going to do.
7 Philip answered, “Bread worth two hundred denarii would not be enough for them, even if each person received only a little.”
8 One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter’s brother, said to him,
9 “There is a young boy here who has five barley loaves and two cooked fish. But what are these among such a great crowd?”
10 Jesus said, “Have the people recline.” There was plenty of green grass in that place, so they reclined; the men numbered about five thousand.
11 Jesus took the loaves, spoke the words of blessing over them, and distributed them to those reclining in the circle. He did the same with the fish, and everyone received as much as they wanted.
12 When they were satisfied, he said to his disciples, “Gather the pieces left over, so that nothing is lost.”
13 They gathered twelve baskets full of pieces left over from the five barley loaves.
14 When the people saw the sign that had taken place through him, they said, “This truly is the prophet who is to come into the world.”
15 Jesus realized that they were about to seize him and proclaim him king, so he withdrew once more to the mountain, entirely by himself.
16 When evening came, his disciples went down to the shore,
17 got into a boat, and set out across the sea toward Capernaum. It had already grown dark, and Jesus had not yet come to them.
18 The sea was being violently stirred by a strong wind.
19 When they had rowed about twenty-five or thirty stadia, they saw Jesus walking on the sea and coming near the boat, and they were filled with fear.
20 But he said to them, “I am the I AM. Do not be afraid!”
21 Then their will stirred, but when they wanted to take him into the boat, the boat was suddenly at the shore, at the place where they had been heading.
22 The next day, the crowd that had remained on the other side saw that there had been no other boat there except the one. They knew that Jesus had not boarded the boat with his disciples, and that the disciples had gone away alone.
23 Other boats from Tiberias then came near the place where the people had eaten the bread blessed by the Lord.
24 When the crowd saw that neither Jesus nor his disciples were there, they got into their boats and went to Capernaum to look for Jesus.
25 They found him on the other side of the lake and said to him, “Teacher, when did you come here?”
26 Jesus answered them, “Truly, I tell you: you are looking for me not because you saw deeds performed through spiritual power, but because you ate the loaves and were satisfied.
27 Do not strive for food that perishes, but for food that endures and grants a share in the life of all cycles of time. The Son of Man will give you this food; God the Father has placed his seal upon him.”
28 They said to him, “What must we do to take part in God’s work?”
29 Jesus answered, “This is God’s work: that you trust the one whom God has sent.”
30 They asked further, “What sign will you perform, so that we may see your true nature and put our trust in you? What work will you do?
31 Our fathers ate manna in the solitariness, as Scripture says: ‘He gave them bread from heaven to eat.’”
32 Jesus answered, “Truly, I tell you: it was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven. It is my Father who gives you the spiritually real bread from heaven.
33 For the bread of God is that which descends from heaven and gives true life to the world.”
34 They said, “Lord, give us this bread at all times.”

35 Jesus answered, “I AM the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will hunger no more, and whoever takes me into their thoughts will thirst no more.
36 But I have already told you: you have seen me, and yet your hearts have remained closed.
37 Everyone whom the Father gives me will find the way to me, and whoever comes to me I will not cast out.
38 I have descended from heaven not to do my own will, but the will of the one who sent me.
39 And this is the will of the one who sent me: that I should lose none of those he has given me, but give them the power of resurrection at the end of the ages.
40 For this is the will of the Fatherly Ground of the World: that everyone who sees the Son and trusts him may share in the life of all cycles of time. My I will give that person the power of resurrection at the end of the ages.”
41 The Jews began to grumble about him because he had said, “I am the bread that descends from heaven.”
42 They said among themselves, “Is this not Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know? How can he say, ‘I have descended from heaven’?”
43 Jesus answered them, “Do not grumble among yourselves.
44 No one can find the way to me unless the Father who sent me brings it about that they feel drawn to me; and I will give that person the power of resurrection at the end of the ages.
45 It is written in the books of the prophets: ‘They will all be taught by God himself.’ Everyone who has received the Father’s word and teaching finds the way to me.
46 No one has ever seen God the Father except the one who himself comes from the Fatherly Ground of the World; he has seen the Father.
47 Truly, I tell you: whoever has faith has the life of all cycles of time.
48 I AM the bread of life.
49 Your fathers ate manna in the solitariness and died.
50 This is the bread that descends from heaven, so that whoever eats it will not die.
51 My I is the life-bearing bread that descends from heaven. Whoever eats this bread lives through all cycles of time. And the bread I give is my earthly body, given up for the life of the world.”
52 The Jews argued among themselves, saying, “How can he give us his physical body to eat?”
53 Jesus answered, “Truly, I tell you: unless you eat the earthly body of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life within you.
54 Whoever eats my earthly body and drinks my blood has the life of all cycles of time, and I will give that person the power of resurrection at the end of the ages.
55 For my flesh is true food, and my blood is true drink.
56 Whoever truly eats my flesh and drinks my blood remains in me, and I in that person.
57 Just as the Father, who bears life, sent me, and just as I bear life through the Father’s will, so whoever makes me their food will bear life within themselves through me.
58 This is the bread that descends from heaven. It is not as it was with the fathers, who ate and died. Whoever eats this bread will live through all cycles of time.”
59 He said this while teaching in the synagogue at Capernaum.
60 Many of his disciples who heard this said, “This is a hard saying. Who can understand it?”
61 Jesus realized that his disciples were struggling with it and said to them, “Does this offend you?
62 What will you say when you see the Son of Man ascending again to where he was before?
63 It is the Spirit that gives life; the physical alone is of no help. The words I have spoken to you are Spirit and are life.
64 But there are some among you who do not trust.” For Jesus knew from the beginning who would trust him and who would betray him.
65 And he continued, “That is why I told you: no one can find the way to me unless it is granted to them by the Fatherly Ground of the World.”

66 After this, many of his disciples turned back and no longer went about with him.
67 Jesus said to the Twelve, “Do you also want to leave me?”
68 Simon Peter answered him, “Lord, to whom would we go? You have words filled with imperishable life.
69 We have perceived with the heart and recognized with the mind that you are the Holy One of God.”
70 Jesus said to them, “Did I not choose you, the Twelve? And yet one of you is an adversary.”
71 He meant Judas, the son of Simon from Kerioth. He was the one who would betray him, one of the Twelve.

7

1 After this, Jesus traveled through Galilee. He avoided Judea because the Jews were seeking his life.
2 The Jewish Feast of Tabernacles was approaching.
3 His brothers said to him, “Leave here and go to Judea, so that your disciples may openly see the deeds you are doing.
4 No one wants to work in secret. Everyone wants to stand before the public. If you do such deeds, show yourself to the world.”
5 His brothers said this because they had no trust in him.
6 But Jesus answered them, “The time has not yet come for the I who lives in me. For you, any time is suitable.
7 People cannot hate you; but they hate me, because through me it becomes clear that their actions and ways serve the opposing powers.
8 You may go up to the festival. I am not yet going up to this festival, because my time has not yet come.”
9 Having said this, he remained in Galilee.
10 But after his brothers had gone up to the festival, he also went up—not visibly in the body, but in a hidden way.
11 The Jews were looking for him at the festival and asking, “Where is he?”
12 There was much whispering about him among the crowds. Some said, “What he brings is good.” Others said, “No, he is misleading the people.”
13 No one dared speak openly about him, however, for fear of the Jews.
14 When the festival was already well underway, Jesus went up into the Temple and taught.
15 The Jews were astonished and said, “How does he know the Scriptures when he has never studied them?”
16 Jesus answered them, “The teaching I proclaim is not mine; it is the teaching of the one who sent me.
17 Whoever wills and acts in harmony with his will will recognize whether this teaching flows from divine sources or whether I speak only from myself.
18 Whoever speaks only from himself seeks the glorification of his own being. Only the one who seeks to reveal the one who sent him is a bearer of truth, with nothing false in his being.
19 Did Moses not give you the Law? Yet none of you truly acts according to the Law. Why are you trying to kill me?”
20 The crowd answered, “You are possessed by a demon! Who is trying to kill you?”
21 Jesus continued, “I performed a single deed, and you are already beside yourselves.
22 Moses gave you circumcision—not that it originated with Moses, for it goes back to the fathers—and so you circumcise people on the Sabbath.
23 If a person receives circumcision on the Sabbath so that the Law of Moses is not broken, why are you outraged that I made a whole person well on the Sabbath?

24 Stop judging by outward appearances; instead, get to the heart of things and then form your judgment.”
25 Some people from Jerusalem said, “Is this not the man they are trying to kill?
26 Look, he is speaking openly, and no one opposes him. Have the leaders really come to recognize that he is the Christ?
27 Yet we know him and know where he comes from. When the Christ comes, no one will know where he comes from.”
28 Then Jesus, teaching in the Temple, raised his voice and called out, “You say that you know me and know where I come from. But I have not come on my own authority. The one who is truth itself has sent me. You do not know him.
29 I know him, because I come from him; he has sent me.”
30 Then they tried to seize him, but no one could lay a hand on him, because his hour had not yet come.
31 Many among the crowd came to trust him. They said, “When the Christ comes, can he perform greater deeds of spiritual power than this man?”
32 The Pharisees heard the crowd talking and thinking this way, and the chief priests and Pharisees sent their attendants to take him into custody.
33 Jesus said, “I will be with you only a little longer. Then I will go to the one who sent me.
34 You will look for me and not find me. You cannot come to the place where I am.”
35 The Jews said to one another, “Where might he go, that we will not be able to find him? Perhaps he intends to go to the Jews living in Greek lands, or even to teach the Greeks themselves.
36 What does he mean by saying, ‘You will look for me and not find me; where I will be, you cannot come’?”
37 On the last and greatest day of the festival, Jesus stood and called out loudly, “Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink.
38 Whoever fills themselves with my power, from their body, as Scripture says, will flow streams of the water of life.”
39 By these words he was referring to the Spirit, whom those who joined themselves to him would receive. But this Spirit was not yet at work, for Jesus had not yet revealed his spiritual form.
40 Some in the crowd who heard these words said, “He truly is the Prophet.”
41 Others said, “He is the Christ.” Still others objected, “Can the Christ come from Galilee?
42 Does Scripture not say that the Christ will come from David’s seed and from Bethlehem, David’s city?”
43 And so a division arose among the crowd because of him.
44 Some wanted to seize him, but no one could lay a hand on him.
45 When the attendants returned to the chief priests and Pharisees, they asked them, “Why did you not bring him?”
46 The attendants answered, “No one has ever spoken as this man speaks.”
47 The Pharisees said, “Have you too been led astray?
48 Has any one of the people’s leaders or of the Pharisees joined him?
49 This crowd, which knows nothing of the Law, is under his spell.”
50 Nicodemus, who had earlier come to Jesus and was one of their number, said to them,
51 “Does our Law permit us to judge a person before hearing him and establishing his guilt?”
52 They answered him, “Are you from Galilee too? Search, and you will see that no prophet arises from Galilee.”
53 Then everyone went home.

8

1 And Jesus went to the Mount of Olives.
2 At daybreak the next day, he was again in the Temple. The people streamed to him, and he sat down and taught them.
3 Then the scribes and Pharisees brought in a woman who had been caught in adultery and made her stand in their midst.
4 They said to him, “Teacher, this woman was caught in the very act of adultery.
5 Moses commanded us in the Law to stone such women. Now what do you say?”
6 They said this to test him and to find a reason to bring a charge against him. Jesus, however, simply bent down and wrote on the ground with his finger.
7 When they continued pressing him with questions, he straightened up and said, “Let the one among you who is free of sin be the first to throw a stone at her.”
8 Then he bent down again and wrote on the ground.
9 When they heard his words, they went away, the elders first, one after another. At last he was left quite alone, with the woman still standing in the middle.
10 Jesus stood up and said to her, “Woman, where are they now? Has no one condemned you?”
11 She said, “No one, Lord.” Then Jesus said, “I do not condemn you either. Go, and from now on sin no more!”
12 And Jesus began speaking to them again: “I AM the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light in which life dwells.”
13 Then the Pharisees said to him, “You are your own witness. Your testimony has no force.”
14 Jesus answered them, “Even if I bear witness to myself, my testimony is valid, for I know where I come from and where I am going. But you do not know where I come from or where I am going.
15 You judge according to the outward human being. I, however, judge no one.
16 And if I did judge, my judgment would be valid, for I am not alone; the One who sent me is with me.
17 It is written in your Law that the testimony of two people is valid.
18 I bear witness to myself, and the Father who sent me also bears witness for me.”
19 Then they said to him, “Where is your Father?” Jesus answered, “You know neither me nor my Father. If you knew me, you would know my Father as well.”
20 He spoke these words while teaching in the Temple treasury. No one could seize him, for his hour had not yet come.
21 And he continued: “I am going away, and you will seek me, and in your sin you will meet death. Where I am going, you cannot come.”
22 Then the Jews said, “Is he going to kill himself, since he says, ‘Where I am going, you cannot come’?”
23 He said to them, “You come from below; my I comes from above. You belong to this world, which passes away; I do not come from this world.
24 That is why I told you that you will meet death in your sins. Unless you permeate yourselves with the power of my I, you will meet death in your sins.”
25 Then they said to him, “Who are you?” Jesus answered, “From the realm of the primal beginnings comes the power of the Word that I speak to you.
26 I have much to say about you and much to judge. But the One who sent me is Truth itself, and I proclaim to the world what has been revealed to me from him.”
27 They did not understand that he was speaking to them about the Father-God.
28 And Jesus continued: “When you have lifted up the Son of Man, you will recognize that I am the I-AM, and that I do nothing of myself, but proclaim what the Father teaches me.

29 The One who sent me works together with me in my work. He does not leave me alone; what I do is always in harmony with him.”
30 Through these words, many came to trust in him.
31 And Jesus said to the Jews who had come to trust in him, “If you can live in my word and find constancy in it, then you are truly my disciples,
32 and you will recognize the truth, and through knowing the truth you will find freedom.”
33 They answered him, “We are Abraham’s descendants. We have never been slaves to anyone. How can you say, ‘You will find freedom’?”
34 Jesus answered, “Truly, I tell you: everyone who sins is a slave of sin.
35 A slave, however, does not truly and permanently belong to the household. It is the son who truly and permanently belongs to the household.
36 If the Son gives you freedom, then you will truly be free.
37 I know that you are Abraham’s descendants. But you want to kill me because my word finds no room in your souls.
38 I proclaim what the Father has allowed me to behold. And you, too, act according to what you have heard from your father.”
39 They answered him, “Our father is Abraham.” Jesus said, “If you are Abraham’s children, then do the works of Abraham.
40 You are seeking to kill me—a human being who has proclaimed to you the truth as I hear it from God. Abraham did not act in this way.
41 You are truly doing the works of your father.” They said to him, “We were not born of an unclean union. We have only one Father: God himself.”
42 Jesus replied, “If the divine Ground of the World were your Father, you would love me. For my I has come forth from the divine Ground of the World and continually comes forth from it. I have not come on my own authority; he sent me.
43 Why, then, do you not understand my speech? You cannot open your ears to my word.
44 You come from the father of the adversary, and the desires of this father live in your will and your deeds. From the primal beginning he has sought to destroy the human being. You have no share in true being, because true being is not in him. When he proclaims deceptive appearances, he speaks from his own nature, for he is the bringer and father of deception.
45 But I proclaim true being, and you close yourselves off from me.
46 Which of you can prove me guilty of error? Why do you close yourselves off from me, who proclaim true being to you?
47 Whoever is of God hears the divine words. You do not hear them because you are not of God.”
48 The Jews answered him, “Are we not right in saying that you are a Samaritan and possessed by a demon?”
49 Jesus said, “My I is free of demons. Nothing is within me but reverence for the Father; you, however, dishonor me.
50 I do not seek a glorifying revelation of my being. But there is One who seeks it and intends thereby to bring about a decision.
51 Truly, I tell you: whoever carries my word in the heart is freed from the sight of death for all earthly ages.”
52 The Jews said to him, “Now we know quite clearly that you are possessed by a demon. Abraham died, and all the prophets died, yet you say, ‘Whoever keeps my word will never taste death.’
53 Are you greater than our father Abraham, who died? And than the prophets, who also died? Who do you think you are?”
54 Jesus answered, “If I were to reveal my own being, that revelation would be worthless. But it is the Father who reveals me. You call him our God, yet you do not know him.

55 I know him. If I were to say that I did not know him, I would fall into deception as you do. But I know him and carry the power of his word within me.
56 Abraham, your father, rejoiced that he would be allowed to behold the dawn of my I-being. And he beheld it with joy."
57 Then the Jews said to him, "You are not yet fifty years old, and you have seen Abraham?"
58 Jesus answered, "Truly, I tell you: from the times before Abraham was born, I am the I-AM."
59 Then they picked up stones to throw at him. But Jesus withdrew into hiding and left the Temple.

9

1 As he passed by, he saw a man who had been blind from birth.
2 And his disciples asked him, "Teacher, who sinned, this man himself or his parents? What is the cause of his blindness?"
3 Jesus answered, "His blindness comes neither from his own sin nor from the sin of his parents; rather, through it the working of the divine core of being within him is to be revealed."
4 "Through our work, we must serve the work of the One who sent me, while the day lasts. The night is coming, when no one can work."
5 "As long as I am in the world of human beings, I am a light for the world of human beings."
6 After saying these words, he mixed his saliva with earth and made a muddy paste from it; he placed this on the blind man's eyes
7 and said to him, "Go and wash in the pool of Siloam." (This means "sent forth.") So he went and washed, and returned able to see.
8 Then the neighbors, and those who had previously seen him as a blind beggar, said, "Isn't this the same man who used to sit by the road and beg?"
9 Some said, "Yes, it is he." Others said, "No, he only looks like him." But he himself said, "I am the I AM."
10 They asked him, "How, then, were your eyes opened?"
11 He answered, "The man they call Jesus made a muddy paste, spread it on my eyes, and said to me, 'Go to the pool of Siloam and wash.' So I went and washed, and I could see."
12 Then they asked him, "Where is he?" He answered, "I do not know."
13 They brought the man who had been blind to the Pharisees.
14 Now the day on which Jesus had opened his eyes with the muddy paste was a Sabbath.
15 The Pharisees also asked him how he had come to see. He answered, "He put a paste of earth on my eyes, and I washed. Since then I can see."
16 Some of the Pharisees said, "This man is not sent by God, for otherwise he would keep the Sabbath holy." Others said, "Can a sinful man perform such spiritual deeds?" And there was a division among them.
17 Once again they turned to the man who had been blind and asked, "What do you say about him, since he opened your eyes?" He answered, "He is a prophet."
18 The Jews did not believe that he had been blind and had gained his sight, so they summoned the parents of the man who could now see
19 and asked them, "Is this your son, and do you confirm that he was born blind? How is it that he can now see?"
20 His parents answered, "We certainly know that he is our son and that he was born blind.
21 But how it is that he can now see, we do not know. We do not know who opened his eyes. Ask him yourself. He is an adult and can speak for himself."
22 This was what his parents said because they were afraid of the Jews. For the Jews had already decided that anyone who acknowledged him as the Christ would be expelled from their community.

23 That is why his parents said, “He is an adult; ask him yourself.”
24 So they summoned a second time the man who had been blind and said to him, “We ask you now before the divine presence: we know that this man is a sinner.”
25 He replied, “Whether he is a sinner, I do not know. One thing I do know: I was blind, and now I can see.”
26 They asked him again, “What did he do to you? How did he open your eyes?”
27 He answered, “I have already told you, but you did not listen. Why do you want to hear it again? Do you want to become his disciples too?”
28 They berated him, saying, “You are his disciple; we are disciples of Moses.”
29 “We know that God’s own voice spoke to Moses; but as for this man, we do not know what spirit he belongs to.”
30 The healed man replied, “This is astonishing: you do not know what spirit he belongs to, even though he opened my eyes!
31 We know that God does not listen to a sinful person, but to one who is reverent and acts according to the divine will.
32 In our age of the world, no one has ever heard of anyone opening the eyes of a person born blind.
33 If this man were not sent by God, he could not have the power to do such a thing.”
34 They answered him, “You were born entirely in sin, and you presume to teach us?” And they threw him out.
35 Jesus heard that they had thrown him out. He found him and said, “Do you trust in the Son of Man?”
36 He answered, “Tell me who he is, Lord, so that I may put my trust in him.”
37 Jesus said to him, “You have seen him. The one speaking with you is he.”
38 He said, “I trust, Lord,” and fell down before him.
39 Jesus said, “I have come into this world to bring about a decision: those who do not see shall gain sight, and those who see shall become blind.”
40 Some Pharisees who were with him heard this and asked him, “Are we blind too?”
41 Jesus answered, “If you were blind, you would be free of guilt. But now you claim to see, and so your guilt remains.”

10

1 “Truly, I tell you: whoever does not enter the sheepfold through the gate, but climbs in by another way, is a thief and a murderer.
2 The one who enters through the gate is the shepherd of the sheep.
3 The gatekeeper opens for him, and the sheep hear his voice. He calls each of his own sheep by name and leads them out.
4 When he has brought them all out, he goes ahead of them, and the sheep follow him because they know his voice.
5 They will not follow a stranger; they flee from him, because they do not know the stranger’s voice.”
6 Jesus spoke this image to them, but they did not understand what he was saying to them.
7 Jesus continued, “Truly, I tell you: the I within me is the gate for the sheep.
8 All who stand in the way of the I are thieves and murderers. But the sheep do not listen to them.
9 I AM the gate. Whoever enters through me will be saved. They will learn to cross the threshold from here to there and from there to here, and will find nourishment for their soul, just as sheep find food in the pasture.
10 The lower self comes like a thief, only to seize, kill, and destroy. I came as the true I so that they may have life, and life in overflowing abundance.

11 I AM the good shepherd. The good shepherd gives his life and soul for the sheep.
12 The hired hand, who is no true shepherd and does not care for the sheep, abandons them and runs away when he sees the wolf coming; and the wolf tears them apart and scatters them.
13 He is a hired hand and does not care about the sheep.
14 I AM the good shepherd, and I know those who belong to me, and those who belong to me know me, just as the Father knows me and I know the Father.
15 I give my life and soul for the sheep.
16 I have other sheep that do not belong to this fold. I must lead them too; they will listen to my voice, and then there will be one great flock with one shepherd.
17 The Fatherly Ground of the World loves me because I give my life and soul, and so I receive them back anew.
18 No one can take my life from me; I give it up freely myself. I have the freedom to give it up, and the freedom to receive it again. This is the charge my Father has given me."
19 Because of these words, a division arose among the Jews once again.
20 Many said, "He is possessed by a demon and completely out of his mind. Why do you listen to him?"
21 Others said, "These are not the words of someone possessed. Can a demon open the eyes of a blind person?"
22 At that time the Feast of Dedication was being celebrated in Jerusalem. It was winter.
23 Jesus was walking in the temple, in Solomon's Colonnade.
24 The Jews gathered around him and said, "How long will you keep us in suspense? If you are the Christ, tell us plainly."
25 Jesus answered, "I have spoken to you, but you have not opened yourselves to my words. The works I do in my Father's name testify on my behalf.
26 But you close yourselves to this testimony, because you do not belong to my sheep.
27 My sheep hear my voice; I know them, and they follow me.
28 I give them true, deathless life. They will never perish throughout the ages, and no one will snatch them from my hand.
29 The Father, who has entrusted them to me, is greater than all, and no one can snatch them from the Father's hand.
30 I and the Father are one."
31 Again the Jews picked up stones to stone him.
32 But Jesus said to them, "Through many deeds of salvation I have shown that I work by the power of the Father of the World. For which deed do you want to stone me?"
33 The Jews answered, "We stone you not for a deed of healing, but for blasphemy: you are a human being and make yourself a god."
34 Jesus replied, "Is it not written in your law: 'The divine I has spoken: You are gods'?
35 If Scripture, which cannot be undone, calls those to whom the word of God came 'gods,'
36 how can you say to the one whom the Father God consecrated and sent into the world, 'You blaspheme,' because I said, 'I am a Son of God'?
37 If I am not doing the works of my Father, then let your hearts remain closed to me.
38 But if I do them, then open your hearts at least to these deeds of mine, even if you cannot trust me myself. Then you will increasingly recognize that the Father is in me and that I am in the Father."
39 Again they tried to seize him, but he escaped their grasp.
40 He went back across the Jordan to the place where John had first baptized, and stayed there.
41 Many people came to him and said, "John performed no signs, but everything John said about this man was true."
42 And many there came to trust in him.

11

1 A man was ill: Lazarus of Bethany, the village of Mary and her sister Martha.
2 This was the Mary who had anointed the Lord with precious ointment and wiped his feet with her hair. Her brother Lazarus was ill.
3 The sisters sent word to him: “Lord, see, the one you love is ill.”
4 When Jesus heard this, he said, “This illness does not lead to death; through it the innermost core of being is to be revealed, and the creative power of the Son is to become manifest.”
5 Jesus loved Martha, her sister, and Lazarus.
6 When he heard that Lazarus was ill, he remained for two more days where he was.
7 Then he said to his disciples, “Let us go back to Judea.”
8 The disciples replied, “Teacher, just now the Jews were seeking to stone you, and you want to go back there?”
9 Jesus said, “Does not the day have its allotted measure of twelve hours? Whoever walks by day does not stumble, because they see the light that shines on this world.
10 But whoever walks by night stumbles, because no light shines for them.”
11 After saying this, he added, “Lazarus, our friend, is asleep; but I am going there to wake him.”
12 The disciples said to him, “Lord, if he is asleep, he will recover.”
13 Jesus had been speaking about his death, but they thought he meant ordinary sleep.
14 Then Jesus told them plainly, “Lazarus has died.
15 And for your sake, and because your hearts are growing in maturity, I am glad I was not there. But now let us go to him.”
16 Thomas, who was called the Twin, said to the other disciples, “Yes, let us go too, so that we may die with him.”
17 When Jesus arrived, he found that Lazarus had already been in the tomb for four days.
18 Bethany was near Jerusalem, about fifteen stadia away.
19 Many Jews had come to Martha and Mary to comfort them concerning their brother.
20 When Martha heard that Jesus was coming, she went out to meet him. Mary, however, remained at home, withdrawn into herself.
21 Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died.
22 But I know that the divine Father grants every request you make of him.”
23 Jesus answered, “Your brother will rise again.”
24 Martha said, “I know that he will rise at the great resurrection at the end of the ages.”
25 Jesus said to her, “I AM the resurrection and the life. Whoever fills themselves with my power through faith will live, even if they die;
26 and whoever receives me within as their life is freed from the power of death for all ages. Do you feel the truth of these words?”
27 She said, “Yes, Lord. In my heart I have recognized that you are the Christ, the Son of God, who comes into the earthly world.”
28 After saying this, she went and called her sister Mary privately, saying, “The Teacher is here and is calling for you.”
29 When Mary heard this, she got up at once and went to him.
30 Jesus had not yet entered the village; he was still at the place where Martha had met him.
31 When the Jews who were in the house comforting Mary saw her get up quickly and go out, they followed her, thinking she was going to the tomb to weep there.
32 Mary came to where Jesus was. When she saw him, she fell at his feet and said, “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died.”

33 When Jesus saw her weeping, and the Jews who had come with her weeping too, his spirit was seized by deep emotion,
34 and, profoundly shaken, he said, “Where have you laid him?” They answered, “Come, Lord, and see.”
35 And Jesus wept.
36 Then the Jews said, “See how he loved him!”
37 But some of them said, “Could not the one who gave sight to the blind man have kept this man from dying?”
38 Once again a powerful emotion stirred within Jesus, and he came to the tomb. It was a cave, and a stone lay across it.
39 Jesus said, “Take away the stone!” Martha, the sister of the one who had passed on, said to him, “Lord, there must already be decay, for this is the fourth day.”
40 But Jesus said, “Did I not tell you that if you had faith, you would see the revelation of the spiritual form of light?”
41 So they took away the stone. Jesus lifted his soul into spiritual vision and said, “Father, I thank you that you have heard me.
42 I knew that you always hear me. But I say this for the sake of the people standing here, so that their hearts may recognize that you sent me.”
43 Then he cried out in a loud voice, “Lazarus, come out!”
44 The dead man came out, his hands and feet bound with strips of cloth and his face covered with a sweat cloth. Jesus said to them, “Unbind him and let him go.”
45 Many of the Jews who had come to Mary and witnessed what Jesus did came to trust in him.
46 But some went to the Pharisees and reported what Jesus had done.
47 Then the chief priests and the Pharisees assembled the Council and said, “What are we to do? This man is performing many signs.
48 If we leave him alone, everyone will eventually follow him, and then the Romans will come and take away both our land and our people.”
49 One of them, Caiaphas, who was high priest that year, said, “You understand nothing;
50 you do not see that it is better for you that one man should die for the people than that the whole people should perish.”
51 He did not say this on his own; rather, because he was high priest that year, he prophesied that Jesus would die for the people,
52 and not for the people only, but also to unite the scattered bearers of divine sonship throughout all humanity.
53 From that day on, they were resolved to kill him.
54 Jesus therefore no longer moved about publicly among the Jews, but went away to the region near the wilderness, to the town of Ephraim, and stayed there with his disciples.
55 The Jewish Passover was near, and many people from the countryside went up to Jerusalem before the festival to purify themselves.
56 There they looked for Jesus and said to one another as they stood in the temple, “What do you think? Will he come to the festival?”
57 The chief priests and Pharisees had ordered that anyone who saw him should report it to them, so that they could arrest him.

12

1 Six days before the Passover festival, Jesus went to Bethany, where Lazarus was, whom he had raised from the dead.

2 There they prepared a meal for him. Martha served at the table, and Lazarus was one of those reclining at table with him.
3 Then Mary took a jar of costly nard oil and anointed Jesus' feet, drying his feet with her hair. The whole house was filled with the fragrance of the anointing oil.
4 Then Judas of Kerioth, one of his disciples, who would soon betray him, said:
5 "Why was this ointment not sold for three hundred denarii and the proceeds given to the poor?"
6 He said this not because he cared about the poor, but because he claimed for himself what did not belong to him. He kept the money box and administered the gifts.
7 Jesus replied, "Leave her alone; what she has done shall stand for the day of my burial.
8 You always have the poor with you, but you do not always have me."
9 A large crowd of Jews had learned that he was there, and they came—not only to see Jesus, but also Lazarus, whom he had raised from the dead.
10 The chief priests had decided to put Lazarus to death as well,
11 because many Jews were being led by him to join Jesus.
12 The following day, the crowd that had come for the festival heard that Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem.
13 They took branches from the palm trees, went out to meet him, and cried, "Hosanna! Blessed is the one who comes; the power of the Lord is in him. He is the King of Israel."
14 Jesus found a young donkey and sat on it, in keeping with the words of Scripture:
15 "Do not be afraid, daughter of Zion. Behold, your king comes, seated on the foal of a beast of burden."
16 At first the disciples were not aware of what was happening. Later, however, when Jesus' spiritual form had been revealed, they remembered that this had already been foretold in Scripture and that they themselves had helped fulfill the words of Scripture.
17 The people who had been present when he called Lazarus out of the tomb and raised him from death bore witness to him.
18 For this reason the crowd had also gone out to meet him: they had heard of the sign he had performed.
19 The Pharisees said to one another, "You can see that all your efforts are in vain. Look, the whole world is following him."
20 Among those who went up to worship at the festival were some Greeks.
21 They approached Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee, and asked him, "Sir, we would like to see Jesus."
22 Philip went and spoke with Andrew, and then Andrew and Philip came to Jesus to speak with him.
23 Jesus said to them, "The hour has come for the Son of Man to be revealed in his spiritual form.
24 Truly, I tell you: unless the seed that is buried in the earth dies, it remains what it is. But if it dies, it bears much fruit.
25 Whoever loves their own soul will lose it; but whoever hates in their soul what belongs to transience preserves it for the deathless, true life.
26 Whoever wishes to serve me must follow me on my path. Where I am, there also must be the one who serves me; and my Father will honor whoever serves me.
27 Now my soul is deeply shaken. What shall I say? Father, carry me through this hour. Yet it was for this suffering that I came to this hour.
28 Father, reveal your name." Then a voice came from heaven: "I have revealed your spiritual form, and I will reveal it again."
29 The crowd standing there and listening said, "It has thundered." Others said, "An angel has spoken to him."
30 Jesus said, "This voice was heard not for my sake, but for yours.
31 This is the hour of decision for the whole world. The ruler of transience has been cast out.

32 And when my I AM is lifted up from earthly existence, I can draw all people up to myself.”
33 He said this to indicate the death he was about to undergo.
34 The crowd answered him, “We have always heard from the Law, when we were taught in it, that the Christ remains and leads us into the coming aeon. How can you say that the Son of Man must be lifted up? Who is this Son of Man?”
35 Jesus answered, “The light is among you for only a little while longer. Walk your path while you have the light, so that darkness does not overwhelm you. Whoever walks in darkness does not know where they are going.
36 While you have the light, open your hearts to the light, so that you may become children of light.” After Jesus had spoken these words, he went away, and they saw him no more.
37 Although he had performed so many spiritual deeds before their eyes, they still did not find the strength to trust him.
38 The words of the prophet Isaiah had to be fulfilled: “Lord, who has opened themselves to our message? And to whom has the Lord’s creative arm been revealed?”
39 They truly could not open their hearts, and so Isaiah says elsewhere:
40 “He has blinded their eyes and hardened their hearts, so that they do not see despite their eyes and do not understand despite their hearts; they are not to return to their former spiritual powers. Yet one day I will heal them.”
41 Isaiah said this because he had seen Jesus’ spiritual form, and therefore had already spoken of him.
42 Some of the people’s leaders did come to believe in him, but for fear of the Pharisees they did not dare confess it, lest they be excluded from the synagogue.
43 They loved human honor more than divine revelation.
44 Jesus cried aloud, “Whoever is filled with my power receives not me, but the one who sent me.
45 And whoever sees me sees the one who sent me.
46 My I AM has come into the world as a light, so that all who unite themselves with me may be freed from the spell of darkness.
47 If anyone hears my words and does not keep them, I do not judge that person. I have not come to judge people, but to heal them.
48 Whoever rejects me and makes no room within themselves for my words has already found their judge. The word I have spoken will itself be their judge at the end of the ages.
49 For I have not spoken on my own. The paternal Ground of the World, who sent me, has himself set the spiritual purpose that I am to speak and proclaim.
50 And I know that his spiritual purposes carry within them the life of all ages. What I proclaim, I proclaim just as the Father himself has spoken to me.

13

1 The Passover festival was near. Jesus perceived in spirit that the hour had come for him to pass from the earthly world into the world of the Father. He loved all those from among humanity who had become his own, and he carried this love through to its fulfillment.

2 When the meal began, the adversary had already put into the heart of Judas, son of Simon of Kerioth, the thought of betraying him.

3 Jesus knew that the Father had placed everything in his hands, now that he, who had come from the divine world, was to return to the divine world.

4 So he rose from the meal, laid aside his outer garment, took a cloth, and tied it around himself.

5 Then he poured water into the basin used for washing and began to wash the disciples’ feet, drying them with the cloth tied around him.

6 He came also to Simon Peter, who said to him, “Lord, are you washing my feet?”

7 Jesus answered, “You do not yet understand what I am doing, but later you will understand.”

8 Peter said, “You shall never wash my feet—not now, nor at any time in the future.” Jesus answered, “Unless I wash you, you have no share in me.”

9 Simon Peter said, “Lord, then not my feet only, but also my hands and my head!”

10 Jesus replied, “Whoever has been washed needs only to have their feet washed; that makes their whole being clean. You have now undergone purification, though not all of you.”

11 For he knew who would betray him. That is why he said, “Not all of you have undergone purification.”

12 After he had washed their feet, he put on his garment and sat down with them again. He said, “Do you understand what I have done for you?

13 You call me Teacher and Lord, and rightly so, for that is what I am.

14 If I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another’s feet.

15 I have given you an example, so that you too may do for one another what I have done for you.

16 Truly, I tell you: a servant is not greater than their master, nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent them.

17 If you understand this, blessed are you if you act accordingly.

18 I cannot say this of all of you: I perceive the higher being of those I have chosen. But the words of Scripture must be fulfilled: ‘The one who eats my bread has trampled me underfoot.’

19 I tell you this before it happens, so that when it happens you may recognize with inner certainty: I AM.

20 Truly, I tell you: whoever receives the one I send receives me; and whoever receives me within themselves receives the one who sent me.”

21 After saying this, he was deeply shaken by what he perceived in spirit, and he testified, “Truly, I tell you: one of you will betray me.”

22 The disciples looked at one another, perplexed and wondering whom he meant.

23 One of his disciples, the disciple whom Jesus loved, was reclining at table beside Jesus.

24 Simon Peter motioned to him and said, “Ask who it is he is speaking about.”

25 So the disciple, leaning against Jesus’ breast, asked him, “Lord, who is it?”

26 Jesus answered, “It is the one to whom I give the piece of bread after dipping it.” Then he dipped the bread and gave it to Judas, son of Simon of Kerioth.

27 After Judas had taken the piece, the dark power entered him. Jesus said to him, “What you are going to do, do quickly.”

28 None of those reclining at the table understood why he said this to him.

29 Some thought that, since Judas kept the money, Jesus was telling him to buy what they needed for the festival, or to give something to the poor.

30 After Judas had received the piece of bread, he went out immediately. And it was night.

31 When he had gone out, Jesus said, “Now the spiritual form of the Son of Man has been revealed; the God within him has become manifest.

32 And since God has become manifest in him, God will also reveal him as received into God—and will do so very soon.

33 Little children, I am with you only a little while longer. Then you will seek me. As I said to the Jews, ‘Where I am going, you cannot come,’ so now I say it to you as well.

34 I set before your souls a new purpose for the world: Love one another! Just as I have loved you, so you must love one another.

35 By this everyone will recognize you as my disciples: if you love one another.”

36 Simon Peter said to him, “Lord, where are you going?” Jesus answered, “Where I am going, you cannot follow me now, but you will follow later.”

37 Peter said, “Lord, why can I not follow you now? I will lay down my life for you.”

38 Jesus answered, “You will lay down your life for me? Truly, I tell you: before the rooster crows, you will deny me three times.”

14

1 Do not let your hearts grow faint. Trust in the power that leads you to the divine Ground of the World and that leads you to me.
2 In my Father’s house are many dwelling places. Otherwise, would I have told you, ‘I am going to prepare a place for you’?
3 And when I go to prepare a place for you, I will also come to you anew and receive you, uniting your being with my being, so that where my I AM is, your I AM may also be.
4 And you know the way to the place where I am going.”
5 Thomas said to him, “Lord, we do not know where you are going. How can we know the way that leads there?”
6 Jesus answered, “I AM the way and the truth and the life. No one finds the way to the Father except through me.
7 If you had recognized me, you would also have known my Father. From now on you recognize him, for you have seen him with your own eyes.”
8 Philip said to him, “Lord, show us the Father; that is all we need.”
9 Jesus answered, “Have I been with you so long, Philip, and you have not recognized me? Whoever sees me sees the Father. How can you still say, ‘Show us the Father’?
10 Does your heart not recognize that I am in the Father and the Father is in me? The words I speak to you I do not speak on my own. The Father, who lives in me as my true being, brings his works to completion through me.
11 Be filled with my I AM, for my I AM lives in the Father, and the Father lives in my I AM. If you cannot trust me, then trust these works.
12 Truly, I tell you: whoever receives my I AM within themselves will also be able to do the works I do, and will do greater works, because I am going to the Father.
13 Whatever you ask in my name, I will do, and the Father will be revealed through the Son’s work.
14 Whatever you ask in my name, I will do.
15 If you truly love me, take my purposes for the world into your will.
16 And I will ask the Father, and he will send you another helper—the awakener and comforter, the giver of spiritual courage—who will be with you throughout all ages.
17 This is the Spirit of true understanding. Not all people can receive him. They do not seek him and do not recognize him. But you recognize him, for he works as your higher being above you and is to enter your inner life.
18 I will not leave you as orphans. I am coming to you.

19 In a little while the world will see me no more, but you will see me. I am life, and you are to share in this life.
20 On that day you will clearly recognize that I am in the Father, and you are in me, and I am in you.
21 Whoever knows my purposes for the world and takes them into their will is the one who truly loves me. Whoever loves me will be loved by my Father, and I will love them and reveal myself to them."
22 Judas—not Iscariot—said to him, "Lord, why do you intend to reveal yourself to us and not to everyone?"
23 Jesus answered, "Whoever truly loves me carries my word within their being, and my Father will love them, and we will come to them and make our lasting dwelling within them.
24 Whoever does not love me does not carry my word within themselves. And the word you hear is not mine, but the Father's, who sent me.
25 I have spoken these things to you while I am still with you.
26 The awakener, the giver of spiritual courage, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you everything and awaken within you the memory of all that I have said to you.
27 I leave you peace; I give you my peace. I do not give it as the world gives. I give it to you in the I AM. Do not let your hearts grow faint or fearful.
28 You heard me say, 'I am going away, and yet I am coming to you.' If you truly loved me, you would rejoice that I am going to the Father, for the Father is greater than I.
29 And now I have told you before it happens, so that when it happens you may possess inner certainty.
30 I will not speak with you much longer. The ruler of transience is already coming, but he has no power over me.
31 Humanity is to recognize how I love the paternal Ground of the World and how I fulfill the mission the Father has given me. If you too are ready, we can leave this place in peace.

15

1 I AM the true vine, and my Father is the vine-grower.
2 Every branch in me that bears no fruit he cuts away, and every branch that bears fruit he prunes so that it may bear more fruit.
3 You have already been cleansed through the power of the word I spoke to you.
4 Make your lasting home in me, and I will make my lasting home in you. Just as a branch cannot bear fruit by itself unless it is filled with the life of the vine, neither can you unless you find your abiding in me.
5 My I AM is the vine, and you are the branches. Whoever dwells in my being, and allows my being to dwell within them, will bear abundant fruit. Apart from me, you can accomplish nothing.
6 Whoever does not dwell in me is cast away like a branch and must wither. They are like branches gathered up, thrown into the fire, and burned.
7 If you dwell in me and let my words live on in your heart, you can attain the purposes you set for yourselves.
8 My Father is revealed when you bear abundant fruit and become more and more my disciples.
9 As the Father has loved me, so I have loved you. Continue to live in my love.
10 If you take my purposes for the world into your will, you will continue to live in my love, just as I have taken my Father's purposes for the world into my will and continue to live in his love.
11 I have spoken these words to you so that my joy may live in you and your joy may thereby be made complete.
12 This is the purpose I give you: Love one another as I have loved you.
13 No one has greater love than this: to give up their life and soul for their friends.

14 You are my friends if you follow the purpose I give you.
15 I no longer call you servants, because a servant does not know what their master is doing. I call you friends, because I have made known to you everything that my Father has revealed to me.
16 You did not choose me; rather, I chose you and enlivened your higher being. I gave you the power, when you leave the earth, to carry your life's fruits onward and grant them permanence. And I will work so that the paternal Ground of the World gives you whatever you ask in my name.
17 This is the great purpose I give you: that you love one another.
18 If people hate you, remember that they hated me before they hated you.
19 If you belonged to humanity in general, people would love you as their own. But you do not belong to them; my I AM has chosen you out of humanity, and that is why people hate you.
20 Remember the word I spoke to you: a servant is not greater than their master. If they persecuted me, they will persecute you too. If they kept my word within themselves, they will keep yours within themselves as well.
21 They will do all these things to you as though they were doing them to me, because they do not know the one who sent me.
22 If I had not come and spoken to them, they would be without guilt. But now they have no excuse that can acquit them.
23 Whoever hates me also hates my Father.
24 If I had not done among them works such as no one else has ever done, they would be without guilt. But now they have seen me and hate both me and my Father.
25 Yet the word in their Law had to be fulfilled: 'They hated me without cause.'
26 When the awakener, the giver of spiritual courage, comes—the Spirit of true understanding whom I will send to you from the Father, who proceeds from the Father—he will bear witness to me.
27 And you too will be my witnesses, because from the very beginning you have been connected with me.

16

1 I have spoken these words to you so that your I AM may not stumble.
2 They will expel you from their community, and the time will come when those who kill you will believe they are thereby serving God.
3 They will act this way because they have known neither the Father nor me.
4 I have told you all this so that, when the time comes, you may remember that I told you. Never since the beginning have I needed to tell you such things, because I myself was with you.
5 But now I am going to the one who sent me, and none of you asks me, 'Where are you going?'
6 Now that I have spoken these things to you, sadness has entered your hearts.
7 Yet I tell you the truth: it is for your salvation that I go away. For if I did not go, the awakener, the giver of spiritual courage, would not come to you. But since I am going, I will send him to you.
8 When he comes, he will call humanity to account for its hardening in the sickness of sin, for the permeation of the higher being, and for the great decision facing the world.
9 For the hardening in the sickness of sin, because people do not fill themselves with my power.
10 For the permeation of the higher being, because I am going to the Father and you will see me no longer.
11 For the great decision facing the world, because judgment has already been passed on the ruler of transience.
12 I still have much to tell you, but you cannot bear it now.

13 When that one comes, the Spirit of true understanding, he will guide you on the way to the all-embracing truth. He will not speak from himself, but will speak whatever he hears, and he will announce to you what is to come.
14 He will reveal my being, for he will draw from my being and proclaim it to you.
15 Everything the Father has is also mine. That is why I said he will draw from my being and proclaim it to you.
16 In a little while you will see me no more; and again, after a little while, you will see me.
17 Some of his disciples said to one another, ‘What does he mean by saying, “In a little while you will not see me, and again after a little while you will see me,” and, “I am going to the Father”?’
18 So they said, ‘What does he mean by “a little while”? We do not understand his words.’
19 Jesus recognized that they wanted to ask him, and said, ‘Are you discussing among yourselves what I meant when I said, “In a little while you will not see me, and again after a little while you will see me”?’
20 Truly, I tell you: you will weep and mourn, while the world will rejoice. You will be sorrowful, but your sorrow will be turned into joy.
21 A woman in childbirth suffers great pain when her hour comes. But when she has given birth to the child, she no longer remembers the ordeal, because of her joy that a human being has been born into our world.
22 So you too are now suffering great pain. But I will see you again, and then your heart will be full of joy, and no one can take that joy away from you.
23 On that day you will have no need to ask me anything. Truly, I tell you: whatever you ask of the Father from then on, he will give you through my power, which is within you.
24 Until now you have not prayed in my name. Ask from the heart, and it will be given to your heart, and your joy will be fulfilled.
25 I have spoken all this to you in figurative words. But the time is coming when I will no longer speak to you in figures; then I will speak openly and directly to you about the paternal Ground of the World.
26 On that day you will ask in my name, in the power of my being. I am not saying that I will ask the Father on your behalf.
27 For the Father himself loves you, because you love me and have inwardly experienced that I come from the Father.
28 I came forth from the Father’s ground and entered the earthly world. Now I am leaving the world of the senses again and going to the Father.
29 His disciples said, ‘See, now you are speaking openly and directly, not in figurative words.’
30 Now we recognize that everything lies open before you. You do not need anyone to question you. And so our hearts affirm that you come from the Father.
31 Jesus answered, ‘Do you now feel my power in your hearts?
32 Behold, the hour is coming—and has already come—when you will all be scattered, each into their own selfhood. Then you too will leave me alone. Yet I am not alone, for the Father is with me.
33 I have spoken these words to you so that you may find peace in me. In the world you will undergo severe trials. But take heart: my I AM is the victory over the world.

17

1 After saying this, Jesus lifted his soul into the vision of the spirit and said, ‘Paternal Ground of the World, the hour has come. Reveal the being of your Son, so that your Son may reveal your being.
2 You have made him a creative power in all earthly human bodies, so that he may grant the true, deathless life to all who came to him through you.

3 And this is the deathless life: that the soul’s eye recognizes you as the truly unified Ground of the World, and Jesus Christ as the one you sent to them.
4 I have revealed your being on earth and completed the work you gave me to do.
5 And now, paternal Ground of the World, let my being be revealed in the light that surrounded me with radiance in your presence before the world existed.
6 I have brought your being and your name into manifestation for the people who came to me from the world through you. They were yours, you gave them to me, and they have kept your word within themselves.
7 Now they have recognized that everything you have given me comes from you,
8 for I have brought them all the power of the word that you gave me. They have been filled with it and have recognized that I come from you, and with their hearts they have affirmed that you sent me.
9 I ask you on behalf of these individuals, not on behalf of humanity in general—only on behalf of those you gave me, because they are yours.
10 Everything that is through me is through you, and what is through you is through me, and the light of my being can shine in them.
11 I am no longer in the world of the senses, but they are still in the world of the senses, and I am coming to you. Holy Father, preserve those who came to me through you in the power of your being, so that they may be one, just as we are one.
12 While I was with them, I preserved and protected in the power of your being those who came to me through you, and none of them was lost except the one who makes himself an instrument of destruction; thus Scripture was fulfilled.
13 Now I am coming to you, and I speak these words while still among people so that my joy may be fulfilled in them.
14 I have brought your word to them, and the people have hated them because they are not of their world, just as I am not of their world.
15 My request is not that you take them out of the earthly world, but that you protect them from evil.
16 They are not of the earthly world, just as I am not of this world.
17 Sanctify them through the truth. Your word is truth.
18 As you sent me into the world, so now I send them into the world.
19 And I sanctify myself for them, so that they too may be sanctified in truth.
20 I ask you not only on their behalf, but also on behalf of those who will unite themselves with me through their proclamation,
21 so that they may all be one. Just as you, Father, are in me and I am in you, may they also be in us, so that the world may recognize that you sent me.
22 I have given them the power of revelation that you gave me, so that they may be one, just as we are one.
23 I am in them, and you are in me, and so they may be consecrated into perfect unity, so that the world may recognize that you sent me and that you love them as you love me.
24 Paternal Ground of the World, this is my will: that those who came to me through you may always be with me wherever I am, and that there they may behold the revelation of my being, which you lovingly caused to shine before me before the earth existed.
25 Exalted Ground of the Father, the people of earth do not recognize you; but I recognize you, and they have recognized that you sent me.
26 I have revealed to them the word that reveals you, and I will carry this word into human souls, so that the love with which you love me may remain in them, and my I AM may thus be revealed in their I AM.

18

1 After these words, Jesus left the house with his disciples and crossed the roaring brook Kidron. On the other bank there was a garden. He entered this garden with his disciples.
2 This place was also known to Judas, who betrayed him, for Jesus had often gathered his disciples there.
3 So Judas took a detachment from the Roman cohort, together with some servants of the chief priests and the Pharisees, and came with torches, lanterns, and weapons.
4 Jesus perceived in spirit everything that lay ahead of him. He therefore came forward and said to them, “Whom are you seeking?”
5 They answered, “Jesus of Nazareth.” He said, “I am the I AM!” Judas, who betrayed him, was also standing there with them.
6 When he said to them, “I am the I AM,” they drew back and fell to the ground.
7 Once again he asked them, “Whom are you seeking?” They answered again, “Jesus of Nazareth.”
8 Jesus said, “I told you: I am the I AM. If you are looking for me, let the others go, so that they may go their way.”
9 This was to fulfill the word he had spoken: “Of those whom you have given me, I have not let a single one be lost.”
10 Simon Peter had a sword. He drew it, struck the high priest’s servant, and cut off his right ear. The servant’s name was Malchus.
11 Then Jesus said to Peter, “Put your sword into its sheath. Shall I not drink the cup that the Father gives me?”
12 Then the soldiers, the commander, and the servants of the Jews seized Jesus and bound him.
13 They led him first to Annas. He was the father-in-law of Caiaphas, who held the office of high priest that year.
14 Caiaphas was the one who had advised the Jews that it was better for one person to die for the people.
15 Simon Peter and another disciple followed Jesus. This disciple was acquainted with the high priest and went with Jesus into the courtyard of the high priest’s house.
16 Peter stood outside by the gate. The other disciple, who was known to the high priest, went out, spoke with the woman guarding the gate, and brought Peter in.
17 The servant girl guarding the gate said to Peter, “Are you not also one of this man’s disciples?” He answered, “I am not I.”
18 The servants and attendants were standing around a charcoal fire they had made to warm themselves, for it was cold. Peter joined them and warmed himself.
19 Meanwhile, the high priest questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching.
20 Jesus answered him, “I have spoken openly before the whole world. I have always taught in the synagogue and in the Temple, where all the Jews gather. I have proclaimed no secret teachings.”
21 “Why do you question me? Ask those who heard what I said to them. They know what I proclaimed from within myself.”
22 When he said this, one of the attendants standing nearby struck Jesus on the face and said, “Is that how you answer the high priest?”
23 Jesus said to him, “If I have spoken falsely, prove that it is false. But if I have spoken the truth, why do you strike me?”
24 Then Annas sent him, still bound, to the high priest Caiaphas.
25 Simon Peter was still standing there warming himself. They said to him, “Are you not also one of his disciples?” He denied it and said, “I am not I.”

26 One of the high priest’s servants, a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off, said, “Did I not see you with him in the garden?”
27 Peter denied it again, and at that moment the rooster crowed.
28 They led Jesus from Caiaphas to the Roman governor’s headquarters. It was early morning. They themselves did not enter the headquarters, so that they would not become defiled before continuing the Passover festival.
29 Pilate came out to them and said, “What accusation do you bring against this man?”
30 They answered, “If he were not a criminal, we would not have handed him over to you.”
31 Pilate said to them, “Take him yourselves and judge him according to your law.” The Jews replied, “We are not authorized to put anyone to death.”
32 This was to fulfill the word Jesus had spoken when he indicated the kind of death he was to die.
33 Pilate went back inside the headquarters, summoned Jesus, and said to him, “Are you the King of the Jews?”
34 Jesus answered, “Do you say this of your own accord, or have others told you about me?”
35 Pilate said, “Am I a Jew? Your own people and the chief priests have handed you over to me. What have you done?”
36 Jesus answered, “My kingdom does not belong to the world of the senses. If my kingdom belonged to this world, my servants would have fought for me and would not have let me fall into the hands of the Jews. But my kingdom is not here.”
37 Pilate asked, “So, are you a king?” Jesus replied, “You must say whether I stand at this level. My I has descended into the earthly world to be born, in order to bear witness to the world of true being. Everyone who comes from the world of truth hears my voice.”
38 Pilate said to him, “What is truth?” After saying this, he went out again to the Jews and said, “I find no fault in him.”
39 “You have a custom that I release one prisoner to you at Passover. If you wish, I will release the King of the Jews to you.”
40 They shouted back, “Not this man, but Barabbas!” Barabbas was a murderer.

19

1 Then Pilate took Jesus and had him flogged.
2 The soldiers twisted a crown of thorns and placed it on his head, and they put a purple robe around him.
3 They came up to him and said, “Hail, King of the Jews!” And they struck him in the face.
4 Pilate came out again and said to them, “Look, I am bringing him out to you so that you may understand that I find no fault in him.”
5 Jesus came out, wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe. Pilate said to them, “Behold, the human being!”
6 When the chief priests and the Temple attendants saw him, they shouted, “Crucify him! Crucify him!” Pilate said to them, “Take him yourselves and crucify him, for I find no fault in him.”
7 The Jews answered, “We have a law, and according to that law he must die, because he has made himself the Son of God.”
8 When Pilate heard this, he became even more afraid.
9 He went back into the headquarters and said to Jesus, “Where does your commission come from?” But Jesus gave him no answer.
10 Pilate said to him, “Will you not speak to me about this? Do you not know that I have authority to release you and authority to have you crucified?”

11 Jesus answered, “You would have no power over me if it had not been given to you from above. Therefore the heavier burden of destiny falls upon those who handed me over to you.”
12 From then on Pilate tried to release him. But the Jews shouted, “If you release this man, you are no friend of Caesar. Everyone who makes himself a king opposes Caesar.”
13 When Pilate heard these words, he brought Jesus out and sat down on the judgment seat at the place called the Stone Pavement, in Hebrew Gabbatha.
14 It was the day of preparation for Passover, about noon. He said to the Jews, “Behold, your king!”
15 They shouted, “Away with him! Away with him! Crucify him!” Pilate asked, “Shall I crucify your king?” The chief priests answered, “We have no king but Caesar.”
16 Then Pilate handed him over to them to be crucified. They took Jesus,
17 and he carried the cross out to the place called the Place of the Skull, in Hebrew Golgotha.
18 There they crucified him, and with him two others, one on either side, with Jesus in the middle.
19 Pilate had an inscription written and fastened to the cross. It read: “Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews.”
20 Many Jews read this inscription, because the place where Jesus was crucified was near the city. It was written in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek.
21 The chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate, “Do not write, ‘The King of the Jews,’ but rather, ‘This man said: I am the King of the Jews.’”
22 Pilate answered, “What I have written, I have written.”
23 When the soldiers had nailed Jesus to the cross, they took his garments and divided them into four parts, one part for each soldier. They also took his robe. This robe was seamless, woven in one piece from top to bottom.
24 They said to one another, “Let us not tear it, but cast lots to see who will get it.” This was to fulfill the Scripture: “They divided my clothes among themselves, and for my robe they cast lots.” The soldiers fulfilled this word.
25 Standing by Jesus’ cross were his mother, his mother’s sister, Mary the wife of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene.
26 When Jesus saw his mother standing there, and the disciple whom he loved, he said to his mother, “Woman, behold, your son.”
27 Then he said to the disciple, “Behold, your mother.” From that hour the disciple took her into his own care, so that she became wholly one with him.
28 After this, Jesus perceived in spirit that everything was near the completion of the consecrating deed, and that the word of Scripture had reached its goal. He said, “I thirst.”
29 A vessel of vinegar stood there. They soaked a sponge in vinegar, put it on a hyssop branch, and held it to his mouth.
30 When Jesus had taken the vinegar, he said, “The completion has come.” Then he bowed his head and breathed out his breath.
31 Because it was the day of preparation, the Jews did not want the bodies to remain on the crosses during the Sabbath, for that Sabbath was a great festival day. They asked Pilate to have their legs broken and their bodies taken down.
32 So the soldiers came and broke the legs of the first man, and then of the other who had been crucified with him.
33 But when they came to Jesus and saw that he was already dead, they did not break his legs.
34 Instead, one of the soldiers pierced his side with a spear, and at once blood and water flowed from the wound.
35 The one who saw this has testified to it himself, and his testimony is true. He knows that he speaks the truth, so that you too may be led along the path of faith.
36 These things happened so that the word might be fulfilled: “Not one of his bones will be broken,”
37 and also the other passage of Scripture: “They will look upon the one whom they pierced.”

38 After this, Joseph of Arimathea went to Pilate and asked permission to take Jesus' body down from the cross. He was a disciple of Jesus, but secretly, for fear of the Jews. Pilate gave him permission, so he came and took the body down.
39 Nicodemus also came—the one who had first come to Jesus in the realm of night—and brought about a hundred pounds of a mixture of myrrh and aloes.
40 They took Jesus' body and wrapped it in strips of linen soaked with aromatic spices, as was the Jewish custom for burial.
41 At the place where Jesus was crucified there was a garden, and in the garden a new tomb in which no one had ever been laid.
42 They laid Jesus there because it was the Jewish day of preparation, and the tomb was nearby.

20

1 On the first day after the Sabbath, the day of the Sun, Mary Magdalene came to the tomb as the first light of morning broke through the darkness, and she saw that the stone had been moved away.
2 She ran to Simon Peter and the other disciple whom Jesus loved and said to them, "They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we do not know where they have put him."
3 So Peter and the other disciple set out for the tomb.
4 They ran together, but the other disciple ran faster than Peter and reached the tomb first.
5 He bent down and saw the linen cloths lying there, but he did not go in.
6 Then Simon Peter, who was following him, arrived and went straight into the tomb. He saw the linen cloths lying there,
7 and the cloth that had been on Jesus' head. It was not lying with the other cloths, but was rolled up separately in a place of its own.
8 Then the other disciple, who had reached the tomb first, also went in. He saw everything, and assurance of soul entered into him.
9 For they had not yet understood the meaning of the Scripture that he would rise from the dead.
10 Then the disciples returned to their home.
11 But Mary stood outside the tomb, weeping. As she wept, she bent down to look into the tomb,
12 and she saw the forms of two angels in brilliantly shining garments, sitting where Jesus' body had lain, one at the head and the other at the feet.
13 They said to her, "Woman, why are you weeping?" She answered, "They have taken my Lord away, and I do not know where they have put him."
14 As she said this, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but she did not recognize that it was Jesus.
15 Jesus said to her, "Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you seeking?" She thought he was the gardener and said to him, "Sir, if you have taken him away, tell me where you have put him, so that I may take him away."
16 Jesus said to her, "Mary!" She turned again and said to him in Hebrew, "Rabbuni!"—which means Teacher.
17 Jesus said, "Do not touch me, for I have not yet ascended to the paternal Ground of the World. Go now to my brothers and tell them: I am ascending to the Ground of the World, which gives existence paternally to me and to you, and which lives as divine power in me and also in you."
18 Mary Magdalene came and brought the disciples the message: "I have seen the Lord," and she told them the words he had spoken to her.

19 That evening, on the first day after the Sabbath, the disciples had locked the doors of the room where they were, for fear of the Jews. Jesus came and stood among them and said, “Peace be with you!”
20 As he said this, he showed them his hands and his side. The disciples recognized the Lord and were filled with joy.
21 He said to them again, “Peace be with you! As the Father has sent me, so I send you.”
22 When he had said this, he breathed on them and said, “Receive the Holy Spirit.”
23 Those whose sins you release shall truly be released from them, and those whose sins you leave bound shall truly remain bound.
24 Thomas, one of the Twelve, called the Twin, was not with them when Jesus came.
25 Later the other disciples said to him, “We have seen the Lord.” But he answered, “Unless I see the mark of the nails in his hands and put my finger into the nail marks, and put my hand into his side, I cannot believe.”
26 Eight days later his disciples were again gathered in the inner room, and Thomas was with them. Jesus came while the doors were locked, stood among them, and said, “Peace be with you!”
27 Then he said to Thomas, “Reach out your finger and look at my hands; reach out your hand and put it into my side. Do not remain rigid in your heart; rather, feel my power in your heart.”
28 Thomas answered him, “You are the Lord of my soul; you are the God whom I serve.”
29 Jesus said to him, “Because you have seen me, you have found my power within you. Blessed are those who find my power in their hearts even when their eyes do not see me.”
30 Jesus performed many other signs before the eyes of his disciples. They are not recorded in this book.
31 What is written in this book has been written so that assurance of soul may arise within you: that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God. And when you gain this assurance of soul, you will find true life through the power of his being.

21

1 After this, Jesus revealed himself again to the disciples by the Sea of Tiberias. This is how the revelation took place:

2 Simon Peter, Thomas called the Twin, Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples were together.

3 Simon Peter said to them, “I am going out to cast the nets.” They answered, “We will go with you.” They left the house and got into the boat, but that night they caught nothing.

4 As morning was breaking, Jesus stood on the shore, but the disciples did not recognize that it was he.

5 Jesus said to them, “Children, have you nothing to eat?” They answered him, “No.”

6 He said to them, “Cast your net on the right side of the boat, and you will find something to eat.” They cast the net, but they could scarcely haul it in because of the great number of fish.

7 Then the disciple whom Jesus loved said to Peter, “It is the Lord!” When Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord, he put on his garment and tied it around himself, for he was naked, and threw himself into the sea.

8 The other disciples came in the boat, for they were only about two hundred cubits from shore, dragging the net full of fish.

9 When they came ashore, they saw a charcoal fire laid, with fish and bread on it.

10 Jesus said to them, “Bring some of the fish you have just caught.”

11 Simon Peter went aboard and hauled the full net ashore. It contained one hundred and fifty-three large fish. Despite their great number, the net was not torn.

12 Jesus said to them, “Come and eat.” None of the disciples dared to ask him, “Who are you?” They recognized by sight that it was the Lord.

13 Jesus came, took the bread, and gave it to them. He did the same with the fish.

14 This was already the third time that Jesus had revealed himself to the disciples as the one risen from the dead.

15 When they had eaten, Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me more than the others do?” He answered, “Yes, Lord, you know that I love you.” Jesus said to him, “Feed my lambs.”

16 He asked him a second time, “Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me?” He answered, “Yes, Lord, you know that I love you.” Jesus said to him, “Be the shepherd of my sheep.”

17 He asked him a third time, “Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me?” Peter was grieved that he had asked him a third time, “Do you love me?” He answered, “Lord, your knowing eye sees everything; you know that I love you.” Jesus said to him, “Feed my sheep.”

18 Yes, I tell you: When you were young, you girded yourself and pursued goals of your own choosing. But when you reach the maturity of age, you will stretch out your hands, and another will gird you and lead you toward goals you do not choose for yourself.”

19 With these words he awakened in Peter an image of the path of sacrifice through which he would henceforth reveal the divine. Then he continued and said to him, “Follow me!”

20 Peter turned and saw the disciple whom Jesus loved following them—the one who had reclined against Jesus at the meal and had asked, “Lord, who is it that betrays you?”

21 When Peter saw him, he said to Jesus, “Lord, what is his task?”

22 Jesus answered, “If I appoint him to carry the Spirit through until my return, that does not interfere with your path. You follow me!”

23 From then on, the saying spread among the disciples that this disciple would not die. But Jesus had not said to Peter, “He will not die.” He had said, “If I appoint him to carry the Spirit through until my return, that does not interfere with your path.”

24 This is the disciple who bears witness to all these things. He wrote them down, and we know that his testimony is true.

25 Jesus performed many other deeds of the Spirit. If they were all written down one after another, I believe that even the universe itself would not have enough room for the books that would be written.

Explanations of Rudolf Steiner.

Chapter 1.

GA094
The first twelve chapters of the Gospel of John contain John’s experiences in the astral world. From the thirteenth chapter onward, they are John’s experiences in the devachanic, or mental, world.

“Deva” means God, and “chan” means region or dwelling; Devachan therefore means the realm of God.

Thus the writer of the Gospel of John ascended into the two higher worlds and underwent initiation. It was an initiation, and the writer describes his initiation into the astral world and into the devachanic, or mental, world.

John also indicates what placed him in this particular state of soul and led him to perceive on the astral plane. The formula he used for meditation stands at the beginning of his Gospel:

“In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word. This was in the very beginning with God. All things came into being through it, and apart from this Word nothing that came into being was made. In it was life, and the life was the light of human beings. And the light shone into the darkness, but the darkness did not comprehend it.”

These five sentences contain eternal truths that conjure great visions in John’s soul. This is the meditation formula. The person for whom the Gospel of John was written must not read it merely as any other book. The first five sentences should be treated as a meditation formula; then one follows John’s path and seeks to experience what John experienced. That is the way to follow him. John says: Do what I did; let the great sentences “In the beginning was the Word,” and so on, work within your souls, and you will find confirmed what is said in my first twelve chapters.

This alone can contribute to an understanding of the Gospel of John. That is its intended meaning and how it should be used.
GA094

GA103
“In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word. This was in the very beginning with God. All things came into being through it, and apart from it nothing that came into being was made. In it was life, and the life was the light of human beings. And the light shone into the darkness, but the darkness did not comprehend it. There was a man sent by God; his name was John. He came as a witness, to bear witness to the light, so that through him all might believe. He was not the light, but a witness to the light. For the true light, which enlightens all human beings, was to come into the world. It was in the world, and the world came into being through it, yet the world did not recognize it. It came to individual human beings—to the human beings who possess an “I”—but they did not receive it. Those who did receive it could reveal themselves through it as children of God. Those who trusted in its name were born not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of human will, but of God. And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we heard his teaching, the teaching of the only Son of the Father, filled with devotion and truth. John bears witness to him and declares plainly: This is the one of whom I said, “He who comes after me has gone before me,” for he is my predecessor. From his fullness we have all received grace upon grace. For the law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. No one has ever seen God with their eyes. The only-begotten Son, who was within the innermost being of the Father of the world, became the guide to this vision.”

These words approximately convey the meaning of the opening sentences of the Gospel of John.
GA103

GA094

The Gospel of John must be experienced. Its opening words must be taken as material for meditation and allowed to live within oneself. They are spiritual nourishment. One should say: “This is material with which I will live for five minutes each day.” These words will open the eyes and ears of the spirit. You will experience their magical power—their forces—in astral images. Let me bring before your soul the impulse the writer of the Gospel of John felt and what he wished to express. First, he was, in his soul, a newborn, awakened by the power of insight contained in these sentences:

“In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word. This was in the very beginning with God. All things came into being through it, and apart from it nothing that came into being was made. In it was life, and the life was the light of human beings. And the light shone into the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it.”

This is the first part of the meditation. The second part is:

“There was a man sent by God; his name was John. He came as a witness, to bear witness to the light, so that through him all might believe. He was not the light, but a witness to the light. For the true light, which enlightens all human beings, was to come into the world. It was in the world, and the world came into being through it, yet the world did not recognize it. It came to individual human beings—to those who possess an “I”—but they did not receive it. Those who received it could reveal themselves through it as children of God. Those who trusted in its name were born not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of human will, but of God. And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we heard his teaching, the teaching of the only Son of the Father, filled with devotion and truth.”
GA094

GA100
The disciple John is nowhere named in the Gospel of John. He is referred to only as “the disciple whom the Lord loved,” for example in chapter 19, verse 26. This is a technical expression denoting the person initiated by the Master himself. John describes his own initiation in the raising of Lazarus in chapter 11. The most hidden relationships between Christ and the evolution of the world can be revealed only because the writer of the Gospel of John was initiated by the Lord himself. As stated above, the ancient initiations lasted three and a half days; hence Lazarus was raised on the fourth day. Lazarus, too, is said to have been loved by Christ (chapter 11, verses 3, 35 and 36). This is again the technical expression for the beloved disciple. While Lazarus’s body lay as if dead in the tomb, his etheric body was drawn out so that he could undergo initiation and receive the same power that is in Christ. Thus he became one who had been raised—the one whom the Lord loved, from whom the Gospel of John originates.

Initiation means raising a person up so that he can behold the spiritual world. In all pre-Christian initiations, the person to be initiated had to be brought into a kind of sleep. Initiatory sleep differs from ordinary sleep: in ordinary sleep the etheric body remains connected with the physical body, whereas in initiatory sleep the etheric body is separated from the physical body for a short time. During this period the hierophant had to keep the body alive. By withdrawing the etheric body, it could be led with the other bodies into the higher worlds, where it underwent experiences that could later be conveyed to the physical brain. These were the only methods of initiation in pre-Christian times.

These are the mysteries that lie dormant in the Gospel of John. The disciple whom the Lord loved is the one whom he himself initiated. The writer of the Gospel of John was the one whom the Lord loved.
Only through the appearance of Christ Jesus did it become possible to impress what was the spirit of life directly into the life body. Experiences in the higher worlds could now be incorporated into the physical brain without first separating the etheric body. Christ Jesus was the first being to possess an

etheric body wholly permeated by the spirit-self and a physical body wholly permeated by the spirit of life. Because Christ Jesus came to Earth, those connected with him could undergo the same initiation without separating the etheric body from the physical body. All pre-Christian initiates therefore experienced initiation outside the physical body, returned to it, and could then proclaim from personal experience what had taken place in the spiritual world.

Buddha, Moses, and others were such initiates. In Jesus, for the first time, a being came to Earth who could behold the life of the higher worlds while remaining in the physical body.
GA100

GA094
When a person enters this state of sleep, he is no longer in the sensory world. He enters a soul-world, where he experiences the truth about the sensory world. The truth of the sensory world dawns upon him. He moves from the derivative words of the sensory world back to the primal forces and rises to the words of truth. Every truth has seven meanings. For the mystic who immerses himself in meditation, however, it has this meaning: the insight, the Word that dawns, is not something true yesterday and today only; it is eternal. This Word leads to God because it has always been with God himself, because it is the very essence that God has placed within things.

What do we find in this Word? Life. What do we recognize through life? Through light? We must understand religious documents quite literally if we wish to rise to higher knowledge. Where does the light shine when a person reaches this state? Into the darkness of night. It enters those who sleep; it enters everyone who sleeps. But the darkness has not comprehended it—until the capacity arose to perceive it on the astral plane. Thus the fifth sentence should also be understood literally. The astral light shines into the darkness of night, but people ordinarily do not see it; they must first learn to see.

A divine human being lives within every individual. In the distant future this divine human being will rise up from every person. As a person appears before us today, his outward expression is more or less an imprint of the inner divine human being, who continually works upon the outer person.

A person becomes more mature, and is mature when the inner Word has become entirely flesh, when the outer has become an exact imprint of the inner, so that the flesh is wholly spiritualized. He understood this only after the higher self had clearly appeared before his astral eye. It stood before John’s soul on the astral plane, and he recognized: “That is me.” He had experienced it on the astral plane for the present, but it would gradually descend, as it had in the case of the one he followed. This is the deep kinship between Christ Jesus and the divine human being latent in every person. That was John’s profound inner experience. The inner self lives unconsciously within a person and becomes conscious to the soul only through the processes described.

What does it mean for something to become conscious to us? Can something become conscious within us if it merely lives inside us? As long as it merely lives within us, we are not conscious of it. We are not conscious of what is subjective, what a person carries within himself. Let me use a rough comparison: you all have a physical brain, but you do not see it. It would have to be cut out for you to see it. The same reason, in a somewhat different way, explains why you do not see your higher “I.” It is the “I” within you. It must come out for you to perceive it, and this can happen only on the astral plane. When it comes out and stands before you, spiritually the same thing has occurred as if you placed a physical brain on a plate and made it an object of sensory observation.

The writer of the Gospel of John describes this process: his own higher “I” appears before him—the higher “I” which, in its perfection, represents Christ. Only when you understand this can you grasp certain indications and truths in the opening chapters of the Gospel of John. Some things become quite clear if you take only what I have said so far. In occult language, the physical body—the body the “I” has built for itself to dwell in—is called the temple. Thus it is said that the soul dwells in the temple.
It is not entirely painless for the soul to leave the temple of the body for the first time and become visible outside it. This departure is painful; it is like a tearing apart when the astral body leaves the physical body in a perceptible way. Leaving the body during sleep is different, because a person perceives nothing. But if the person leaves consciously, the pain becomes perceptible.

When a person has entered the astral world from this world, he finds himself in a region from which further ascent leads to a still higher world, the mental or devachanic world. Entry into that world must be won at the cost of complete cessation of being—a killing of the lower nature. A person must pass through the three-day death and then be awakened. Once he has gained sight on the astral plane and its images have appeared before him, he is ready to become knowing on the mental or devachanic plane. His awakening on the devachanic plane can then be described. Becoming consciously aware, through thought, of one’s own self on the higher plane—this is the raising of Lazarus.

John also describes the raising of Lazarus. Beforehand, he has shown that one can enter the higher world through this whole process, and that this is the door to the higher worlds. In chapter 10, verse 9, it says:

“I am the door; if anyone enters through me, he will be saved, and will go in and out and find pasture.”
This is the awakening of what had been enveloped in sleep and is now awakened on the devachanic plane. John undergoes it. John is Lazarus, and he means nothing other than what is described in his first twelve chapters: as an astral experience, he described how he had been awakened on the astral plane. Then came initiation for the devachanic plane. He lay in the tomb for three days and then received the awakening. The raising of Lazarus is the writer John’s own awakening.

All who are awakened are called “John.” It is a generic name, and the raising of Lazarus in the Gospel of John is nothing other than a description of this awakening.
GA094

GA112
And who was to be born into the being of Jesus of Nazareth?

As we indicated yesterday, it was the God who had existed from the beginning, who had, so to speak, remained in the spiritual world while allowing human beings to develop for the time being. Now this God was to descend and incarnate in Jesus of Nazareth. Does the writer of the Gospel of John point this out? We need only take the Gospel’s words seriously in this respect. For this purpose, let us read the beginning of the Old Testament:

“In the beginning (or in the primal beginning) God created heaven and earth. And the earth was formless and empty, and confusion and darkness lay over the abyss. And the divine Spirit moved over the waters.”

Imagine the situation: the Spirit of God moved over the waters. Below stood the Earth and its kingdoms, successors of the divine Spirit. Among them an individuality developed to the point where it could receive within itself the Spirit that moved over the waters. What does the writer of the Gospel of

John tell us? He says that John the Baptist recognized that the corresponding being spoken of in the Old Testament was present. He says: “I saw the Spirit descend from heaven like a dove, and it remained upon him.” John knew that when the Spirit descended upon someone, that was the one who was to come: the Christ. Here we have the beginning of the world’s evolution, the Spirit moving over the waters; we have John baptizing with water; and we have the Spirit that once moved over the waters now entering the individuality of Jesus of Nazareth. The writer of the Gospel of John could not more magnificently connect the event in Palestine with the earlier event related at the beginning of the same sacred document to which the Gospel is linked.

The writer of the Gospel of John also connects with this oldest sacred document in another way. He does so through the very words expressing that what was present at the beginning of all earthly evolution is joined to Jesus of Nazareth. We know that the Gospel of John begins:

“In the very beginning was the Word (or Logos), and the Word (or Logos) was with God, and a god was the Word (or Logos).”

What is the Logos, and how was it with God? Let us look at the beginning of the Old Testament, where we encounter the Spirit of whom it says:

“And the divine Spirit moved over the waters. And the divine Spirit called out, “Let there be light!” And there was light.”

Let us hold on to this and express it somewhat differently. Listen to how the divine Spirit calls the creative Word through the world. What is the Word? In the primal beginning was the Logos, and the divine Spirit called out, and what the Spirit called out came to pass. This means that life was in the Word; for if life had not been within it, it could not have happened. And what happened? It is told:
“And God said, “Let there be light!” and there was light.”

Now let us return to the Gospel of John:

“In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word.”

The Word had now flowed into matter and had, as it were, become the outward form of the Godhead.

“In it was life, and the life was the light of human beings.”

Thus the writer of the Gospel of John connects directly with the oldest sacred document, Genesis. In slightly different words, he points to the same divine Spirit, and then makes clear that this is the divine Spirit that appears in Jesus of Nazareth.

When Christ united with the outer covering of Jesus of Nazareth, this event appeared in an opposite form to those whose spiritual eyes were open. In a physical incarnation, something spiritual descends from higher worlds and unites with the physical. In this case, however, what was sacrificed in order to receive the Christ-Spirit appeared above the head of Jesus of Nazareth as a white dove. A spiritual being appears as it separates itself from the physical! This is a genuine clairvoyant observation. It is quite incorrect to say that it is merely allegorical or symbolic. It is a real clairvoyant spiritual fact, present to clairvoyant perception on the astral plane. Just as physical birth involves the drawing down of something spiritual, this birth was a sacrifice, a giving up. This made it possible for the Spirit that

“moved over the waters” at the beginning of Earth’s evolution to unite with the threefold covering of Jesus of Nazareth and permeate and kindle it with power, as described.
GA112

GA100
If the Gospel of John is translated according to its spirit rather than its wording, the first fourteen verses read as follows:

“In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word. This was in the very beginning with God. All things came into being through it, and apart from it nothing that came into being was made. In it was life, and the life was the light of human beings. And the light shone into the darkness, but the darkness did not comprehend it. There was a man sent by God; his name was John. He came as a witness, to bear witness to the light, so that through him all might believe. He was not the light, but a witness to the light. For the true light, which enlightens all human beings, was to come into the world. It was in the world, and the world came into being through it, yet the world did not recognize it. It came to individual human beings, to those who possess an “I”; but they did not receive it. Those who received it could reveal themselves through it as children of God. Those who trusted in its name were born not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of human will, but of God. And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we heard his teaching, the teaching of the only Son of the Father, filled with devotion and truth.”

For John, truth—ἀλήθεια (aletheia)—is Manas; devotion—χάρις (charis)—is Buddhi; and wisdom—σοφία (sophia)—is Atma.

Modern people already take the first word in an abstract sense, imagining the primal beginning as an abstract start. To grasp its proper meaning, however, one must recall what was taught about it in the Christian mystery school of Dionysius the Areopagite. Mineral, plant, animal, and human form the developmental sequence of beings that need a physical body. Above them stand beings that exist without such a body: angels, archangels, the Primordial Beginnings, Powers, Dominions, Thrones, Cherubim, Seraphim, and ever higher beings.

The Primordial Beginnings are therefore real beings. This name was given to beings who, at the beginning of our world’s evolution, had reached the stage that humanity will reach in its development during the Vulcan phase.

Just as human beings can already transform their thoughts into air vibrations through speech, one day they will be able to create their own likeness through the Word.

The Primordial Beginnings already possessed this creative power at the beginning of our present world evolution and may therefore rightly be regarded as divine beings. At the beginning of Earth’s evolution, a divine Word was spoken, and it became mineral, plant, animal, and human.
GA100

GA094
There are beings above the human level that no longer need a physical body: angels, archangels, Primordial Beginnings or Origins, Powers, Might, Dominions, Thrones, Cherubim, and Seraphim.

Verse 1: “In the Primordial Beginnings was the Word; it received life, and because it was creative, it was a god.” Everything, everything is crystallized divine Word, spoken Word. Human beings now

possess the Word; later they will bring forth beings like themselves through the Word. The Primordial Beginnings were beings who, at the start of Earth's evolution, already stood at the stage humanity will reach at the end of Earth's evolution.

Because John was able to feel this impulse, he experienced in great astral visions what these sentences contain. But this was only the second thing in his soul; the first was the awakening of these forces. The third was the following. Consider an example: one night you dream of someone you have never seen. The dream gives you the certainty that this person matters to you, and shortly afterwards you meet them. Something similar happened to John in his experience of Christ. In a dreamlike state he had astral visions of what later became history in Palestine. What he experienced and beheld in the higher worlds became an experience in earthly life.

The meditation should be practised by beginning one morning to let the opening words of the Gospel of John pass through the soul every day. After months, years, or decades, a person will experience something in the soul of what these words contain. In particular, this translation is important: "It came to those who possess an 'I,' but those who possess an 'I' did not receive it." If you work through these words, you have a brief outline of the theosophy in the Gospel of John—the theosophy we teach. Hence their tremendous effect. Only those who first awaken these soul-spiritual forces within themselves will experience it.
GA094

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When the first Word sounded within the human being, that was the person's true spiritual beginning.

Here we reach the point touched on by the Evangelist in chapter 1, verse 1: "In the primal beginning was the Word…"

In esoteric teaching, the highest Spirit connected with the Sun, who sent the "I"s toward Earth, is called Christ. The "I"s, as members of the Solar Logos, entered forms only gradually. Light streamed forth from the Solar Logos, but in ancient times few received it. Those who did became different from their fellow human beings and were called children or sons of God (chapter 1, verse 12). They consisted of four members: the physical body, etheric body, astral body, and "I," although the fourth and youngest member was still weak and dim. The light is intended to reach everyone, but this takes time; verses 8–14 point to this. Some individuals had already received the light to such a degree that they knew of it and could bear witness to it, teaching others. Those who testified to the light from their own experience rather than through the teaching of others, and who pointed to the coming of one who would bring the light to everyone for the first time, are called "John" in esoteric teaching (chapters 6 and 7). The writer of the Gospel of John is such a "John." Chapter 1, verse 18 says, "No one has ever seen God"—that is, no one before John, for God was first personified with Christ Jesus. The greatest event in the evolution of the cosmos and humanity is the event of Golgotha.
GA100

GA089
When a person sees a thing, he asks how it came into being and assumes something from which it arose. This applies only to things that occur in the world. We must posit something about which we can no longer ask what it arose from. That is the Logos. Nor should we ask when the Logos came into being, for that would limit it by saying it arose earlier or later. It was now and always. All concepts of time cease to have meaning in relation to the Logos. What we say about the Logos now was true millions of primordial years ago. It is not in time, but before all time.

We shall develop several concepts.

If we call that which is absolute in itself—lacking everything we ordinarily know—"beyond being," we have formed an abstract concept of the Logos: the self-contained, self-grounded, resting, absolute Logos.

First Logos—Sat—Father.

If this Logos is considered alone, it rests in itself, is and is not, and is beyond being; it can never be perceived, because it is beyond all perception and transcends existence. It follows that this Logos is the absolutely hidden, occult, because it transcends all revelation. If it is not to remain occult, it must reveal itself. Then we have its mirror image, the revealed Logos. In this idea we can immediately recognize two concepts, giving us a threefold reality, for the revealer must contain the activity of revealing:

1. Logos: the Revealer
2. Logos: Revelation, activity
3. Logos: the revealed reflection

Sat, Ananda, Chit

The Trinity:
1. Father
2. Son, Word
3. Holy Spirit

These three are initially so exalted that, in relation to anything ordinarily called revealed or perceptible, they must themselves again be called occult. They are three occult beings and must first become manifest. Since there are only three, they can reveal themselves only to one another:

The Father reveals himself to the Word.

The Word reveals itself to the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit reveals itself back to the Father.

These are three kinds of revelation. We may attribute them to three beings whose activity consists in carrying out these transmissions. The three can enter into different relationships.

The Father can hide himself in the Word and communicate himself through this concealment. He veils himself in the Word and reveals himself to the Spirit.

The Word can veil itself in the Holy Spirit and, within this covering, reveal itself to the Father.

The Holy Spirit can veil itself in the Father and reveal itself to the Word.

The only remaining possibility is for the Father to clothe himself in both Word and Spirit and become manifest to himself.

If we conceive the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, and 7 as existing essentially, we obtain seven essential forms: the seven relationships of the three Logoi.

1st relationship — All-Might, Omnipotence: the Father reveals himself to the Word.

2nd relationship — All-Wisdom: the Word reveals itself to the Spirit.

3rd relationship — All-Love: the Holy Spirit reveals itself to the Father.

4th relationship — All-Justice: the Father veils himself in the Word and reveals himself to the Spirit.

5th relationship — All-Redemption: the Word veils itself in the Spirit and reveals itself to the Father.

6th relationship — All-Sanctification: the Holy Spirit veils itself in the Father and reveals itself to the Word.

7th relationship — All-Blessedness: the Father clothes himself in Word and Spirit and becomes manifest to himself.

These beings arose through mutual fecundation. They are the seven rulers, the seven powers standing before the throne [of God], and these are their attributes. The attributes arise from the relationships of the three Logoi. Only seven are possible.

All-Might, Omnipotence consists in the Father revealing himself to the Word. This is called the first creation, or Chaos.

After All-Might, Omnipotence has completed its task, All-Wisdom governs and orders everything according to measure and number.

After All-Wisdom has completed its task, All-Love governs and introduces the principles of sympathy and antipathy throughout creation.

After All-Love has completed its task, All-Justice comes and governs, introducing karma—that is, birth and death.

After All-Justice has completed its task, All-Redemption begins its work and brings redemption everywhere—that is, the Last Judgment.

After the Last Judgment has taken effect, All-Sanctification begins its work, bringing sanctification everywhere; then All-Blessedness begins.

Let us imagine these distributed across seven planets. In truth all seven are present, but one always holds the power while the others serve in subordinate roles.

If we take the fourth globe, it is our own. Our watchword, therefore, is: “The Father veils himself in the Word and reveals himself to the Spirit.” And with this, Christianity is given.
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This example really did exist in Christian schools. First something is a spoken word; then it solidifies and becomes a fixed form. Earlier still, before it solidified, it was a thought hidden within. Christians imagined that creation in the great world works as creation does here in space. Creation began with the thought of things; then the Godhead spoke the thought outward into space. What you see outside—plants and minerals—are such solidified words of God. You could imagine everything dissolved into sound vibrations of the divine Word of the world. “Everything I see,” the Christian would say, “I see as a solidified Word of God.” In this sense, the Christian distinguished the “Father in secret,” who has not yet expressed himself; the “Word” or “Son,” which resounds through space; and the solidified Word, the “Revelation.” In this deeper sense we can understand the beginning of the Gospel of John: “In the very beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and a god was the Word. This was in the very beginning with God. All things came into being through it, and apart from it nothing that came into being was made.” Everything that came into being arose from the Word. We should take these things as literally as possible; then we can readily recognize the creative nature of the Word or Logos. In the Christian sense, the second of these is the Word, or Logos. “Logos” must not be translated otherwise than as “Word,” because the meaning is that the unspoken creative Word underlies all creation outside us, sounded forth as the Word, and is the origin of all that exists. If we could go far enough back in the turning of the ages, we would hear all the things we know as animals, plants, minerals, and human beings resounding as “Word” through the world-space, as you hear my words today, because the air had not yet cooled sufficiently for them to fall into formed shapes.
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GA089
The first from which everything else proceeded is the unmanifested Godhead. From it then proceeded the second, life, or the unmanifested creative substance. This life passes through the most varied forms and is named in the forms Akasha or Mahat. This Akasha or Mahat contains all the forms of life that exist in the world. All the hierarchies of Thrones, Cherubim, Seraphim, Powers, Primal Forces, Archangels, and Angels came forth through life and form the shapes in which this one life appears.

The first force, the unmanifested Godhead, is also called the Father; the second force is the Son, who is at once life and creative substance; and the third force is the Spirit. Together, these three primal forces thus appear as Father, Son, and Spirit—as consciousness, life, and form. The force of life is guided by Michael, who belongs to the Sun; the force of form is guided by Samael, who belongs to Vulcan, where all life will be transformed into living forms. The force of consciousness is guided by Anael, who encompasses all that exists. The three highest are therefore:

Unmanifested Godhead — Father — [Consciousness]

Unmanifested creative substance — Life — Son

Manifested life — Akasha, Mahat — Form

These three are reflected in the human being’s higher triad:

Spirit-Man (Atma)

Life-Spirit (Budhi) — Spirit-Self (Manas)

This is the part of the human being toward which he must develop fully. In it, the Life-Spirit is reflected twice in his spirit: as the Intellectual Soul and the Sentient Soul. And the Spirit-Self is

reflected in his soul, in the astral realm, as the Sentient Body and the etheric double-body. Finally, Atma is reflected in him as his physical body. The highest Three are also reflected in the human being, but as that which descends below his actual physical level—as his lower nature.
GA089

GA094
If one imagines cosmic intelligence as the world of thoughts accessible to the higher I (Manas), one immediately notices this force of warmth that permeates the universe, as though proceeding from the creative source of all life (Life-Spirit: Budhi). Through it, one can begin to sense the world of creative power that existed before ours and envelops it. One then rises from Manas to Budhi, and from Budhi to Atma.

The Word that kindles the I in the human being, the microcosm, is the Third Logos.

Next, imagine the force of the higher I in the human being, Manas, extended throughout the whole universe like a source of warmth that kindles life. One then arrives at the Second Logos, which kindles macrocosmic life and of which the human soul receives a reflection in its creative activities (Budhi). Their common source is the First Logos, the unfathomable Godhead, the center of every manifestation.

At all times, occultism has depicted these three Logoi by means of the following symbols:



Every state of consciousness develops over the course of seven states of life, and every state of life over the course of seven states of form. Seven states of form always make up one state of life; seven states of life together constitute a planetary evolution, such as that of our Earth.

The seven states of life lead to the formation of seven kingdoms, of which four are presently visible: the mineral kingdom, the plant kingdom, the animal kingdom, and the human kingdom.

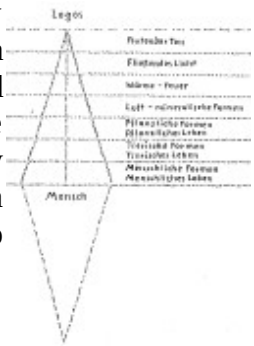
The passage through a state of life is called a Round.

Thus, in every state of consciousness the human being passes through 7 × 7 states of form; this means 7 × 7 × 7 metamorphoses, or 343 metamorphoses, representing just as many stages of human nature.
If someone could picture the 343 states of form on a single chart, they would have an image of the Third Logos.

If they could picture the 49 states of life, they would have an image of the Second Logos.

If they could picture the seven states of consciousness, they would have an idea of the First Logos.

If we went further back, we would see that in earlier states our planet had a purely gaseous body, and, further back still, a body composed purely of sound. Human evolution begins with this sound—which is itself the cosmic Word—and subsequently advances to light, fire, and air. Only in the fourth state does the human spirit become conscious. From that point onward, the orientation formerly given to it by the Word comes from within, and its consciousness becomes its own guide. Its essential being is realized in the I. The awakening of the I to consciousness means the realization of the Christ-principle in the human being.



If we went back to the first elemental form, we would be received by the Word, by the surging tone. With the second elemental stage, we would pass over into surging light. The third elemental stage would permeate us with warmth. Finally, on the fourth elemental stage, in the Earth's atmosphere, we would see self-consciousness emerge—the capacity that allows the human being to say "I" to himself.
GA094

GA089
The law of form is birth and death. The law of life is rebirth. The law of spirit is karma. Life passes through birth and death and appears in ever-new forms. Form is transitory, life repeats itself, and spirit is imperishable, eternal.

The world's emergence from the Logos must be a free act of the Logos, not an act of necessity.

In Christian esotericism, the states of consciousness are designated as the Father (A), the states of life as the Son or Word (B), and the states of form as the Holy Spirit (C).

Theosophy calls A the First Logos, B the Second Logos, and C the Third Logos.

The following overview of evolution therefore emerges, if we also bear in mind that the First Logos manifests in the human being as Atma, the Second Logos as Budhi, and the Third Logos as Manas.



All life in its manifold forms has proceeded from unity, from the one Logos. In it, all diversity still rests hidden, undivided and undifferentiated. As it becomes perceptible and recognizes itself as a self, it emerges from the Absolute, from that which has no distinctions, and creates the non-self, its mirror image: the Second Logos. It ensouls and enlivens this mirror image; this is its third aspect, the Third Logos.

The First Logos would thus be regarded as the undifferentiated, in which life and form rest undivided, as the Father. With its existence, time begins; it separates its mirror image from itself—the form, the feminine—which it fills with its life: the Second Logos. From this ensouling, the Third Logos emerges as the Son, as living form. In this way, all religions have conceived their God in a threefold form: as Father, Mother, and Son. Thus Uranus and Gaia, the maternal Earth, and Cronus, Time, who emerged as their son from her womb; Osiris, Isis, and Horus, and so on.

Only after completing all 343 states will the human being become what we call a "god"—yet not the highest God, but what we call the Third Logos. This is in truth the Logos of Form, which will have passed through the 343 metamorphoses. It represents form at its highest stage. These different configurations of consciousness are, in turn, form on the higher plane. Considered as a unity, these 343 forms are therefore the Third Logos. The Second Logos will represent life at its highest stage, and the First Logos consciousness at its highest stage. Esotericists represent the stages of form by colors and symbols, and the stages of life by tones—life resounds. In the physical world, there are no signs with which to characterize the stages of consciousness.
GA089

GA103

Let us now consider the whole picture we have brought before our souls today. We shall say: the entire evolution has been guided in such a way that the capacity for speech, the Word, originally existed in God, and that God first created the preconditions for the physical apparatus to acquire the ability to sound forth this Word from within. Everything was directed and guided in this way. Just as the flower is present in its seed, the sounding, speaking human being—the human being endowed with word and Logos—was already present in seed form on Saturn. Yet the sound was hidden in the seed; it developed from the seed, just as the whole plant is hidden in the seed and develops from it.

Let us look back at the physical human body as it already existed on Saturn and ask: Where does this physical body come from? What is its ultimate origin? Without what could it never have undergone its entire evolution? It comes from the Logos, or the Word. For already on Saturn the physical human body was guided in such a way that it would later become capable of speech, a witness to the Logos. The fact that you are formed today in such a way that the human body has its present form is due to the fact that the "Word" lay at the foundation of the entire plan of our creation. The whole human body is oriented toward the Word, and from the beginning it was predisposed so that, ultimately, the Word could spring forth from it. Therefore, when the esoteric Christian looks at this physical human body and asks what its original archetype and its image are, he tells himself: this physical body has its archetype in the Word or Logos; the Logos or Word has been active in the physical human body from the beginning. And the Logos is still active today: when the physical human body lies in bed, abandoned by the I, the divine Logos works in the human being's members that have been left behind. If we ask about the first origin of the physical body, we answer: the first is the Logos, or the Word.

While on Saturn the physical body was a kind of machine, a kind of automaton, yet wholly permeated and sustained by the Logos, the life-body was incorporated on the Sun, and the divine spirit of life worked within it. On Saturn, we shall say, the human body is an expression of the Logos. Saturn passes away; this human body is embodied anew on the Sun, where the life-body, permeated by the spirit of life, is incorporated into the physical body. On the Sun, the Logos became life by bringing the human being to a higher stage. The Logos became life on the Sun! And now let us go further. On the Moon, the astral body was incorporated into the human being. What is the astral body? Even today, clairvoyant consciousness perceives it as an aura surrounding the human being. It is a body of light that cannot be seen by ordinary present-day consciousness. But when seen by clairvoyant consciousness, it is light, spiritual light; our physical light is only transformed spiritual light. Physical sunlight, too, is the embodiment of the spiritual-divine, auric light of the cosmos. That is its foundation. In today's world there is light that flows to the human being from the Sun. But there is also another light that streams from the human being's own inner light. On the Moon, the human astral body shone for the beings around it. Thus, on the Moon, the astral body of light was added to the human being's physical and etheric bodies.

In the beginning, the Logos existed as the archetype of the physical human body and lay at the foundation of all things. All animals, plants, and minerals came into existence later. On Saturn, of all these, only the human being was actually present; the animal kingdom was added on the Sun, the plant kingdom on the Moon, and the mineral kingdom on Earth. On the Sun, the Logos became life, and on the Moon it became light; when the human being was endowed with an I, this light appeared before him. But the human being had to learn to recognize what the Logos was and what it would ultimately become. First there was the Logos, then it became life, then light, and this light lives in the astral body. The light shone into the human being's inner darkness, into his lack of knowledge. Earthly existence has the purpose of enabling the human being to overcome the darkness within and thereby recognize the light of the Logos.
GA103

GA112
The great power that, out of the cosmic chaos during Saturn's evolution, provides the spiritual seed for the physical human form is called the "Logos" by the author of the Gospel of John. What was added on the Sun and incorporated into what had arisen on Saturn is called "life"—what we would correspondingly call the etheric or life-body. What was added on the Moon is called "light," for it is spiritual light, astral light. This astral light causes hardening on the Moon that had separated off, and spiritualization on the Sun itself. What arose in a spiritualized form could continue to develop, and did so. When the Sun separated anew from the Earth, what had developed at the third stage shone into the human being. But the human being was not yet capable of seeing what shone into him from the Sun. It shaped and worked within him as a force, but he could not see it.
We now express in the words of the Gospel of John what we have clarified as essential to Saturn's evolution:

"In the beginning was the Logos."

Now we move on to the Sun. If we state the fact that what arose on Saturn developed further on the Sun, we say: the etheric body was added:

"And the Logos was life."

On the Moon, the astral being was added, both in its bodily and spiritual aspect:

"In the living Logos, the light came to be."

The light continues to develop: on the one hand into clairvoyant light, when the Sun separated from the Earth, and on the other hand, together with the human being, into darkness. For when the human being was meant to receive the light, he—who was darkness—did not understand it.

Thus, when we illuminate the Gospel of John from the perspective of the Akashic Chronicle, we read the following account of the world's evolution:

In the beginning, during Saturn's evolution, everything arose from the Logos. During the Sun's evolution, life was in the Logos. And from the living Logos, light arose during the Moon's evolution. During the Earth's evolution, the shining, living Logos produced on the Sun light in an enhanced form, while human beings remained in a state of darkness.

From the Sun, the beings who were the continuing Bull, Lion, Eagle, and Human spirits shone down as light onto the Earth, into the forms of human beings that were taking shape. Those human beings, however, were darkness and could not comprehend the light shining down upon them. We must not imagine this as physical light, but as the light that consisted of the sum of emanations from spiritual beings—the Bull, Lion, Eagle, and Human spirits—which continued the spiritual evolution of the Moon. What streamed down was spiritual light. Human beings could not receive it; they did not understand it. Their entire evolution was advanced by it, but without their being conscious of it: "The light shone in the darkness, but the darkness could not comprehend the light."

In this way, the author of the Gospel of John sets forth these great truths as paradigms. Those who knew such things have always been called "servants" or "priests of the Logos, as it was from the beginning." A priest or servant of the Logos as it was from the beginning speaks in this way. In essence,

we find exactly the same thing in the introduction to the Gospel of Luke. Try reading with proper understanding what the author of Luke says. He wishes to give an account of the things that have happened from the beginning, “as they delivered them to us, who from the beginning were eyewitnesses and servants of the Word.”
GA112

GA056
What spiritual research tells us points toward what humanity will be able to create in its own likeness in a later age: it will be the Word. A human being will speak the Word, and the Word will be a human being. This will happen when the human being has become increasingly spiritualized. By placing his physical instruments, as we have seen with the heart and larynx, in the service of his spirit, the human being spiritualizes himself and returns to spirit at the end of the Earth’s evolution. This is shown by the predecessors of human beings, the creators who began their earthly existence at the beginning of Earth’s evolution, standing where the human being will stand at its end. And one day, at the end, the human being will come into being through the Word: the human being will speak the Word at the ultimate end, and the Word will be a human being. Of those beings, the divine-spiritual beings who already stood at the beginning of Earth’s evolution at the height to which human beings will one day develop, one of the deepest religious documents, the Gospel of John, tells us correctly and appropriately: “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was a God.” Just as in the beginning the Word was, and the Word was a God, so at the ultimate end the Word will be a human being, and the human being will be the Word.
GA056

GA100
“The law was given through Moses; grace and truth came through Jesus Christ” (John 1:17). When we fully understand this passage, we also grasp the profoundly significant turning point in human history brought about by the appearance of Christ.

Throughout the period of the Old Testament, the law was understood as something that imposed order on human society from outside. After blood kinship had lost its binding force, people had to be brought into a certain relationship with one another through an external, intellectual order. The law was experienced as something coming from outside. This law given to us from outside remains in force until the grace and truth that came to us through Christ have created within us, from the inside, an understanding of true knowledge. Grace and truth can develop only gradually. Christianity, which seeks to bring grace in place of law, is still at the beginning of its becoming. As the Earth advances in its evolution, Christianity’s influence on humanity will grow stronger. Humanity is meant to rise to a level of communal life at which each person is moved from within to relate to their neighbor as brother to brother. Humanity could not rise to this high stage of development through its own power alone; it is Christianity’s task to help it do so. A person no longer needs an external law when the inner impulse leads them to act so that grace and truth guide their conduct.

In ancient times, people still used the expression: “The initiate is a divine human being.” This was based on the fact that, during the initiation ceremony, the initiate was above in the spiritual world among spiritual or divine beings. There he was the divine human being. But it was only through Christ Jesus that the “divine human being” could be seen in a physical body, never before. John 1:18—“No one has ever seen God; the only-begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, has made him known”—is therefore to be taken literally. Previously, only someone who had made the ascent could perceive the Godhead. In Christ, for the first time, the Godhead had visibly descended to Earth. This is proclaimed in John 1:14 and was also taught in the Dionysian school. Christ came to show human

beings the way; they are to become his followers and prepare to imprint what is in the etheric body into the physical body—that is, to develop the Christ-principle within themselves.
GA100

GA103
Thus, what the human being became under the influence of divine-spiritual forces and beings over the course of three planetary states was permeated by the human I once the Earth had become our present-day planet. We can say that a being came over to Earth from the ancient Moon like a kind of seed, consisting of a physical body that had arisen from the divine Primal Word, an etheric or life-body that had arisen from divine life, and an astral body that had arisen from divine light. Within this being, the light of the I itself was kindled during earthly existence. This threefold embodiment—the physical body, etheric body, and astral body—became capable of speaking "I am" within itself. In a certain sense, therefore, we can call the evolution of the Earth the evolution of "I am," of human self-consciousness. This "I am," this capacity for full self-consciousness, emerged only slowly and gradually during the evolution of earthly humanity. We must understand how earthly humanity developed as the I, full self-consciousness, slowly and gradually came into being within it.

How must an I that had matured to this extent have felt—not feeling any longer its connection with the other individual personalities of the group-soul? How must the isolated I have felt in an age when one could say: the time is past when belonging to the other people, to all the I's that belong to a group-soul, could be experienced as a living human truth. Yet the one who gives the soul the spiritual bread by which the individual I is nourished must still come. The individual I had to feel lonely, and Christ's forerunner had to say: "I am an I that has separated itself out and feels lonely. And precisely because I have learned to feel lonely, I feel myself to be a prophet, to whom the I gives the right spiritual nourishment in solitude." That is why the herald had to call himself a voice crying in the solitariness: the already isolated I, separated from the group-soul, crying out for that through which the individual I can be nourished. "I am the voice of one crying in the solitariness." Here again we hear the profound truth: every individual human I stands entirely on its own. I am the voice of the I that has become detached and seeks the ground on which it can stand as a detached I. Now we understand the passage: "I am the voice of one crying in the solitariness" (1:23).
GA103

GA097
The human being descended into the body, and through this came birth and death. The light then penetrated the darkness.

Now the human being was to be led back to an understanding that life is the victor over death. The forerunner appeared: John the Baptist. He proclaimed that the old order, still wholly marked by what the divine powers had once brought forth, would now be replaced by a new kingdom. Previously it had been said: God will destroy you if you act against his law. The new kingdom, however, is something the human being can experience within himself when he experiences God. The idea of the Old Covenant is: we must submit to God's command. The New Covenant says: the human being should follow God inwardly and voluntarily. This is love of the good. It is foretold prophetically and must increase. Christ, the representative of the New, must increase; John, who is only his forerunner, must decrease.
GA097

GA112

We see that we must make a precise distinction here. We have a high initiate who is reborn as Jesus of Nazareth, of whose birth it must be said: a child is born. Yet with this child something appears that will not be encompassed by the child's physical body. Alongside this Jesus of Nazareth, there is something that has significance in the spiritual world and will gradually develop this body upward to the point at which it is ready for this spirit. When the body was ready for this spirit, the event occurred in which the Baptist approached Jesus of Nazareth and a higher spirit descended and united with him: Christ entered into Jesus of Nazareth. Then the one who, as the Baptist, was the forerunner of Christ Jesus could say: "I came into the world. I was the one who prepared the way for a higher being. With my physical mouth I proclaimed that the kingdom of God, the kingdom of heaven, was near, and that people should change their minds. I came among people and was able to speak of a special impulse that would enter humanity. Just as the Sun rises higher in spring to announce that something new is sprouting, so I appeared to announce what is sprouting in humanity as the reborn human I!"

When the human element in Jesus of Nazareth had risen to its highest point, so that his human body expressed the spirit of Jesus of Nazareth, it had also become ready to receive Christ within itself at the baptism by John. The body of Jesus of Nazareth had unfolded like the bright Sun on the June feast of St. John. This had been foretold. Then the spirit was to be born out of darkness like the Sun, which gains ever more strength and grows and grows until St. John's Day, and then begins to wane. This was what the Baptist had to proclaim. He was to proclaim how the Sun rises in ever-greater splendor, up to the point where he could say: "The one whom the ancient prophets promised, who was called the Son of the spiritual realms, has appeared!" John the Baptist worked up to this point. Then, as the days grow shorter and darkness once again gains the upper hand, the inner light of the spirit is to shine through the preparations and grow ever brighter, as Christ shines forth in Jesus of Nazareth.

John saw Jesus of Nazareth approaching in this way. He felt the growth of Jesus of Nazareth as his own decline, and as the Sun's increase. "From now on I will decrease," he says, as the Sun wanes after St. John's Day. But he will increase—the spiritual Sun—and shine out of the darkness! This is how he announced himself. In this way began the rebirth of the human I, upon which the rebirth of every individual higher human I within humanity depends.
GA112

GA117
Those people who were prepared to know and recognize clairvoyantly what Christ truly means are called Nazarenes. Through clairvoyance they could perceive what was being prepared among the ancient Hebrew people so that Christ could be born from this people and understood. In their way of life, shaped inwardly by their clairvoyant development, these Nazarenes were bound by strict rules. Since they belonged to a very different age, these rules differed considerably from those by which spiritual knowledge is developed today, although there are certain similarities. Some things important in Nazarene practice are only secondary conditions today, while some things that were secondary then would be central today. Therefore, no one should believe that what once enabled someone to become a clairvoyant knower of Christ would, for a person today, lead to the same degree or extent of knowledge.

During the period of preparation, the Nazarene was to be brought to a very specific clairvoyant experience, intended to provide an idea of how close humanity already was to the coming of Christ. The last great Nazarene at the time of Christ is called John the Baptist. He experienced the completion of the Nazarene discipline himself and also enabled all those he wished to make fully human to experience it. This completion was nothing other than John's baptism. We must learn to understand its value for human development. What was this baptism, and what did it lead to? First, the person was

immersed in water, which loosened the etheric body slightly from the physical body around the head; ordinarily, the etheric body is firmly connected with the physical body. You know that when a person is drowning, the loosening of the etheric body suddenly causes the whole panorama of their life to appear before them. At John's baptism, the person likewise saw the panorama of their life: the characteristics of their entire life, which would otherwise have remained forgotten. They also saw what the human being truly was in that particular age. The physical body develops out of the etheric body, which shapes it. Yet this member of the human being—the one that forms the physical body—could be observed only when it was loosened from the physical body. This occurred at John's baptism.

If a person had undergone this baptism three thousand years before our era, they would have become aware that the best spiritual gift that could be given to human beings had to come as an ancient inheritance, for what had been given from the spiritual worlds in ancient times was, in effect, still an inheritance. This existed as an image in the etheric body and shaped the physical body. Even in those who had developed beyond ordinary humanity, the baptism would have shown that all their knowledge was based on ancient inspiration. This was described as seeing the etheric nature of the soul in the form of a serpent. Those who experienced this were called children of the serpent because they had seen how Luciferic beings had descended into human beings. That which shaped the physical body was a creature of the serpent.

But at a baptism by John not three thousand years before John the Baptist, but in his own time, something quite different became apparent: among those being baptized were people whose nature showed that human evolution had advanced, and that the I, fertilized by the outer world, had acquired great power. A very different image appeared from the one seen at earlier baptisms by John: people no longer saw the creative forces of the etheric body in the image of the serpent, but in the image of the Lamb. This etheric body was no longer permeated from within by what came from Luciferic forces; instead, it was wholly devoted to the spiritual world, which shines into the human soul through the phenomena of the outer world. Seeing the Lamb was the experience at John's baptism of those who could truly understand what the baptism meant at that time. They were also able to say that the human being had become entirely different, a new being. The few who experienced this at John's baptism could say: "A great and mighty event has taken place; the human being has become different; the I has now gained dominion on Earth!" The people John baptized had been prepared to understand the signs of the times and to recognize that such a great event had occurred.

Thus, those who adhere only to the law, as it came from Sinai—the Pharisees and Sadducees—are in danger of remaining stationary in their development. They are the ones who do not wish to see the Lamb at John's baptism, but the serpent.
GA117

GA124
The human being has thinking, feeling, and willing; these various soul-faculties are, so to speak, the servants of the soul. But there is one master in the soul, a kyrios: the I. This is expressed by the fact that we do not merely say, "It thinks within us." In ancient times one could not say, "I think"; instead, one said, "It thinks." And with regard to feeling and willing, one said likewise, "It feels," and "It wills" in there.

At the time when the master of the soul-faculties, the I, began to assert itself, this great turning point in human evolution was experienced in such a way that people now said: "I think, I feel, I will." In earlier times, souls were, as it were, in a certain subconscious state, trapped and submerged in the serving forces. Now the master of the soul-faculties, the I, was approaching. This passage does not initially

refer to any particular personality or being, but only to the emergence of the I as master within the whole structure of the soul: the master within the soul is coming!

When we look at the astral body, we find various forces in the soul. We usually call them thinking, feeling, and willing. The soul thinks, feels, and wills. These are the three forces active in the soul, but they are its serving forces. As the human being progressed in evolution, these forces—which had formerly been the masters, to whose promptings the human being had to surrender, waiting to see whether thinking, feeling, or willing would be called forth—were placed under the authority of the κύριος (Kyrios), the master of the soul-faculties, the I. When the word was used in reference to the soul, it meant nothing other than the I, which no longer held to the old understanding that "the divine-spiritual thinks, feels, and wills in me," but instead declared: "I think, I feel, I will." The master makes itself felt in the soul-faculties.

"Prepare yourselves, you human souls, to tread such paths of the soul that you awaken within it the strong I, κύριος (Kyrios), the master in your soul. Hear how it calls in the solitude of the soul. Prepare the power, or the direction, of the soul's master, the I. Open its powers!" This is approximately how the words must be translated: make it open so that it can enter, so that it is no longer the slave of thinking, feeling, and willing; open its powers! If you translate the words as, "Behold, the I-ness sends its angel before you, who is to give you the possibility of understanding how it calls in the solitude of the astral soul; prepare the directions of the I, open the powers for it—for the I!" then you have the meaning of these significant words of the prophet Isaiah. You have an indication of the greatest event in human evolution. You understand from this how Isaiah speaks of John the Baptist and points to the longing of the solitude of the human soul for the arrival of the master within the soul, the I. Only then do these words become as solid as bronze and iron; this is how we must understand them.

And why could John the Baptist be the bearer of the Angelos? He could because he had undergone a very particular initiation. Initiations, in fact, are specialized. They are not general or undifferentiated; they are specialized. For individuals with a very particular task, initiation must take place in a very particular way. Everything that happens in the spiritual world is provided for, so that spiritual facts are shown in star-writing in the heavens. One can receive the Sun initiation—that is, enter the mysteries of the spiritual world that is the world of Ahura Mazda, for which the Sun is the outward expression. But one can be initiated into the Sun mysteries in twelve different ways. Every initiation is, in a certain respect, a Sun initiation, yet each differs in its relation to the other eleven.

Depending on the task a person has for all humanity, that person receives an initiation of which one can say: this is a Sun initiation, but one whose forces flow in as if the Sun stood in the sign of Cancer. This differs from a Sun initiation in which the forces flow as if the Sun stood in Libra. These are expressions for differently specialized initiations. Individuals with as high a task and mission as the one described here for John the Baptist must be initiated in a very special way, because only through such an initiation can they possess the powerful strength to carry out their mission in the world, even in a one-sided way when necessary.

John the Baptist therefore received the Sun initiation that may be called the initiation from the sign of Aquarius. Just as the Sun stands in Aquarius, this is a symbol of the kind of initiation John received in order to become the bearer of the angel, taking in the Sun's force as it flows in when the Sun's relation to the other stars is described by saying that it stands in Aquarius. This was the symbol. John had the Aquarius initiation. The sign even acquired the name Aquarius because the person who had this initiation, as a spiritual initiation, had a special ability to do with people what John did as the "Aquarius," the baptizer: to bring them, by immersing them under water, to a point where their etheric body was sufficiently released that they could attain self-knowledge and recognize what was most important in that era.

The people were submerged, and for a moment the etheric body was released. Through baptism in the Jordan, a person could feel the particular importance of this epoch in world history. John was therefore

initiated into this very baptismal initiation. Because the symbolic expression was the flowing of the Sun's rays from the sign in which it stood, the sign was also called Aquarius. Thus a human capacity was given a name and then transferred upward to the heavens.

John the Baptist's vision was trained so that at night he could see through the material Earth to the constellation of Aquarius. He had therefore received the initiation called the Aquarius initiation, at the moment when the Angelos took possession of his soul. John the Baptist, with everything he himself knew and felt, could make all his faculties available to the Angelos, so that the Angelos could express everything contained in the Aquarius initiation and everything that pointed to the coming rule of the I, the κύριος (Kyrios), the master in the soul. This was what the Aquarius initiation provided.

At the same time, John the Baptist indicated that the time had come when this Aquarius initiation stood at a transition and had to be replaced by another, so that the approaching rule of the I could be fully understood. He therefore told his intimate disciples: "I am the one able to make available to my angel all the powers that come from the Aquarius initiation. But after me someone must come who can make the later powers available to his angel."

If you follow the Sun's direction by day from the constellation of Aries through Taurus, Gemini, and so on to Virgo, then by night you must follow the direction from Libra and Aquarius toward Pisces; this is the direction of the spiritual Sun. John had received the Aquarius initiation and indicated that the one who was to come would have the Pisces initiation—the initiation that had to follow John's and was regarded as higher. John the Baptist thus told his intimate disciples: "Through the Aquarius initiation I can make available to my angel only the powers that allow him to proclaim that the Lord, the κύριος (Kyrios), is coming. But someone will come who has the powers symbolized by the initiation of the constellation Pisces. And he will receive the Christ!"

In this way John the Baptist pointed to Jesus of Nazareth. That is why ancient traditions gave Christ Jesus the symbol of the fishes. And because everything that happens outwardly is a symbol of inner processes, even when it also happens outwardly, fishers are assigned as helpers to the one initiated through the fish. These are at once outward historical events and deeply symbolic actions pointing to spiritual mysteries.

If we draw the Sun's arc across the sky, we discover that as the physical Sun descends, its spiritual counterpart rises. We must therefore draw the daytime or summer arc of the Sun, which moves from Taurus to Aries and onward, and the winter or nighttime arc, through which we can indicate the mysteries of the Aquarius and Pisces initiations. Physically, the movement goes from Virgo to Leo, Cancer, Gemini, Taurus, and Aries; spiritually, it goes from Virgo to Libra, Scorpio, Sagittarius, Capricorn, Aquarius, and Pisces. The spiritual counterpart of the physical course of the Sun is the Sun's passage from Aquarius to Pisces.

Thus John could say: "He must increase, but I must decrease." My mission is such that you can picture it when the Sun moves from Aquarius to Pisces. I am an initiate of Aquarius, and I am not worthy to give you the mystery of the solar Pisces. I am not worthy to untie the shoe straps of the one whom I must announce to you.

Through John, the angels spoke—beings one level above humanity. Through Christ, the powers of the Dominions spoke, in the way described as speaking through natural events. These were the powers that suffused Christ's body and made him preach "with power."

John the Baptist had received the highest initiation, which took place under the sign of Aquarius. In the ancient signs of the zodiac, the figure of Aquarius bends forward with a certain position of the arms. This relates to the biblical words: "One is coming after me, whose sandals I am not worthy to stoop down and untie."
GA124

GA175
On the occasion when John the Baptist performs the baptism, he says that the kingdoms of heaven, or the kingdom of God, are near. Here we have this idea. And what does John the Baptist do? The whole context makes it clear: because the kingdoms of heaven, the kingdom of God, are near, he does the following. He baptizes with water, as he himself explains. He baptizes with water for the forgiveness of sins, and he foretells that someone will come who will baptize with the Holy Spirit. What is the difference between the baptism performed by John the Baptist and the baptism of which he speaks, the baptism with the Holy Spirit?

What, ultimately, is the water with which John baptizes? Outwardly, of course, it is the water of the Jordan. But we know that those being baptized were completely submerged, so that during the immersion a kind of loosening of the etheric body from the physical body took place, allowing them for a moment to see clairvoyantly. This was the real meaning of John's baptism and of similar baptisms. Yet when John speaks of baptism with water, he means more than this. Above all, he points to the passage in the Old Testament that says: "The Spirit of God hovered over the waters." What was to be achieved by baptism in the Jordan? Through the loosening of the etheric body and everything that happened to them, the baptized were to feel in their consciousness that they had been carried back to the time before what is called the Fall. Everything that had happened since the Fall was, as it were, to be erased from their consciousness; they were to be returned to the original state of innocence so that they could see what the human being had been before the Fall.

The baptized were meant to understand that through the Fall humanity had taken a wrong path, and that continuing along it could not end well. Humanity had to turn back to the beginning, as it were tearing out of the soul everything that had entered it through this wrong path.

Here we must understand what we said last time about souls that had become worse and worse since the Fall, increasingly less suited to be what they should be for the human body, and which had, in a sense, become ever more corrupted. This could continue for a certain stretch of Earth's evolution, but it had to come to an end when the whole course of Earth's evolution was seized by the evolution of heaven—when heavenly evolution took hold of earthly evolution. People such as John foresaw prophetically that the time was coming when souls could no longer be saved in the old way; they would have to perish unless something special occurred.

Either souls had to withdraw from all life since original sin, which had brought about their corruption —in which case Earth's evolution would have been in vain—or something else had to happen. John the Baptist expressed this by saying that someone would come who would baptize with the Holy Spirit. John could save people from the consequences of the Fall only by pulling them out of the world. Christ Jesus wanted to save them in a different way: to leave them in the world and nevertheless save them. He did not want to return them to the time before the Fall, but to let them continue through the further stages of Earth's evolution while still allowing them to participate in the kingdom of heaven.
GA175

GA112
Human beings had increasingly come to love the physical world, to find one another in the physical world, and to believe more and more that the physical is what is truly real. Those who came to the Baptist, however, experienced their own life as spiritual. When they had been baptized, they knew: "I am something more than what I am through my physical body." Human perception had gradually developed in such a way that it was directed toward the physical world. Through his baptismal candidates, John awakened the awareness that a spiritual world exists and that a higher part of oneself belongs to it.

So if you put his preaching into other words, it means: "Change the direction of your mind, which is turned toward the physical world!" Those who truly received the baptism changed their outlook. They

then knew: “There is something spiritual within me; my I belongs to the spiritual world.” They gained this conviction while remaining within the physical body. No special procedure like initiation had taken place. They experienced it in the physical body. And the way the whole teaching that had existed since Moses’ proclamation was received and united with the soul gave the experience of John’s baptism an additional meaning.

After baptism, people did not merely have the awareness, “I am one with the spiritual world”; they also recognized which spiritual world was approaching the Earth. Such a person knew that what had revealed itself to Moses as “Ehyeh asher ehyeh” in the burning bush and in the fire on Sinai was permeating the Earth. The spiritual world was rightly expressed by the name Yahweh or Jehovah, or “Ehyeh asher ehyeh,” meaning “I am the I-am.” Through John’s baptism, therefore, a person knew not only that they were one with the spiritual world, but also: “In this spiritual world lives the I-am, from whom I have been born in spirit.” John had prepared his baptismal candidates by awakening this feeling and experience. Naturally, only a few could experience it; most were not mature enough to do so while submerged. But some recognized that the Spirit was drawing near—the one later called the Christ.

The ancient spiritual beings had fostered a love founded on blood ties and physical community. The Luciferic spirits, however, sought to place each person on the basis of their own personality and individuality. Lucifer and the higher spiritual beings had worked together. Gradually, the old bonds of blood loosened; this can be traced historically. Consider the mixture of peoples in the great Roman Empire. It had come about because the old blood ties had weakened and each person wanted, more or less, to stand on the firm ground of their own personality. But people had thereby also lost their connection with the spiritual world, had grown together with the physical world, and had developed a love for the physical plane. As self-awareness increased through Lucifer, humanity became more closely bound to the physical world, and life between death and a new birth became impoverished.

John the Baptist had already prepared something great and significant for humanity. He prepared people to remain within their own personality and, within that personality, to find through immersion in water what they had once experienced as “gods”—when they themselves still lived in water, when water vapors and mists permeated the atmosphere. That experience in the divine worlds was now repeated. Although the human being had become an I, they were prepared to be led again, as human beings, to other human beings, and to be brought once more into a love that had become spiritualized.
From another side, this characterizes the core of the Christ event. Christ represents the descent into the Earth of the spiritual power of love, whose work is only now beginning.

The person immersed in water by John did not need to be an initiate. Through the baptism, however, they could learn the connection between their individuality—their existence as a personality—and the great Father-Spirit of the world. Only a few could achieve this result. Most had to accept the baptism merely as a symbol, something that helped them, under the significant influence of John the Baptist’s teaching, to believe in the existence of the God Yahweh. Among those immersed, however, were some who had prepared themselves in earlier incarnations to learn certain things through their own observation. Nevertheless, the state into which a person was brought by John’s baptism was an abnormal one.

John baptized with water, and this had the effect of separating the etheric body from the physical body for a short time. But John the Baptist wished to be the forerunner of the one “who baptizes with fire and with the Spirit.” Baptism with fire and the Spirit came to Earth through Christ. What, then, is the difference between John’s water baptism and Christ’s baptism with fire and Spirit?

Ancient initiation proceeded in the following way. First, the person learned in full all that we today learn in anthroposophy. This was the preparation for the old initiation. Then everything was brought to a certain conclusion. This conclusion was achieved by the candidate resting in a tomb for three and a half days, as if dead. When the etheric body had been lifted out and the person traveled through the

spiritual world in that etheric body, they became a witness to the spiritual world. At that time it was necessary to lift out the etheric body so that the person could behold the spiritual world through its forces. Formerly, these forces were not available in the ordinary waking state; the person had to be brought into an abnormal state of consciousness.

Christ also brought this power to Earth for initiation, because today a person can become clairvoyant without the etheric body leaving the physical body. When a person becomes mature enough to receive so strong an impulse from Christ that, even if only briefly, it can influence the circulation of the blood and express itself in a particular pattern of blood circulation—an influence extending into the physical body—then that person can be initiated within the physical body. The Christ impulse makes this possible.

Whoever can immerse themselves deeply enough in the events that took place in Palestine and in the Mystery of Golgotha—so that these events become inwardly alive and present, working like a force that communicates itself to the circulation of the blood—attains through this experience what was formerly attained by the etheric body's leaving the physical body.

Thus, through the Christ impulse, something entered the world that enables the human being to act upon what makes the blood pulse within. No abnormal event and no immersion in water is required; what works here is solely the powerful influence of the Christ individuality. One is not baptized with some material substance perceptible to the senses, but with spiritual influence, without any change in ordinary everyday consciousness. Through the Spirit that has flowed forth as the Christ impulse, something enters the body that otherwise could be brought about only through physical and physiological development: through fire, an inner fire expressed in the circulation of the blood.

John still immersed people in water; the etheric body then emerged, and the person could look into the spiritual world. But when a person allows the Christ impulse to work, it acts so that the experiences of the astral body pour into the etheric body and the person becomes clairvoyant.

Here, then, is the explanation of the expression "to baptize through the Spirit and through fire," and the difference between John's baptism and Christ's baptism as it corresponds to the facts. The Christ impulse made a new class of initiates possible. In earlier times there were a few people among humanity who were pupils of the great teachers and were led into the Mysteries. Their etheric bodies were lifted out so that they could become witnesses of the Spirit, come before others, and say: "There is a spiritual world—we have seen it ourselves! Just as you see plants and stones, we have seen the spiritual world!" These were the "eyewitnesses." Those who emerged from the depths of the Mysteries could proclaim the gospel of the Spirit, though from ancient wisdom.

Whereas they led people back to a wisdom from which humanity had originally emerged, Christ made possible initiates who could observe the spiritual world while remaining within the physical body and ordinary consciousness. Through the Christ impulse, they recognized the same truth that had become clear to the ancient initiates: that a spiritual world exists. They could then proclaim the gospel of this spiritual world themselves. To become an initiate and proclaim the gospel of the spiritual world in the new, Christ-centered sense, the power present in Christ had to flow over to another person, who would become a pupil and a proclaimer of this power. When did such a Christ-initiated person first arise?

In the progress of evolution, the old must always be joined with the new. Christ therefore had to lead the old initiation gradually into the new, creating a transition. He still had to take account of certain processes of the old initiation, but everything that came from the old gods had to be permeated by the being of Christ. Christ initiated the disciple who would later communicate the gospel of Christ to the world in the deepest way. Such an initiation lies hidden behind a story in the Gospel of John: the story of Lazarus, in chapter 11.

According to clairvoyant observation of the life of the founder of Christianity, we must distinguish two aspects. First, we must consider the life of the great initiate whom we call Jesus of Nazareth. Within Jesus of Nazareth lived an I that, as we have shown, had passed through many previous incarnations, had repeatedly lived on Earth, and had risen higher in each life, gradually developing the capacity for the great sacrifice. This sacrifice consisted in the fact that, around his thirtieth year, the I of Jesus of Nazareth could leave the physical body, etheric body, and astral body, which it had purified and ennobled up to that point. A threefold human sheath was thus left behind: a pure and excellent human sheath consisting of the physical, etheric, and astral bodies.

At the baptism by John, while the I of Jesus of Nazareth departed from these sheaths, they received the being that had not previously been on Earth and that had not passed through earlier incarnations. The Christ being is one that, before this, could be found only in the world beyond our Earth. Only at this moment of John's baptism did this individuality unite with a human body for three years and walk on Earth, to accomplish during those three years what we must continue to characterize.

What I have just said is the result of clairvoyant observation. The Evangelists clothe this fact in their account of John's baptism. They mean to say that, while this or that happened to the various people who received John's baptism, the event that occurred in Jesus of Nazareth was that the Christ descended into his three sheaths. I have already said in the first lecture that this Christ is the same being of whom the Old Testament says: "And the Spirit of God moved—or brooded—over the waters" (Genesis 1:2). This same Spirit, the divine Spirit of our solar system, entered the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth.

What, then, happened at John's baptism? As we have said, the I of Jesus of Nazareth emerged from the physical, etheric, and astral bodies, leaving this threefold sheath for the Christ being. We may schematically depict what remained of Jesus of Nazareth as the physical body, etheric body, and astral body. The I left the physical body. In place of the I of Jesus of Nazareth, the Christ being entered this threefold sheath—essentially, and above all, the physical body.

I say "essentially" because, of course, everything in the human being interpenetrates, so one can also say that the I is in the etheric body, and so on. That is indirectly true, but the main point is as I have described it.

At the same moment that the Spirit of Christ descended into the body of Jesus of Nazareth and the transformation we have described took place, an effect was also exerted upon the mother of Jesus of Nazareth. At that moment of John's baptism, she regained her virginity—that is, her inner organization became as it had been before the female body reached sexual maturity. The mother of Jesus of Nazareth became a virgin at the birth of the Christ.

The human being who had served as the sheath of Jesus of Nazareth thus came under the rule of Christ. Christ's will, his free will, penetrated through this rule into the skeletal system, so that for the first time he could act within it. The significance of this can be described as follows: humanity acquired on Earth the form it now has through its skeletal system, not during an earlier embodiment of our planet. But humanity would lose this form if the spiritual power we call Christ had not come. Human beings would carry nothing but the harvest and fruit of Earth into the future if Christ's dominion over the skeletal system had not occurred. Something of tremendous force therefore penetrated the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth at the moment of John's baptism, right into its innermost marrow. We must picture this moment inwardly, for this was one of the things that happened.

Until the baptism of Christ Jesus by John, there had never been, anywhere in Earth's evolution—among initiates or non-initiates—a human individuality powerful enough to reach into the chemical and physical processes of the skeletal system. Through Christ's entry into the body of Jesus of Nazareth, the present-day I of Christ became ruler even over the skeletal system. As a result, a body once lived on Earth that was able to master its forces so as to incorporate the spiritual form of the skeletal system into

Earth's evolution. Nothing of what humanity experiences during Earth's evolution would remain if humanity could not incorporate the noble form of its skeletal system as a law of Earth's evolution, gradually becoming master of that law.
GA112

GA103
Symbolic and historical at the same time—not only one or the other: that is what genuine interpretation of the Gospels is about. In almost all the events and indications, we shall see that John, or the writer of the Gospel of John, who truly sees through supersensible perception, also sees the events and the revelation of profound spiritual truths. He has in mind the historical figure of John the Baptist and looks toward that historical figure; yet the historical figure is also a symbol for all people in ancient times who were already called to imprint the I into themselves, but were only on the way toward doing so. The light of the world could shine into their individual I, but not into those who were not yet able to comprehend it in their darkness. What appeared in Christ Jesus as life, light, and Logos had always shone in the world; but those who were still maturing had not recognized it. The light was always there, for without it the capacity for the I could never have arisen. On the Moon, the human being of today had only a physical body, an etheric body, and an astral body; there was no I within. Only because the light had transformed itself into the way it shines on Earth did it gain the power to kindle individual I's and gradually bring them to maturity: "The light shone in the darkness, but the darkness could not comprehend it" (1:5). It came "into individual human beings"—it reached those who had an I, for people with an I could never have arisen unless the Logos had poured into them. "But the people with an I did not receive it." Only a few received it: the initiates, who rose into spiritual worlds. They were always called "children of God" because they had knowledge of the Logos, of light and life, and could always bear witness to it. A few had always known of spiritual worlds through the ancient Mysteries. What lived in them? That which is eternal in the human being lived in them, consciously. Even before the great saying, "I and the Father are one" (10:30), they had an intimation of it: I and the great primal ground are one! The deepest thing they carried in consciousness—their own I—did not come from father and mother; they received it through initiation into the spiritual world. They had it not from blood, flesh, or the will of a father or mother, but "from God," that is, from the spiritual world. This explains the words that the great majority of people, although already possessing the capacity to become I-beings, did not receive the light. It had indeed descended as far as the group-I, but individuals did not receive it. Those who did receive it—and they were few—could become children of God through it; those who trusted it became so through initiation. This gives us a clear picture. Yet for all people with earthly senses to recognize the God who was present, he had to appear on Earth in a form visible to bodily eyes; that is, he had to take on flesh, since only bodily eyes can see such a form. Previously, only initiates in the Mysteries could see him. Now, for the salvation of all, he took on bodily form: "The Word, or Logos, became flesh" (1:14). In this way the writer of the Gospel of John connects the historical appearance of Christ Jesus with the whole course of evolution. "We have heard his teaching, the teaching of the Father's only-begotten Son" (1:14). What kind of teaching is this? What, then, are the other people who are born?

In ancient times, when the Gospels were written, those born of the flesh were called "twice-born." They were called twice-born, so to speak, because of the mingling of the blood of father and mother. What is not born of the flesh, not brought about by human agency or by the mingling of blood, is "born of God"; it is "only-begotten." Those who were formerly called "children of God" had always, in a certain sense, been the "only-begotten"; and the teaching about the Son of God is the teaching about the "Only-Begotten." The physical human being is the "twice-born"; the spiritual human being is the "only-begotten." Do not understand this as meaning "born into" something: "only-begotten" is the opposite of "twice-born." The word indicates that, in addition to physical birth, a person can undergo spiritual birth—the union with spirit, the birth through which one becomes an only-begotten child or son of the Godhead. Such teaching could be heard only through the one who represented the Word made flesh. Through him it became universal: "the teaching of the Father's only-begotten Son, filled with devotion and truth" (1:14). "Devotion" would be better translated here, for the point is that one is born out of the Godhead while remaining united with it and, at the same time, having all illusion

removed. Illusion arises only from being twice-born and surrounds people with sensory deceptions. This contrasts with the one teaching that brings truth in Christ Jesus, who stood and dwelt among people as the embodied Logos. John called himself—this is the literal meaning—the forerunner, the predecessor, the one who goes ahead to proclaim the I. John describes himself as one who knew that the I must become independent within each individual, but who had to bear witness to the one who would come to bring this about. He said plainly that the one who would come is the eternal "I AM," who can truly say of himself: "Before Abraham was, I AM." John could say: The I of which we speak existed before me; although I am his forerunner, he is also my predecessor. I bear witness to what was present in every human being before me: "The one who comes after me existed before me" (1:15).

Now significant words are spoken: "For from his fullness we have all received grace upon grace" (1:16). Many people call themselves Christians but read over the word "fullness," without giving it any precise meaning. In Greek, "pleroma" means "fullness." The Gospel of John says: "From the Pleroma we have all received grace upon grace!" I have said that if one is to understand the Gospel of John at all, every word must be weighed as if on a gold scale. What is the Pleroma, the fullness? Only someone who knows that in the ancient Mysteries the Pleroma or fullness referred to something quite specific can understand it. The teaching then held that when the spiritual beings who had risen to divinity during the ancient Moon first manifested—the Elohim—one separated from the others. One remained on the Moon and radiated back the power of love from there, until human beings had matured sufficiently for the light of the other six Elohim. Thus people distinguished Yahweh, the individual god who reflected the light back, from the fullness of the Godhead consisting of six: the "Pleroma." Since Christ means the total consciousness of the Solar Logos, one had to speak of the fullness of the gods when pointing to him. This profound truth lies behind the words: "For from the Pleroma we have all received grace upon grace."

Let us now return in thought to the age of group-souls, when an individual felt the I as a group-I. Consider the social order that existed within the group. Insofar as they were visible people, human beings lived as individuals. They felt the group-I, but to the senses they were separate individuals. Because they did not yet experience themselves as individuals, they could not yet fully possess love inwardly. One person loved another because they were related by blood. Blood relationship was the basis of all love. Blood relatives loved one another first, and love arising from blood relationship also extended beyond sexual love. People must increasingly free themselves from this group-soul love and offer love as a free gift of the I. At the end of Earth's evolution, human beings will attain a time when the I, having become independent, feels within its innermost being a wholehearted impulse to do what is right and good. Because the I has this impulse, it does what is right and good. When love has become so spiritualized that no one wishes to do anything other than what is right, then what Christ Jesus sought to bring into the world will have been fulfilled. One of the mysteries of Christianity is this teaching: Look to Christ, fill yourselves with the power of his being, and try to become like him and follow him. Then your liberated I will become such that it needs no law; as a being free in its innermost nature, it will do what is good and right. Thus Christ brings the impulse toward freedom from the law, so that good is done not because of the law, but through the impulse of love living within.

This impulse will need the whole remainder of Earth's time to develop. Christ Jesus made the beginning, and the figure of Christ will always be the power that leads human beings toward this goal.
In earlier times, those who were initiated were brought to higher organs of spiritual perception. Before then, no one had seen a god with physical eyes. The only-begotten Son, however, appeared in a physical form so that people could see him with their bodily eyes.

In occult terminology, the human being who lies in bed today is called the actual earthly human being. That was "the human being." But the being in whom the I dwells day and night, although it is not always conscious of itself, is the higher human being.
GA103

GA100

The Spirit-Self is equivalent to the Holy Spirit, which, in Christian terms, is the guiding being on the astral plane. The Life-Spirit is called the “Word” by Christians.

Those who had brought the Spirit-Self to birth within themselves were called “children of God”; in them “the light shone in the darkness,” and “they received the light.” Outwardly, however, they were still human beings like everyone else.

Since the Consciousness-Soul is the principle in which the Spirit-Self has developed, it is called the “Mother of Christ,” or, in the mystery schools, the “Virgin Sophia.”

In fact, the human being is the firstborn of Earth. Humanity has developed along a direct line, leaving the other beings behind at the various stages.

If we consider the point at which birds and reptiles branched off, we see that physical human forms were indeed present then, forms resembling those of later reptiles.

The seer looks back to that distant time when the spiritual being of the human being had not yet taken possession of its body. The human form then resembled forms that later developed into reptiles.
GA100

GA353
The Gospels tell us that Jesus had himself baptized in the Jordan by John. At that moment a dove descended. This dove points to the influence of the Sun. And the fact that it descended in this way is meant to show that a new spiritual influence was entering the Earth.

Let us return to the people of the ancient Orient. Anyone could say then: Throughout life the Sun influences the human being; a new being enters the human being through this influence.

What, then, had to take the place of worship of the Sun? In ancient times, before the age of the Jews, people worshipped the Sun because they knew that life and spiritual forces came to human beings from the Sun.
GA353

GA103
Let us consider that, although what precedes the raising of Lazarus conveys tremendously important things, the writer does not turn to the actual event until later.

A person initiated into the first degree mediates between occult and outward life and is sent back and forth between them. At this first stage, the person has begun to overcome the purely personal element. Especially in ancient times, a person stood within their community and therefore felt themselves, even when aware of their I, more as a member of a group-soul. But the person who had undergone initiation began to extend this awareness beyond the group.

“This is a true Israelite!” (1:47)

Here the person is designated by the name of a people. Just as among the Persians a fifth-degree initiate was called a “Persian,” so among the Israelites such a person was called an “Israelite.”

“Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you!” (1:48)

This is a symbolic designation for an initiate, just as the Buddha’s sitting beneath the Bodhi tree is symbolic. The fig tree is a symbol of Egyptian-Chaldean initiation.

“Nathanael answered him: ‘Rabbi, you are the Son of God; you are a king in Israel.’” (1:49)

The word “king” in this phrase means: You are higher than I am, for otherwise you could not say, “When you were sitting under the fig tree, I saw you.” Christ then indicates that Nathanael will recognize still greater things.

“You believe because I told you that I saw you under the fig tree; you will see greater things than these.” (1:50)

We shall discuss the words “truly, truly” later. Then he says:

“I tell you, you will see the angels of heaven ascending and descending upon the Son of Man!” (1:51)

Those who are able to recognize Christ will see things greater than what they have already seen. What significant words these are!

To explain this, let us recall what the human being essentially is. We have said that a person is different by day and by night. By day, the physical body and etheric body are connected in a particular way; at night, the astral body and I withdraw from them. The human being therefore lives in different states of consciousness. The development of higher consciousness changes the relationship among these members of the human being, allowing spiritual realities to be perceived.
GA103

GA100
The physical human being is born through the union of two people. The higher human being can be born only from a Consciousness-Soul that embraces an entire people. In all peoples, the possibility of this higher birth is connected with the development of the soul beyond the merely individual.
GA100

GA094
I would like to name once again the seven stages of initiation found in the Persian Mithras initiation. This was a form of initiation widespread throughout western Asia, including the regions around the Mediterranean. The seven degrees were symbolized by the Raven, the Occult One, the Fighter, the Lion, the Persian, the Solar Hero, and the Father.

The second degree was that of the “Occult One.” This was the name given to those who had been entrusted with several important and essential occult secrets.

The third degree was that of the “Fighter.” These were initiates in whom the higher self had been felt so strongly that sayings of this kind became meaningful: “Even if you fight, you are not the fighter.” Only when a person has reached a certain stage of development do they understand this sentence fully. Even interests ordinarily regarded as higher then fall away, becoming lower interests and mere servants of the fighter.

The fourth degree is reached when complete inner harmony and calm, balance, and strength have been attained. This stage of initiation is called the degree of the “Lion.” Such an initiate has realized the occult life within so fully that they may stand up for the occult not only in words but also through deeds.

The consciousness of a person who passes through these four stages continues to expand. It identifies with ever larger groups of people. These expressions also have a hidden meaning. Consider the term “the occult one.” What concerns us in an ordinary person is what exists within that individual. As a Raven, an initiate of the first degree, a person seeks to overcome what is merely personal; their interests then broaden. What those around them are, what they feel and want, becomes that person’s own feeling and will as well. These terms were coined in times when human communities were

regarded as clans or extended families. People thought of a clan or family as members of a soul-family extending back to a common ancestral couple. Such a clan was seen as the members of a hidden I, the members of a soul-family.

Anyone initiated into the second degree, the Occult One, had refined their I until it embraced the I of their community, making its interests their own. The occult life of a human community could live within them. The community whose I the initiate made their own became their dwelling place. The Fighter fought for the larger community. In ancient Palestine, a person who had risen to take into themselves the consciousness and I of an entire tribe was called a "Lion." "The Lion of the tribe of Judah" is an expression for someone who had reached an initiation stage at which they had taken in the I of the whole tribe.

The fifth-degree initiate had overcome their personality to such an extent that they could take the soul of a people into themselves. The spirit of the people lived within them. In Persia such an initiate was called a "Persian"; in Greece, such an initiate would have been called a "Greek," had that been customary. What does this degree mean? Everything individual has disappeared for the initiate, and their consciousness has become identical with the whole. This is a higher consciousness.
It is a higher consciousness.

Today the situation is different. The fragmentation of communities is leading us toward quite different stages of initiation. But this still had significance when Christianity arose, when souls initiated into the fifth degree were spoken of. You can see this in the Gospel of John. Please read chapter 1, verse 45:

"Philip finds Nathanael and says to him: 'We have found the one of whom Moses in the Law and the prophets wrote: Jesus, son of Joseph, from Nazareth.' Nathanael said to him: 'Can anything good come out of Nazareth?' Philip says to him: 'Come and see!' Jesus saw Nathanael coming toward him and said: 'Behold, a true Israelite, in whom there is no deceit.'"

Nathanael is described here as an initiate of the fifth degree. He has therefore come to know what constitutes the power of life for us human beings: the Tree of Life. Earlier, one partakes of the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge. A person partakes of the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge when they become able to say "I" of themselves at all. But when the higher, spiritual element awakens in a person, God may seek to protect them. Yahweh's concern was that after human beings had partaken of the Tree of Knowledge, they should not also partake of the Tree of Life, for they were not yet ready. The fifth-degree initiate, however, learns what allays this concern and raises one above death and transience: the spiritual element.

How can this spiritual element take root in a human being? For anyone who studies Theosophy more deeply, this spiritual element is something that permeates the whole world. To one who can see into higher worlds, everything that is initially an inner stage of development also appears as an image on higher planes, first on the astral plane. When a person reaches the fifth degree of initiation, they continually see an image on the astral plane that they did not see before: the image of a tree, a white tree with spreading branches. This image on the astral plane, which you should regard as a symbol of the fifth degree of initiation, is called the Tree of Life. Of the person who has reached this stage, it is said that they sat beneath the Tree of Life. Thus the Buddha sat beneath the Bodhi tree and Nathanael beneath the fig tree. These are expressions for images on the astral plane. What can be seen there reflects inner processes that are now also bodily inner processes. The Bodhi tree is nothing other than the astral reflection of the human nervous system. Through initiation, the person who can turn their gaze inward sees their inner life, including its bodily aspects, reflected in the astral outer world. You can see what this chapter of the Gospel of John intends to say: Nathanael is addressed as someone who understands these matters. The message is: we recognize one another. "Jesus said to him: Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you." That means: we are brothers of the fifth degree of initiation. It is a recognition scene between initiates. "Nathanael said to him: Rabbi, you are the Son of God; you are the King of Israel." You see that recognition has taken place. Jesus

immediately answers that he will prove to be not only an initiate of the fifth degree, but something more. He says: “You believe because I told you that I saw you under the fig tree; you will see greater things than these!”

That is, he will see what illuminates his four states of consciousness. The human being becomes a ladder on which the angels of God can be seen ascending and descending.

The initiate of the sixth degree is the Solar Hero. Just as the Sun itself cannot deviate from its course, neither can this initiate.

The seventh stage is that of the Father. It is union with the primal Spirit.

The “Persian” therefore bears the name of the whole people; the individual soul becomes the soul of the people. The image expressing this stage of initiation is sitting beneath a tree. You will find this expression throughout occult language. The Buddha, for example, sits beneath the Bodhi tree. A tree grows from one seed and becomes many branches. The same process occurs in the initiate, who has gained the ability to enter into each individual soul. What, then, would such a person be called among the Israelites? Naturally, an “Israelite.” As we have seen, Jesus recognizes Nathanael as an initiate of the fifth degree, one who has attained the consciousness of a people. Nathanael recognizes Christ as an initiate of a higher degree: “Rabbi, you are the Son of God.” Christ is an initiate of the seventh degree, whose consciousness has expanded to the Father: “I (or the I AM) and the Father (or the Divine) are one.” He is the life and light of humanity, for he has brought his high consciousness into the physical body.

The first five stages of initiation are passed through as the candidate ascends or descends on the astral plane. It makes no difference which direction is taken, for here the Hermetic principle applies: as above, so below. Everything spiritual has its counterpart in the physical. If you ascend in this way to the astral plane, you enter into the soul of a people, for it lives on the astral plane.

The sixth stage is equivalent to the preceding five combined: here the human being rises in the etheric body and develops it. One people always emerges from another because the astral body changes; astral beings stand behind the soul of every people. The etheric body of humanity and of the individual, however, remains unchanged from one people to another; a new etheric body arises only in the transition from one race to another. Even the physical body is subject to change. The ancient Atlanteans had a very different physical body, and the earliest Lemurians did not yet have a true physical body at all. The Solar Hero embraces an entire human race in consciousness, as if its individuals were atoms. Their consciousness takes hold of the whole race. The seventh stage, the Father initiation, leads beyond race to all humanity on Earth, to all peoples and races of the planet. Christ Jesus is its representative: he bears all humanity within himself. That is why the Gospel of John calls humanity the bride and the initiated Son of Man the bridegroom. Christ Jesus is the one who, in essence, embraces the consciousness of all humanity.
GA094

GA148
Attention has been drawn to the fact that in ancient times there were mystery initiations, through which the human soul was raised to participate in spiritual life. This pre-Christian mystery system becomes most vivid when we consider the so-called Persian or Mithraic Mysteries. There were seven stages of initiation. The person who was to be led upward into the higher degrees of spiritual experience was first brought to what was symbolically called a “Raven.” Then he became an “Occult One,” a “Hidden One.” At the third degree he was a “Fighter,” at the fourth a “Lion,” and at the fifth he was given the name of the people to which he belonged. At the sixth degree he became a “Sun Hero,” and at the seventh a “Father.” For the first four degrees, it is enough for us today to say that the person was gradually led ever more deeply into spiritual experience. At the fifth degree, the person acquired the ability to have an expanded consciousness, and this expanded consciousness gave him the ability to

become a spiritual guardian of the whole people to which he belonged. That is why he was also given the name of that particular people. When someone was initiated into the fifth degree in these ancient Mysteries, he had a particular kind of participation in spiritual life.

From a cycle of lectures I gave here, we know that the peoples of the Earth are guided by those whom, among the hierarchies of spiritual beings, we call the Archangeloi, or Archangels. The person initiated into the fifth degree was raised into this sphere, so that he participated in the life of the Archangels. Such initiates of the fifth degree were needed; they were needed in the cosmos. Therefore, an initiation into this fifth degree took place on Earth. When such a person was initiated into the Mysteries and underwent all the inner experiences of the soul, receiving the content of the soul corresponding to the fifth degree, the Archangel of the particular people to which that person belonged would, as it were, look down upon this soul and read in it as we read in a book that tells us certain things we need to know in order to perform this or that deed. The Archangels read in the souls of those initiated into the fifth degree what a people needed and what was necessary for it. For the Archangels to guide in the right way, fifth-degree initiates had to be created on Earth. These initiates are mediators between the actual leaders of the peoples, the Archangels, and the people themselves. They carry upward, as it were, into the sphere of the Archangels what is needed there so that the people can be guided in the right way. How, then, could this fifth degree be attained in ancient pre-Christian times? It could not be attained while the human soul remained in the body. The human soul had to be lifted out of the body. The initiation consisted precisely in bringing the human soul out of the body. Outside the body, the soul then underwent what gave it the content I have just described. The soul had to leave the Earth and ascend into the spiritual world in order to attain what it was meant to attain.

When the sixth degree of the ancient initiation was attained—the degree of the Sun Hero—something became active in the soul of such a Sun Hero that was necessary not merely for the guidance, direction, and governance of a people, but that was higher than the mere guidance and governance of a people. If you turn your gaze to the development of all humanity on Earth, you see peoples arise and then fade away, peoples changing, as it were. Like individual human beings, peoples are born and die. But what a people has accomplished for the Earth must be preserved for the whole development of humanity on Earth. It is not enough for a people simply to be guided and governed; what that people accomplishes through its earthly work must be carried forward beyond the people itself. For the spirits higher than the Archangels—the spirits of the ages—to carry a people's achievements beyond that people, initiates of the sixth degree, the Sun Heroes, were necessary. For in what lived in the soul of a Sun Hero, beings of the higher worlds could read what carried the work of a people over into the work of the entire human race.

In this way, the forces could be gained that would carry a people's work over into the work of all humanity in the right way. What lived in the Sun Hero was carried across the whole Earth. And just as the person who was to be initiated into the fifth degree in the ancient Mysteries had to leave his body in order to undergo what was necessary, so the person who was to become a Sun Hero had to leave his body and, during the time he was outside it, truly have the Sun as his dwelling place.

These are things that sound almost like fables to the consciousness of our time, and may even be regarded as foolishness. Yet the Pauline saying also applies here: what is wisdom before the gods is often foolishness to human beings. During his initiation, the Sun Hero therefore lived in communion with the entire solar system. The Sun was his dwelling place, just as the ordinary human being lives on Earth, his planet. Just as mountains and rivers surround us, the planets of the solar system surrounded the Sun Hero during his initiation. During initiation, the Sun Hero had to be transported to the Sun. In the ancient Mysteries, this could be achieved only outside the body. When he returned to his body, he remembered what he had experienced outside it and could use it as forces for action in the evolution of all humanity, for the salvation of all humanity. Thus the Sun Heroes left their bodies during initiation; once they had filled themselves with these forces, they returned to their bodies. On returning, they possessed in their souls the forces that could carry the work of a people forward into the development of all humanity.

And what did these Sun Heroes experience during the three and a half days of their initiation? While they—we may put it this way—walked not on Earth but on the Sun, what did they experience? Communion with the Christ, who had not yet been on Earth before the Mystery of Golgotha! All the ancient Sun Heroes ascended in this way into the solar sphere, for in ancient times communion with the Christ could be experienced only there. From that world, into which the ancient initiates had to ascend during their initiation, the Christ descended to Earth. We can therefore say that what in ancient times could be attained by a few individuals through the whole procedure of initiation was attained, as though through a natural event, by those who were Christ's apostles during the days of Pentecost. Whereas human souls had formerly needed to ascend to the Christ, the Christ had now descended to the apostles. In a certain sense, the apostles had become souls who carried within themselves the same content that the ancient Sun Heroes had carried in their souls. The spiritual power of the Sun had poured itself into the souls of these people and from then on continued to work in the evolution of humanity. For this to happen, for the activity of an entirely new force to come to Earth, the event in Palestine—the Mystery of Golgotha—had to take place.
GA148

GA112
One of the first to be led to Christ Jesus in the sense of the Gospel of John was Nathanael. The others, who were already confessors of Christ Jesus, now said to Nathanael:

"We have found the Master, the one who dwells in Jesus of Nazareth!" Nathanael replied: "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" But when Nathanael was brought before Christ, Christ said to him: "Behold, a true Israelite, in whom there is no deceit!"

A true Israelite, one in whom the truth dwells! Christ says this because he knows the degree to which Nathanael has been initiated. Nathanael then recognizes that he is dealing with someone who knows as much as he does—or even sees through him and knows more than he does. And Christ says to him, to indicate further that this is indeed a matter of initiation: "I did not see you only when you came toward me; before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you!" (1:41 ff.)

The word "fig tree" is used here in exactly the same sense as in the case of Buddha: the fig tree is the Bodhi tree. It is a sign of initiation. Christ is saying to him: "I recognize you as someone initiated into the fifth degree!" You can see from this how the writer of the Gospel of John indicates that Christ sees through someone who has been initiated up to the fifth degree. Step by step, the writer of the Gospel of John leads us onward, showing that in the body of Jesus of Nazareth dwells someone who can see through a person initiated into the fifth degree.

And further: we have just seen that the person initiated into the fifth degree masters the occult-magical forces that flow through the blood of successive generations. He has, as it were, become one with the soul of the people. And above we saw that this soul of the people expresses itself in the forces of woman. Thus someone initiated into the fifth degree would, in an ancient way, have to do with the forces of woman. You must understand all of this spiritually.

But Christ relates to woman in an entirely new way. He relates to the woman who, through the baptism of John, has become virginal again, who once more possesses the fresh, sprouting forces of the virginal. This is the new element the writer of the Gospel of John wished to indicate when he says that a certain current flows from the Son to the mother. That the Son, if he had been initiated only into the fifth degree, could magically use the forces of the people expressed in the mother's element of the people was familiar to all those who possessed occult knowledge in that age. Christ, however, revealed the forces of woman, restored to virginity, in a spiritually higher way.
GA112

GA123

The ancient Mysteries, and in a certain respect also the more recent Mysteries, had three stages of macrocosmic initiation. The first stage was reached when a person grew into such a state that he perceived everything that can be perceived through the Spirit-Self. At that point he was not merely a human being in the new sense, but had grown upward into what, in the language of the hierarchies, is called angelic nature—the next hierarchy above the human being. In the Persian Mysteries, such a person, who grew into the macrocosm so that the Spirit-Self was active within him, was therefore called either a "Persian," because he was no longer an individual but belonged to the Angel of the Persian people, or such people were directly called angels or divine natures. The next stage was one in which the Life-Spirit awakened accordingly. A person at this stage was called a "Sun Hero" in the sense of the Persian Mysteries, because he then received the power of the Sun and developed upward from below toward the forces of the Sun, where the spiritual power of the Sun came to meet the Earth. He was also called a "Son of the Father." And the one into whom Atma, or the Spirit-Man, reached was called in the ancient Mysteries the "Father." These were the three stages of the person to be initiated: Angel, Son or Sun Hero, and Father.
GA123

GA112
With regard to its composition, the Gospel of John—if its earliest chapters are properly understood, if one knows what the words actually contain—is one of the most stylistically refined and most perfectly rounded documents in the world. This cannot, however, be recognized through a superficial examination. A superficial examination first reveals that the writer of the Gospel of John—we now know who he is—lists precisely seven such miracles in the account of the signs, up to the actual event of Lazarus.

What are these seven miracles or signs?

1. The sign given through the wedding at Cana in Galilee (Chapter 2).
2. The sign given through the healing of the royal official's son (Chapter 4).
3. The healing of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years at the pool of Bethesda (Chapter 5).
4. The feeding of the five thousand (Chapter 6).
5. The sign given through witnessing Christ walking on the sea (Chapter 6).
6. The sign given through the healing of the man born blind (Chapter 9).
7. Finally, the greatest sign: the initiation of Lazarus—the transformation of Lazarus into the writer of the Gospel of John himself (Chapter 11).
GA112

Chapter 2.

GA103
What follows was already referred to yesterday. It is the wedding at Cana in Galilee, often called "the first of the miracles"; it would be more accurate to say "the first of the signs" performed by Christ Jesus (2:1–11).

Christ Jesus was to baptize in a different way. He was not to direct people toward the past, but toward the future through the development of spirituality within them. Through the "Holy Spirit," the unclouded spirit, the spiritual element in the human being was to become connected with the Godhead. Baptism with water was a baptism of remembrance. Baptism with the "Holy Spirit," however, is a prophetic baptism that points toward the future. The connection that had been entirely lost, and which water baptism was meant to recall, had also been lost in what was expressed through the symbol of wine, the sacrificial wine. Dionysus is the dismembered god who entered the individual souls, so that the separate parts no longer knew anything of one another. Through what alcohol— the symbol of Dionysus—brought to humanity, the human being was shattered into many pieces and cast into matter. Yet a great principle is preserved in the wedding at Cana: the pedagogical principle of

evolution. There are absolute truths, but they cannot simply be handed down to humanity at every point in time. Each age must have its own particular practices and truths.

We must therefore understand that there is nothing absolute about the forms in which truth is expressed; at each time, what is recognized corresponds to a particular epoch of humanity. The highest impulse had, as it were, to descend to the level of the customs of life of that time. For the highest truth had to be clothed in words and practices suited to the understanding of the age concerned. Thus Christ had to use a kind of Dionysian or wine sacrifice to show how humanity should rise toward the Godhead. One must not say zealously: Why does Christ turn water into wine? The age must be taken into account. Through a kind of Dionysian sacrifice, Christ had to prepare what was to come. Christ goes to the Galileans, who are a mixture of all kinds of nations and are not bound together by ties of blood, and performs the first sign of his mission there. He accommodates himself to their customs of life to the extent of turning water into wine for them.

Let us hold fast to what Christ really means to say here: "I also want to lead those people into a spiritual connection who have descended to the degree of materiality symbolized by drinking wine." He does not wish to be there only for those who can rise through the symbol of water baptism. It is very significant that we are explicitly told that six purification jars stand there (2:6). We shall return to the number later. "Purification" is what baptism brings about. In the times from which the Gospel derives, the act of baptizing was spoken of as "baptizing," while the effect brought about by baptism was called "purification." The corresponding Greek word, βαπτίζειν, is never found in the Gospel of John as a noun, but only as a verb. When a noun is used, it is always purification—the effect—that is expressed, so that the human being may remember the state of purification and the connection with the Godhead. Thus, even through the symbolic jars for the purification offering, Christ Jesus performs the sign by which he points to his mission in a manner appropriate to that age.

In this way, the wedding at Cana in Galilee expresses something of the deepest mission of Christ. There he had to say: My time will come in the future, but it has not yet arrived. What I have to accomplish here is still partly connected with what my mission must overcome. He stands in the present while pointing toward the future, showing how he works for his age not in an absolute sense but in a cultural and pedagogical one. It is therefore his mother who urges him, saying, "They have no wine." He replies that what he must accomplish now is still connected with the old times, with "me and you"; for his true time, when wine is transformed back into water, has not yet come. What sense would it make to say, "Woman, what have I to do with you?" if he then simply did what his mother asked? It makes sense only if we are meant to understand that blood relationship brought about humanity's present condition, and that a sign is given in accordance with old customs, which still require the element of alcohol to point toward the time when the independent "I" will develop out of blood ties. For the time being, the old element symbolized by wine must still be reckoned with, but a later age will come that will be "his time."

We can see how sharply and significantly the Gospel of John points to the historical event in Palestine, and how paradigmatic and clearly defined its words are. Yet these words must be weighed very carefully if we are to use them to understand esoteric Christianity. In the next lectures we shall see this theme developed further, and it will also be shown that Christ is not only the guide of those connected with a group soul, but comes into each individual and wishes to endow the individual "I" with his impulse. Blood relationship remains, but the spirituality of love is added to it. Christ gives the impulse to this love, which passes from one free "I" to another. For the person who understands initiation, one truth after another is revealed day by day. An important truth is always revealed on the third day. It is the truth that one learns to understand fully: in the evolution of the Earth there is a point at which material love, tied to the blood, becomes increasingly spiritualized. This is the event meant to illustrate the transition from pure blood-love to spiritual love. Christ Jesus points to it in significant words when he says that a time will come when the most important things will be created by people no longer connected through blood relationship, but standing as individuals in their own right. That time must first arrive. Christ himself, who gives the first impulse, says on an important occasion that

this ideal will one day be fulfilled, but that his time has not yet come. He prophetically indicates this when his mother stands before him and urges him to do something for humanity, as if suggesting that she has the right to prompt him to perform an important deed for people. He replies that what they can do today is still connected with blood ties, with the relationship of “me and you,” “for my time has not yet come” (2:4). The story of the wedding at Cana expresses that a time will come when the individual must stand on their own. Jesus answers the request “They have no wine!” (2:3) by saying that this still has to do with “me and you”; his time has not yet come. The phrases “between me and you” and “my time has not yet come” therefore appear in the text. They point to this mystery. Like many other passages, this one has often been translated rather crudely. It should not read, “Woman, what have I to do with you?” but rather, “This concerns the connection between me and your blood relationship.” The text is so fine and subtle, though it is understandable only to those willing to understand it. When all sorts of people explain these religious documents today, one might ask: Do those who call themselves Christians feel nothing when, in an inaccurate translation, they make Christ say, “Woman, what have I to do with you?”

At the very beginning of humanity’s development on Earth, marriage took place only within very narrow circles, among families closely related by blood. In the earliest stages of human development, people held firmly to marriage within the immediate kin group. The narrow circles of blood relationship gradually widened. People married outside their tribe, but not yet into another people. The people of the Old Testament held firmly to the preservation of kinship by blood within the nation. A person was a “Jew” by Jewish blood.

Christ Jesus does not address this principle. He turns to those who break through the principle of mere blood relationship, and therefore he first demonstrates what he has to show not in Judea but outside it, in Galilee. Galilee was a region where peoples from many different tribes and nations were mixed together. “Galilean” means, in this interpretation, a person of mixed descent. Christ Jesus goes to the Galileans, to those whose ancestry is most mixed. From the kind of human reproduction brought about by such mixing, something is to emerge that is no longer bound to the material basis of love. That is why he teaches what he has to show at a wedding. Why at a wedding? Because a wedding can point to the propagation of humanity. He does not show it where people marry only within narrow limits and blood ties, but where they marry independently of those ties. That is why the event takes place at a wedding, specifically a wedding in Galilee.

Whenever ancient documents speak of numbers, the mystery of number is involved. When we read, “On the third day there was a wedding at Cana in Galilee” (2:1), every initiate knows that “the third day” means something special. What is at issue here? The writer of the Gospel of John indicates that this is not only an actual experience, but at the same time a great and powerful prophecy. This wedding expresses the great wedding of humanity, revealed in initiation on the third day. The first day showed what takes place in the first epoch, in the transition from the third to the fourth cultural epoch; the second day showed what takes place in the transition from the fourth to the fifth; and the third day showed what will happen when humanity passes from the fifth to the sixth cultural epoch. These are the three days of initiation. The Christ impulse had to wait until the third point in time. Before then, the moment when it could act had not arrived.
GA103

GA100
If we recall the five cultural epochs—the Indian, Persian, Egyptian, Greco-Latin, and European—we see that in the third period the foundation was laid for the Christ power that will bear fruit for all humanity. What was planted in humanity’s development then will only come to life in the sixth period. In that sixth period, the Spirit-Self, developed out of the Consciousness Soul, will unite with the Life-Spirit. The Christ power shines prophetically from the third into the fourth period. In the sixth period, the great marriage of humanity will be celebrated, when the Spirit-Self unites with the Life-Spirit. Humanity will then be united in a great brotherhood, with one “I” standing beside another, brother beside brother. This brotherhood is foretold in the account of the wedding at Cana in Galilee, which is

not merely a historical fact but symbolically depicts how the sons and daughters of humanity will unite in the sixth period in a great brotherhood embracing all humanity. Three periods remain to be traversed after the third period before this event comes: the third, fourth, and fifth. In esoteric language, a period is called a day; hence the beginning of chapter 2 says, “And on the third day there was a wedding at Cana.” This indicates that the following account of the wedding points to something that will occur in the future. Jesus’ mother, the Consciousness Soul, is present at the wedding. Christ says to her, “What is there between me and you? My hour has not yet come.” This clearly says that the wedding at Cana points to something that is to happen only in the future. What does Jesus do because his hour has not yet come? He turns water into wine!

Christ appears to give humanity the powers needed to attain the highest consciousness of the “I” in the sixth period. He wants to prepare people for that “time which has not yet come.” If he had left matters at the water offering, humanity would never have attained the individual “I.” The transformation of water signifies the human being’s elevation into an individual being. Humanity had reached a point in its development at which it needed wine; therefore Christ turns water into wine. When the time comes when human beings no longer need wine, Christ will turn wine back into water. How could such a power arise in Christ that he could transform water into wine? Because Christ’s body is the Earth itself, he could make the Earth’s forces active within himself. In the Earth, water is transformed into wine as it flows through the vine. Christ, as a personality, could also accomplish what happens in the Earth, because all the Earth’s forces must also be present in him if the Earth is his body and is ensouled by his astral body.
GA100

GA097
There was a wedding on the third day. This means that John lay in initiatory sleep for three days. During that time, the vision of the wedding at Cana in Galilee occurred. During the three-day sleep, he experienced what was taking place in the spiritual world. On the third day he experienced the vision of the wedding at Cana. Everything that follows consists of events he sees in astral vision.
GA097

GA094
Everything appears reversed on the astral plane. Even time is reversed. If you follow a person on the astral plane, you begin at the place where they are. Then you can go backward as far as their birth. On the physical plane you follow them forward; on the astral plane, backward. This is how the emergence from physical embodiment appears to us. It is as though we were leaving the temple of the body and being seized from every side. This is the process John wishes to describe: he has stepped outside himself in order to experience Christ—his own higher, divine self—before him. The people around him are bound to their physical bodies as if by chains, with their astral bodies firmly attached. Had John remained as they were, he would have stayed bound to the physical body.

Such a process—the final act that leads to this emergence and makes a person fully clairvoyant—usually lasts three days. When these three days are over, the person attains on the astral plane a consciousness like that formerly possessed on the physical plane. The person then unites with the higher world.

In occult language, this union with the higher world is called the wedding of the soul, celebrated with the powers of the higher world. Once a person has emerged from the physical body, that body stands opposite them as a mother would stand opposite a child, if the child could be conscious at birth, facing the mother from whom it was born. The physical body thus stands before the person, and the astral body can quite properly say to the physical body: “This is my mother.” After celebrating its wedding, it can say this, looking back at the union that existed earlier. This can happen after three days. Such is the occult process on the astral plane. Chapter 2, verse 1, says: “And on the third day there was a wedding at Cana in Galilee; and the mother of Jesus was there.” This is a pictorial expression of what I have just described. It happened on the third day.

One of the greatest symbols of this wedding feast is the wedding at Cana in Galilee, a place where many peoples came together in a colourful international mixture. We see a wedding feast being celebrated there. “And the mother of Jesus was also there,” the text says. In the Gospel of John, Jesus’ mother is never called “Mary,” just as the writer of the Gospel—the disciple whom the Lord loved—is never called “John.” Jesus’ mother is, in fact, the human soul, which must first mature before Christ can work within it. Hence the words: “Woman, what have I to do with you? My hour has not yet come.” Otherwise, such a lofty individuality as Christ would never have spoken this way to his physical mother.

Just as the plant today transforms its watery juices into wine, the human being cannot do this today, but will transform their blood in the future.

From this perspective, light is shed on the mystery of the transformation of water and wine at the wedding at Cana. Why specifically Cana in Galilee? Galilee (= el gojim) is, in this interpretation, the land of mixed peoples, of those not of unmixed descent. Mixing between peoples had long been common there, overcoming barriers that separated nations; there, a wedding between people of different blood took place.

We have seen that the wedding in Galilee signifies people joining with one another across the barriers of blood.

We live today in the fifth sub-race of the fifth root-race. What took place in Palestine belongs to the fourth sub-race, the Greco-Latin one. The Jewish people emerged from the third sub-race, prepared for their mission in Egypt and then departed from there. Jesus descended from this people. The third root-race flows into the fourth, the fourth into the fifth, and the fifth into the sixth. We must therefore distinguish three epochs. In esoteric language, they are called three days of creation.

On the third day, however, there was a wedding at Cana. The writer of the Gospel of John sees here what will occur only in the future, in the sixth race: the marriage of Manas, expressed in law, with Buddhi, grace and joy—the great wedding of the entire Manasic element with Buddhi. This can fully take place only when Christianity’s task has been completely fulfilled. “Whoever does not leave father and mother, brother and sister, for my sake cannot be my disciple” means that love must be drawn out of narrow communities and made into universal love for humanity; it must turn away from those related by blood toward those related in spirit. Thus, the wedding at Cana symbolizes what is to happen one day. “And on the third day” is not written by chance: it is to be understood literally as a world-day. Every number, every word—everything in the Gospel of John—is deeply significant.

This transition from patriarchal marriage to freely chosen marriage corresponds to the new development of intellectual faculties and the human “I.” It took place at the same time as the temporary darkening of astral faculties: clairvoyance and the direct reading of the astral and spiritual worlds.

The wedding at Cana, also recounted in this Gospel, encompasses one of the profound mysteries in humanity’s spiritual history. It relates to the words of Hermes: “As above, so below.” At the wedding at Cana, water is transformed into wine. This event has a universal symbolic meaning: in religious worship, the water offering is for a time to be replaced by the wine offering.

There was a time in human history when wine was still unknown. In the age of the Vedas it was scarcely known. As long as people did not drink alcoholic beverages, the idea of previous stages of existence and of many lives on Earth was widespread, and no one doubted it. Since humanity began to drink wine, the idea of reincarnation quickly grew dim and eventually disappeared from general consciousness. It was preserved only by initiates who abstained from wine. Alcohol has a particular

effect on the human organism, especially on the etheric body, where memory has its seat. Alcohol veils memory and darkens it in its inner depths. Wine brings forgetfulness, as the saying goes. This is not superficial, momentary forgetfulness, but a deep and lasting one: a darkening of the etheric body's power of memory. Thus, as people began to drink wine, they gradually lost their original feeling for reincarnation.
GA094

GA112
I have indicated to you in recent days that everything general in the human being—what makes people within a certain group alike—lies in the feminine element of heredity. I have said that through women, over generations, what makes one face resemble another within a people is passed on, if we look at outward appearances. Through the masculine element, from generation to generation, what distinguishes one person from another is passed on: what makes a person an individual being on Earth and gives their "I" a ground of its own.

Let us look within ourselves. We have seen that the mother is active within the human being where the etheric and astral bodies interpenetrate, while the father finds expression where the "I" is in the physical body. In other words, the mother and the feminine element are active in what is general in us —in what belongs to our kind, and in our inner life of wisdom and ideas. The father and masculine element are active in what arises from the union of the "I" and the physical body: in the outwardly differentiated form, in what makes the human being an "I." What, then, did the ancient sages who thought in this way chiefly require of human beings? They required them to become clear within themselves about the relationship of the physical body and "I" to the etheric and astral bodies—to understand the maternal and paternal elements active within them. Because a person has an etheric body and an astral body, they carry the maternal element within. Besides the external mother on the physical plane, they have the maternal element, the mother, within themselves. And besides the father who stands on the physical plane, they have the paternal element, the father, within. Bringing the inner father and mother into the right relationship had to appear as an ideal, a great ideal. If a person does not harmonize the paternal and maternal elements within, the discord between them must pass outward into the physical world and cause devastation. Thus the ancient sage said that the human being's task is to establish harmony within between the paternal and maternal elements. If this fails, what appears in the world must be something truly terrible.

In such an initiation, the etheric and astral bodies were lifted out of the configuration formed by the physical body, etheric body, astral body, and "I," while the "I" remained behind. For this reason, during the three and a half days of initiation, the person could have no self-consciousness: self-consciousness was extinguished. The person received consciousness from the higher spiritual world, infused by the priest-initiator, who guided them completely and made his own "I" available to them. What actually happened? It was expressed in a formula that may seem strange. But if you understand it, it will no longer seem strange. It was said that when a person was initiated in the ancient way, the maternal element emerged and the paternal element remained behind. That is, the person killed the paternal element within and united with the mother within—in other words, killed the father within and married the mother. Thus, while the ancient initiate lay in the lethargic state for three and a half days, they had united with the mother and killed the father within. They had become fatherless. This had to happen because they had to relinquish their individuality and live in a higher spiritual world. They became one with their people. What lived in their people was precisely the maternal element. They became one with the entire organism of their people. They became what Nathanael was, and what was always named after the people in question: among the Jews, an "Israelite"; among the Persians, a "Persian."

What had to happen to make it possible, once and for all, to find a harmonious balance within oneself between the maternal and paternal elements, between one's own "I," which bears the paternal element, and the maternal element? The Christ impulse had to come! Let us now look at certain depths of the wedding at Cana in Galilee from another perspective.

The text says: “The mother of Jesus was there. Jesus and his disciples were also invited to the wedding.” Jesus—or, more precisely, Christ—was to present humanity with the great example of a being who had found within himself the unity between his own “I” and the maternal principle. At the wedding at Cana in Galilee, he indicated this to his mother: “Something passes from me to you.” This was a new movement from me to you. It was no longer in the old sense; it signified a renewal of the entire relationship. It was the great ideal, once and for all, of achieving inner balance without first killing the father—that is, without first leaving the physical body—and finding harmony with the maternal principle within the “I.” The time had now come for human beings to learn to overcome the excessive power of egoism, of the “I”-principle, within themselves, and to bring it into the right relationship with what is active as the maternal principle in the etheric and astral bodies. The wedding at Cana was therefore to present a beautiful image of the relationship between one’s own “I,” the paternal principle, and the maternal principle: an inner harmony reflected in the love existing in the outer world between Christ Jesus and his mother. This was to be an image of the harmonious balance between the “I” and the maternal element within the human being. It had not existed before; it came about only through the deed of Christ Jesus. Since it came through Christ’s deed, it provided the only possible refutation—refutation through action—of everything that might have arisen under the influence of remnants of the old wisdom, which would have led to killing the father and uniting with the mother.

What was necessary in ancient times for such a sign to occur—for water to be in the vessels, yet to be wine when drunk? The magical power produced by blood relationship was necessary. The people at the wedding at Cana in Galilee still possessed the soul-power needed to perceive something of this kind. Only a transition had to be brought about.

You need only consult the Greek text: you will find nothing more than the words spoken when Jesus of Nazareth points to something: “O woman, this passes from me to you!” He is pointing precisely to this subtle, intimate power passing from soul to soul, from him to his mother. He needs this at that moment. He cannot yet perform a higher sign; the time for that must first mature. Therefore he says: “My time, when I shall act solely through my own power, has not yet come!” For now, the magnetic bond of the soul is still necessary, passing from the soul of Jesus of Nazareth to his mother. “O woman, this passes from me to you!” Otherwise, after hearing “Woman, what have I to do with you?” how could his mother go on to tell the servants, “Do whatever he tells you”? She must still possess the ancient powers of which people today have no idea. She knows that he is pointing to the blood bond between son and mother, a bond that is to lead onward to others. She knows that an invisible spiritual power is active here and can bring something about.

“Do whatever he tells you!” the mother had said to the servants. What kind of water did Christ need? He needed water that came directly from nature’s springs. That is why it must be specifically stated that the water had just been drawn. Only water that had not yet lost the inner forces possessed by an element while it remains connected with nature was suitable for his purpose. As has been said, no word in the Gospel of John is without deep significance. Freshly drawn water had to be used because Christ is the being who had just approached the Earth and become related to the forces active within the Earth itself. When the living forces of the water work together again with what flows “from me to you,” what the Gospel describes can happen: the chief steward is called and senses that something special has occurred, although he does not know what it was. The text expressly says that he did not see what happened; the servants saw it, but he did not. Under the influence of what occurred, he experiences the water as wine. This is stated clearly, so that an effect of soul-power is shown reaching into an external element—in other words, into the physical body. What had to be present in the mother of Jesus of Nazareth for her faith to be strong enough at that moment to bring about such an effect? She had to possess something she did indeed possess: the insight that the one called her son had become the Spirit of the Earth. Then her strong power of faith, joined with his strong power—what flowed from him to her—could work so powerfully that the described event took place.

Through the entire constellation of circumstances surrounding the first sign, we have been shown how the harmony of souls, still tied to blood bonds, can exert an influence on the physical world. It was the first sign, and the power of Christ was shown in its smallest degree. It still needed reinforcement from the soul-forces of his mother and from the forces still united with nature in the water, present when the water has just been drawn. Here we encounter the working power of the Christ-being in its smallest degree. Particular emphasis is placed on the Christ power acting upon another soul and calling forth effects from that soul because it is suited to receive them. The essential point is that the Christ power can make the other soul receptive, so that the effects occur. It had made the wedding guests receptive to experiencing the water as wine. Any true power, however, strengthens itself through its own action. When Christ exercises this power a second time, it is already stronger. Just as the simplest ability grows stronger through practice, a spiritual power grows especially strong when it has once been applied successfully.
GA112

GA100
While the five bodies of purification require purification from outside, the Spirit-Self will keep the human being pure from within. Christ's body is already filled with purity. He also wishes to purify humanity, and therefore enters and cleanses the temple of merchants and money changers (chapter 2:14–22). That is, he purifies the temple of the Holy Spirit—the human body—of the lower principles clinging to it and makes it capable of receiving the spirit.
GA100

GA094
The human being shares the physical body with the mineral world, the etheric body with all plants, and the astral body with all animals. But the human being rises above all these beings through "I"-consciousness, through the little word "I," which is unique. "I" is the only name that each person can say only of themselves. This is a fact of the greatest significance. In the ancient Hebrew religion, this "I," this "occult word," could be spoken only by the highest initiate, the high priest. It was a solemn ritual moment. The whole people waited for the word "Yahweh" ("I") to be spoken, and a sacred awe passed through the devout crowd. Yahweh: the God who speaks within. The name Yahweh (Jehovah) was regarded as the unspeakable name. It is the voice with which God begins to speak within the human being. This word never enters us from outside. In the word "I," the eternal touches the temporal. We have now become acquainted with the four members of the human being: the physical body, the etheric body, the astral body, and the human being's essential core, the "I."
Whoever rises higher must purify every member of their being and cast out whatever drags them downward. Christ, as the representative of Earth-consciousness being purified and ascending, drives out what is impure: the money changer's mentality, the spirit of profiteering, and greed for money. This is the meaning of the cleansing of the Temple, which is also an image of humanity's future. After driving out the money changers and merchants, Jesus says, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up." The text continues, "But he was speaking of the temple of his body" (2:14–21). These words point to the three coming world-days of which we have already spoken. Here Christ Jesus speaks of the evolution of the whole Earth. The old order is to pass away, and on the third world-day a body will come into being that no longer contains anything base.
GA094

GA266a
The biblical story of Christ wielding a scourge to cleanse the Temple of money changers has a profound meaning. At the time when darkness on Earth was at its deepest, Christ appeared as humanity's saviour. One hundred and nine years after Christ's appearance, the rule of Oriphiel ended and was replaced by Anael. Zachariel followed, then Raphael. During the Renaissance, Samael ruled; from the sixteenth century until November 1879, Gabriel ruled. Then Michael assumed the leadership, and around the year 2400 Oriphiel, the terrible angel of wrath, will once again take charge. As in former times, spiritual light will then shine brightly and radiantly into the darkness: Christ will appear

on Earth again, though in a different form from that in which he appeared before. We are called to welcome him and serve him.
GA266a

Chapter 3.

GA100
If a clairvoyant contemporary of Christ wanted to know what was happening in the spiritual world, he had to enter the state of sleep. This is indicated in the third chapter. Nicodemus, an elder of the Jews, came to Christ at night. He came because he wanted to become a seer, because he had entered the state in which he could become one; and he came “at night” because his waking consciousness had been extinguished. In the fifth verse of this chapter we also find the important teaching that a human being can be born “of the Spirit.”
GA100

GA103
Chapter by chapter, the Gospel of John now shows us two things. First, what is communicated is intended for those who are able, in a certain way, to understand occult truths. Today, spiritual science is presented exoterically; in those days, however, spiritual-scientific truths could be understood only by people who were genuinely initiated to one degree or another. Who could understand anything of the deeper facts that Christ Jesus had to communicate? Only someone able to perceive outside the body, to step out of the body and become conscious in the spiritual world. If Christ Jesus wished to speak to people who could understand him, they had to be initiated in some way and already able to see spiritually. For example, when he speaks of the soul’s rebirth in the chapter about his conversation with Nicodemus, we are shown that he reveals this truth to someone who sees with spiritual senses. You need only read:

“There was a man of the Pharisees, named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews. The same came to Jesus by night …” (3:1–2)

Let us simply get into the habit of weighing the words carefully! It is indicated that Nicodemus comes to Jesus “by night”—that is, he receives what Christ Jesus has to communicate to him while outside the physical body. “By night” means that he comes to Christ Jesus by using his spiritual senses. Just as Nathanael and Christ Jesus communicate as initiates through the reference to the fig tree, a similar capacity for understanding one another is indicated here.
GA103

GA097
In the third chapter comes the conversation with Nicodemus. In the astral vision, the Lord himself continually appears to John. What is to happen to John is presented to him in the conversation with Nicodemus. The Lord speaks plainly, although Nicodemus does not initially understand him. John himself is meant to come to understand; in the vision it is explained to him that the lower human being must be put to death and the higher human being brought to life. Gradually he comes to understand who Jesus really is: that in Jesus the original forces of the world, the Father of the world, are active. This is why Christ’s discourses about the Father follow here. The power of the occult forces possessed by Jesus appears to John as an astral reflection of the actual events. Everything really happened, but John experiences it in astral vision. In this way, John comes to know the deepest truths through the Lord himself.
GA097

GA094
I would now like to direct your attention to the conversation with Nicodemus, which you can find in the third chapter. There the significant words are spoken: “Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.” What does it mean to be born again and to see the kingdom of God? It means to have awakened one’s higher self—to be born in such a way that the eternal core of one’s being has awakened. What does it mean to enter the kingdom of heaven? It means not merely to see the reflection of Devachan here, as it appears through physical eyes, but to see that kingdom directly. This is possible only for someone who is not born solely for this physical world, but is born a second time.

It is therefore entirely justified to speak of a higher world and to value it more highly than our lower world. But we must use this expression in a technical sense only. Fundamentally, all worlds are equally valid manifestations of the highest principle. We must not regard any world with contempt. In this way we learn to relate properly to both the lower and the higher worlds. This is the prerequisite for the third chapter of the Gospel of John.

We must be clear that Jesus is speaking to Nicodemus about true rebirth, and above all wishes to urge him to see ordinary life, from this perspective, as something that must be born into a higher life and understood accordingly. Anyone who reads this chapter more closely and examines it carefully will see that this is precisely its subject.

Let us also remember that when a chela advances toward mastery, he is laid in a tomb for three and a half days. The temple of the body is dismantled and then raised again. This happens to the individual, and it happened for all humanity through Christ’s death and resurrection. You must sense in the Gospel of John how its sentences shine in many directions, for they are profound and multifaceted, encompassing the mystery of the whole world.

In initiation, the soul is separated from the body, yet remains conscious in the higher worlds. Nicodemus comes to Christ “by night,” that is, outside waking consciousness (3:1–21). Christ tells him: “Except a man be born of water”—that is, from the astral world, experienced like flowing waters —“and of the Spirit”—Devachan—“he cannot enter into the kingdom of God”; that is, he cannot experience the spiritual world. Christ speaks of this while ordinary waking consciousness has no part in the matter, namely during initiation. Every word in the Gospel of John signifies something deeper, and there is no end to the interpretation of this Gospel.
GA094

GA103
For anyone who understands such things, this is clearly indicated in the Gospel by the statement that Nicodemus came to Christ Jesus “by night”—that is, in a state of consciousness in which a person does not use the outer sense organs. We will not concern ourselves with trivial explanations that various people have offered for this “by night.” You know that this conversation concerns human rebirth—“of water and Spirit.” The words Christ speaks to Nicodemus about rebirth in chapter 3, verses 4 and 5, are very important:

“Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man be born when he is old? Can he enter the second time into his mother’s womb, and be born? Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God!”

If we wish to characterize the meaning of this development, we can say that in former times, when the human being was still among the gods, the physical and etheric bodies were watery and airy. Only gradually, as the Earth became denser, did they condense into their present material form. This was the descent. Just as the human being descended, so will he ascend again. Having experienced what can be experienced here in solid matter, he will rise again to regions where his physical body is watery and airy. A person must carry within himself the awareness that, if he wishes once more to unite in consciousness with the gods, his true being will be in the regions from which he originated. The human being condensed out of water and air; he will once again become more subtle. Today he can anticipate this state spiritually only by inwardly cultivating an awareness of what he will later become bodily. People gain the strength to do this only by consciously taking in this awareness now. If a person acquires this awareness, he will fulfil his earthly goal and mission. What does this mean? It means that human beings were once born not of flesh and earth, but of air and water, and that later they must truly be reborn in spirit from air and water. The language of the period when the Gospels arose—which we must also study—used the word "water" for water, but "pneuma," now rendered as "Spirit," meant "air"; at that time the word certainly had this meaning. "Pneuma" must be translated as "air" or "vapour"; otherwise, misunderstanding arises. The sentence in the conversation with Nicodemus should therefore read:

"Amen, amen, I say unto you: Except a person be born of water and air, he cannot enter the kingdoms of heaven." (3:5)

Christ thus points to the future state into which human beings are meant to develop, and in this conversation we have before us a profound mystery of our evolution. We need only understand the words correctly and apply what anthroposophy can offer us. Something of this meaning has survived in everyday language, where volatile substances are called "spirits." Originally, however, the word "pneuma" means "air." You can see how important it is to grasp words in an exact, precise sense and weigh them carefully. Yet it is precisely from the literal meaning that the most wonderful spiritual significance emerges.

In occult terminology, what lies in bed today is called the actual earthly human being. This was "the human being." But the being in whom the I dwells day and night, and who has been born out of the physical and etheric bodies, was called the "child of man" or the "Son of Man." The Son of Man is the I and the astral body as they emerged, during Earth's evolution, from the physical and etheric bodies. "Son of Man" is the technical term for this.

This "Son of Man," who has loosened himself from the bosom of the Godhead and separated from the connection in which he once existed, but in doing so has won physical consciousness, is meant—through the power of Christ, who appeared on Earth—to regain consciousness of the spiritual. He is not meant merely to see the physical surroundings with physical senses; through the power of his own inner being, now unconscious to him, awareness of divine existence is meant to dawn within him. Through the power of Christ, who came to Earth, the Son of Man is to be raised again to the divine. In earlier times, only a select few could look into the divine-spiritual world through the old mystery initiations. There was a technical term for such people in ancient times. Those who were permitted to look into the divine-spiritual world and become witnesses to it were called "serpents." In ancient times, "serpents" were people initiated in this way into the mysteries. These "serpents" were forerunners of the deed of Christ Jesus. Moses demonstrated his mission by raising before his people the symbol of the exaltation of those able to look into the spiritual worlds: he raised up the serpent (Numbers 21:8–9). Through Christ's power on Earth, every Son of Man was meant to become what these individuals had been. Christ expresses this later in the conversation with Nicodemus, saying:

“As the serpent was once lifted up by Moses, so must the Son of Man be lifted up!” (3:14)
GA103

GA112
A time came when, within the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth, the etheric body was made freer and less closely bound to the physical body. As a result, it gained greater mastery over the physical body. In a sense, it could perform even more powerful deeds within the physical body than before; that is, it could employ powerful forces right into the physical body itself. The potential for this had been established at the baptism by John. Now this potential was to be developed in a special way. All of this was to take place from the spiritual side. The astral body was to work so powerfully within the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth that the etheric body gained such power over the physical body.

How can the astral body act so powerfully? By acquiring the right feelings and giving itself over to appropriate feelings concerning what happens in our surroundings, and above all by establishing a proper relationship to human egoism. Did Christ act in this way through the body of Jesus of Nazareth? Did he act so as to establish a proper relationship to all the egoism around him and bring the egoistic nature of people’s souls to light? Yes, he did. The author of the Gospel of John tells us how Christ appears as the purifier of the Temple against those who indulge their egoism and profane the Temple by selling all kinds of things in it. In this way, he gains the ability to say that he has made the astral body so powerful that, if the physical body were to perish, he could rebuild it in three days. The author of the Gospel of John also indicates this:

“Jesus answered and said unto them, Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up. Then said the Jews, Forty and six years was this temple in building, and wilt thou rear it up in three days? But he spake of the temple of his body.” (2:19–21)

This indicates that the sheath which has been sacrificed to him now has the power to direct the physical body so completely that it is master within it. And because this body has now become so free, it can move anywhere independently of the laws of the physical world; regardless of the ordinary laws of space, it can bring about and direct events in the spiritual world. Does it do so? Yes. This is indicated in the chapter that follows the account of the cleansing of the Temple.

“There was a man of the Pharisees, named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews; the same came to Jesus by night, and said unto him …” (3:1–2)

Why does it say “by night”? The most trivial explanation imaginable is that the Jew was afraid to come to Jesus in broad daylight and sneaked in through the window at night. Anyone can offer such an explanation. “By night” here means nothing other than that the meeting between Christ and Nicodemus took place in the astral world, the spiritual world, and not in the surroundings perceived through ordinary waking consciousness. Christ could now converse with Nicodemus outside the physical body, “by night,” when the physical body was not present—when the astral body was outside the physical and etheric bodies.
GA112

GA103
Above all, I would like to remind you of a passage that can open up a deep understanding if you grasp it correctly: the passage in chapter 3, verses 31 to 34, which must of course be read with the awareness that John the Baptist is speaking these words:

“He that cometh from above is above all: he that is of the earth is earthly, and speaketh of the earth. He that cometh from heaven is above all. And what he hath seen and heard, that he testifieth; and no man receiveth his testimony. He that hath received his testimony hath set to his seal that God is true. For he whom God hath sent speaketh the words of God: for God giveth not the Spirit by measure.”

I would like to meet someone who genuinely understands these words in this translation. What is the contrast meant by “He who comes from God speaks God’s words, for God does not give the Spirit by measure”? What do these sentences mean?

Through countless discourses, Christ wishes to say: When I speak of the I, I speak of the eternal I in the human being, which is one with the spiritual ground of the world. When I speak of this I, I speak of something that dwells in the innermost depths of the human soul. If someone listens to me but speaks only from the lower self, which feels nothing of the eternal, that person does not accept my testimony and does not understand me at all. For I cannot speak of something that simply flows from me into that person; otherwise, the person would not be independent. Each person must find within himself, as his eternal ground, the God I proclaim. Just a few verses earlier you will find the passage:

“And John also was baptizing in Aenon near to Salim, because there was much water there: and they came, and were baptized. For John was not yet cast into prison. Then there arose a question between some of John’s disciples and the Jews about purifying” (3:23–25)—that is, about the form of baptism. When such a question was raised in this circle, people were always speaking about the connection with the divine, about the human being’s immersion in matter, and about how, according to the old idea of God, people were connected with the divine through the group soul. The others then came and told John that Jesus was also baptizing. John had to explain that what was entering the world through Jesus was something quite special. He explained that Jesus was not teaching the connection symbolized by the old baptism, but rather how the human being is guided by the free gift of the now-independent I. Each person must discover the “I am”—God—within himself; only then can a person find the divine within. Read in this way, the listener realizes that He himself, the “I am,” is sent by God. One who is sent by God to kindle the “God” in this way proclaims God in the true sense, no longer through blood kinship.

Now let us translate this passage as it truly means. We can find the basis for doing so if we understand the teachings of the ancients. These were written down artfully in many books. We need only recall the Psalms, where the divine is proclaimed in the Old Testament through beautifully structured speech. There, people speak of the old ties of blood as the bond with a god. One could learn all this, but one learned nothing more from it than one’s connection with that old deity. To understand Christ, however, one did not need all the old laws and elaborate forms. Christ’s teaching could be grasped to the extent that one apprehended the spiritual I within oneself. One might not yet have full knowledge of the Godhead, but one could understand what was heard from the lips of Christ Jesus; that was the prerequisite. One no longer needed all the Psalms or all the artfully constructed teachings, but only the simplest expressions—babbling utterances. One need only babble in one’s words and one could bear witness to God. Even the simplest, babbling words could suffice; they did not need to have any “measure.” Whoever merely babbled, yet felt in the I that he was sent by God, could understand what Christ said. Whoever knew only an earthly connection with God spoke in the metre of the Psalms, but all that metre led to nothing beyond the old gods. The person who feels rooted in the spiritual worlds is above all and can bear witness to what he has seen and heard in those worlds. But those who accept testimony only in the customary way do not accept such a person’s testimony. If some do accept it, their acceptance shows that they feel themselves to be sent by God. They do not merely believe; they

understand what the other person says, and by their understanding they themselves seal the words. “Whoever feels the I reveals God’s words even in babbling.” That is what this means. The Spirit referred to here need not express itself through metre or measured syllables; it can speak in the simplest, babbling way. Such words can easily be taken as a licence to be unwise. But anyone who rejects wisdom because, in their opinion, the highest mysteries must be expressed in the simplest form does so—often unconsciously—out of a certain inclination toward spiritual laziness. When it is said, “God does not give the Spirit by measure,” the point is simply that measure does not lead to the Spirit. Where the Spirit is truly present, however, measure also arises. Not everyone who has measure has the Spirit, but whoever has the Spirit will certainly attain measure. One must not reverse the argument: lacking measure is not a sign of possessing the Spirit, just as having measure is not itself a sign of the Spirit. Scholarship is certainly not proof of wisdom, but neither is ignorance.

Thus we are shown that Christ appeals to the independent I that has developed in every human soul. Here “measure” should be understood in a way similar to “metre,” as artfully constructed language. The preceding sentence literally means: “The one who apprehends God in the ‘I am’ bears witness to divine speech, or God’s language, even in babbling, and finds the way to God.”
G103

Chapter 4.

GA103
Now let us consider the outward sign through which the Logos flows down to the Israelites insofar as they can grasp it conceptually, in thought. This outward sign is the “manna” of the wilderness. Manna is in truth—those who know occult science are aware of this—the same word as Manas, the Spirit-Self. Thus the first glimmer of the Spirit-Self flows into a humanity that has gradually attained consciousness of the I. But what lives and comes into being within Manas itself may be given another name. It is not merely something one can know; it is a force one can take into oneself. When the Logos merely calls his name, one must understand and grasp him with reason. When the Logos becomes flesh and appears within humanity, he is an impulse of power brought among human beings—not merely a teaching or concept, but a force present in the world in which a person can participate. It is no longer called “manna,” but the “bread of life” (6:48), the technical term for Buddhi, or Life-Spirit.

The water transformed by the Spirit, offered symbolically to the Samaritan woman, and the bread of life are the first proclamation of the inflow of Buddhi, or Life-Spirit, into the human being.
GA103

GA094
The fourth chapter of the Gospel of John shows Jesus with the Samaritan woman at Jacob’s well. Here Jacob represents the tribal deity, and the well represents the old tradition from which one must draw, but which does not satisfy. “Then saith the woman of Samaria unto him, How is it that thou, being a Jew, askest drink of me, which am a woman of Samaria?” (For the Jews have no dealings with the Samaritans.) Here we have the old law. But a new life-principle was to take the place of what flowed through tribal blood: Buddhi. “Whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life.”

The divine human being united with the human soul; Buddhi descended into Manas, and from then on humanity could draw its awareness of good and evil from another source, the spring of “living water,” rather than from the well of Father Jacob, the Mosaic law. This, and no other, is the sense in which the conversation between Christ Jesus and the Samaritan woman at the well is to be understood.

GA094

GA097
In the fourth chapter comes the encounter with the Samaritan woman. The Lord says to her: “You have had five husbands, and the one you now have is not your husband.” She is to be raised up to the higher self. To do this, she had to pass through the lower bodies. These are the former husbands. Now she must be united with the higher self, which is the new husband.
GA097

GA100
At the beginning of the post-Atlantean age, we still find remnants of blood kinship. Christ’s words, “Whoever does not leave father and mother … cannot be my disciple,” point to the stage of humanity in the sixth age. Then the one universal spirit of humanity will rule in place of the spirits of peoples, tribes, and races. Human beings will no longer be sons of their tribe or people, but sons of humanity, Sons of Man.

Indeed, Christ is the first who rightly bears this name (John 3:13–14). Even then, he behaved as human beings will behave when they become Sons of Man.

This is expressed by Christ’s going to the Samaritan woman, for the Samaritans had no dealings with the Jews. What human beings carry within themselves, and what makes their development possible, is feminine and passive in relation to the spirit, which represents the fertilizing, masculine, active principle. The continual influence of the masculine on the feminine principle first brings about the development of the etheric body, then the astral body, the sentient soul, the intellectual soul, and the consciousness soul. The Spirit-Self then takes shape in the latter. This is indicated in Christ’s conversation with the Samaritan woman (4:18) in the words: “You have had five husbands, and the one you now have is not your husband.” The five husbands the woman has had are the five spiritual bodies that acted upon the physical body; the sixth, the Spirit-Self, is no longer a husband in the old sense. The other five are lower, transient stages of development, while the sixth—the Spirit-Self, the divine and eternal—represents what is everlasting. Thus, in the conversation with the Samaritan woman, we also see Christ Jesus proclaiming the coming age.
GA100

GA112
Once again, something had to precede this that would show how Christ worked within the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth, making the power of that threefold sheath ever greater. He worked by healing, which means that he could pour his power into another soul. He could do this only by acting in the way he describes in his conversation with the Samaritan woman at the well: “I am the living water!” Earlier, at the wedding in Cana, he had presented himself as an initiate of the fifth degree, one who had mastery over the elements. Now he presents himself as one who is himself within these elements, living in them.
GA112

GA103
The other thing shown to us is that Christ seeks to fulfil a mission that goes beyond mere blood ties. This is made very clear by his going to the Samaritan woman at the well. He gives her the instruction he wishes to give to those whose I has been lifted out of the community of blood.

“Then cometh he to a city of Samaria, which is called Sychar, near to the parcel of ground that Jacob gave to his son Joseph. Now Jacob’s well was there. Jesus therefore, being wearied with his journey, sat thus on the well: and it was about the sixth hour. There cometh a woman of Samaria to draw water: Jesus saith unto her, Give me to drink. (For his disciples were gone away unto the city to buy meat.) Then saith the woman of Samaria unto him, How is it that thou, being a Jew, askest drink of me, which am a woman of Samaria? (For the Jews have no dealings with the Samaritans.)” (4:5–9)

The point is that it is something special for Christ to go to a people whose I’s have been lifted out of the group soul and uprooted from it. This is the essential point. The account of the royal official further shows that Christ breaks through not only the blood ties that unite people through marriages within a nation, but also the class divisions formed along blood lines. He comes to those whose I is, so to speak, uprooted: he heals the son of the royal official, who, from the Jewish point of view, is a foreigner. Everywhere we are shown that Christ is the missionary of the independent I found in every human individuality. Therefore he can also say: when I speak of myself, in a higher sense I am not speaking of the I that resides within me; when I speak of the “I am,” I speak of a being, of something each person finds within himself. My I is one with the Father; but the I present in every personality is one with the Father. This is also the deeper meaning of Christ’s teaching to the Samaritan woman at the well.
GA103

GA264
The Gospel of John (4:47–54) tells of the son of a royal officer—the Roman official—who was gravely ill. In him, the fourth post-Atlantean age, the Greco-Roman age, is wasting away. Christ heals him at the father’s request because the father believed even without “signs and wonders.” The son is not raised from the dead, because he has not died. The fourth age was still alive at the time of Christ Jesus; it was merely ill and could be healed only through faith. For the Greco-Roman age could receive the power of Christ within itself only in the form of faith.
GA264

GA112
The second of the signs, as you know from the Gospel of John, is the healing of the son of a royal official. How is the official’s son healed? Here too, you will recognize the right meaning only if you read the Gospel of John in the proper measure and pay attention to the most important words in the relevant chapter. In verse 50 of chapter 4, after the official has told Jesus of Nazareth of his distress, we read:

“Jesus saith unto him, Go thy way; thy son liveth. And the man believed the word that Jesus had spoken unto him, and he went his way.”

Once again, there were two souls in harmony: the soul of Christ and the soul of the boy’s father. How does Christ’s word, “Go thy way; thy son liveth,” work? It kindles in the other soul the power to believe the word that has been spoken. These two forces worked together. Christ’s word had the power to kindle belief in the official’s soul. Had the man not believed, the son would not have recovered. One force acts upon the other; both are needed. Here, however, we have a greater degree of Christ’s power. At the wedding in Cana, the power of the mother was still needed to strengthen Christ’s power so that it could act at all. Now the time has come when Christ’s power can pour the word that kindles faith into the official’s soul. Christ’s power has increased.
GA112

Chapter 5.

GA112
Let us now turn to the third of the signs: the healing of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years at the pool of Bethesda. Here, once again, we must read the most important words, which shed light on the whole matter. They are the words:

“Jesus saith unto him, Rise, take up thy bed, and walk.”

Earlier, when explaining why he had to remain lying there, the sick man had said that he could not move:

“Sir, I have no man, when the water is troubled, to put me into the pool: but while I am coming, another steppeth down before me.” (5:7)

Christ speaks to him—and it is important that this takes place on a Sabbath, a time of celebration and of the highest expression of human love—and puts what he wishes to say in these words: “Rise, take up thy bed, and walk!” (5:8). We must connect these words with another statement he makes, which is equally important:

“Behold, thou art made whole: sin no more, lest a worse thing come unto thee.” (5:14)

What does this mean? It means that the illness of the man who had been sick for thirty-eight years was connected with his sin. We will not discuss here whether this sin was committed in this life or a previous one. What matters to us is that Christ poured into his soul the power to do something that reaches into the other person’s moral and soul life. Here we see Christ’s power increase once again. Previously, the effect was limited to bringing about something physical. Now, however, there is an illness that Christ himself says is connected with the sick man’s sin. At this moment Christ knows how to intervene in the man’s own soul. Previously the father was still needed; now Christ’s power acts directly within the sick man’s soul. This takes on a special significance because it happens on the Sabbath. People today no longer have a proper feeling for such things. But for someone who followed the Old Testament, the fact that it happened on the Sabbath meant something: it was quite extraordinary. That is why the Jews were especially outraged that the healed man carried his bed on the Sabbath. This is a remarkably important detail. People should learn to think when they read the Gospels! They should not take it for granted that the sick man could be healed, that someone who had been unable to walk for thirty-eight years now walked. They should reflect on a passage such as this:

“The Jews therefore said unto him that was cured, It is the sabbath day: it is not lawful for thee to carry thy bed.” (5:10)

What struck them was not that he had been healed, but that he carried his bed on the Sabbath! The healing of this man therefore included the whole situation: the deed was performed precisely on the sacred day. Christ himself holds the thought that if the Sabbath is truly to be holy to God, then souls must receive special strength from divine power on that day. Through this strength he acts upon the person standing before him; that is, it is transferred into the sick man’s own soul. Previously the man had found no strength within his soul capable of overcoming the consequences of sin; now he receives this strength through the action of Christ’s power. Once again, Christ’s power has increased.
GA112

GA264
Immediately after this account in the Gospel of John comes the healing of the sick man at Bethesda, the pool with five porches. These porches signify the fifth post-Atlantean period, with all the forces of earlier cultural periods that live within it. The people lying there are ill: they do not have the right relationship to the spiritual world and have fallen too deeply into matter. From time to time an angel descends and stirs the water. A new revelation from the spiritual worlds heals those who are nearest to it, but it no longer helps those who come later. Thus there was a man who had waited thirty-eight years without reaching the water in time. Thirty-eight is twice nineteen, and nineteen years is the period after which the Sun, Moon, and Earth again stand in the same relationship to one another. In other words, it is the period in which human thinking, feeling, and willing pass through all kinds of variations in their relationship to one another. Thus nineteen years represents an incarnation, and the thirty-eight years point to the two incarnations that, on average, humanity has experienced since the appearance of Christ Jesus. These bring us up to our own time, when a renewed revelation of Christ from the spiritual world will take place. Christ does not heal the sick man by letting him into the water when the angel descends; instead, he says to him, “Rise, take up thy bed, and walk!” That is, he strengthens within the man the power capable of overcoming the illness. But the man did not know who had healed him, “for Jesus had conveyed himself away, a multitude being in that place” (John 5:13). Christ had indeed acted within him, but the man was not aware of it in his upper consciousness. This is how it had been throughout the period from the Mystery of Golgotha up to our own time. Later, however, “Jesus findeth him in the temple,” and the man went away and declared that Jesus had made him whole.

Now he knew that the word spoken by Christ Jesus to the Jews was true: “My Father worketh hitherto, and I work.” Christ further says: “The hour is coming, and now is, when the dead shall hear the voice of the Son of God: and they that hear shall live”—the hour that is about to strike in our present age, when Christ will assume the office of judge over the dead and become Lord of Karma. In many ways, then, this account of the healing at Bethesda points toward our own time.
GA264

GA094
Christ himself is the living consciousness of the Earth’s Akashic Record. Therefore the Father has entrusted judgment to him, and he has the power to forgive sins and take them upon himself (John 5:21–23): “For as the Father raiseth up the dead, and quickeneth them; even so the Son quickeneth whom he will. For the Father judgeth no man, but hath committed all judgment unto the Son: that all men should honour the Son, even as they honour the Father. He that honoureth not the Son honoureth not the Father which hath sent him.”
GA094

GA100
Let us first recall Christ Jesus’ conversation with the Samaritan woman (chapter 4, verse 7 and following). Christ speaks the significant words: “Thou hast had five husbands; and he whom thou now hast is not thy husband.” The number five appears once more in the healing of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years (chapter 5:5). The pool of Bethesda has five porches. Let us look more closely at the significance of this mystical number five. Consider the human being in relation to the evolution of humanity. As we have seen, the human being consists of nine parts, which can be reduced to seven. In human development, these seven bodies unfold gradually. In people today, not all seven members have yet developed. The average person has developed as far as the consciousness soul; the Spirit-Self is only at the beginning of its development.

In the sixth and seventh ages, through the power of Christ, the Spirit-Self and Life-Spirit will develop in those who turn to Christ. They will also attain healthy thinking and healthy feeling. Christianity brings great health and great healing. Christ's life-force overcomes all illness and death. The human body developed as a solid body out of the fluid, and spiritual science therefore regards the fluid element as the bodily element. The five porches surrounding the pool of Bethesda signify the five ages through which humanity moves ever more deeply into corporeality, until at their end it has become wholly bound to matter. Only after these five periods have been traversed can human beings become well. Anyone who has succumbed to these five porches cannot be healed unless the great healer, Christ, comes to them. Then what is described in the fifth chapter of the Gospel of John takes place. The account of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years is thus a prophetic foretelling of what will occur in the sixth epoch, when human beings will no longer need remedies because they will be their own healers.
GA100

GA112
The next sign is the healing of the son of the royal official, followed by the healing of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years at the pool of Bethesda. What increase in the forces through which Christ worked on Earth is present here? The increase consisted in this: Christ could now act not only upon the people physically present around him. At the wedding in Cana, he acted so that when the people drank the water, it was wine. In other words, he acted upon the etheric bodies of those around him. By allowing his power to stream into their etheric bodies, the water became wine in the mouths of those who drank it—that is, they experienced the water as wine. Now, however, the effect was meant to reach not only the body but the deepest part of the soul. Only in this way could he act, through the mediation of the father, upon the son of the royal official. And only in this way could he act within the sinful soul of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years. It would not have been enough merely to pour his forces into the etheric body. The astral body had to be affected, because it is the astral body that commits sin. By acting upon the etheric body one can transform water into wine, but to continue acting upon another individual one must intervene at a deeper level. For this, Christ had to continue working with the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth.

Take careful note: this does not make Christ into someone else; rather, he works upon the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth. In the period that followed, he worked upon it in such a way that the etheric body could become freer from the physical body than it had been before.
GA112

Chapter 6.

GA112
The fourth sign is the feeding of the five thousand. Here again we must focus on the most important words. Which are they? In such matters, we must remember that we cannot view an event through the consciousness of the present day. If those who wrote about Christ at the time when the Gospel of John was composed had believed what our materialistic age believes today, they would truly have written differently, because different things would have caught their attention. The most important words—the other details do not particularly attract their notice, not even the fact that five thousand people could be fed with so little—are these:

"Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to the disciples, and the disciples to them that were set down; and likewise of the fishes as much as they would." (6:11)

What is Christ Jesus doing here? To accomplish what was to happen, he makes use of the souls of his disciples, those who were with him and had gradually matured toward his stature. They are part of the event. They surround him, and through them he can now awaken a soul-force of beneficence. His power streams into the souls of the disciples. We will speak further about how what happened here could take place. But once again we notice an increase in his power. Earlier he had allowed his power to flow into the soul of the man who had been ill for thirty-eight years. Now his power acts upon the forces within the disciples' souls. The tension of forces flowing from the Lord's soul to the souls of the disciples is at work here. The power has expanded from the soul of one person to the souls of others. It has grown stronger. What lives in Christ's soul is now already alive in the souls of the disciples as well.
GA112

GA100
What does the Earth do with its forces? If a seed is placed in the soil, it sprouts and bears fruit. It multiplies: from one, many arise. In the same way, one animal produces many through reproduction. The same force of increase and multiplication is also at work in Christ, and it is indicated in the feeding of the five thousand. Christ possesses the Earth's inherent power to multiply seeds. If we keep in mind the thought that "Christ's body is the Earth with its forces" and apply it to what is reported in the Gospel of John, many details become understandable.
GA100

GA112
The author of the Gospel of John has told us this, if only we take the Gospel seriously. Does he say anywhere that even the few loaves and fish were eaten in the ordinary physical way? Nowhere, even if you read the entire Gospel of John. If you take every word literally, he tells you clearly that Christ broke the bread but offered a prayer of thanks to heaven:

"Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to the disciples, and the disciples to them that were set down; and likewise of the fishes as much as they would." (6:11)

But the meaning of these words in the original text—which is poorly rendered in the German—is approximately this: the disciples passed the loaves and fish along, and allowed each person to do with them as he wished.

Yet no one wanted to do anything other than experience, at that moment, the power streaming from the mighty etheric body of Christ Jesus. No one wanted anything else. And how were they satisfied? Verse 23 says:

"Howbeit there came other boats from Tiberias nigh unto the place where they did eat bread, after that the Lord had given thanks."

They had eaten the bread through the Lord's prayer! They had eaten bread without the physical act taking place. This enabled Christ Jesus afterward to interpret what had happened by saying, "I am the bread of life!"

What, then, had they eaten? They had eaten the power of Christ's body! What could remain? Only the power of Christ's body could remain. It had worked so strongly that something could still be gathered up afterward.

According to occult understanding, every body consists of twelve members. The highest member is called Aries; the next, Taurus; the part where the two hands are, Gemini; the chest, Cancer; the region of the heart, Leo; the lower torso, Virgo; then the hips, Libra; below that, Scorpio; then Sagittarius, the thighs; Capricorn, the knees; Aquarius, the lower legs; and the feet are Pisces.

The human body is well founded as a structure of twelve members. If one gathers what remains after using the power of Christ's body for nourishment, it must be gathered in twelve measures!

"Therefore they gathered them together, and filled twelve baskets with the fragments of the five barley loaves, which remained over and above unto them that had eaten." (6:13)

They had not eaten the barley loaves. They had consumed the power that had flowed from Christ, and they had been satisfied by the power that came from Christ through the thanksgiving prayer, as Christ appealed to the spheres from which he had descended.
GA112

GA094
The "mountain" has always been an expression for ascent, as, for example, the summit of the mountain at the feeding of the five thousand.

What Christ Jesus did when he fulfilled the saying "I am the bread of life" (John 6:48)—the feeding of the five thousand—is not merely an event belonging to that time, but one of deep and lasting significance. The Earth is the body of Christ Jesus: the few seeds, the disciples, are multiplied. These are among the reasons Christianity is so great: the physical and the moral correspond so wonderfully. The most remarkable monism is expressed in Christianity through the way John presents it.

Consider also how Christ Jesus contrasts his mission with the events in the wilderness: "Your fathers did eat manna in the wilderness, and are dead. I give you another bread; I am the bread of life." Moses gave bread in the wilderness; Christ gives the bread of life.

Since Lemuria, Manas has been prepared and formed in opposition to what developed in the lower kingdoms. Manas enters the physical body through the senses; death is conditioned by Manas—without Manas there would be no death. This is the meaning of the passage in the Gospel of John: "Your fathers did eat manna, and are dead." One cannot die through the bread of life. Christ is the one who brings about renewed etheric development. The Christ impulse is the entry of Buddhi. Manas is therefore a transitional stage, which occurred when, in Lemuria, the etheric body entered the physical body. Through Christ, Buddhi is brought into the etheric body from within. Christianity brings this principle of enlivening from within: "I am the bread of life." As long as human beings have been bound to the physical body and to the principle of heredity, they have been unable to look beyond death. This becomes possible when the life-body, the etheric body, can be enlivened from within by Buddhi, when Manas receives Buddhi. Moses is therefore the messenger of Manas, while Christ brings Buddhi. At this stage, an initiate can be outside the body.
GA094

GA112
And further: the fifth sign, recounted in the same chapter, begins as follows:

"And when even was now come, his disciples went down unto the sea, and entered into a ship, and went over the sea toward Capernaum. And it was now dark, and Jesus was not come to them. And the

sea arose by reason of a great wind. So when they had rowed about five and twenty or thirty furlongs, they see Jesus walking on the sea, and drawing nigh unto the ship: and they were afraid." (6:16–19)

Those who publish Gospels today, for example, place an utterly unnecessary heading over this passage: "Jesus walks on the sea," as though that were what the chapter says. Where does it say, "Jesus walks on the sea"? It says, "The disciples saw Jesus walking on the sea." That is the point. We must take the Gospels literally. Christ's power had once again increased! Through the natural strengthening brought by practising his recent deeds, it had become so strong that Christ's power could now do more than act from one soul to another or communicate the forces of Christ's soul to other souls: Christ could live in his own form before the soul of another person who was capable of perceiving him. The event is this: someone is in another place, and his power is so strong that it affects people far away. Christ's power now acts so strongly that it does not merely awaken a force in the disciples, as it did among those who sat with him on the mountain—the force there had passed to the disciples so that the miracle could occur. Now, even though they cannot see the place where Christ is with their physical eyes, they have the power to see Christ and behold his own form. Christ could become visible at a distance to those with whom a bond of soul had already been established. His own form had now reached the point where it could be seen spiritually. At the very moment when the disciples' ability to see physically fades, their ability to see spiritually emerges all the more strongly, and they see Christ. Seeing at a distance is such that the image of the object appears as though it were immediately nearby. Once again, Christ's power has increased.

Thus Christ, dwelling within the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth, had prepared it for the next deeds: acting within other souls. The soul within the threefold sheath of Jesus of Nazareth had to become so free that it could act into other bodies. But acting within another soul is something quite different from the kind of effect we considered yesterday. This is the next increase in power: the feeding of the five thousand and walking on the sea. Something more was required for Christ to be seen bodily even when he was not physically present—not only by the disciples, but, such was the strength already present in the body of Jesus of Nazareth, also by those who were not his disciples. Here again, however, we must read the Gospel of John correctly, for someone might say: "I can readily believe this of the disciples, but not of others."

"The day following, when the people which stood on the other side of the sea saw that there was none other boat there, save that one whereinto his disciples were entered, and that Jesus went not with his disciples into the boat, but that his disciples were gone away alone; (Howbeit there came other boats from Tiberias nigh unto the place where they did eat bread after the Lord had given thanks.) When the people therefore saw that Jesus was not there, neither his disciples, they also took shipping, and came to Capernaum, seeking for Jesus."

I ask you expressly to note that the people were seeking Jesus, and that it is then said:

"And when they had found him on the other side of the sea, they said unto him, Rabbi, when camest thou hither?" (6:22–26)

This means exactly the same thing as it does in the case of the disciples. It does not say that every ordinary eye saw him; it says that those who sought him and found him saw him through an elevation of their soul-force. To say that "someone saw another person" is different from saying that "the other person stood there as a spatial, fleshly form visible to physical eyes." What people usually call "taking the Gospel literally" in ordinary life is, in fact, the least literal way of taking the Gospel.
GA112

Chapter 7.

GA093
The moment that we must recognize as the instant when spiritual life flowed into self-conscious humanity is indicated precisely in the Gospel, in the New Testament. This moment is indicated in the deepest of the Gospels, the Gospel of John—which present-day theology fails to understand—where Jesus is described as attending the Feast of Tabernacles. There the founder of Christianity speaks of pouring spiritual life out over humanity. It is a remarkable passage. The Feast of Tabernacles consisted of going to a spring from which water flowed. A festival then developed that pointed to the need for people to turn their thoughts once more to the spiritual, to the nature of the devas, and to spiritual striving. The water drawn there served as a reminder of the soul-spiritual realm. After repeatedly declining, Jesus nevertheless went to the festival. And on the last day of the festival, the following took place (John 7:37): On the last, greatest day of the festival, it is said, Jesus stood up and cried, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink!” Those who drank were celebrating a festival of remembrance for spiritual life. Jesus, however, connects something else with it, as John indicates in these words: “Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture says, out of his body will flow rivers of living water.” He said this about the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were to receive; for the Holy Spirit had not yet come, because Jesus had not yet been glorified.

Humanity descended all the way into the physical body, so that, unlike the nature of the devas, the human being consists of three principles: spirit, soul, and body. The deva stands above the human being, but does not have to overcome physical nature as the human being does. This physical nature must be transfigured so that it can receive spiritual life. The human being’s physiological consciousness —the physical body as it lives today—is itself to kindle freely within itself the spark of spiritual life.

Christ’s sacrifice is an example of how the human being can develop higher consciousness out of physical life. The lower self lives in the physical body, but it must be kindled so that the higher self may develop. Only then can streams of living water flow from this physical body as well. Then the spirit can appear; then the spirit can pour itself out. In this sense, the human being as an ego must become as though dead to this physiological life.

Only when considered together with the mystery of Pentecost does the Easter mystery present a complete whole: how the human ego, in the great representative, relinquishes the lower, living self and dies away in order to transfigure physical nature completely and return it to the divine powers. The Ascension is the symbol of this. When the human being has transfigured this physical body
and restored it to the spiritual, then the human being is ready for spiritual life to pour into them, and to experience what, according to the explanation of humanity’s greatest representative, is called the “outpouring of the Holy Spirit.” Hence it is also said: “There are three that bear witness on earth: the blood, the water, and the spirit.” Pentecost is the outpouring of the Spirit into humanity.
GA093

Chapter 8.

GA112
Try to understand properly the sermons of those who were the leaders of the ancient Hebrew people. They stood before their people and said: You have reached the point where each person emphasizes their personal self within themselves, where everyone seeks their being only within themselves. But you advance your development if you put the personal ego to death and summon all those forces that

bring you to the awareness that you all descend from Abraham and are connected back to Abraham, that you are members of the great organism extending back to Abraham. If you are told, “I and Father Abraham are one,” and take this into yourselves while setting aside everything personal, then you have the right consciousness that leads you to the divine, for the path to the divine passes through the forefather. The Hebrew people had preserved longest the essential principle in the leadership of those who fought the Luciferic influence.

Christ transformed the teaching of the ancient initiates and said: There is a way for people to cultivate their own individuality, not merely to follow the physical bonds of blood kinship, but to look into their own ego and seek and find the divine there! The force we have characterized as the Christ impulse makes it possible, if we unite with it, to establish a spiritual bond of brotherhood from person to person despite the individuality of the ego. Thus the power of Christ was different from that which prevailed in the circle into which he had been placed. There people said: “I and Father Abraham are one! I must know this if I am to find my way back to the divine.” But Christ said: “There is another Father through whom the ego will find its way to the divine; for the ego, the ‘I am,’ and the divine are one! There is an eternal reality you can find if you remain within yourself.” Therefore Christ could describe the power he wished to impart to humanity in the words of the Gospel of John: “Before Abraham was, the I AM was!” And “I AM” was none other than the name Christ gave himself. If a person kindles this awareness—something lives within me that existed long before Abraham; I need not go back to Abraham, for I find the divine Father-Spirit within me!—then they can transform for the good what came through Lucifer to cultivate and develop the ego, and what had led to humanity’s hindrance. This is Christ’s deed: he transformed Lucifer’s influence into good.
GA112

GA094
Now read how this process is depicted symbolically in John 8:58–59: “Jesus said to them, ‘Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am.’ Then they picked up stones to throw at him. But Jesus hid himself and went out of the temple, passing through their midst”—through the obstacles. This brings the eighth chapter to a close. It describes the astral body emerging from the physical body.

John 8:3–11 tells of Christ and the woman caught in adultery. Christ wrote signs of occult script on the ground with his finger in order to bring about the right thought-forms in the accusing crowd and prompt them to do what was right in that moment. “Let the one who is without sin cast the first stone at her.” He entrusts her guilt to karma, to the justice that restores balance. Christ meant to say: every deed carries its own reward. “Go, and sin no more.”

When Christ says, “Before Father Abraham was, I am,” he points to the higher consciousness living within him. When the crowd wants to stone him, he goes “out of the temple” (John 8:58–59)—that is, he rises to a consciousness inaccessible to his persecutors.

In the moral world, everything is connected like cause and effect, and judgment belongs to what is exercised by the deepest and purest being of the Earth. In occult writing, everything a person has done is inscribed in the Akashic Chronicle. Once this is understood in the future, people will no longer punish in a worldly way. In John 8:1–11, in the story of the woman caught in adultery, Christ shows how justice will be administered in the future. What Christ says and does is intended to show that everything a person has done is inscribed in the Earth’s Akashic Chronicle. This is the direct handing over of judgment to the self-fulfilling law of karma.
GA094

GA100
We find another passage in the Gospel that recalls the teaching of karma. There is a remarkable passage in chapter eight: when the Pharisees asked Jesus for his opinion of the woman caught in adultery, he bent down (verses 6 and 8) without saying a word and wrote on the ground with his finger. As we have seen, the Earth is his own body. He does not condemn the woman, but inscribes her deed into his own organism. He thereby indicates that, just as a seed placed in the earth sprouts and bears fruit corresponding to it, every human deed will likewise sprout in a later earthly life and bear the corresponding fruit—and that no earthly power can remove the consequences of a deed.

We see, then, that the law of karma is also mentioned in the Gospel of John, and that its existence in no way impairs freedom of action. Through the single act of self-sacrifice, Christ Jesus entered into a relationship with all humanity. According to the law of karma, every deed is inscribed in the book of life's debts. It is brought into connection with Christ's body, with the Earth. Thus he does not judge the woman caught in adultery in that moment, but inscribes the deed into his own body. He takes into his own body everything that can happen from one person to another, just as karma must always work itself out again in the earthly world. This story points, with profound significance, to the fact that through his deed Christ connected himself with the karmic development of all humanity. He guides humanity's future development.
GA100

GA112
It was the same being that the Rishis knew as Vishva Karman. What would Vishva Karman have had to say of himself—not if the Rishis had spoken, but if he himself had spoken? He is the exalted Sun Spirit, working as spirit in the light; he would have had to say: "I am the light of the world!" What would Ahura Mazda have had to say if he had wished to speak of himself? "I am the light of the world!" And what did that same spirit say when a human being had become ready to receive it within? How does that which was formerly in cosmic space, on the Sun, now speak from within a human being? "I am the light of the world!"

What resounded from cosmic heights down to Earth as the innermost self-characterization of the guiding cosmic spirit is heard echoing again from within a human being, when that being has taken up residence in a human interior. It sounds from Jesus of Nazareth, rightly, when Christ is within him: "I am the light of the world!"

Christ thus stood before humanity teaching, to the extent that it could understand, the idea of reincarnation. He taught karma: the causes of one embodiment extending into another. He taught it as one teaches practically for life. He meant to say: A future will come when all people acknowledge karma and understand that when someone does something evil, no external earthly power need punish them, because that evil necessarily brings about a balancing of accounts in this or a later incarnation. Then we need only inscribe the deed in the great book of the Akashic Chronicle, in the spiritual world,

"But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives. Early in the morning he came again into the temple, and all the people came to him; and he sat down and taught them. The scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to him who had been caught in adultery, placed her in the midst, and said to him: 'Teacher, this woman was caught in the very act of adultery. Moses commanded us in the law to stone such women. What do you say?' They said this to test him, so that they might have something to accuse him of. But Jesus bent down and wrote with his finger on the ground." (8:1–6)

What did he write? He inscribed the sin into the spiritual world. And from the spiritual world, the sin will find its balancing! He also reminds the others to ask whether they themselves are conscious of no sin. Only if they had nothing to make amends for could they claim to have no connection with this woman's sin and judge her. Yet they cannot know whether in a former life they themselves laid the causes of what now befalls them; they cannot know whether they may have led this woman to adultery in a previous life, or whether they themselves committed this sin or laid its causes in earlier lives. Everything is inscribed in karma. Jesus wrote on the Earth, which he had already permeated with his spiritual light; that is, he entrusted to the Earth what was to become the adulterous woman's karma. He meant: Follow the paths I now set out for you! Become such that you say: We do not judge; we leave what is within a person to karmic rebalancing! When people follow this, they come to karma. Karma need not be taught as dogma. It was taught through an act. Thus Christ taught it.

If Christ is to pour a force into the individuality of a human being that gives the eye the ability to become a light-sensitive organ, which it was not before, then Christ must contain the spiritual force that is present in light. This must be indicated in the Gospel of John. The chapter preceding the healing of the man born blind in the Gospel of John says:

"Again Jesus spoke to them, saying, 'I am the light of the world.'" (8:12)

The healing of the man born blind is not mentioned until this statement has first been made: "I am the light of the world."
GA112

GA103
Anyone who has not yet grasped the idea of karma in this sense has not grasped it in its depth. As long as one person judges another, they place the other under the compulsion of their own ego. But if someone truly believes in the "I AM" in the Christian sense, they do not judge; they say: I know that karma is the great force that restores balance. Whatever you have done, I do not judge! Suppose a sinner were brought before someone who truly understood Christ's words. How would that person behave toward the sinner? Suppose everyone claiming to be Christian accused this person of a grave sin. The true Christian would say: Whatever you allege, whether or not the person did it, the "I AM" must be respected; the matter must be left to karma, the great law that is itself the law of the Spirit of Christ. It must be left to Christ himself. Karma unfolds in the course of the Earth's evolution; we can leave it to this evolution to determine what punishment karma imposes. One might turn to the Earth and say to the accusers: Look to yourselves! It is for the Earth to bring the punishment to expression. Let us therefore inscribe it in the Earth, where it is already inscribed as karma!

"But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives. Early in the morning he came again into the temple, and all the people came to him; and he sat down and taught them. The scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to him who had been caught in adultery, and set her in the midst. They said to him: 'Teacher, this woman was caught in the very act of adultery. Moses commanded us in the law to stone such women. What do you say?' They said this to test him, so that they might have something to accuse him of. But Jesus bent down and wrote with his finger on the ground. When they persisted in questioning him, he straightened up and said to them: 'Let the one among you who is without sin cast the first stone at her.' And he bent down again and wrote on the ground. When they heard this, they went away one by one, beginning with the elders, each convicted by conscience; and Jesus was left alone, with the woman standing in the midst. Jesus straightened up and, seeing no one but the woman, said to her: 'Woman, where are they? Has no one condemned you?'" (8:1–10)

He says this to turn attention away from all external judgment and point toward inner karma.

“She said, ‘No one, Lord.’” (8:11)

She is left to her karma. The only thing to do is not to dwell further on the punishment being fulfilled through karma, but to improve oneself:

“And Jesus said, ‘Neither do I condemn you; go, and from now on sin no more.’” (8:11)

Thus we see how the idea of karma is connected with the deepest idea of Christ and the significance of his being for the Earth: if you have understood my being, then you have also understood the one whose being I express, and that the “I AM” brings about the balancing of accounts. Independence and inner integrity—this is what Christ gave humanity as an impulse.
GA103

GA103
The adherent of the Old Testament did not yet feel as self-contained in their individual personality as the adherent of the New Testament. The adherent of the Old Testament did not yet say, as an individual: I am an ego. They felt themselves within the whole ancient Jewish people and experienced the “group-people ego.” Let us vividly place ourselves in the consciousness of such an adherent of the Old Testament. Just as the true Christian feels the “I AM,” and will gradually learn to feel it more and more, the adherent of the Old Testament did not feel the “I AM.” They felt themselves to be a member of the whole people and looked up to the group soul. If they wished to express this, they said: My consciousness reaches back to the father of the whole people, to Abraham; we—I and Father Abraham—are one. A shared ego encompasses us all; only then do I feel sheltered in the spiritual substance of the world, when I feel myself resting within the substance of the whole people. Thus the adherent of the Old Testament looked back to Father Abraham and said: I and Father Abraham are one. The same blood flows in my veins as in Abraham’s. They felt Father Abraham to be the root from which each individual descendant of Abraham emerged as a member.

Then Christ Jesus came and said to his closest, most intimate initiates: Until now, people have judged only according to the flesh, according to blood relationship; this gave them the awareness that they rested in a higher, invisible connection. But you are to believe in a much more spiritual connection, one that goes beyond blood relationship. You are to believe in a spiritual ground of the Father in which the ego has its roots, more spiritual than the ground that unites the Jewish people as a group soul. You are to believe in that which dwells within me and within every human being, and which is not merely one with Abraham but one with the divine ground of the universe! Therefore Christ Jesus emphasized, in the sense of the Gospel of John:

“Before Father Abraham was, the I AM was!” (8:58)
GA103

GA103
Now let us listen a little to what his most intimate initiates said, and how they expressed what had been revealed to them. They said: Until then, no individual human being of flesh had existed to whom the name “I AM” could be given in the same way as to the one who first brought the full significance of the “I AM” into the world. Therefore they called “I AM” the name of Christ Jesus. It was the name through which his most intimate initiates felt united—the name they understood: “I AM.”

You must immerse yourselves in the most important chapters of the Gospel of John. Take the chapter containing the words, “I am the light of the world!” and understand them literally, quite literally. What is the “I AM” that appeared in the flesh for the first time? It is the same as that which streams toward the Earth in sunlight as the power of the Logos. Throughout the whole of chapter 8, beginning at verse 12, usually headed “Jesus, the Light of the World,” you find this profound truth about the significance of the “I AM” expressed in different words. Read the chapter by emphasizing “I” or “I AM” throughout,

remembering that “I AM” was the name through which the initiates felt united. Then you will understand it; the chapter will appear as though you should read it in something like this way:

“Then Jesus spoke to his disciples and said: What the ‘I AM’ can say of itself is the power of the light of the world; and whoever follows me will, in the bright, clear consciousness of day, see what those who walk in darkness do not see.”

Those who clung to the old belief that the light of love could be implanted in human beings only in a nocturnal way—the people called Pharisees—answered: “You appeal to your ‘I AM,’ but we appeal to Father Abraham. There we feel the power that entitles us to appear as self-conscious beings; we feel strong when we sink into the common ground of the ego that reaches back to Father Abraham.”

“Jesus said: If one speaks of the ‘I’ in the sense in which I speak, the testimony is true; for I know that this ‘I’ comes from the Father, from the common primordial ground of the world, and knows where it is going.” (8:14)

And now the important sentence, chapter 8, verse 15, which you must translate literally in the following way:

“You judge everything according to the flesh. But I do not judge what is insignificant in the flesh. And if I judge, my judgment is true. For then the ego is not alone, by itself; the ego is united with the Father from whom it originates.” (8:15–16)

That is the meaning of this passage. Everywhere you can see the reference to the common Father. We will be able to bring the concept of the Father more clearly before our minds. Thus you can see how the words “Before Father Abraham was, the I AM was” contain, in living form, the quintessence of Christian teaching.
GA103

GA115
This is precisely the central point that has always been emphasized: Christ, as Christ, does not belong among the other beings of the physical plane. From the moment of the baptism of John in the Jordan, a being that had not previously been on Earth, a being that did not belong to earthly beings, entered the body of Jesus of Nazareth. In Christ, therefore, we are dealing with a being who could rightly say to the disciples: “I am from above; you are from below” (John 8:23)—that is, I am from the heavenly realm, you are from the earthly realm. Now consider what follows from this. Must the judgment of that cosmic being who entered the body of Jesus as Christ be the same as an earthly judgment—the kind of judgment that is entirely justified on Earth and that everyone must make insofar as they are an earthly being? The being who entered the body of Jesus at the baptism in the Jordan does not have an earthly judgment, but a heavenly one; it must judge differently from the way human beings must judge.

In one passage, Christ shows in a way that cuts deeply into our hearts how he approaches this question. When those who condemn bring the woman caught in adultery before him—we can picture this scene in our minds (John 8:1–11)—Christ responds to them in two ways: first, by writing on the ground; second, by forgiving, by not judging or condemning at all. Why does he write on the ground? Because karma is at work, because karma is objective justice. The woman’s deed cannot be erased; Christ writes it into the Earth. But the spiritual, non-earthly consequence is different: Christ takes that upon himself. “He forgives” does not mean that he erases it in an absolute sense, but that he takes upon himself the consequences of what was objectively done.

Christ does not want merely “good faith”; Christ wants to lead people to the truth. He himself said: “The truth will set you free!” (John 8:32) But where did Christ ever say that it is possible, if one thinks in his spirit, to shout or write this or that out into the world without knowing anything?

That is why, from the standpoint of spiritual science, the words of the Gospel of John touch us so deeply: In the beginning, when humanity had not yet succumbed to temptation, the Logos was. Humanity belonged to the Logos. The Logos was with God, and humanity was with the Logos in God. Through the baptism of John in the Jordan, the Logos entered human evolution; it became human.
GA115

Chapter 9.

GA052
Only with difficulty can one struggle upward to an insight into the true meaning of the Last Supper. You will not hear about it today in detail; but let me indicate what this, which belongs to the deepest mysteries of Christianity, actually signifies. The Christ gathers His apostles in order to celebrate with them the institution of the unbloody sacrifice. This is what we wish to understand.

To make a path for ourselves toward understanding this event, let us return to another, little-noticed fact, which is to show us how we are to understand the Last Supper. In the Gospel we hear that the Christ passed by a man blind from birth. And those who were with Him asked: ‘Did this man sin, or his parents, that he was born blind as a punishment?’ The Christ answered: ‘Neither this man himself sinned nor his parents, but he was born blind in order that the works of the Godhead might be revealed,’ or, still better, ‘in order that the divine manner of governing the world might be revealed.’ Thus it is justified with the words ‘in the divine manner of governing the world’ that he was born blind. Since he did not sin in this life, and neither did his parents, the reason must be sought elsewhere. We cannot remain with the individual personality, nor with the parents and forebears; rather, we must think the inner being of the soul of the man born blind as eternal. We must resolve to seek the cause in the previously existing souls, the souls that have experienced the effect of an earlier life. What we call karma is indicated here, though not spoken out. And we shall soon hear why such a thing is not spoken out. That the sins of the fathers are avenged upon the children and grandchildren is a teaching among those into whose midst the Christ was placed. The sins of the fathers are expiated in children and grandchildren. This is a teaching that does not accord with the view which the Christ expressed with regard to the man born blind. If one holds fast to the teaching that it can only be sin of the fathers, that guilt and expiation exist only within the physical world, then he would have to suffer for what his fathers had committed.

This shows us that the Christ raises His own to a wholly new conception of guilt and expiation, to a conception that would have nothing to do with what takes place in the physical world, to a conception that cannot have validity in the real reality revealed through the eyes. Christ wished to overcome among His own the old conception of sin, the conception that clings to physical heredity and to physical fact. And was it not such a conception of guilt, one that adheres to physical fact, which lay at the basis of the old sacrifices? Did not the sinners go to the altar and bring their expiatory offerings, presenting a purely physical event in order to cast off their sins? The old sacrifices were physical facts. But guilt and expiation cannot be sought in physical fact: this the Christ taught. Therefore even the Highest, even the Spirit of God, the living Word, can succumb to facticity, down to the death to which the Christ succumbed, without being guilty. No outward sacrifice can coincide with the conception of guilt and expiation. The Lamb of God was the most innocent of all; it can die the sacrificial death.
GA052

GA094
First of all, in the Gospel of John there is a clear sign that Jesus, when He spoke intimately with His disciples, taught reincarnation. For one can attach a meaning to the ninth chapter—healing of a man blind from birth on the Sabbath—only if one takes the teaching of reincarnation as a basis. One must bear in mind that He spoke in the language customary at that time. In Greece at that time it was not customary to speak otherwise than of the force which permeates the human being in his inmost being and carries him forward in his inmost being. The force that forms and develops the human being: for the Greeks that was God, and so it was among all the peoples of that time. A merely external God, a God in the beyond, such times did not yet know at all. Therefore what lives in the human being was designated above all as the God in the human being. Thus, when one speaks of the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the higher self is meant. You understand the Old Testament only when you know that God must be understood in this way. Jesus too, when He speaks intimately with His disciples, speaks of the God living in the human being: ‘His disciples asked Him and said: Master, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind? Jesus answered: Neither this man sinned nor his parents, but that the works of God might be revealed in him.’

These three sentences speak clearly enough. Neither did he sin—that is, not the physical part—nor did his parents; therefore the Jewish law also does not apply, that God visits the sins of the fathers unto the so-and-so-th generation. But the works of the God in the human being are to become visible: that is, of the self in the human being which passes through all incarnations. The words which Jesus spoke to His disciples in this manner are as clear as they could possibly be.
GA094

GA100
Direct theosophical teachings can also be demonstrated in the Gospel of John. The fact that an individual I lives in every human being, that within this I there is a spark of divine substance, that this spark must develop into the ‘God in us’—this is mentioned by the writer of the Gospel of John (Chapter 9). In most translations of the Bible, Christ’s answer to the question of who had sinned, this man born blind or his parents, is rendered thus: ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but that the works of God might be revealed in him.’ But is it a conception worthy of a Christian, that God permits a human being to be born blind so that God may reveal His glory in him? A conception of God capable of reaching such consequences is impossible. This passage reads much more simply and clearly if we take the theosophical view as our basis. Christ answered: ‘Neither he nor his parents have sinned; he fulfils his karma, in order that the divine spark in him may become visible, in order that the works of the <God in him> may become visible.’ Thus Christ’s answer (9:3) is to be translated: ‘He was born blind in order that the works of the God in him may become visible in the body.’ Every human being passes through repeated earthly lives. We see a man born blind. He need not have sinned in this life; he may also have brought with him from a former life the guilt that led to this birth. It is the teaching of karma, working through the incarnations in an altogether theosophical sense, which is portrayed through this occurrence. That Christ must, through His teaching, come into conflict with the customary Jewish view is evident; from this is also explained the conflict into which He comes with the Jews (Chapter 9:22).
GA100

GA112
The next sign is the healing of the man blind from birth. This healing of the man born blind, as it stands in the Gospel of John, is once again distorted in a very particular way. Perhaps you have often read the story in the Gospel:

‘And Jesus passed by and saw a man who was blind from birth. And His disciples asked Him and said: Master, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind? Jesus answered: Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but that the works of God might be revealed in him.’ (9:1–3)
And then He heals him.
Nor does it say at all that ‘the works of God were to reveal themselves in this blind man.’
If we are to understand this sign, we must go back to the usage of language in which the word ‘God’ was used. You will find this most easily if you open another chapter, where the Christ is directly accused of claiming that He was one with God. How does He answer?
‘Jesus answered them: Is it not written in your law: I have said, You are gods?’ (10:34)

That is, the Christ answers: In the inmost being of the human soul there is the potentiality for a god. It is something divine. How often we have expressed that the fourth member of human nature is the potentiality for the divine in the human being. ‘You are gods!’ means: something divine dwells in you! This divine element is something other than the human being, other than the person of the human being as he lives here between birth and death; it is also something other than what a human being inherits from his parents. Whence comes this divine element, this individuality of the human being? It goes from incarnation to incarnation, through repeated earthly lives. This individuality comes over from an earlier earthly life, from an earlier incarnation. Thus: neither his parents sinned, nor his personality, which one usually calls ‘I.’ But in an earlier life this man laid the cause for being born blind in this life. He has become blind because the works of the God in him, proceeding from an earlier life, show themselves in his blindness. Karma, the law of cause and effect, is here clearly and distinctly indicated by the Christ Jesus. What, then, must now be affected if this illness is to be healed? That which does not live as a transitory I between birth and death must be affected; the forces must penetrate more deeply, into the I that goes from life to life. The Christ-force has once more intensified itself. Until now we have seen that it worked only upon what stands before it. Now it works upon what outlives human life between birth and death, what goes from life to life. The Christ feels Himself to be the representative of the I-am. By pouring His force into the I-am, by thus communicating the high God of the Christ to the God in the human being, the human being receives the power to heal himself from within. Now the Christ has penetrated into the inmost being of the soul. His force has worked into the sick man’s eternal individuality and made it strong, in that the Christ’s own force appears in the sick man’s individuality and thereby works even into the consequences of earlier incarnations.
GA112

GA103
When one day the full higher human being shall be developed, then the whole astral body will be so purified that at the same time it will have become Manas, or Spirit Self; the etheric body will be so cleansed that at the same time it will be Life Spirit, or Buddhi; and the physical body will be so far transformed that, as truly as it is a physical body, it will at the same time be Spirit Man, or Atma. The greatest force will be required to overcome the lowest body, and therefore the overcoming and transformation of the physical body will signify the highest victory for the human being. When human beings fully accomplish this, this physical human being will be Spirit Man, or Atma. Today all this lives in the human being only as a potentiality; one day, however, it will live fully in the human being. And looking toward the Christ-personality, toward the Christ-impulses, permeating oneself with force and allowing oneself to be strengthened through the Christ-impulse, draws toward the human being that through which he can accomplish this transformation.

If the human being has not yet accomplished this transformation today, what follows from this? Spiritual science states it very simply: because the astral body is not yet purified, not yet transformed

into Spirit Self, selfishness or egoism is possible; because the etheric body is not yet permeated with force by the I, falsehood and error are possible; and because the physical body is not yet permeated with force by the I, illness and death are possible. In the Spirit Self, once fully developed, there will no longer be selfishness; in the Spirit Man, that is, in the fully developed physical body, there will be no illness and death, but solely healing and health. What, then, does it mean: the human being takes in the Christ-impulses? He learns to understand what force is in the Christ; he takes into himself the forces that enable him to be master even in relation to his physical body.

Imagine for once that a human being could take the Christ-impulse fully into himself; that the Christ-impulse could pass wholly over into a human being; that the Christ Himself stood directly before a human being and the Christ-impulse passed directly over into this human being. What would that mean? If the human being were blind, he could become seeing through the direct influence of this Christ-impulse, because the final goal of development is the conquest of the forces of illness and death. When the author of the Gospel of John speaks of the healing of the man born blind, he speaks out of such depths of mystery; through an example he shows that the Christ-force is a healing force when it appears in its full strength. Where is this force? In the Christ-body, in the earth. This earth need only be permeated in truth with the being of the Christ-Spirit, or of the Logos.

Let us see whether the writer of the Gospel of John tells the matter as one who understood it thus. How does he tell it? The blind man is there; Christ takes earth, moistens it with spittle, and lays it upon him —He lays upon the blind man the body permeated by His Spirit. With this description (9:6), the writer of the Gospel of John shows a mystery which he knows exactly. And now, disregarding all prejudices, we must speak a little more precisely about this one of the great signs of Christ Jesus, in order that we may know exactly the nature of such a thing and not concern ourselves that our very clever contemporaries may regard what is now said as madness or folly. Rather, we may say that there are great and mighty secrets in the world for which human beings today are not yet ready. Human beings today, however developed they may be, are not strong enough actually to perform the great mysteries. One may know of them, one may understand them if one can experience them spiritually; but to translate them into the physical, the human being who has descended so deeply into matter is incapable of this.

All life actually consists of opposites, of extremes. Life and death are such extremes. For the feeling and disposition of the occultist, something very peculiar arises when, for example, he sees a corpse and a living human being beside one another. When one has before one a living, waking human being, one knows: soul and spirit dwell within him. But in this waking human being, as far as consciousness is concerned, they are, so to speak, shut out from all connection with the spiritual world; they do not look into the spiritual world. If we have a corpse before us, we feel that the spirit and soul which belonged to this corpse are now on the way to pass over into the spiritual worlds, where consciousness, the light of the spiritual world, dawns upon them. Thus the corpse becomes a symbol of what happens in the spiritual worlds. But in the physical there are also images of what occurs in the spiritual, only in a remarkable way. When a human being descends again toward birth, a bodily part must be built up for him. Matter must, as it were, shoot together so that a body may be built for him. And to a clairvoyant, this shooting together of matter appears as though, in the spiritual world, the consciousness there dies. There it dies—here it comes to life. In the shooting together of matter into a physical human body, one sees in a certain sense a spiritual consciousness dying away. And truly, in the decay or burning of the physical body, when the parts move apart and dissolve, the opposite shows itself at the same time in the spiritual: the arising of a spiritual consciousness. Physical dissolution is spiritual birth. Therefore all processes of decomposition, all processes of dissolution, are something quite different for the occultist as well. A cemetery, where physical bodies dissolve, is, seen spiritually—setting aside the human

beings; what is meant now is what takes place spiritually in the cemetery itself—a remarkable process: a continual flashing forth and shining forth of spiritual births. Let us assume now that a human being gave himself physically—no one is naturally advised to do this, for present-day bodies cannot endure it at all—let us assume that a human being submitted to a certain training, and trained his physical body by breathing, for a prescribed period, air of decay with the consciousness of taking into himself the spiritual process just described. If he does this in the corresponding way, then in later incarnations—this cannot be done in one incarnation—he can indeed be incarnated with that force which gives enlivening and healing impulses. To breathe the air of the dead belongs to the training that gradually brings his spittle to the force which, together with ordinary earth, gives what the Christ rubbed into the blind man's eyes.

This mystery, through which one consumes death, eats or breathes death, and thereby receives the force to heal, is the secret to which the writer of the Gospel of John points by showing us such signs as the healing of the man born blind. And one would far rather, instead of people continually declaiming whether such a thing must be taken in this way or that, that they might learn that something exists literally as it is described in the healing of the blind man, and that they might gain respect for such a personality as the writer of the Gospel of John, so that they might say to themselves: He was such a personality, well initiated into these mysteries, and we must strive to acquire an understanding of these mysteries.
GA103

Chapter 10.

GA094
When the human being has entered from this world into the astral world, he finds himself in a region from which a further ascent leads him into a still higher world, into the mental or devachanic world. This entrance into the mental or devachanic world must be bought at the cost of a complete passing-away, a killing of the lower nature. The human being must pass through the three-day death and then be raised up. If he has become seeing on the astral plane, if the images on the astral plane have come before him, then he has also become ripe to become knowing on the mental or devachanic plane. Thus one can then describe his resurrection on the devachanic plane. The conscious, thoughtful finding of oneself on the higher plane for one's own self—that is the resurrection of Lazarus.

John also describes this resurrection of Lazarus. Before this he has shown that through this whole process one can enter the higher world, that this is the door to the higher worlds. In Chapter 10, verse 9, it says: 'I am the door; if anyone enters through Me, he will be saved, and will go in and out and find pasture.' This is the resurrection of that which was wrapped in sleep and is now raised up on the devachanic plane. John undergoes it. John is Lazarus, and John wishes to say nothing other than what is described in his first twelve chapters: as an astral experience he has described that he was raised up on the astral plane. Then the initiation for the devachanic plane took place. He lay three days in the grave, and then he received the resurrection. The resurrection of Lazarus is the resurrection of John himself, who wrote the Gospel.

Christ is an initiate of the seventh degree, who has extended His consciousness to the Father: 'I (or the I-am) and the Father (or the Divine) are one.' He is the life and the light of human beings, for He has brought His high consciousness down into the physical body.

The human being has his four members of being on the physical plane. What in the human being is of a physical nature remains physical body, but has for itself a consciousness in Devachan, of which the

human being indeed knows nothing, though it haunts about in his members. The etheric body has another consciousness, which lives itself out in lower Devachan. Finally, the astral body too has a consciousness of its own on the astral plane. Thus the human being is a very complicated being. The following scheme may serve to explain this:

Higher Devachan	Physical body
Lower Devachan	Etheric body
Astral plane	Astral body
Physical plane	I

His I is at home in the physical world; no one can dispute that with him. There also lives in the human being, and belongs to him, that part of his astral body which has an unconscious consciousness and is at home on the astral plane. Further, there is an unconscious consciousness of the etheric body on the lower devachanic plane, and such a consciousness of the I on the higher Devachan. The most important thing, then, is that from the I the human being works into the other bodies, and that only thereby do the various consciousnesses become conscious to him.

There is a peculiar connection of the human being with the different worlds, which is a most important mystery. If one learns to recognize this, one gradually knows what an initiation is. When the human being works from his I into his astral body, then he ascends to the astral plane and becomes a companion of all astral beings. All that has an astral consciousness is around him. When with his I he works into his etheric body, then he simultaneously ascends into the lower regions of Devachan; etheric beings then appear around him. This is a great and mighty moment: he sees light not merely as light, but as the bearer of luminous beings; with the physical rays of the sun angelic beings approach, whose body is light. This is a result of initiation.

When the human being ascends still higher, or descends—let us recall Goethe's words: 'Then sink! I might also say: rise! It is the same ...' (Faust II, lines 6275 f.)—then the moment comes when he first becomes one with the primal Father of the world. Then he can say: 'I and the Father are one.' Then beings appear—still higher than those described. Now imagine a personality so highly initiated that in his own bodies he bears consciously the nature of the higher beings, as John experienced this in the Christ Jesus. In the one Christ Jesus the writer of the Gospel of John sees the beings of the three worlds.
GA094

GA112
Now consider the last chapter before the raising of Lazarus, and try for once to bring a few words of this chapter before your mind. You need do nothing other than bring before your mind the passage where it says:
'Therefore does My Father love Me, because I lay down My life, that I may take it again. No one takes it from Me, but I lay it down of Myself. I have power to lay it down, ... If I do not do the works of My Father, do not believe Me; ...' (10:17 f. and 37)

Everything said there about the 'good shepherd' is meant to indicate that the Christ feels: 'I and the Father are one!'—that He no longer wishes to say I to Himself otherwise than that He takes the Father-force into Himself. If earlier He said: 'I am the light of the world,' He now says: I give up my I-force by taking the Father into myself, so that the Father works in me, so that the primal principle may flow in me and flow out into another human being. I lay down my life that I may receive it anew. This precedes the raising of Lazarus.

GA112

GA124
In the first years the child still feels itself in its surroundings, feels itself to be a member of the whole environment. The human being begins to isolate himself from his surroundings as an independent being only at the point of time to which he later remembers back.

You must acquire this as a conception: the Son of Man, who is found in the human being from the point in time to which the human being today remembers back, together with all that the human being can acquire from culture. Direct your attention to this human being, and then think of all that the human being could be through connection with the macrocosm, if there were added what penetrates in from the macrocosm during the first years of childhood. In the first years of childhood it can be nothing but a foundation, because the developed human I is not yet there. But if it were to fall into the developed human I, then there would occur what first occurred at the moment when the Spirit came down from above upon Jesus of Nazareth through the baptism in the Jordan: the three innocent stages of childhood development were mingled with the rest of humankind. This is the next thing. And what was the consequence? The consequence was that this innocent child-life, when it sought to develop on the physical earth, could develop only for three years—as everywhere it develops only for three years—and then found its end on Golgotha; that is, it could not mingle with what the human being becomes at the time to which he later normally remembers back.

If you think this through—what it would mean if all the connection with the macrocosm, which arises dimly and twilight-like in the first years of childhood, but cannot yet truly shine because the child does not yet have I-consciousness, were to mingle into a human being; and if you further think how, if it dawned in later consciousness, something would form, something would fall into us which does not come from the human being in us but from the whole depth of the world out of which we are born—then you have the interpretation of the words which were spoken in regard to what is represented in the descent of the dove: ‘This is My well-beloved Son; today have I begotten Him!’ That is, here the Christ was incarnated, ‘begotten,’ in Jesus of Nazareth: the Christ who was in truth born into Jesus of Nazareth at the moment of the baptism of John, and who stood at the height of that consciousness which otherwise human beings have only in their first years of childhood, but with all the feeling of cosmic belonging which the child would have if it knew what it feels in the first three years. Then indeed those words too would receive a wholly different meaning: ‘I and the Father’—the cosmic Father—‘are one.’

If you allow this to work upon your soul, you will feel a little of what, so to speak, entered as a first basic element into the revelation at Damascus for Paul, and what is expressed in the beautiful saying: ‘Unless you become as little children, you cannot enter the kingdoms of heaven!’ This saying has manifold meanings, but this is one of them. Paul said: ‘Not I, but the Christ in me!’—that is, the being that has such a macrocosmic consciousness as the child would have if it could permeate the consciousness of its first three years with the consciousness of later time. In the normal human being of today these two kinds are separate, and must be separate, for otherwise they could not be compatible. They were not compatible in the Christ Jesus either. For after those three years death had necessarily to occur, under the circumstances as they played out in Palestine. They did not present themselves by chance, but through the living together of these two factors: the Son of God, who is the human being from the time of birth until the development of I-consciousness, and the Son of Man, who is the human being after the time when I-consciousness has been attained. Through the living together of the Son of Man and the Son of God were brought about the events which then led to the events of Palestine.
GA124

GA013
Humanity proceeded from a unity; but the earthly development hitherto has led to differentiation. In the conception of Christ, there is first given an ideal which works against all differentiation, for in the human being who bears the name Christ there live also the forces of the high Sun-being, in which every human I has its primal ground. Even the Israelite people felt itself as a people, the human being as a member of this people. In that it was first grasped in the mere thought that in Christ Jesus lives the ideal human being, to whom the conditions of differentiation do not penetrate, Christianity became the ideal of all-embracing brotherliness. Beyond all special interests and special kinships arose the feeling that the innermost I of every human being has the same origin. (Alongside all earthly forefathers appears the common Father of all human beings: 'I and the Father are one.')
GA013

GA094
The Father of the Christ, then, is the 'Holy Spirit.' This does not correspond merely to the Gospel of John, but to an ancient tradition. Christ says: 'I and the Father are one.' This means: I and the Holy Spirit are one.
GA094

Chapter 11.

GA008
It must be conceded that the entire narrative in the Gospel of John is shrouded in a mysterious veil. To see this, one need only point to one thing. What sense could Jesus' words have, if the narrative were to be taken literally in a physical sense: 'The sickness is not unto death, but unto the glory of God, that the Son of God may be glorified thereby.' This is the customary translation of the corresponding Gospel words; but one comes closer to the facts if one translates—as is also correct according to the Greek—'unto the manifestation (unto the revelation) of God, that the Son of God may thereby be revealed.' And what should the other words mean, when Jesus says: 'I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in Me shall live, even though he die.' (John 11:4 and 25.) It would be a triviality to believe that Jesus meant to say Lazarus had merely become ill so that He could display His art upon him. And it would be a further triviality to suppose that Jesus claimed faith in Him makes a dead person alive again in the ordinary sense of the word. What would be special about a human being raised from the dead if after the resurrection he were the same as before dying? Indeed, what sense would there be if the life of such a person were described with the words: 'I am the resurrection and the life'? Jesus' words immediately acquire life and meaning if we understand them as the expression of a spiritual event, and then in a certain way even literally as they stand in the text. Jesus says He is the resurrection that happened to Lazarus, and He is the life that Lazarus lives. Let us take literally what Jesus is in the Gospel of John. He is the 'Word made flesh.' He is the Eternal that was in the beginning. If He is truly the resurrection, then the 'Eternal, Primal' has risen in Lazarus. We are therefore dealing with an awakening of the eternal 'Word.' And this 'Word' is the life to which Lazarus has been raised. We are dealing with a 'sickness'; but with a sickness that does not lead to death, rather serves the 'glory of God,' that is, the revelation of God. If the 'eternal Word' has risen in Lazarus, the entire process truly serves to make God appear in Lazarus. For through the whole process Lazarus has become another person. Previously the 'Word,' the spirit, did not live in him; now this spirit lives in him. This spirit has been born in him. Certainly every birth is connected with a sickness, the sickness of the mother. But this sickness does not lead to death; it leads to new life. In Lazarus, that from which the 'new human being,' the human being permeated by the 'Word,' is born becomes 'sick.'

Let us place the whole process before us as an initiation. Lazarus is loved by Jesus (John 11:36). This cannot mean loving in the ordinary sense. It would contradict the meaning of the Gospel of John, in which Jesus is the 'Word.' Jesus loved Lazarus because He considered him ripe for awakening the 'Word' within him. There were relations between Jesus and the family at Bethany. This means only that Jesus had prepared within this family everything that was to lead to the great final act of the drama: to the raising of Lazarus. Lazarus is a disciple of Jesus. He is such a disciple that Jesus can assume with certainty: in him the awakening will one day take place. The final act of a drama of awakening consisted of an image-like action revealing the spiritual. The human being had not merely to comprehend 'Die and Become'; he had to accomplish it himself in a spiritually real action. The earthly element, of which the higher human being must be ashamed in the sense of the mysteries, had to be cast off. The earthly human being had to die the image-like yet real death. That his body was then placed into a somnambulistic sleep for three days can, beside the magnitude of the transformation of life that took place, be regarded only as an outward process corresponding to a spiritual process incomparably more significant. Yet this action was also the experience which divided the life of the mystic into two parts. Whoever does not know the higher content of such actions as something living cannot understand them.

Through the magically significant process connected with initiation, a similar process is accomplished in the human being at a higher level. He experiences in an image what he gains spiritually. The word 'image-like' here means that an outward fact takes place sensibly and really, but as such is nevertheless an image. One is not dealing with an unreal image, but with a real one. The earthly body was truly dead for three days. From death arises the new life. This life has survived death. The human being has gained trust in the new life. So it was with Lazarus. Jesus prepared him for the awakening. It is a matter of an image-like yet real sickness: a sickness that is an initiation and that after three days leads to genuinely new life.

Lazarus is ripe to accomplish this action upon himself. He clothes himself in the garment of the mystics. He shuts himself away in a state of lifelessness which is at the same time image-like death. And when Jesus came, the three days were fulfilled. 'Then they took away the stone where the dead man lay. And Jesus lifted up His eyes and said: Father, I thank You that You have heard Me.' (John 11:41.) The Father had heard Jesus, for Lazarus had arrived at the final act of the great drama of knowledge. He had recognized how one comes to resurrection. An initiation into the mysteries had been accomplished. What throughout antiquity was understood by such an initiation lay before them. It had happened through Jesus as initiator. This was how union with the Divine had always been conceived.

In Lazarus, Jesus had accomplished the great miracle of the transformation of life in the sense of ancient traditions. With this, Christianity is linked to the mysteries. Lazarus had become an initiate through Christ Jesus Himself. He thereby became capable of ascending into the higher worlds. At the same time he was the first Christian initiate, initiated by Christ Jesus Himself. Through his initiation he became able to recognize that the 'Word' which had become living in him had become person in Christ Jesus; that therefore in sensory personal appearance, in his awakener, the very same thing stood before him which had been spiritually revealed in him. From this point of view, Jesus' words (John 11:42) are significant: 'But I knew that You hear Me always; nevertheless, because of the people standing around, I said it, that they may be led to believe that You have sent Me.' That is: it is a matter of revealing that in Jesus the 'Son of the Father' lives in such a way that, when He awakens the essential being in the human being, the latter becomes a mystic. Jesus thus expresses that the meaning of life lay hidden in the mysteries, and that they led to this meaning. He is the living Word; in Him what was ancient

tradition has become person. And the Evangelist may express this with the sentence: In Him the Word became flesh. He may see in Jesus Himself an incarnated mystery. Therefore the Gospel of John is a mystery. Read it so that the facts are spirit alone, and you will read it correctly. Had an ancient priest written it, he would have told of a traditional rite. For John, this rite becomes person. It becomes the 'Life of Jesus.'

In the words 'Lazarus, come forth,' one can recognize the call by which the Egyptian priest-initiators called back into everyday life those who, in order to die to the earthly and gain conviction of the existence of the Eternal, underwent the world-removed processes of 'initiation.' But Jesus had thereby revealed the secret of the mysteries. It becomes understandable that the Jews could no more leave such a process unpunished in Jesus than the Greeks could have left it unpunished in Aeschylus had he betrayed the secrets of the mysteries. Jesus' concern was to place before all the 'people standing around' in the Lazarus initiation a process which, in the sense of ancient priestly wisdom, could take place only in the concealment of the mystery. This initiation was to prepare an understanding of the 'Mystery of Golgotha.' Previously, only those who 'saw,' that is, who were initiated, could know what took place in such a process of initiation; now even those who 'believed although they did not see' were to be able to gain conviction of the secrets of the higher worlds.
GA008

GA112
An unbelievable amount has been written about this Lazarus story. Yet only those have ever understood it who knew from the esoteric schools and from their own observation what lies behind it. First I wish to cite only one characteristic word from the Lazarus story. When Christ Jesus is told that Lazarus lies ill, He replies: 'The sickness is not unto death, but that the God in him may be revealed!' The sickness is for the revelation of the God in him. It is only through a misunderstanding in translation that the word δόξα, doxa, which stands in the Greek text, has been translated 'unto the glory of God.' It is not undertaken for the glory of God, but so that the God in him may emerge perceptibly from concealment. That is the true sense of this word. It means that the Divine which is in the Christ is to flow over into the individuality of Lazarus, that the Divine, the Christ-Divine, is to become visible in Lazarus, through Lazarus.

When we understand the raising of Lazarus in this way, it first becomes completely transparent. Do not believe, however, that where facts of spiritual science are communicated, one can speak so openly that everything is at once handed to everyone on a platter. Under manifold embellishment and veiling, what lies behind such a fact of spiritual science is communicated. This must be so. For anyone who wishes to come to an understanding of such a mystery must first work his way through apparent difficulties, so that his spirit may be strengthened and fortified. Precisely because he has trouble winding his way through the words, he reaches the spirit standing behind such a thing. Consider how, when it speaks of the 'life' which is said to have vanished from Lazarus and which the sisters Martha and Mary wish back, Christ Jesus replies: 'I am the resurrection and the life.' Life is to appear again in Lazarus. Take everything literally, especially in the Gospels. We shall see all that follows from taking the Gospels literally. Do not speculate at all; take the sentence literally: 'I am the resurrection and the life.' What does the Christ bring when He can appear and raises Lazarus? What passes over to Lazarus? The Christ-impulse, the force that flowed out from the Christ. The Christ gave Lazarus life, as He also said: 'The sickness is not unto death, but that the God in him may become visible.' Just as all ancient initiates lay as though dead for three and a half days and then the God in them became visible, so Lazarus too lay for three and a half days in a death-like condition. But Christ Jesus knew exactly that the old initiations would thereby come to an end. He knew that this apparent death leads to something higher, to a higher life, and thus that during this time Lazarus had perceived the spiritual world. And

because the guide in this spiritual world is the Christ, Lazarus took the Christ-force into himself: the beholding of the Christ.

It was therefore necessary that, in the resurrection of Lazarus, a kind of transition be created. Lazarus was still in a death-like condition for three and a half days. Yet you must make clear to yourselves that this condition was something other than that undergone by the ancient initiates. The condition of Lazarus was not artificially brought about by the initiator as in the ancient times, when through processes I may not describe here the etheric body was drawn out of the physical body. It happened, we may say, in a more natural manner. You can gather from the Gospel itself that the Christ had already associated with Lazarus and the two sisters Martha and Mary, for it says there (11:3): 'The Lord loved him'; that is, Christ Jesus had for a long time made a great and mighty impression upon Lazarus, who had been sufficiently prepared and made ripe thereby. The consequence was that it was not necessary in Lazarus to bring about artificially, by initiation, a rapture lasting three and a half days; rather, this came about in him of itself under the mighty impression of the Christ-impulse. Lazarus was therefore, so to speak, like a dead man for the outside world for three and a half days, although during that time he had experienced what was most important, so that only the final act, the raising, was performed by the Christ. And whoever knows what happened there recognizes a lingering echo of the old process of initiation in the words used by Christ Jesus:

'Lazarus, come forth!'

And the awakened Lazarus was, as we have seen, John—or, more precisely, the writer of the Gospel of John—thus the one who, as the first initiate in the Christian sense, could bring into the world the Gospel of the being of the Christ.

What increase is now still possible for the Christ-force? Only the increase that Christ approaches a human being and awakens within him that through which His own impulse is awakened in the other human being; that the other human being takes in the Christ-force in such a way that his whole being is permeated by it and he becomes another human being, a human being permeated by Christ. This takes place in the raising of Lazarus. Here we again have an increase of the Christ-force. The Christ-force increases from stage to stage.
GA112

GA264
The second post-Atlantean age is that of Zarathustra. It thereby has a special relation to the Christ. For Zarathustra pointed to the Sun God, Ahura Mazdao, who was drawing near to the earth and who was none other than the future Christ. In his whole mission, Zarathustra was a forerunner of the Christ, by teaching people to value and cultivate the earth, not to flee the evil powers but to overcome them and thereby redeem them. Thus the I of Zarathustra, the most highly developed human I, could be chosen to dwell for eighteen years in the sheaths that were then to receive the Christ. His I left the sheaths shortly before the baptism of John in the Jordan. Thus he was not incarnated in flesh when the Christ walked upon the earth. Soon after leaving the three sheaths of the Nathan Jesus, he himself incarnated; his I joined itself to the etheric body of the Solomon Jesus, which at his death had been taken by the mother of the Nathan Jesus into the spiritual world.

Christ Jesus could therefore not awaken Zarathustra as the appointed representative of the second post-Atlantean age. Yet, as it were representatively, another individuality was incarnated on earth at that time, whose development and mission, most significant for humanity, ran in a remarkable way parallel to that of Zarathustra. This was Lazarus, the reborn Hiram Abiff, the most significant of the sons of

Cain, who likewise had worked upon the mission of the earth from the human I, as Zarathustra had done in ancient Persia. He becomes ‘ill,’ he ‘dies,’ and is laid in the grave. Christ Jesus learns of his illness and speaks to His disciples of the death of Lazarus. ‘Then Thomas, who was called the Twin, said to the disciples: Let us go with Him, that we may die with Him.’ (John 11:16.)

In this raising which is to take place with Lazarus, the souls belonging to the second post-Atlantean age—just as the ‘people from the city’ at the raising of the young man at Nain represent the third post-Atlantean age—are represented by Thomas, the ‘Twin.’ For the second post-Atlantean period was the period of the Twins. His otherwise utterly senseless words testify that the second post-Atlantean period is ready to be raised by the Christ. What lived as a seed of culture in the ancient Persian epoch has not died. It is not a matter of raising a dead person but of initiating a living one. This is the great difference between the narrative of this raising and the other two. Therefore Christ Jesus says: ‘I am the resurrection and the life; he who believes in Me shall live, even though he die.’

And Christ Jesus comes to the grave into which the supposedly dead Lazarus had been laid, and before all the people He speaks the sacramental words: ‘Lazarus, come forth!’ And the dead man came out, bound hand and foot with grave-cloths, and his face covered with a sweat-cloth. And Christ Jesus speaks the words that indicate, as it were, that from that hour this initiate will begin to work: ‘Loose him and let him go.’
GA264

GA265
Before this initiation of Hiram Abiff by Christ Jesus could take place, the spiritual sun, the sun in spring, first had to appear, and the old principle had to recede. The sun first had to shine with its light upon the full moon; only then could the day of resurrection take place. Christ brought the new principle in place of the old Jehovah principle; therefore the Pharisees, the representatives of the old principle, hated Him. And when they recognized that He represented this new thing, that He brought the new initiation, they sought to kill Him after the raising of Lazarus. (‘This man does many signs and wonders.’)

This Christ, the high Sun Spirit, initiated Lazarus, the reborn Hiram Abiff.

But this meant a radical break with the previous principle of initiation. The Pharisees, who were themselves initiates, understood this very well, and it filled them with fear and terror. They recognized what was taking place; but they also saw that from then onward, if this new principle were to prevail, their own power would be at an end. From that time they sought how they might render harmless the bearer of the new principle of initiation, and they were indeed those who finally made it possible for the Christ to be led to death.
GA265

Chapter 12.

GA 265
Before this initiation of Hiram Abiff through Christ Jesus could take place, the spiritual Sun—the Sun in spring—first had to appear, and the old principle had to recede. The Sun first had to illuminate the full Moon with its light; only then could the day of resurrection take place.
Christ brought the new principle in place of the old Jehovah principle. That is why the Pharisees, the representatives of the old principle, hated him. When they recognized that he represented something

new, that he was bringing a new form of initiation, they sought to kill him after the raising of Lazarus. (“This man performs many signs and wonders.”)

This Christ, the great solar spirit, initiated Lazarus, the reborn Hiram Abiff.

This, however, meant a radical break with the previous principle of initiation. The Pharisees, who were themselves initiates, fully recognized this, and it filled them with fear and alarm. They understood what was taking place, but they also saw that if this new principle were to prevail, their own power would come to an end.

From that moment onward, they sought ways to neutralize the bearer of the new principle of initiation. Indeed, they were the ones who ultimately made it possible for Christ to be led to his death.
GA 265

GA 94
This was always how things were when Jesus spoke intimately with his disciples. This becomes especially clear in a scene we call the Transfiguration. That scene, however, does not appear in the Gospel of John. You will find it in Matthew, chapter 17, and in Mark, chapter 9; we do not find it in John.

The only passage in John that might relate to it is in chapter 12, verse 28:

“Father, glorify thy name.” Then came there a voice from heaven, saying, “I have both glorified it, and will glorify it again.”

And further, in verse 31:

“Now is the judgment of this world: now shall the prince of this world be cast out. And I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me.”

He said this to indicate the kind of death he was going to die.

The people answered him:

“We have heard out of the law that Christ abideth for ever: and how sayest thou, The Son of man must be lifted up? Who is this Son of man?”

Jesus then said to them:

“Yet a little while is the light with you. Walk while ye have the light, lest darkness come upon you: for he that walketh in darkness knoweth not whither he goeth. While ye have light, believe in the light, that ye may be the children of light.”
GA 94

GA 123
In this way, we arrive at the following figure: two interweaving spirals, with a small leap in the middle. This is the sign of Cancer, which is intended to symbolize our growth outward into the macrocosm and to represent the emergence of some new shoot within the course of evolution.

There was also another symbol used to portray these relationships. Strange as it may seem to you, it was formed by depicting a donkey and its foal—the ancestor and its descendant. This was intended to represent the actual transition from one state into another.

Indeed, in ancient depictions, the constellation of Cancer was very often represented by a donkey and its foal. It is important to know this.

It is an important lesson for human beings to understand that, even when ascending into the macrocosm, there is such a significant transition. A person grows upward into the spiritual world but must then connect with entirely new illuminations.

This is represented quite accurately in the language of the stars by the apparent passage of the physical Sun through the constellation of Cancer. After reaching its highest point, the Sun begins to descend again.

The same thing happens when a person undergoing initiation first ascends into the spiritual world to become acquainted with its forces and then, having recognized those forces, brings them back down again in order to place them at the service of humanity.

The Gospels of Matthew (Matthew 21:1–11) and the other Gospels recount how Christ Jesus demonstrated this to his disciples. The account shows that he did not act through words alone. Instead, he presented his disciples with an imaginative, living picture of what he himself was accomplishing: moving toward the height that humanity, through its development, was destined to reach in that age.

For this purpose, he used the image of the donkey and its foal. In other words, he guided his disciples toward an understanding of what corresponds, in spiritual life, to the constellation of Cancer.

This therefore expresses something that took place within the living spiritual relationship between Christ and his disciples. It was an event of such majesty and grandeur that it could not be expressed through human words taken from any language. It could only be conveyed by Christ leading his disciples into the realities of the spiritual world and creating, within physical circumstances, images of the macrocosmic world.

He led them upward to the point at which the powers of the initiate once again become useful to humanity. There he stands at the summit, a height that can only be indicated by saying that he stands at the height of the Sun in the sign of Cancer.

It is therefore no wonder that the Gospel of Matthew draws attention at this point to the fact that Christ’s life on Earth had reached its culmination. It emphasizes this powerfully with the words:
“Hosanna in the highest!”

Every sound and expression is chosen so that, through what takes place, the disciples may grow and develop, allowing what Christ Jesus brought into humanity’s evolution to grow within humanity through the changes taking place in them.
GA 123

GA 112

Let us imagine that Christ entered the world in a completely universal way and first accomplished the great work through an etheric body that was entirely permeated by Christ.

For this is what Christ had made the etheric body of Jesus of Nazareth capable of doing: that this etheric body could also give life to the physical body.

At the moment when the etheric body of Jesus of Nazareth, in which Christ was now present, had become a complete enlivening force for the physical body, Christ's etheric body appeared transfigured. The writer of the Gospel of John describes this moment:

"Father, glorify thy name." Then came there a voice from heaven, saying, "I have both glorified it, and will glorify it again."

The people who stood nearby and heard it said that it thundered.

But the text never says that a person who had not been prepared for such an experience would also have heard it.

Others said that an angel had spoken to him. Jesus answered:

"This voice came not because of me, but for your sakes."

Why? So that those around him might understand what had taken place.

Christ then speaks about the event:

"Now is the judgment of this world: now shall the prince of this world be cast out." (John 12:28–31)

Lucifer-Ahriman was cast out of Christ's physical body at this moment!

Here stands the great example of what must take place throughout all humanity in the future: through the impulse of Christ, the hindrances of Lucifer-Ahriman must be cast out of the human physical body. The human earthly body must be so enlivened by the impulse of Christ that the fruits of Earth's mission can be carried forward into those ages that will succeed the age of Earth.
GA 112

GA 346
Now that the fifth post-Atlantean cultural period—as I said yesterday—is destined gradually to have death increasingly present beside it as a companion, we shall need moral strength to endure this constant presence of death.

It is important for us that our present age coincides with two developments: the age in which the consciousness soul emerges, bringing with it the human being's constant companionship with death, and the period of Michael's rule.

Michael's archangelic reign signifies, in a certain sense, a kind of ending and a goal of perfection, although it involves decadence and perfection at the same time.

Michael was the spirit who lived in the Sun and was the most important servant of the Christ spirit there. At the time of the Mystery of Golgotha, he experienced the event from the other side.
Humanity on Earth experienced the Mystery of Golgotha by seeing Christ arrive. Michael and his hosts, who were still in the Sun at that time, experienced it as having to take leave of Christ.

Now, my dear friends, we must allow the two poles of this all-surpassing cosmic event to work upon our souls: the "Hosanna" on Earth, the arrival of Christ on Earth, and the farewell of Michael's hosts above, in the Sun.

These two belong together.
GA 346

Chapter 13.

GA097
From Chapter Thirteen onward, John's experiences relate to the Devachanic plane. John indicates this by being raised from the dead: Lazarus, who was raised, is John. We can therefore understand why it is only from this point that the disciple whom the Lord loved is mentioned. This is the central mystery of the Gospel of John: its author is Lazarus, the one who was raised from the dead.

John now undergoes experiences with Christ in the spiritual world. The second part in particular is not merely a narrative of what happened on some plane of existence; it describes what each person can experience inwardly. The way one feels that one has reached the stage John describes is this: from a certain point in development, a person no longer feels separate from all things, but immerses himself in the things around him. This means expanding one's own self to encompass the universe. John feels himself to be a member of the entire world surrounding him. This is expressed in the Devachanic image of the washing of the feet. John experiences this in the spiritual world, although the washing of the feet is also a historical event.
GA097

GA094
Let us consider Chapter Thirteen: the washing of the feet (13:1–20). What does this washing mean? The human being is bound in two directions; he is a dual being, with his head turned toward the Sun and his feet toward the Earth. What part of the human being still needs to be purified? The part assigned to the Earth must be cleansed by the representative of perfected humanity (13:8–10). Peter, whose name means "rock," represents the part turned toward the Earth. If this part, too, is to become pure, it must be washed by Christ. Hence Christ's words: "If your earthly part is not washed, you have no part in me." When Peter replies, "Lord, not my feet only, but also my hands and my head," Christ says to him: "He who has bathed needs only to wash his feet, but is entirely clean. And you are clean, but not all of you." Christ knew well who would bring about his death: Judas Iscariot, the representative of the egoistic principle.

And further, verse 18: "He who eats my bread has lifted his heel against me." How can Jesus—he who possesses Earth-consciousness and feels the whole Earth as his body—say these words? He can. Imagine the Earth's consciousness as though it were that of a human being. If the Earth had consciousness, it would say to humanity: "He who eats my bread has lifted his heel against me." Christ possesses this consciousness; as the representative of the consciousness of the whole Earth, he may say this.
GA094

GA112
Take anything from the Earth. When do you understand it rightly? When you say: “This is a part of Christ’s body!” What could Christ say to those who were able to recognize him? As he broke the bread that comes from the grain of the Earth, he could say: “This is my body!” And when he gave them the juice of the vine, which comes from the sap of plants, what could he say? “This is my blood!” Because he had become the soul of the Earth, he could say of what is solid, “This is my flesh,” and of the sap of plants, “This is my blood”—just as you say of your flesh, “This is my flesh,” and of your blood, “This is my blood.” Those who can grasp the true meaning of Christ’s words form mental images that draw Christ’s body and blood into the bread and the juice of the vine, drawing the Christ-Spirit into them. They unite themselves with the Christ-Spirit.

In this way, the symbol of the Last Supper becomes a reality.
GA112

GA094
Let us ask one more question. A people is made the bearer of the development of Manas, and the consciousness of the whole people is concentrated in a single initiate. When the Jewish people were close to forfeiting their mission, the Lord said: “I will destroy them, but I will make you, Moses, into a great people.” This passage is to be taken literally: it describes a higher initiation of Moses. His mission is thereby transferred to him in such a way that he becomes an initiate bearing the consciousness of a people.

Another deeply significant circumstance is the role played by blood in the Manas process, for the higher process must naturally be reflected in the blood. Moses takes the sacrificial blood and sprinkles it over the people. This is the sign of the truth of the covenant through blood kinship. When Manas has taken up the blood, and Buddhi has done so as well, we understand the passage in the Gospel of John: “Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood remains in me, and I in him.” If Christ is to work upon humanity, he must establish a covenant with it through his blood. If Christ is to implant Buddhi in a human being, that person had to receive Christ’s blood in the sacrament of the Last Supper.
GA094

GA097
Various images from the higher world now appear. The betrayal by Judas Iscariot is presented to us. He represents one of the races—namely, the race that brings everything down to the material plane, our present fifth sub-race, the materialistic one. Since human development required people, who had previously lived in spiritual vision, to be led into the physical world, it was quite understandable that the representative of this fifth sub-race should become the betrayer. Judas Iscariot represented the race that descends the farthest. Because the Gospel of John is to be understood symbolically, it retains its value beyond space and time. Judas’s deed fits organically into Christ’s mission. Judas undergoes a kind of martyrdom. He is the betrayer and, in a certain sense, also a martyr. He brings about Christ’s sacrifice.

A higher kingdom of nature always rises at the expense of a lower one. Without the mineral kingdom, the plant kingdom could not draw its nourishment from it. The plant kingdom is brought down so that a higher kingdom, the animal kingdom, can develop, and so on. The human kingdom also needs the other kingdoms. The more highly developed being needs the less developed one. Without the formation of a subordinate caste, there could be no higher caste. Just as the plant kingdom presupposes the mineral kingdom, so Christ Jesus presupposes the apostles. No saint could develop if others were not brought

down. Chapter 13, verse 16 says: “The servant is not greater than his lord.” Christ grew out of the apostles; therefore he can call them the lords from whose community he himself emerged. He washes their feet to show that, in this respect, he stands beneath them because he owes his existence to them. Everyone must experience this feeling personally. Whoever has never lived through this feeling has not understood the Christian-mystical path.

Jesus goes on to say: “He who eats my bread has lifted his heel against me.” He feels himself to be in community with the whole Earth. He feels all humanity weighing upon him, treading upon him.
GA097

GA100
The Master’s next saying becomes understandable in this light. He says: “He who eats my bread has lifted his heel against me” (13:18). If Christ is the planetary spirit and the Earth is his body, is it not justified to say that people eat his flesh, drink his blood, and tread upon him? If this spirit points to the fruits obtained from the Earth, can he not say, “This is my body,” and, pointing to the pure juices of plants, “This is my blood” (6:56)? Do people not walk about on the body of this planetary spirit, treading upon him? He did not say this in a malicious sense, but to point to the fact that the Earth is Christ’s true body. This passage of the Gospel, too, is to be taken literally. The mystery of the Last Supper is meant to keep the memory of this great truth alive for posterity. Only someone who can feel the significance of this mighty event for the whole of cosmic evolution can appreciate the profound meaning of the Last Supper. Such a person sees the power of Christ sprouting in the plants that the Earth sends toward the sunlight in spring, and knows that Christ’s becoming human is not merely a human event, but a cosmic one.
GA100

GA112
The greatest advance was felt to consist in not remaining with the old principle, not rigidly clinging to the old line, but recognizing what had entered the world through Christ. Is this indicated to us as well? Yes. Tales and myths contain the deepest wisdom. There is a legend—it does not appear in the Gospel, but it is no less a Christian legend and no less a Christian truth—which runs as follows:

There once lived a married couple who had long been without a son. One night the mother was told in a dream—pay close attention to this—that she would have a son, but that he would first kill his father, then unite with his mother, and bring terrible misfortune upon his entire lineage.

Here again we have a dream, like the oracle in the story of Oedipus; that is, a remnant of ancient clairvoyance. In the old manner, the mother was shown in advance what would happen. Is this enough to see through the circumstances of the world and prevent the disaster revealed to her? Let us ask the legend. It tells us more:

Under the influence of the wisdom that came to her in the dream, the mother took the child she had borne to the island of Kariot. He was abandoned there, but a queen from a neighboring land found him. Since the royal couple had no child, she took him in and raised him herself. Later the couple had a child of their own. The foundling soon felt himself disadvantaged and, because of his passionate temperament, killed the royal couple’s son. He could no longer remain there and had to flee. He came to the court of the governor Pilate, where he soon became an overseer of the household. One day he quarreled with his neighbor, knowing nothing about him except that he was his neighbor. In the quarrel he killed him, unaware that he had killed his own father. He then married the neighbor’s wife—his own mother! This foundling was Judas of Kariot. When he realized his terrible situation, he fled once more.

The only person who showed him mercy was the one who had mercy on all who came near him: the one who sat at table not only with tax collectors and sinners, but who, despite his profound insight, also admitted this great sinner into his company. For his task was to work not only for the good, but for all people, and to lead them from sin toward salvation. Thus Judas of Kariot came into the circle of Christ Jesus. He then brought into that circle the misfortune that had been foretold and that, in the words attributed to Schiller, “is the curse of an evil deed, that it must go on producing evil.” He became the betrayer of Christ Jesus. In a sense, what was to be fulfilled through him had already been fulfilled in the murder of his father and his marriage to his mother. Yet he remained, so to speak, as an instrument, because he was meant to be an instrument—the evil instrument that would bring about the good, committing one further deed beyond the fulfillment already accomplished.
GA112

GA113
There is another legend, told approximately as follows. An oracle foretold to a couple that they would have a son who would bring disaster upon his entire people. He would murder his father and marry his mother. The mother gave birth to this son. Because the prophecy had been made, the child too was exposed: he was left on the island of Kariot, where the island’s queen found him. Since the royal couple had no son, they took him in. Later they had a son of their own. The foundling believed he was being treated unfairly and killed the natural son, so he had to flee the island. He went to the court of Pilate in Palestine and was given a position overseeing Pilate’s household. He quarreled with his neighbor, knowing nothing about him beyond the fact that he was his neighbor. He killed him in the quarrel and later married the man’s wife. Only afterward did he learn that the man he had killed was his real father and that he had married his own mother. The legend says that, unlike Oedipus, the man who now saw all this calamity descend upon him was overcome with remorse. He went to Christ, who received him; for this was Judas of Kariot. The evil that lived in Judas becomes incorporated into the whole development of humanity like a ferment. The event in Palestine is connected with Judas’s betrayal: he belongs to the whole, and he belongs among the Twelve; they cannot truly be thought of without him. The prophecy was fulfilled, but its content became part of humanity’s development, like evil that is transformed and continues to live on in a good sense. In a significant way, this legend—which is truly wiser than external science—points to a transformation in human nature over time, so that the same matter must be understood very differently in different periods.
GA113

GA094
We cannot take the Gospel of John deeply enough. The giving of names is also extraordinarily important. The names used in the Bible are drawn from the inner nature of the people concerned. One example is the names of the twelve apostles. They indicate their relationship to the Lord, Christ, who is the head and whose sign is the Ram or Lamb. John means “the one who proclaims Buddhi.” The human being can be divided into twelve parts; the human being as a whole is a twelvefold being. The human being as we know him today developed gradually. Each time the Sun entered a new constellation, a new organ developed in the human being. When the Sun was in Leo, for example, the heart took shape. As the human being rises higher, he incorporates a group-soul within himself. The parts of the human being are also hidden in the names of the twelve apostles. What the twelve constituents of an ordinary body are, the twelve apostles represent in the collective body of Christ. The part representing the “I,” in which egoism rules and which brings about Christ’s death, is called Judas Iscariot. The naming also adds that Judas held the purse—the money, representing the lower principle of greed.
GA094

GA102
Nothing happens in the innermost part of the “I” that does not send its consequences upward into the zodiac. This is entirely true. Through the human “I,” the human being lays the foundations for developing toward Atma, or the Spirit-Man, and increasingly develops the forces that enable him to act upon the Balance of the zodiac. He will gain full power over this Balance when he has carried his “I” through to Atma, or the Spirit-Man. Then he will be a being that radiates something, passing from the condition of time into the condition of duration, of eternity.

As the human being follows this path, however, there are other beings for whom what is the highest effect in the human being is, so to speak, the lowest. Let us seek these beings, for whom the lowest has the same effect as the zodiacal Balance has for the human being. If we set the human being within the zodiac, he extends as far as Libra. The being whose essential nature belongs wholly to the zodiac, whose forces belong wholly to it, and which expresses itself in planetary life only through its lowest member, designated by Libra—just as the lowest member of the human being is designated by Pisces—is the being that spreads life throughout the whole universe:

		The Mystical Lamb
7. Spirit-Man	Aries	12.
6. Life-Spirit	Taurus	member
5. Spirit-Self	Gemini	11.
4. I (Self)	Cancer	member
3. Astral body	Leo	10.
2. Etheric body	Virgo	member
1. Physical body	Libra	9. member
	Scorpio	8. member
	Sagittarius	7. member
	Capricorn	6. member
	Aquarius	
	Pisces	



Just as the human being receives life, this being radiates life throughout the whole universe. It is the being capable of making the great sacrifice, inscribed in the zodiac as the being that sacrifices itself for our world. As the human being strives upward into the zodiac, this being sends us its offering from Aries, which belongs to it as Libra belongs to the human being. And just as the human being directs his “I” upward toward Libra, this being pours its own being into our sphere as a sacrifice. It is therefore called the self-sacrificing “Mystical Lamb,” for lamb and ram are the same; hence Christ is described as the sacrificial Lamb or Ram. Christ is thus characterized as belonging to the whole cosmos. His “I” strives as far as Aries; when it reaches Aries, he himself becomes the “Great Sacrifice” and enters into a relationship with all humanity. In a certain sense, the beings and forces on Earth are his creations. In his whole being he is in the Sun, and through his creations he is connected with the Moon and the Earth; his power lies in the constellation of the Lamb. The forces that enabled him to become the creator of these beings lie in Aries, the Ram or Lamb. The designation “sacrificial Lamb” or “Mystical Lamb” has been brought down from heaven itself.
GA102

GA264
Among the twelve apostles, Lazarus-John is himself, as it were, represented by someone else. John, the brother of James and son of Zebedee, is not an apostle in the strict sense. James and John are, in a way, one: among the more intimate disciples of Christ Jesus, they represent the power of the intellectual or

emotional soul, which has a double function in the human being but is nevertheless a unity. That is why they are called “Sons of Thunder,” since thunder in the macrocosm is the same as thought in the human microcosm. When Lazarus becomes John, however, he takes the place of one of the sons of Zebedee, and as such he is the one who lay against Jesus’ breast at the Last Supper.
GA264

GA265
Humanity is only at the beginning of its Christian development. Its future lies in recognizing the Earth as Christ’s body. Through the Mystery of Golgotha, a new center of light was created within the Earth; the Earth was filled with new life down to its very atoms. Therefore, when Christ broke the bread at the Last Supper—the bread that comes from the grain of the Earth—he could say, “This is my body!” And when he gave the juice of the vine, which comes from the sap of plants, he could say, “This is my blood!” To quote the passage literally: “Because he had become the soul of the Earth, he could say of what is solid, ‘This is my flesh,’ and of the sap of plants, ‘This is my blood,’ just as you say of your flesh, ‘This is my flesh,’ and of your blood, ‘This is my blood.’ Those who are able to grasp the true meaning of Christ’s words form mental images that draw Christ’s body and blood into the bread and the juice of the vine, drawing the Christ-Spirit into them. They unite themselves with the Christ-Spirit. In this way, the symbol of the Last Supper becomes a reality.”
GA265

GA052
The ancient sacrifices were physical realities. But Christ taught that guilt and atonement are not to be sought in physical reality. Thus even the highest being, the divine Spirit, the living Word, may be subjected to the facts of physical existence, even to death—as Christ was—without being guilty. No external sacrifice can correspond to the concept of guilt and atonement. The Lamb of God was the most innocent of all, and it could die a sacrificial death.

This was meant to testify before the whole world, on the stage of history, that guilt and atonement are not embodied in factual events and cannot exist within physical reality; they must be sought in a higher sphere, the sphere of spiritual life. If a guilty person could incur actual punishment only in physical life, or if it were enough for the guilty merely to make sacrifices, then the innocent Lamb would not have needed to die on the Cross. Christ accepted the sacrifice of the Cross so that people might be freed from the belief that guilt and atonement are found in external events or are consequences of inherited sin. He truly died for the faith of all people, bearing witness that the awareness of guilt and atonement is not to be sought in physical consciousness. Let everyone remember: even the sacrifice on the Cross is not, in itself, the essential point. Truth is reached only when a person rises beyond guilt and atonement and seeks the causes and effects of deeds in the spiritual realm.

The final sacrifice, the bloodless sacrifice, is therefore also proof that an external sacrifice is insufficient. The bloodless sacrifice is established so that human beings will seek, in the spiritual realm, guilt and atonement and an awareness of the connections between their actions. This is what must be remembered. The sacrificial death should not be regarded as the essential thing; in place of the bloody sacrifice, the bloodless, spiritual sacrifice—the Last Supper—should stand as a symbol that the causes and consequences of human actions live in the spiritual field. This is the theosophical teaching of karma: everything a person causes through actions brings its effects in accordance with purely spiritual laws. Karma has nothing to do with physical heredity. The external sign of this is the bloodless sacrifice, the Last Supper.

The Christian confession does not explicitly state that the Last Supper is a symbol of karma. Christianity had a different task, which I have already indicated. Karma and reincarnation—the weaving together of destiny in the spiritual realm and the re-embodiment of the human soul—were profound esoteric truths taught within the inner sanctuaries of the mysteries. Christ, like all great teachers, taught these truths to his own disciples within the temples. But afterward they were to go out into the world, with the power and fire of God kindled within them, so that even those who could not see might nevertheless believe and be blessed.
GA052

GA097
All peoples before Christ appeared on Earth had mysteries. The mysteries portrayed what was to happen in the future. Through long exercises, the disciples were prepared to undergo a symbolic entombment. The hierophant could then bring the disciple into a higher state of consciousness, in which he lay as though in a deep sleep. In ancient times, consciousness had to be lowered whenever the divine was to emerge in the human being. The soul was led through the regions of the spiritual world, and after three days the hierophant brought the person back to life. The person then felt like a new human being, received a new name, and was called a son of God.

This whole process took place openly on the physical plane in the Mystery of Golgotha. Previously, the disciples had been enlivened by a spark of Christ's spirit and told: "One will come who will make it possible for all people to become Christ-filled. One will truly be the Word made flesh. You can experience this only for three days, during which you journey through the kingdoms of heaven. But one will come who continually traverses the kingdoms of heaven and will bring them into the physical world."

What the initiate experienced on the astral plane, Christ was to enact on the physical plane: that from the beginning there had been a divine Word that poured its drops over humanity, but the people of the "I" had not yet been able to receive it. This is what John tells us—the proclaimer of the human being of the "I," who has been filled with Christ and has received Christ. This, too, is what the "Word" means in John.

Every initiation into the mysteries of the spirit pointed toward the appearance of Christ Jesus. Such initiation was present in yogic sleep, Orphic sleep, and the sleep of Hermes. When the initiate awoke again in the body and could hear and speak with physical senses, he uttered the words in Hebrew: "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani"—"My God, my God, how you have exalted me!" (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34. "Sabachthani" is usually translated as "forsaken"; a similar-sounding expression, "shevachthani," means "exalted" or "glorified.")

This was the initiation as it took place in ancient Judaism. During the three days spent in the higher worlds, the initiate experienced the course of all future human development and what awaited humanity. Usually, the future stages of humanity were not seen abstractly; each stage was represented by a person. The seer beheld twelve figures, representing the twelve stages of soul development. The powers of the soul thus appeared to him as external personalities. At a certain point the initiate saw a particular scene: he saw his own individuality transfigured up to the stage at which all humanity would be filled with Buddhi—that is, would become Christ-filled. He saw the God as himself, with the soul-forces standing behind him. Immediately behind him stood John, the final figure, announcing his fulfillment. He saw himself transfigured into the state he would attain when perfected, with his soul-forces personified; the final stage of perfection was represented by John, who proclaims the Christ-stage. During yogic sleep, these twelve figures then formed a group around what was called the

mystical communal meal. The meaning is this: seated and surrounded by the powers of his soul, a person says, “They are one with me; they have led me through the evolution of the Earth. I have advanced on the feet of these apostles.” The meal expresses the unity of the twelve soul-forces with the human being.

Human perfection consists in the lower forces falling away, leaving only the higher forces. In the future, a person will no longer possess the lower forces—for example, the power of reproduction. The soul-force represented by John will have helped raise these forces into the loving heart, which will send out streams of spiritual love. When Christ is within a person, the heart becomes the most powerful organ. The lower soul-force will then have been lifted from the womb to the heart. Every initiate experienced this as the mystery of the heart, expressed in the words: “My God, my God, how you have exalted me!”

With the appearance of Christ Jesus, the whole mystery, the entire experience, was realized on the physical plane. At that time in Palestine there were brotherhoods that had developed out of the ancient Essene order. They held a meal as a symbol of the mystical Last Supper. The expression “to eat the Passover lamb” is a general term for what happened at Easter. Jesus sat at table with the Twelve and instituted the Last Supper with the words: “At the end of the Earth’s evolution, all people will have received what I have brought to Earth; then this will be true: this is my body, this is my blood.” Then he said: “One of you will betray me.” The betrayer is egoism, the lower desire. The disciple whom the Lord loved knew this, for he lay in Jesus’ bosom. As long as this force remains there, it kills—sexual reproduction and death are interdependent. The force that lies in sexuality rises higher in the body, into the heart. In the Gospel, the disciple’s movement upward to the breast signifies this. Just as it is certain that lower desire commits the betrayal, so it is certain that the lower soul-force will be raised higher. “One of his disciples was lying in Jesus’ bosom”—then “he leaned against Jesus’ breast.” This meant that all lower forces, all egoism, had been lifted up to the heart. Jesus then repeated to his disciples the words: “Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani”—“Now the Son of Man is glorified, and God is glorified in him.”
What took place in the mysteries was the same as what happened at Golgotha. Beneath the Cross stood the disciple whom the Lord loved, who had lain in Jesus’ bosom at the Last Supper and had been raised up to his breast. The female figures were also there: his mother, his mother’s sister Mary, and Mary Magdalene. John does not say that Jesus’ mother was named Mary; rather, Mary is named as his mother’s sister. His mother was Sophia.

John baptized Jesus in the Jordan. A dove then descended from heaven. At that moment a spiritual conception took place. Who is the mother of Jesus who is conceived in this way? The chela, or disciple, Jesus of Nazareth, at this moment lays aside his “I”; his highly developed Manas is impregnated, and Buddhi enters into it. The highly developed Manas that has received Buddhi is Wisdom, Sophia—the mother who is impregnated by Jesus’ Father. The name Mary, like Maya, generally means “mother.” Scripture says: “The angel came to her and said, Hail, favored one; behold, you will conceive and bear a son. The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you.” The Holy Spirit is Jesus’ Father; the dove descending from above impregnates the Sophia within Jesus.
The passage should therefore be read as follows: “Standing by the Cross of Jesus was his mother, Sophia.” He says to this mother, “Woman, behold your son.” He himself had transferred the Sophia within him to John. He made John the son of Sophia and said, “Behold your mother”—that is, “From now on, you are to recognize divine Wisdom as your mother and dedicate yourself to her alone.” What John wrote was this divine Wisdom, Sophia, embodied in the Gospel of John itself. John received his knowledge from Jesus, and Christ authorized him to transmit Wisdom to the Earth.

The highest Earth-spirit had to incarnate in a body. That body had to die; it had to be killed, and its blood had to flow. This has a special meaning. Wherever there is blood, there is the self. If all the old communities of selfhood are to cease, the selfhood residing in the blood must once be sacrificed. All individual egoisms flow away with Christ's blood on the Cross. The blood of tribal communities becomes a common human blood because Christ's blood was sacrificed at that moment.

Something else happened that an astral observer might have seen in the astral atmosphere: the entire astral atmosphere of the Earth changed at the moment of Christ's death, making events possible that had never been possible before. Sudden initiation, as in the case of Paul, would previously have been impossible. It became possible because, through the flow of Christ's blood, all humanity became a shared self. At that time the self flowed out of the blood of Jesus' wounds. Only the three bodies remained hanging on the Cross and were later revived by the Risen One. At the moment Christ left the body, the three bodies were so strong that they could themselves speak the words uttered by the transfigured initiate: "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani."

To everyone who knew something of the wisdom of the mysteries, these words would have shown that a mystery was taking place. With a slight alteration in the Hebrew text, they became the scriptural words "Eli, Eli, lama asabthani," meaning, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"
GA097

GA113
A wonderful and magnificent legend of humanity tells that, when Lucifer fell from heaven to Earth, a precious stone fell from his crown. According to the legend, this stone became the vessel in which Christ Jesus shared the Last Supper with his disciples, the vessel that caught Christ's blood as it flowed from the Cross, and the vessel that angels carried to the western world, where it was received by those seeking to attain a true understanding of the Christ principle. The Holy Grail was made from the stone that fell from Lucifer's crown.

What is the Holy Grail? You all know that the human being, as he is today, has four members: the physical body, the etheric body, the astral body, and the "I." In the course of human progress, the "I" must move toward a perfection that fills it more and more; it must rise ever higher. The precious stone fell from the crown of Lucifer, the fallen ruler of the Orient. In a certain respect, that stone is nothing other than the full power of the human "I." The human "I" must first be prepared in darkness so that it can, in a new and worthy way, behold Lucifer's star shining within the light of Christ. The "I" must raise itself through the Christ principle and mature into the jewel that no longer belongs to Lucifer, having fallen from his crown. In other words, it must mature through wisdom until it again becomes capable of enduring the light—not a light that comes to us from outside, but one that shines when we ourselves have done what is necessary. Spiritual-scientific work is therefore work upon the human "I," making it into a vessel once more capable of receiving the light that is present where, to the outer eye and the external human intellect, there is now darkness and night.
GA113

Chapter 14.

GA097
Today we shall seek to understand the promise of the Spirit of Truth. These words concern a secret initiation.

Christ says: “Whoever has my commandments and keeps them is the one who loves me.” “Loving” points to the confidential relationship between teacher and pupil, an esoteric relationship. The deepest secrets of the soul are transmitted there from person to person, in great intimacy. The biblical words we want to clarify today are as follows (John 14:1–2, 15–17, 21–23):

“Let not your heart be troubled. Believe in God, and believe in me. In my Father’s house are many dwelling places …”

“If you love me, keep my commandments. And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Comforter, to remain with you for ever: the Spirit of Truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him. But you know him, for he remains with you and will be in you.”

“Whoever has my commandments and keeps them is the one who loves me. Whoever loves me will be loved by my Father, and I will love him and reveal myself to him.” Judas—not Iscariot—said to him, “Lord, how is it that you will reveal yourself to us and not to the world?” Jesus answered, “Whoever loves me will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come to him and make our dwelling with him.”

“Father” is the name for the innermost power of the soul. It is to be revealed to the intimate disciples. Judas asks: “How is it that you will reveal yourself to us”—the intimate disciples—“and not to the world?” Judas thereby states directly that something is to be revealed to the intimate disciples within the Mystery.

Jesus says: “We will make our dwelling with the Father.” This was the most important aspect of the outpouring of the Spirit, which began with the words: “Let not your heart be troubled.” Christ goes ahead to prepare a dwelling for his intimate disciples: “In my Father’s house are many dwelling places.”

Let us clarify these words. Once a person has attained a level of consciousness, it can never be lost. We must abandon every other conception. People often delight in the idea of “merging into universal consciousness,” imagining that this is redemption. But no such universal consciousness exists, nor will it ever exist. The human being is now acquiring the capacity to say “I.” The more strongly a person says “I” and, from the I, works to purify the three lower bodies—the astral body, etheric body, and physical body—the more powerfully the I develops and the more the person develops toward the future. In this way a person can become selfless consciously and by choice. One day all human beings will have reached the summit of the development of the I. Yet they will be able to grasp the spirit of community selflessly. We are gathered together in this room, and the common spirit here is like a point from which everything radiates collectively. But this common spirit can also radiate voluntarily from every heart and move throughout the room. Let us consider how the Godhead is reflected in the world. Through a great sacrifice, it poured all its life into its reflection. Now imagine that we, too, could pour our life into countless reflections, each of which could say: “I and my origin are one.” Thus, in the beginning, all human beings emerged from the womb of the Godhead as reflections of the Godhead. In the end, they are empty I’s, with their astral, etheric, and physical bodies transformed; they enter the spiritual world and speak the deepest secret of their being: “I and the Father are one.” The animal-like human beings of the Lemurian age could never become spiritual through their own efforts; they could do so only by receiving the divine drops. At the end of their development, purified and refined, they can say: “I and the Father are one.”
GA097

GA100
Christ says (chapter 14:6): “I am the way, the truth, and the life.” What is the way that leads through Christ to the highest Godhead? The “I am” works on the astral body and forms the Spirit-Self from it; it works on the etheric body and forms the Life-Spirit; it works on the physical body and forms the Spirit-Human. When the human I works on these bodies, the Spirit-Self is developed, and within it the Life-Spirit comes into being. Thus the human being arrives at true life. The “I am” contains the way to truth and true life, because it works through the lower bodies and brings true life into being within them. We can represent this as follows:

“I am” — the way — the truth — and the life
Direction — Spirit-Self — Life-Spirit — Spirit-Human

The “I am” indicates the direction the human being must take in order to bring the Spirit-Self, Life-Spirit, and Spirit-Human to development.
GA100

GA094
The scene of the Transfiguration appears in all the Evangelists except John. This will lead us more deeply into the scene. Let us make its meaning entirely clear. What happens there? Jesus goes with three disciples—Peter, James, and John—up the mountain, that is, into the inner sanctuary, the place where one is initiated into the higher worlds and where one speaks in occult language. When it is said that the Master went up the mountain with his disciples, it means that he went to the place where he explained the parable to them. The disciples were transported into a higher state of consciousness. There they see what is not transitory but eternal. Moses and Elijah appear, with Jesus himself among them. What does this mean? In esoteric science, the name Elijah means the same as “EL”—the goal, the way. Moses is the esoteric term for truth. Thus, when Elijah and Moses appear with Jesus in the middle, we have the primordial Christian truth: “I am the way, the truth, and the life.” Jesus himself says—this is an original Christian mystical truth—“I am the way, the truth, and the life.”
GA094

GA095
First, one must put oneself into the mode of speech of that time. In those days, when people heard the external word, they also heard its spiritual content. Consider also this: Christ was the embodiment of the second Person of God. No religious founder before him had embodied the full abundance of the Logos. Yet whatever was divine that became embodied in his predecessors was already part of the Logos—that is, Christ himself. Thus he includes everything that came before him in the words: “I am the way, the truth, and the life.” These words can also be taken literally in another sense. The religious founders before Christ showed the way and taught the truth, but they did not live out the divine Mystery of humanity. They could therefore say: “I am the way and the truth.” Christ alone can say: “I am the way, the truth, and the life.” Elijah means “way,” and Moses means “truth.” At the Transfiguration, Christ appears with Elijah and Moses. The Transfiguration therefore declares: “I am the way, the truth, and the life.” Buddha’s entry into Nirvana—his death—is the same as Christ’s Transfiguration. Where Buddha’s activity comes to an end, Christ’s activity, his life, actually begins.
GA095

GA097
The great powers that rule the world today are international. They are called money, transport, industry, and so on. They have nothing more to do with the old bonds of blood-brotherhood. The reverse side of

this development is materialism. The machine embodies the intellect in the service of selfishness. How differently the Greeks portrayed their god as Zeus, remembering that the principle of the Father underlies everything. Where do we find anything divine in our public life? Machines, railways, and so on—all serve selfishness. This will play a particular role in the future. In the War of All Against All, it will intensify to the utmost.

Although Christ created the bond that unites all human beings, something else must be added to the Redeemer's deed. In people who feel drawn to Christ live the feelings that lead one person toward another. His deed is the great act of connection that can bring spirit and physical existence together again. Today, people still control the physical world in the service of selfishness. One day they are to use it in the service of spirit. Spirit must unite with the Son, so that together they may be taken up into the Father!

Christ says: "No one comes to the Father except through me!" (John 14:6). Each person should say: I am like a branch on the vine; Christ is my vine. Then Christ overcomes selfishness in the organisms of humanity. The Father-Spirit, the spirit of our common origin, must enter the individual I's; then the I works upon the principle of the Father. Each I builds its own house, and yet all are united through the Christ-principle. "In my Father's house are many dwelling places," Christ says. These are the dwelling places that the I's build for themselves. Christ, however, must prepare the place, the dwelling. For this, the Spirit that unites human beings must come: the Spirit of Truth.

Theosophy is meant to teach people to understand what they share in common; it is meant to bring higher wisdom, the Spirit of Truth. People hold differing opinions as long as they have not attained the highest knowledge. The Gnostics called mysticism "Mathesis," for in mathematics no one can simply claim to have a different opinion from everyone else. Two scholars cannot disagree about a mathematical proposition. Personal wishes do not determine the matter. In the great wisdom, we must free ourselves from our wishes. Only those who wish to study the Spirit of Truth without imposing their own desires are ready to receive it. The highest knowledge unites people; there is no mere opinion or conjecture. The Spirit of Truth must shine over humanity. Then, even if people are scattered among different dwellings, the Spirit of Truth will unite them. For the house the I builds to fit into the spiritual world, the common Spirit of Truth must guide the I's. Christ promises his disciples the Spirit of Truth at Pentecost. The disciples speak in different tongues, and all nations learn to understand one another. However much selfishness may grow, each I will possess the spirit of community if it shares in the Spirit of Truth. Whoever strives for this must live in the spirit of John's Gospel. This is true theosophy. Just as all plants turn toward the sun and grow toward it, wherever they may be rooted, so all I's will turn toward the sun of spirit, toward the spiritual light of truth!
GA097

GA266b
There are three important things every human being must learn: walking, speaking, and understanding —that is, forming concepts.

Through walking, the child learns to know the way;
through understanding, the child learns to know the truth;
through speaking, the truth gains life;

so that we can relate these three things to the words of Christ Jesus: "I am the way, the truth, and the life."

Every human being must turn back and “become as little children”—that is, learn these three things that the child accomplishes during the first three years of life.
GA266b

GA265
When a person recognizes himself in this way as a spiritual being within the universal Spirit, he can feel the meaning of the words from the Rosicrucian saying: “In the Holy Spirit I shall be reborn.” For he stands as a new being in relation to his former self, a being that must first acquire the qualities and capacities needed for spiritual life, just as a child must learn to use its bodily organs in the physical world. This spiritual being must also experience within itself the three spiritual powers revealed in cosmic evolution as feeling, thinking, and willing—as love, wisdom, and strength. Just as a child first learns to stand and walk, a person must learn to find direction and a path in the spiritual world. This can be acquired only through feeling, by approaching everything with love. Next, a person must learn to recognize truth by learning to understand the wisdom of the worlds resounding within, allowing the sounds of the spiritual world to ring within and sensing their meaning, just as a child learns to understand language. Then, little by little, the person learns to recognize true life in spirit by experiencing within himself a center from which his own impulses of will and life proceed, so that he can express himself through speech and through his being. Therefore Christ Jesus says: “I am the way, the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me.” No one can penetrate to the true spiritual origin of all existence, to the Father, without developing these three powers in the spirit and combining them in the right way.
GA265

GA093
Within the spirit that developed in Judaism, higher Manas had to be kindled. Thus the new era begins with the descent of the Holy Spirit, which will lead human beings toward the point when, in the sixth sub-race, the Christ-principle—today only hinted at in Christianity—will reach its fulfilment. “No one comes to the Father except through me,” says the Son. He sent the Spirit to humanity to prepare it for the time when good and evil will separate in the sixth sub-race. Humanity would never have developed this impulse without that other influence, which we have called the so-called evil principle. Human beings had to receive free will; then their intellect could be called upon to choose between good and evil. This descent of the Spirit takes place at Pentecost.
GA093

GA093
Spirit, Son, and Father are buried in the Earth: the Father in the physical body, the Son in the etheric body, and the Spirit in the astral body. But the human being has developed the “I” and become self-conscious. Now the I must learn to work down into the physical body. That will happen in the future. In the present age, the human being is working into the astral body. The symbol of this is the outpouring of the Holy Spirit upon the heads of those who are to be humanity’s leaders. That which has received this Spirit is something within the human being that is akin to this Spirit.
GA093

Chapter 15.

GA097
After John had experienced all this on the Devachan plane, he can understand what follows in the parable of the vine and the branches. It expresses the fellowship of the entire Christian community.

We live in the fifth root race of our earthly existence. This fifth root race has seven sub-races: the ancient Indian, the ancient Persian, the Egyptian-Babylonian-Chaldean, the Greco-Roman-Semitic, the Germanic, the Slavic, and the seventh sub-race. The last three sub-races of the fourth root race, the Atlantean, are especially important. The fifth root race emerged from the third-to-last, the ancient Semitic sub-race. This fifth sub-race lived in the region where Ireland is today. From there it migrated and was led to the Gobi or Shamo Desert. From here emerged the parent race for the present root race, the fifth. Thus, three sub-races of the Atlanteans, seven sub-races of the Aryan root race, and two of the sixth root race belong together in a certain respect. When humanity has passed through all these races, it will have reached the point at which a large part of humankind has attained what it is predisposed to attain.

The twelve apostles are symbols of these twelve sub-races. Jesus grew out of the twelve apostles. In the washing of the feet, Jesus bends toward the races to which he is to bring salvation.
In the parable of the vine, Christ feels himself to be the one connected with all races; he supplies them with what constitutes the spiritual lifeblood.
GA097

GA094
The wine—the juice that flows through the vine—is a one-sided development of the blood. What the blood breathes out gives off carbon dioxide and alcohol. Alcohol is, so to speak, the blood of the future. The plant juice that exhales carbon dioxide stands opposite present-day blood as future blood. Through cosmic knowledge, we experience the kinship between wine and blood. Christ may say of the wine: “This is my blood.” For Christ is the representative of future humanity. His teaching itself is a living spring toward which humanity develops. Let us think of the parable of the vine and the branches, and of the parable of the transformation of water into wine. The vine represents only an anticipation of development, analogous to the anticipated hardening of wood. Just as the plant today transforms its watery juices into wine, so human beings cannot do this today, but will transform their blood at a later time.
GA094

Chapter 16.

GA097
Through this series of parables, the apostles are to be led upward into the inner nature of Christianity. At Christ’s sacrificial death, everything that had previously taken place within the mystery cults themselves came onto the world stage, onto the stage of history, as the disciple had formerly lived through it. Here in the Gospel, Lazarus experienced it as a symbolic three-day death. In Christ, this was to emerge onto the great stage of history. From then on, a person was also to be redeemed by believing alone, without having personally seen into the mysteries. Everyone was to experience this when the Spirit of Truth came. He proclaims what is placed into world history as a force through the events of Christianity. “He will declare to you the things that are to come” (John 16:13).
From this Spirit of Truth, John proclaims things in advance. The historical betrayal of Christ unfolds in the future in the race corresponding to Judas.
GA097

GA112
Christ instructed those who were his disciples. To prepare them for the greatest thing, he followed the method necessary for learning to comprehend the greatest thing in the appropriate way: he spoke to the disciples in parables—or, as the German Bible translates it, in “proverbs”—in figurative expressions

and parables. The time comes when the disciples have grown ever more mature and believe themselves ready to hear the truth without proverbs. Christ Jesus brings about the moment when he wishes to speak to his apostles without a proverb, without a parable. For the apostles want to hear the name for whose sake he came into the world; they want to hear that important name:

“Until now you have asked nothing in my name. Ask, and you will receive, so that your joy may be complete. I have spoken these things to you in proverbs. But the time is coming when I will no longer speak to you in proverbs, but will tell you plainly about my Father.”

Let us feel the moment approaching when he wishes to speak to his disciples about the Father!

“On that day you will ask in my name. I do not say to you that I will ask the Father on your behalf. For the Father himself loves you, because you have loved me and have believed that I came forth from God. I came forth from the Father.”

Of course, he came forth from the Father in his true form, and not from the deceptive form of the Father.

“I came forth from the Father and came into the world; again, I leave the world and go to the Father.”

Now it dawns on the disciples, because they have matured, that the world around them is the outward expression of the Father, and that what is most significant in the outer world—where the outer world is most of all Maya, or illusion—is an expression of the Father: that death is the name for the Father. This dawns on the disciples. But one must read it correctly.

“His disciples said to him: ‘See, now you are speaking plainly and not using a proverb. Now we know that you know all things and do not need anyone to question you; for this reason we believe that you came forth from God.’ Jesus answered them: ‘Do you now believe? Behold, the hour is coming, and has already come, when you will be scattered, each to his own, and will leave me alone. Yet I am not alone, for the Father is with me. I have said these things to you so that in me you may have peace. In the world you have tribulation; but take courage, I have overcome the world.’” (16:24–33)

Did the disciples know where he was going now? Yes, from this point on they knew he was going to death; he was to unite himself with death. Now read what he said to them after they had learned to understand the words, “I came forth from death”—that is, from death in its true form, from the Father of Life—“and came into the world; again, I leave the world and go to the Father.” Then his disciples say:

“Now we know that you know all things and do not need anyone to question you; for this reason we believe that you came forth from God.”

Now the disciples knew that the true form of death is grounded in the divine Spirit-Father, and that death as it is seen and felt by human beings is a deceptive appearance, an error. Thus Christ reveals to his disciples the name of death, behind which is concealed the source of the highest life.

The new sun of life would never have arisen if death had not come into the world and allowed itself to be overcome by Christ. Thus death, regarded in its true form, is the Father. Christ came into the world because a false reflection of this “Father” had arisen in death. And Christ came into the world to create the true form, a true image of the living Father-God. The Son is the descendant of the Father, who

reveals the Father's true form. Truly, the Father sent his Son into the world so that the Father's true nature might be revealed—that is, eternal life, which is concealed behind temporal death.
GA112

Chapter 17.

GA345
When we go back to the original language of religious documents, especially the New Testament, we find that this original language is no longer felt in the right way by the soul as it is constituted today. And so an element of untruthfulness has indeed entered into the interpretation of religious documents, including the New Testament. We must not hope that continuing to produce translations in the manner followed until now can lead to anything better. Rather, we must first find the preconditions for truly grasping the meaning of religious documents through a kind of resurrection of the ancient spirituality.

We can do this—and essentially anyone who makes the necessary effort can do it—by applying the spiritual-scientific facts that can be researched today, initially to the New Testament.
What, then, can be said about the relationship between humanity blessed by Christ and humanity not yet blessed by Christ? When humanity not yet blessed by Christ looked back into consciousness, into the very being of its own soul, could it say: "As an individual, I am endowed with an I"? No. The soul could only say: "The Father-God lives within me, and it is because he lives within me that I can say 'I' of myself." The individual was not yet fully individualized; the individual was a child of the Father-God, but in such a way that the child was, as it were, still connected to the Father by a kind of umbilical cord. What the soul could possess when it became conscious of this divine content could no longer be possessed in the same way later. Humanity blessed by Christ received this content in such a way that each person could take this substance into their I from within their own individual soul-being.

Thus Christ brought to human beings on Earth the same thing that the Father-God had given humanity on Earth, but he brought it in a new way, so that each person could now unite it with the I that wells up from within themselves. And so Christ could say to humanity: "I bring you what you are accustomed to recognize through the Logos, but I bring it to you in a new way. I bring it to you so that the Father-God has entrusted to me what he previously gave you directly, but for a different state of consciousness. As his messenger, I bring you the Father's treasure for each one of your individual consciousnesses, for each one of your individualities. I no longer wish merely to make you people who are, as it were, members of the whole cosmos. By virtue of the authority the Father-God has given me, I wish to make each one of you, if you are willing to come, a God-filled human being. Those whom the Father-God entrusts to me as individuals, I fill with God-consciousness."

The essential point of the Mystery of Golgotha, then, is that the way God-consciousness was to come to human beings was different from what it had been before. This is why the words of the Gospel acquire an entirely different meaning through the Mystery of Golgotha. For example, it is quite possible to identify individual parts of the Lord's Prayer in earlier stages of humanity's development. But in this case the content is not what matters; what matters is that the Lord's Prayer, with the same words and sentences, is given in a different, new way to the soul filled with self-consciousness. We can once again penetrate the spiritual forces of history when we ourselves are able to conduct spiritual research. This is what brings us back to the original meaning of the Gospels. Today this original meaning must be brought to light. Humanity must no longer be fobbed off with misunderstood Gospel translations—that is, translations that do not take the Gospels seriously enough. If one is completely honest in one's soul, can one still find meaning today in the words of John 17:1–9?

This renewed penetration into the spiritual forces of history becomes possible when we ourselves are able to conduct spiritual research. This is what brings us back to the original meaning of the Gospels. If we simply return to the meaning that is there in a sober, straightforward sense, I can only render it approximately as follows:

"After Jesus had spoken these things, he lifted his eyes to heaven and said: Father, the hour has come; reveal it to your Son, so that your Son may reveal it from you, just as you have given him power over all flesh, so that he may give lasting life to those whom you have given him as his own. And this is lasting life: that they recognize you as the only true God, and Jesus Christ as the one sent forth. I have revealed you on Earth in order to bring to completion the work you assigned me to do. And now, Father, reveal me with the revelation that came to me through you before the world existed. I have brought you into appearance for the people whom you assigned to me out of the world. They were yours, and you gave them to me, and they have remained filled with your word.

Thus they have recognized that everything you have given me comes from you. For the powers of thought that you gave me, I have brought to them. They have united themselves with these powers and perceived that I come from you, and understood that you gave me to them. I make my request to you for them as individual human beings, not for people in general—only for those you have given me, because they are through you."

The whole presentation contains what I told you earlier, my dear friends: nothing other than the spiritual facts of humanity's development are represented in the Gospels. We can recognize the Gospels as correct precisely when we have arrived at the spiritual facts within them. This gives rise to a consciousness that, I would say, can cast the right light on the words. Surely it is not out of a desire to indulge in vain criticism that I say it is impossible to say: "Father, the hour has come for you to glorify your Son, so that your Son may also glorify you." An honest person must say that this really says nothing—at least nothing with a meaning that can be grasped by the human heart. A correct meaning emerges, of course, if, following the Greek text, one says: "Father, the hour has come; reveal it to your Son"—that is, a request that the Father reveal it to the Son. The Greek word doxa does not mean glorification here; it means revelation, making known, bringing to knowledge. That is the intended meaning: "so that your Son may reveal it from you." The mediation of the Father's content through the power of the Son is expressed directly and in a simple, vivid way in these words. Previously, people had the substance of the Father-God within them in the manner described. Now the Father-God has brought it about that the Son mediates this content to humanity. This is really what the text says, and it cannot be denied: "just as you have given him power over all flesh." The word "flesh" is difficult to translate, because ordinary language leads to a misunderstanding. One should really say: "just as you have given him power over all human bodies, so that he may bestow lasting life on those you have given him as his own." If we consider that human bodies were once such that they were permeated by an original awareness that was still filled with God, and thus received lasting life, we can understand that now, since consciousness is no longer filled by this power, bodies can no longer reflect back into the soul anything that confers lasting life. This is why Christ was sent to humanity. "And this is lasting life: that they recognize you as the only true God, and Jesus Christ as the one sent forth. I have revealed you on Earth in order to bring to completion the work you assigned me to do. And now, Father, reveal me with the revelation that came to me through you before the world existed. I have brought you into appearance for the people whom you assigned to me out of the world. They were yours, and you gave them to me, and they have remained filled with your word."

Christ Jesus ensured that the Word did not die out in human beings, and that the substance of the Father remained with them. Had the Mystery of Golgotha not taken place, people would have forgotten their

content. The Father would have been forgotten if the Son had not maintained the Father's presence. "Thus they have recognized that everything you have given me comes from you. For the powers of thought that you gave me, I have brought to them. They have united themselves with these powers and perceived that I come from you, and understood that you gave me to them. I make my request to you for them as individual human beings, not for people in general—only for those you have given me, because they are through you." I put "for people in general" here instead of "for the world." This is no longer understood. The passage points to a spiritual connection that was a familiar conception at the time: for them as individual human beings, not merely for people in general.

Truly, the New Testament does not become any less beautiful, great, or sublime when one grasps its content. It is also part of rightly placing oneself in the present—in the spiritual life of the present and in a contemporary religious movement—to return to the reality of the Gospel. How often has the demand been made that we should return to original Christianity! This failed because people did not manage to grasp the Logos in its original meaning, and repeatedly took comfort in human convenience by assuming that the Gospels had to be accepted in their more simplistic content. Yet the simple content would no longer be obscured if we attended simply to what is actually written. We must not forget, my dear friends, that words change their emotional value significantly over time. It is not possible simply to transfer a word from an ancient language by consulting a dictionary. Even when we translate something from the present day in a merely dictionary-like way, we arrive at quite different meanings. This is even more true when translating things from the past.

The task is not to attach the emotional value a word has today directly to the wording of the ancient word, but to return to the emotional content of the ancient wording. Throughout the New Testament we can find evidence that the Gospels were spoken at a time when the revelation granted to humanity by the spiritual cosmos had passed from a not-yet-fully-developed consciousness of the I into a fully developed consciousness of individuality. All other facts must be judged in light of this fundamental fact. We must not cling to prejudices and say that the disciples, simple people from the lowest social classes, could not have grasped such a meaning. If the meaning of the Gospels is straightforward to grasp, then we must also reveal the wonderful fact: how did these simple people come to give the Gospels such profound meaning? This is far more spiritual than saying that these simple people from the common folk could not possibly have understood such a meaning. Such an interpretation rests on a different prejudice.
GA345

Chapter 18.

GA148
Christ Jesus had a remarkable effect on his disciples in particular. My dear friends, as I tell you about this, please keep in mind that I am simply recounting what can be read in this Fifth Gospel.

As he travelled through the country, his effect on those around him was quite extraordinary. He was in the company of the apostles and disciples, yet because he was the Christ-being it was as though he was not confined to his own body. As he walked with the disciples, one or another sometimes felt that Christ was within his own soul, even while walking beside him. Some felt the being associated with Christ Jesus within their own souls and began to speak words that Christ Jesus himself could truly speak. The group met people and spoke with them; the speaker was not always Christ Jesus himself, for some of the disciples also spoke. He shared everything with them, including his wisdom.

I must admit that I was greatly astonished to discover, for example, that the conversation with the Sadducee reported in Mark's Gospel (Mark 12:18–27) was not spoken by Christ Jesus from within the body of Jesus, but through one of the disciples—though, of course, it was Christ who spoke. It also often happened that when Christ Jesus left his group, he nevertheless remained among them. He either accompanied them spiritually while far away or was present with them only in his etheric body. His etheric body moved among them and travelled through the country with them, and it was often impossible to tell whether he was present with his physical body or only as an appearance of the etheric body.

This was how he interacted with the disciples and many people among the populace after Jesus of Nazareth had become Christ Jesus. As I have indicated, the Christ-being was initially relatively independent of the body of Jesus of Nazareth, but later had increasingly to become like it. As life advanced, he became more bound to that body, and in the final year he suffered profound pain from being bound to the already ailing body of Jesus of Nazareth. Yet Christ, who now travelled with a large group, still sometimes went out of his body. At different places different members of the apostolic group spoke, and people might believe the speaker was Christ Jesus—or might not. Christ spoke through them all as long as they travelled in intimate fellowship with him.

We can overhear the Pharisees and Jewish scribes saying to one another that, to frighten the people, they could seize and kill any one of the group—but it might be the wrong one, since they all spoke alike. That would not solve their problem, because the real Christ Jesus might still be there. They needed the real one. Only the disciples who had come close to him could distinguish him, and they certainly did not tell the enemy which one was the true Christ.

Ahriman had grown strong in relation to the remaining question, which Christ could not resolve in the spiritual worlds but only on Earth. Christ had to learn through the most difficult deed what it meant to turn stones into bread—or, equivalently, money into bread—for Ahriman made use of Judas Iscariot.

Given the way Christ worked, no spiritual means could identify which of his devoted disciples was Christ. Where the spirit and even the last persuasive force were active, Christ could not be reached. He could be reached only where Judas used a means Christ did not know, one he learned through the hardest earthly deed: money. Christ could not have been identified except through someone who placed himself in Ahriman's service and came to the betrayal through money alone. The connection between Christ Jesus and Judas arose because, in the temptation story, Christ, newly descended to Earth, did not know what is true only in heaven: that stones are not needed to make bread. Ahriman retained this as his weapon, and the betrayal followed. Christ then had to enter the dominion of the lord of death, insofar as Ahriman is that lord. This is the connection between the temptation, the Mystery of Golgotha, and Judas's betrayal.
GA148

GA093
The rooster crows twice; it symbolizes both the lower and the higher I of the human being. It crows the first time when the human being descends and materializes in physical substance, and the second time when the human being rises again, has learned to understand Christ, and Aquarius has appeared. This will occur in the sixth sub-race. Then the human being will spiritually understand what they are meant to become. The I will have passed a certain stage when, in the highest sense, what the Temple of Solomon represents is realized, and the human being becomes a temple for "Yahweh."

Before that, however, the human being must pass through three stages of purification. The I is enclosed in three coverings: first the astral body, second the etheric body, and third the physical body.

While in the astral body, we denied the divine I for the first time; in the etheric body, for the second time; and in the physical body, for the third. The first crowing of the rooster is this threefold denial through the human being's threefold covering. Once the I has passed through the three bodies and found its greatest symbolic realization in Christ, the rooster crows a second time.
GA093

GA148
The ordinary human being is a microcosm in relation to the macrocosm, a small image of the whole macrocosm, because what is expressed in the human physical body—what the human being becomes on Earth—reflects the great cosmos. With the Christ-being, the reverse occurs. The macrocosmic solar being takes on the form of the human microcosm, pressing and contracting itself more and more until it increasingly resembles the human microcosm. The opposite of what happens with an ordinary human being takes place.

At the beginning of Christ's earthly life, immediately after the baptism in the Jordan, his connection with the body of Jesus of Nazareth was at its loosest. The Christ-being was still almost entirely outside that body. What it did while moving across the Earth was then wholly super-earthly: it performed healings beyond human power and spoke with a penetrating force that was divine. But gradually it became more like the body of Jesus of Nazareth, contracting and entering earthly conditions, while divine power increasingly faded. This was a descending development: as the Christ-being became like the body of Jesus of Nazareth, it felt the power and strength of God receding. The God gradually became a human being.

As someone might watch their body waste away amid infinite suffering, so the Christ-being saw its divine content diminish as it increasingly resembled the earthly body of Jesus of Nazareth in its etheric form.

It became so similar to that body that it could feel fear as a human does. The other Gospels also describe this when Christ Jesus went with his disciples to the Mount of Olives and the Christ-being, within the body of Jesus of Nazareth, had sweat of anguish on its brow. This was Christ's humanization—his becoming ever more human and growing like the body of Jesus of Nazareth. As the etheric Christ-being increasingly resembled that body, Christ became human and his divine miraculous powers faded. We can see the whole Passion journey beginning soon after the baptism in the Jordan, when he healed the sick and cast out demons through divine power. People were amazed and said no being on Earth had ever done such things. At that time the Christ-being was still unlike the body of Jesus of Nazareth. Over three years, this wonder gave way to a state in which the Christ-being had become so like the increasingly weak and sick body that it could no longer answer Pilate, Herod, or Caiaphas. It remained silent before the Jewish high priest's question about destroying and rebuilding the Temple in three days, and before Pilate's question whether he claimed to be King of the Jews. This was the Passion path from the baptism in the Jordan to powerlessness. Soon the crowd that had once marvelled at his super-earthly powers stood before the cross mocking the helplessness of the God who had become human: "If you are a god, come down! You helped others; now help yourself!" The Passion was the path from divine omnipotence to powerlessness, a path of immeasurable suffering for God made human, compounded by the suffering caused by the state of humanity at the time of the Mystery of Golgotha, during an era of great intellectual development.

We see, then, my dear friends, that the Christ-being is an entity that requires us to change completely all the concepts we have acquired about the sequence of states in human life. After the brief interval usually called the period of purification or Kamaloka, a human being passes into the spiritual world to prepare for the next earthly life. After death, the human being experiences a spiritual life. From the event of Pentecost onward, the Christ-being experienced something equivalent for it: the transition into the Earth's sphere. Instead of entering Devachan or a spiritual realm as a human being does after death, the Christ-being sacrificed its heaven, as it were, and sought to establish its dwelling on Earth. The human being leaves Earth to exchange this dwelling for heaven; Christ left heaven to exchange his dwelling for Earth. Please consider this in the right light and feel what took place through the Mystery of Golgotha: the sacrifice of the Christ-being consisted in leaving the spiritual spheres to live with the Earth and its people, and to carry human evolution forward through the impulse he gave it. This also means that before the baptism in the Jordan, this being did not belong to the Earth's sphere; it descended from super-earthly spheres. What it experienced between the baptism and Pentecost was necessary to transform the heavenly Christ-being into an earthly one.
GA148

GA211
It is extraordinarily difficult for people today to understand an important truth about the earliest periods of human development on Earth: the first human beings who walked the Earth did not possess the kind of knowledge that we call knowledge today.

Through their atavistic clairvoyant faculties, these first human beings could receive divine wisdom. In other words, they could be taught by divine beings who descended spiritually from the realms of the higher hierarchies to Earth and instructed souls in a spiritual way.

In ancient times, people knew this kind of instruction directly from divine beings who descended from spiritual worlds to Earth. People—often those who had undergone initiation into the mysteries—could enter an ecstatic state in which their souls were largely outside their bodies. They did not depend on external sensory perception or spoken conversation, but could receive divine communications spiritually. They did not receive this wisdom in what we now call dreams, but through living spiritual communion with divine-spiritual beings, who imparted what they regarded as their essential wisdom.
At first, this wisdom concerned communications from the gods about the human soul's sojourn in the divine-spiritual world before descending into an earthly body. The gods taught people what souls experienced before conception and descent into an earthly body. People felt they were simply being reminded of what they had experienced in the spiritual-soul world before birth or conception. Something of this survives in Plato, suggesting that such experiences were known in earlier times. We can therefore look back to a divine-spiritual wisdom received on Earth in the states described—quite literally, not figuratively—from the gods themselves.

This wisdom was unusual because people on Earth knew nothing of death, strange as that may sound today. The child knows nothing of death; similarly, those instructed in this way, who passed their teaching on to others with atavistic clairvoyance, became conscious that their soul had descended from divine-spiritual worlds into a body and would later leave it again. They saw the onward course of spiritual-soul life. Birth and death appeared to them as transformations, not as the beginning and end of something.

Schematically, one might say that people saw the human soul continuing to develop and experienced earthly life as an interruption.

They did not see points A and B as beginning and end, but the continuously flowing spiritual-soul life. They did see people die, of course. These earliest people were not like animals in their inner spiritual nature, despite their outward resemblance to animals. Yet, just as an animal does not understand death when it sees another animal dead, these people—who knew only of the continuing spiritual-soul life—did not understand death. Death belonged to Maya, the great illusion, and made no particular impression on them. They knew life, but despite seeing death, they did not know death. Their spiritual-soul life was not entangled with death. They saw human life from within: looking at birth, they saw life extending beyond birth into the spiritual world; looking at death, they saw spiritual-soul life extending beyond death into the spiritual world. Birth and death had no significance for life. They knew life, not death.

People gradually emerged from this state. If we follow human development from the earliest times toward the Mystery of Golgotha, we can say that people increasingly came to know death as something that made an impression on them. Their souls became entangled with death, and a question of feeling arose: what happens to the soul when a person passes through death?

In the earliest times, people did not regard death as an end. At most, they asked about the particular nature of the transformation. They wondered whether it was the breath leaving the person and flowing onward, carrying the soul into eternity, or formed some other conception of the continuing spiritual-soul life. They reflected on the manner of this continuation, but not on death as an end.

Only as the Mystery of Golgotha approached did people begin to feel that death had significance and that earthly life comes to an end. This was not yet a scientifically formulated philosophical question, but a feeling that settled into the soul. Humanity had to develop this feeling during earthly life, because intellect had to enter human evolution. Intellect, however, depends on our capacity to die, as I have often explained.

Humanity therefore had to become entangled with death and learn to know it. The ancient ages in which people did not know death were non-intellectual. People received ideas through inspirations from the spiritual world rather than thinking them out; there was no intellect. But intellect had to emerge. It can emerge only because, spiritually and psychologically speaking, human beings can die and continually carry forces of dying within themselves. Physically, one could say that death can occur because salts and other mineral, solid, dead components accumulate in the body and also in the brain. The brain continually tends toward salt deposits and incomplete bone formation; it therefore carries within itself a tendency toward death. This infusion of death had to come upon humanity. Only because death came to play a real role in human life did people become outwardly acquainted with it. Had people remained as they were in ancient times, not truly knowing death, they could never have developed intellect, which is possible only in a world ruled by death.

This is how the matter appears from the human side. It can also be considered from the side of the higher hierarchies, where it looks somewhat different.

The higher hierarchies contain the forces that formed Saturn, the Sun, the Moon, and finally the Earth. If they had explained their teaching among themselves up to the Mystery of Golgotha, they might have said: We can form the Earth out of Saturn, Sun, and Moon. But if Earth contained only what we were able to incorporate into Saturn, Sun, and Moon, it could never develop beings who know death and can therefore develop intellect. We can bring forth from the Moon an Earth whose people know nothing of death, but they would also be unable to develop intellect. We cannot shape Earth so that it provides the forces needed for human intellect. We must therefore engage with a very different being, one whose

path differs from ours: the Ahrimanic being. Ahriman does not belong to our hierarchy; he enters the stream of evolution by another route. If we tolerate him in Earth's evolution and grant him a share, he brings death and thus intellect, allowing death and intellect to enter human nature. Ahriman knows death because he is interwoven with Earth and has followed paths linking him to earthly evolution. He is a knower, a wise one in matters of death, and therefore also the lord of intellect.

The gods had, so to speak, to come to terms with Ahriman. They had to acknowledge that evolution could not proceed without him and that he had to be admitted into it. But if Ahriman were admitted and became lord over death and therefore intellect, the Earth would be lost to the gods: Ahriman, whose only interest is to make the whole Earth intellectualized, would claim it for himself.

The gods faced the great question of losing, in a certain sense, their dominion over Earth to Ahriman. There was only one possibility: the gods themselves had to learn something they could not have known in their own worlds, which were not permeated by Ahriman. Through one of their messengers, Christ, the gods had to learn death on Earth itself. A god had to die on Earth, and had to die in a way grounded not in divine wisdom but in the human error that would prevail if Ahriman alone held power. A god had to pass through death and overcome it. For the gods, the Mystery of Golgotha thus meant enriching their knowledge with the wisdom of death. Had no god passed through death, Earth would have become wholly intellectualized without ever entering the evolution the gods had originally intended for it.

People did not know death in ancient times, but they came to know it. They had to feel that with death —that is, with intellect—they were entering a stream of evolution quite different from the one from which they had come. Christ taught his initiates that he came from a world where death was unknown, that he came to know death on Earth and conquered it. Understanding this relationship between the earthly and divine worlds allows intellect to be led back to spirituality. This, approximately, was the content of the esoteric teaching Christ gave his initiated disciples: the teaching about death and how it appears from the standpoint of the gods.

To grasp the full depth of this esoteric teaching, one must understand that anyone who comprehends the whole of human evolution can recognize this: the gods overcame Ahriman by making his forces useful for Earth, and blunted his power by learning death themselves through the being of Christ. The gods incorporated Ahriman into earthly evolution, but by using him they compelled him to enter that evolution without allowing him to carry his own dominion through to the end.

Anyone who has come to know Ahriman since the Mystery of Golgotha, and who knows what preceded it, understands that Ahriman had waited for the world-historical moment when he could affect not only the unconscious and subconscious—as he had done since Atlantean times, as described in my Occult Science—but also human consciousness. If one were to apply human expressions to divine intentions, one might say that Ahriman longed for the moment when he could enter human consciousness with his power.

Ahriman was surprised because he had not known beforehand that a divine decision had been made to send Christ to Earth, a being who would pass through death. Ahriman's intervention thereby became possible, but the edge was taken off his actual dominion. Since then, Ahriman has used every opportunity to reduce human beings to the mere use of intellect; even today he has not abandoned the hope of doing so.

Today, opposition to Ahriman is found chiefly in teachings that flow through anthroposophy. If anthroposophy once again makes clear the independence of the spiritual-soul being from the physical body, Ahriman must first relinquish his hope. Christ's struggle against Ahriman can already be sensed in the Gospel's temptation story. But the matter can be fully understood only by recognizing, as I have often explained, that Lucifer played the greater role in earlier human development, while Ahriman began to influence human consciousness only from the time of the Mystery of Golgotha. Before then he influenced humanity, but not consciousness itself.

Looking into the human heart, we must say that the most important point in earthly human evolution is when a person learns that the Christ impulse contains a force through which they can overcome death within themselves by uniting with it.

Seen from the spiritual world outside us, this means that Ahriman was drawn into earthly evolution by the hierarchies associated with Saturn, Sun, Moon, Earth, and so on, but his claim to dominion was restricted by placing his forces in the service of Earth's development. Ahriman was, in a sense, compelled to enter earthly evolution. Without him, the gods could not have brought intellectualism into humanity. If the Christ event had not blunted Ahriman's dominion, he would have intellectualized Earth inwardly and materialized it outwardly. The Mystery of Golgotha must therefore be seen not merely as an inward mystical event, but as an outward event—not one to be described in the manner of material historical research, but as the incorporation of Ahrimanism into earthly evolution and, at the same time, its overcoming in a certain sense.

Thus a battle among the gods took place through the Mystery of Golgotha. This divine struggle was part of the esoteric teaching Christ gave his initiated disciples after his resurrection. The esoteric Christianity of ancient humanity taught that people were connected with the worlds of the gods and knew them through revelations of the kind described. But the divine worlds could tell them nothing about death, because death did not exist there; human beings too had known only the continuous progress of spiritual-soul life through the divine order. People now encountered the significance of death on Earth and could gain the strength to hold fast to Christ and overcome it. That is inner human development. The esoteric teaching Christ gave his initiated disciples, however, was that what happened on Golgotha reflected super-earthly events—a relationship between the divine worlds associated with Saturn, Sun, Moon, and the earlier Earth, and Ahriman. The cross of Golgotha was not merely an earthly event; it had significance for the entire cosmos. This was the content of esoteric Christianity.

One may gain a sense of what esoteric Christianity meant by imagining two initiated disciples of Christ, advancing in this teaching while still struggling with doubts. One might say to the other: The Christ who teaches us descended from worlds known in ancient times. People knew the gods, but not gods who could speak of death. Had we remained with them alone, we would never have learned the nature of death. The gods had to send one of their own to Earth to learn death through him. After his resurrection, Christ seems to teach us what the gods had to do to bring earthly evolution to its proper goal. By holding fast to him, we learn what people could not previously know: what the gods did behind the scenes of existence to guide Earth's evolution rightly. We learn how they introduced Ahriman's forces without allowing them to destroy humanity, instead making them useful to human beings.

The esoteric teaching brought by the risen Christ to his initiated disciples was deeply moving. Such a disciple might have continued: We would know nothing of the gods today, for we are entangled with death, had Christ not died and risen and then communicated to us, after his resurrection, the gods'

experiences of death. Humanity would sink into an age in which it could know nothing of the gods. The gods found a way to speak to us again, and that way led through the Mystery of Golgotha.

The essential message passed from esoteric Christianity to the disciples was that human beings had again drawn near to the divine from which they had become distant. In the earliest period of Christian development, the disciples were deeply imbued with this shattering teaching. Some people known to history only through outward accounts carried knowledge that could have come only from being taught by the risen Christ himself or from contact with teachers who had received that instruction.

In the first centuries, people valued this living chain of transmission, but later it became externalized into a merely historical account. Essentially, however, it goes back to what I have described. The incorporation of intellect—beginning especially in the fourth and fifth centuries after the Mystery of Golgotha, and undergoing a decisive change in the fifteenth century with the fifth post-Atlantean period—meant that the old wisdom needed to understand these matters had been lost while the new wisdom had not yet developed. For a time humanity effectively forgot what mattered esoterically in Christianity. Notes on it survived in secret societies, though their members today no longer understand what the notes refer to: teachings given by the risen Christ to certain initiated disciples.

Suppose the ancient Hebrew teaching had not been regenerated through Christianity. What happened would have had to contradict Paul's firm conviction before the event on the road to Damascus. Paul may have thought something like this: There is an ancient inherited teaching, originally a divine-spiritual revelation that came spiritually to humanity in primeval times, as I have described. It was then preserved in written texts. Among the Hebrew people, scribes knew from scripture what remained of the ancient wisdom of the gods. From these scribes came the judgment that condemned Christ Jesus to death. When Saul looked back to the primordial wisdom of the gods, he believed that what had descended from that wisdom into the scribes of his day could lead, through their devotion to scripture, only to just judgments. An innocent person condemned to crucifixion? Impossible—if everything had unfolded as it did in the trial of Christ Jesus. Only the Roman governor Pontius Pilate, instinctively caught up in a different worldview, could utter the meaningful question: "What is truth?" For Saul, it was impossible even to consider that what had been carried out as a just judgment might not be true.
Saul could be convinced only by the fact itself. Only Christ could convince him by appearing to him, as happened in the event on the road to Damascus. What did this mean to Saul? It meant that the ancient wisdom of the gods no longer remained pure: something Ahrimanic had flowed into it.

Paul came to see that human evolution had been seized by an enemy, and that this enemy was the source of error on Earth.

By bringing intellect, Ahriman also brings the possibility of error. When error reaches its highest development, it becomes the error that sends the innocent to the cross. Humanity first had to gain the conviction that an innocent person could be crucified. Only then could people perceive how Ahriman had found his way into human evolution and how, during the Mystery of Golgotha, an event beyond the senses and above the earthly realm had taken place in the development of the human I. The esoteric can never be merely mystical. It is a profound misunderstanding to turn mere mysticism into esotericism. Esotericism is always knowledge of facts taking place as such in the spiritual world, behind the veil of sensory appearances. Behind that veil lies the reconciliation between the world of the gods and the Ahrimanic world, enacted through the crucifixion of Christ Jesus.

Paul could now feel that error leading to crucifixion can arise only in a world where the human being has been seized by Ahrimanic powers. Once he understood this, he recognized the truth of esoteric Christianity.

Paul was indeed one of those who belonged to the initiates in this sense. But initiation gradually faded under the influence of intellectualism. Today we need to return to an understanding of esoteric Christianity and recognize that Christianity includes more than its exoteric side, of which the Gospels offer intimations. Little is said about the esoteric today, but humanity must return to what has scarcely any outward documentation and must be discerned through anthroposophical spiritual science: what Christ himself taught his initiated disciples after his resurrection. He could teach it only after undergoing on Earth an experience impossible in the divine world, where until the Mystery of Golgotha no being had passed through death. Christ is the firstborn from the world of the hierarchies connected with Earth's evolution through Saturn, Sun, and Moon to pass through death.

The incorporation of death into life is the secret of Golgotha. Previously, life had been known without death; now death came to be known as part of life, an experience that strengthens life. Humanity lived a weaker life before it knew death. To pass through death and yet continue living, humanity must live more strongly. In this respect death also means intellect. People needed a comparatively weak feeling of life when they did not yet have to struggle with intellect. Ancient people, who received knowledge of divine worlds through inner revelations in images, did not inwardly die; they remained alive and could laugh at death because they remained inwardly living. The Greeks still tell how happy the ancients were, as they were inwardly numbed before dying and did not notice that death was approaching. This was the last remnant of a worldview that knew nothing of death. Modern people experience intellect, which makes us inwardly cold and dead and paralyzes us. We do not truly live when we develop intellect if we pour our life into dead intellectual images. We need a strong life to experience what is present in dead conceptual thought as creative life—when we enter the realm where moral impulses arise from the power of pure thinking and learn to understand human freedom through those impulses.
GA211

GA092
You know that in esotericism matter is represented everywhere by the symbol of water. Water is the esoteric symbol for matter. Consider an example from theology: in the Nicene Creed, where it says "suffered under Pontius Pilate," it should really say "suffered in Pontos Pyletos," meaning "in compressed water." The Son of God descended to suffer in matter existing on the physical plane. In the Christian Creed, the Greek word pontos, meaning sea, was Latinized into "Pontius," and "Pyletos" became "Pilatus."
GA092

GA176
We see this social structure approaching in two ways. On the one hand, forms arose from Jewish law that could not comprehend the divine coming so close to humanity as it did in Christ Jesus. The law therefore had necessarily to exclude the divine that had drawn so near, so thoroughly had it become permeated by Ahriman. The Romans, who also shared responsibility for Christ Jesus's death, were powerful in shaping external social structures. It is difficult to imagine a stronger social structure than that achieved by the Roman Empire at the time of the Mystery of Golgotha. Yet at the moment of the Mystery, Pilate, representative of the strongest worldly power, appears weak before spiritual power; he can establish no firm position regarding what is to happen.

Thus the accompanying circumstances of this event also show what I mentioned in one of our recent discussions: when the Mystery of Golgotha approached, humanity was least able to understand it. In ancient times it would have understood; when the event arrived, humanity was least prepared, and understanding had to come by other paths. It is important to recognize this fully.
GA176

GA088
Christ, who enters human beings, is pure and spiritual; he is virginal spirit-matter. Now he has descended into condensed, sensory matter. Those who speak esoterically call this water or the sea. Thus Genesis says: “The Spirit of God hovered over the waters”—that is, spirit hovers over matter. In Greek this matter is also called “Pontos Pyletos,” literally “compressed sea.” The human being entered this condensed matter, which formed the organs. Thus a being active in the spiritual realm became one that passively receives impressions from outside through the sense organs: the human being became passive, a Pontos Pyletos. This is the difference between perception in the spiritual world and perception in the sensory world. In the spiritual world, if we wish to have an object before us, we first have the thought, and spirit forms this thought in the spiritual realm; in other words, the models for all creation are found there. In the sensory world, the human being receives impressions passively and has become receptive rather than active. We have all become passive, as though suffering within condensed matter. This was the original confession of Egyptian priestly belief. It symbolizes Christ’s descent to humanity: he took on matter and became passively suffering in the condensed sea, the Pontos Pyletos. Over time this passed into Christianity, and a profound misunderstanding of the words Pontos Pyletos produced the misleading passage in the Christian Creed, “suffered under Pontius Pilate,” which is none other than the passage cited from the creed of the Egyptian priests. The human being became one who suffers, no longer active but passive. In the occult symbol, this article of faith signifies what is called the Incarnation.
GA088

Chapter 19.

GA097
The events that follow are exemplary of the Christian mystic’s own inner experience. Christ receives the blow to the cheek. This is the second important event after the washing of the feet. Everyone who wishes to undergo the life of Christ in their soul must experience this. One must endure, with complete calm of soul, receiving no recognition from those before whom one represents one’s very best. The scourging follows as the second event. Morally and psychologically, this means calmly enduring the sufferings that come to us from the world. Together with the blow to the cheek, this is the second stage that the Christian mystic must pass through.

Since that time, the students of Christian mysticism have truly undergone these experiences. The ability to endure suffering in this calm is expressed in the student’s own body. The student actually has a sensation as though being pricked with needles.

The next, third stage is the wearing of the crown of thorns. This means calmly accepting humiliation. What is brought low is precisely the human ego. The forebrain, which developed during the last period of Atlantis, experiences the crown of thorns. Painful manifestations of this mystical-soul condition really do occur, and one must overcome them.

Then comes the fourth stage, the Crucifixion. This is the mystical experience in which one’s own body has become as unfamiliar as something external. The human being then bears the burden of the cross.

The soul has now become independent. It is bound to the body only as Christ's body was nailed to the cross. This is an inner process experienced by the mystic. The person now truly knows that they live in a spiritual body. An accompanying manifestation of this process is the blood test. Then, when the Christian mystic has undergone this experience, the stigmata of Christ really appear on the hands and feet. Everything spiritual has a physical accompaniment.

When a person has reached this point, death on the cross occurs. This is a spiritual experience, expressed in Goethe's words:

And until you have experienced this,
This: Die and Become!
You are only a gloomy guest
Upon the dark earth.

This "Die" does not mean: kill the physical body. Rather, give birth within yourself to a new human being, one who provides you with an instrument for the spiritual world. It is to become an instrument of strength.

And Jakob Böhme says: "Whoever does not die before dying will perish when he dies." The Christian mystic must undergo death completely. Otherwise, they cannot enter into a higher life.

The sixth event is then the entombment. This is the mystical realization of communion with the organism of the Earth. The student unites with the planet Earth and becomes a planetary spirit. Everything around them then becomes their body.

The seventh stage is the higher life, the Resurrection, bestowed upon the human being.

These are the seven stages of Christian-mystical development: the washing of the feet; the blow to the cheek and the scourging; the crowning with thorns; the Crucifixion; death; entombment; and Resurrection. It is an inner path expressed through outward symbols.

John presents all this in such a way that he has indeed provided a foundational book of mysticism. As they are read, its sentences must be used as material for meditation. In this way, a person undertakes the meditation necessary to undergo these events. The Gospel of John is a book of wonders because it works wonders in the soul. It was written for all people, and everyone can experience the Gospel of John within themselves.
GA097

GA094
Now I must tell you something that is easy for the intellect but difficult for people today to grasp with their soul. At the time when the Gospel came into being, Christianity was at its dawn. Names were still used in the way I am about to describe. People did not refer simply to the physical organism. A person of that time always saw the spiritual, the higher, shining through the physical organism. A name did not convey what we understand by it today; names were meaningful designations. Imagine someone named James. James essentially means water. In esoteric wisdom, water is an expression for the soul element. Thus, when I call someone James, I am saying that the soul element shines through that person's body. I am meaningfully designating him as one belonging to water. If I give an initiate the name James, he becomes for me a symbol of water (Hebrew: Jam). James is, in effect, the technical name for an initiate who particularly masters the power of occult water.

These were the three disciples, designated by their initiatory names, who were taken to Mount Tabor: James signifies water; Peter signifies earth—the rock (Hebrew: Jabbaschah); John signifies air (Ruach). John therefore designates one who has attained the higher self. This takes us deeply into esoteric teaching. Imagine the time when human beings possessed only the lower principles, the period of the third root race, the Lemurian age of the Earth. Human beings did not yet breathe air, but breathed through gills. Lungs developed only later, and with them lung breathing. This process coincides with fertilization by the higher self. According to the Hermetic principle, air is the lower in relation to the higher, the higher self. If I call someone John, I designate one who has awakened the higher self and who masters the occult forces of air. Jesus is the one who masters the occult forces of fire (Nur). Thus, these four names represent earth, water, air, and fire. They are the names of the four who ascend Mount Tabor.

Jam — James
Nur — Jesus Ruach — John
Jabbaschah — Peter

Imagine these four together on the Mount of Transfiguration, and you have, at the same time, initiates who master the four elements—the lords of the four elements: fire, water, air, and earth.

What happened, then? At that time, spiritual proof was given that through the appearance of Jesus the entire power of the elements was renewed in such a way that the life pulsing through them underwent a new and important stage of development. This is the occult meaning of the Transfiguration. If someone undergoes the Transfiguration in this way, having within themselves the stages of water, earth, and air and ascending personally to the powers of fire, they are one who has been raised again, one who has undergone the Crucifixion. Thus, in the other Gospels this scene is in truth nothing other than a preparation for the deeper initiation scene itself: the Crucifixion. In John, by contrast, everything appears to have been prepared already. The preparatory scene does not appear at all; instead, we have the death on Mount Golgotha. Jam — Nur — Ruach — Jabbaschah = INRI: that is the meaning of the words placed on the cross. (INRI are the initials of the Latin phrase Iesus Nazarenus Rex Ivdaeorum —“Jesus of Nazareth, King of the Jews.”)

You can go deeper and deeper in this way, and you will never exhaust the religious scriptures.

Anyone who knows something can always say to themselves: “There is probably much more in this; I still have much to learn.” This is the reverence we can offer the religious scriptures.

This reverence is best of all, because it then becomes the strength we gain from the depths. I can only point to an important passage. It is in the Gospel of John, chapter 19, verse 33: “But when they came to Jesus and saw that he was already dead, they did not break his legs ...” Then verse 36 says: “For these things were done, that the scripture should be fulfilled: ‘Not a bone of him shall be broken.’” You know that this echoes a passage in Moses (Exodus 12:46). Properly understood, that passage too has a profound meaning. I would like briefly to explain this passage, which is deeply symbolic.

This is connected with the fact that the human body was once soft and pliable but has now become increasingly firm. If you look back through evolution, you will see that human beings have changed greatly. The skeletal system did not yet exist in the Lemurian age; it developed later. Thus, the skeleton is the last part to have emerged in the human organism. It will remain characteristic of humanity until people have spiritualized themselves again, awakened their inner powers, and learned the lesson they

must undergo in a body that has become dense enough to possess a skeletal system. In his cosmic mission, Christ Jesus is the spirit incarnated in such a body in order to show humanity the way out of this world and into a higher one. He is the guide and teacher leading to that higher world. What must find this path to the higher world is symbolized by what is solid: the human skeleton. When humanity was different, before it had developed such a firm skeletal system, it did not need a Messiah. But in this epoch it needs the Messiah, the Redeemer.

It is therefore clear that, for humanity today, the powers in Jesus connected with the higher world are not the relevant ones. The terminology is as follows: the skeleton = the outer aspect; water = the etheric body; blood = the astral body; and then spirit. Thus, in John's first epistle (1 John 5:7), you can read: "There are three that bear witness: blood, water, and spirit." Hence blood and water can flow from Christ's body. These do not apply to the present cycle of humanity. What must hold the whole together, and bring the human being up to the throne of the Eternal, is that in which the lesson must be learned and which must be preserved intact. This is the skeleton, the symbol of what is lifeless in nature. Through the skeletal system, this has now connected Christ with the present cycle of humanity. It must be preserved until humanity has reached the higher stages. We could follow this further through the corresponding passage in the Books of Moses, but that must wait for another time until the higher stages have been reached. We could trace this further to the corresponding passage in the Books of Moses, but that can be done another time.

However, you must understand this: if I wanted to explain the Gospel of John completely, I would have to speak to you about it for an entire winter.

I would have to go through it line by line; only then would you see how profound the words attributed to John really are—that is, to the one whose name itself indicates that he proclaims the higher self. He represents air, masters the higher powers, and wrote his Gospel of John from the perspective of the higher self.
GA094

GA093
The cross symbolized the four elements. The plant, animal, and human kingdoms are formed from the four elements. On the cross are written: Jam = water = James; Nour = fire, referring to Christ himself; Ruach = air, the symbol for John; and the fourth, Jabeschah = earth, rock, for Peter.

J
Jabeschah — Peter: Earth
N R
Nour — Jesus: Fire Ruach — John: Air
J
Jam — James: Water

Thus the cross bears the same meaning expressed in the names of the apostles, while the single name "J.N.R.J." refers to Christ himself.
GA093

GA112
In the blood flowing from Christ's wounds, we therefore see the actual symbol of the excessive egoism in the human ego. Just as blood is an expression of the ego, the blood that flowed on Golgotha expresses what is excessive in the human ego. Had the blood not flowed on Golgotha, humanity would have become spiritually hardened in egoism and met the fate we described yesterday. The blood

flowing on Golgotha gave the impulse for what makes the ego selfish gradually to disappear from humanity.

Every physical event, however, has a spiritual event as its counterpart. To the same extent that blood flowed from the wounds on Golgotha, something spiritual occurred. At that moment, for the first time, rays went out from the Earth into cosmic space that had not gone out before. We may therefore imagine rays streaming from the Earth into space from that moment onward. As time passed, the Earth had become ever darker, right up to the event on Golgotha. Now the blood flows on Golgotha, and the Earth begins to shine!
GA112

GA100
Four major races share the surface of the Earth: the white, yellow, red, and black races. The atmosphere surrounding the Earth on every side, however, is a unity. This is alluded to in chapter 19:23: “Then the soldiers, when they had crucified Jesus, took his garments and made four parts, to every soldier a part; and also his coat. Now the coat was without seam, woven from the top throughout.” Christ’s garments symbolize the Earth’s surface, while the coat woven in one piece symbolizes the atmosphere, which surrounds the Earth on every side undivided and indivisible. It must be emphasized once more that this symbol is also, at the same time, a historical fact.

John 19:25 says: “Now there stood by the cross of Jesus his mother, and his mother’s sister, Mary the wife of Cleophas, and Mary Magdalene.” To understand the Gospel, it is necessary to know who these three women are. Just as two sisters in a family today would not ordinarily have the same name, this was not the custom in earlier times either. The passage therefore shows that, according to the Gospel of John, Jesus’ mother was not named Mary. If you search the Gospel of John, you will find no statement anywhere that Jesus’ mother was called Mary. At the wedding in Cana, for example (chapter 2), it merely says: “The mother of Jesus was there.” These words indicate something important, which we can understand only if we know how the Gospel’s author uses his words. What does the expression “mother of Jesus” mean? As we have seen, the human being consists of a physical body, an etheric body, and an astral body. The transition from the astral body to the spirit-self must not be imagined as a simple one. The ego gradually transforms the astral body into the sentient soul, intellectual soul, and consciousness soul. The ego continues working, and only when it has developed the astral body into the consciousness soul can it purify it so that the spirit-self may arise within it.

The human being is composed of:

Father — 7. Spirit-human
Son — 6. Life-spirit, in the distant future
transformed etheric body
Holy Spirit — 5. Spirit-self, consciousness soul — Virgin Sophia, purified consciousness soul
4. Intellectual soul, astral soul — Mary, wife of Cleophas
3. Sentient soul — Mary Magdalene
sentient body
2. Etheric body
1. Physical body

The spirit-human will develop only in the distant future. The life-spirit is also present in most people only as a germinal potential. The development of the spirit-self has now begun. It is inseparably connected with the consciousness soul, like a sword in its sheath. The sentient soul, in turn, is

contained in the sentient body or astral body. Thus, in the human personality we find nine members. Since, however, the spirit-self and consciousness soul, as well as the sentient soul and astral body, are inseparably connected, theosophical literature usually speaks of seven members. The spirit-self is equivalent to the Holy Spirit, which, in Christian terms, is the guiding being on the astral plane. Christians call the life-spirit the “Word” or the “Son.” The spirit-human is the “Father-Spirit” or the “Father.”

Those who had given birth to the spirit-self within themselves were called “children of God”; in them “the light shone in the darkness” and “they received the light.” Outwardly they were human beings of flesh and blood, but within themselves they carried a higher human being. Within them, the spirit-self had been born from the consciousness soul. The “mother” of such a spiritualized human being is not a physical mother; she lies within the person. She is the purified and spiritualized consciousness soul, the principle from which the higher human being is born. This spiritual birth—a birth in the highest sense—is portrayed in the Gospel of John. The spirit-self, or Holy Spirit, pours into the purified consciousness soul. This is also what is meant by the expression: “I saw the Spirit descending from heaven like a dove, and it abode upon him.”

Since the consciousness soul is the principle in which the spirit-self has developed, it is called the “Mother of Christ” or, in the esoteric schools, the “Virgin Sophia.” Through the impregnation of the Virgin Sophia, Christ could be born in Jesus of Nazareth. In the mystery schools of Dionysius, the intellectual soul and sentient soul were called “Mary” and “Mary Magdalene.”
GA100

GA094
What will come to pass when, one day, the love he embodied spreads throughout all humanity and all people have become brothers? There will then be an example to follow. Human beings have divided the goods of the Earth among themselves, but one thing—the Earth’s outer covering, the atmosphere—cannot be divided. Just as this “coat” of the Earth cannot be divided, so in the future goods will be held in common. This is also expressed symbolically in the distribution of Christ’s garments among the soldiers at the Crucifixion (John 19:24). The coat of Christ Jesus, as the covering of the Earth’s consciousness, is seamless and made from one piece. The outer garment, divided into four parts, represents through this division the four main continents; the indivisible coat represents the indivisible atmosphere. The sublime moral and spiritual-cosmic foundation of Christianity, expressed so magnificently in the Gospel of John, lies in the fact that all the words and deeds of Christ Jesus point toward how people will live in the future, as Christ Jesus demonstrated.
GA094

GA112
Hence the significant words concerning the one who hung on the cross: “You shall not break a bone of him!” Why not? Because they were not to interfere with the form over which Christ had to retain mastery. Had they broken his leg, a lower human power would have intervened in the power Christ had to exercise down to the very bones of Jesus of Nazareth. No one was to interfere with this form, for it was to remain entirely under Christ’s dominion.

At the foot of the cross stood the mother; there stood the disciple whom “the Lord loved,” Lazarus-John, whom Christ himself had initiated and through whom the wisdom of Christianity was to be passed on to posterity. He was to influence the human astral body so that the Christ principle could live within people. The Christ principle was to live within the human astral body, and John was to pour it into that body. But this Christ principle still had to be united, from the cross, with the etheric principle,

with the mother. Therefore Christ speaks from the cross: “From this hour this is your mother, and this is your son!” That is, he unites his wisdom with the maternal principle.
GA112

GA097
From this perspective, let us look once more at chapter two. Before the washing of the feet, the human being is one who is to give birth to the new human being. Having passed through the seven stages, the person becomes the new human being. The new human being relates to the old as a child relates to its mother. The old human being conceived and carried the new one. This is how we should understand the image of Jesus’ mother. Every old human being has the potential to become a new human being.

The old human beings are of various types. When the new human being is born within them, all will give birth to the same Christ within themselves. The old human being—the mother—can appear in different forms. As Christ hangs on the cross, he looks back at his mother, represented by the three women, who stand for three different forms of human existence from which the mystic can grow beyond. Jesus’ mother cannot be designated by a proper name. Nevertheless, she is called Mary. Mary is the same word as Maya, the veil from which the new human being has emerged.

When Christ was taken down from the cross, no bone was to be broken. This is connected with the whole course of our cultural development. In Atlantis, human beings still had the ability to influence the etheric formative forces. They could therefore use the germinating power of grain to propel airships. From the fifth Atlantean sub-race onward, the task of the twelve sub-races has been to develop forces and abilities relating to the mineral kingdom—the powers of combination. The twelve races are to bring the Earth to the point where the mineral kingdom has been essentially conquered. The era in which Christianity stands at the center is the era in which humanity transforms the mineral kingdom. Human beings will make the Earth’s magnetism serve them once they act upon the Earth through their moral powers. In all other respects, human beings remain more or less unconscious.

All ancient states were founded on the principle of blood relationship. The Ten Commandments of the Jews are tribal commandments. What characterized the Jewish people had not yet become characteristic of all humanity. Then the Son-Spirit appeared on Earth in Christ, and his blood flowed. Blood, which had previously created only narrow bonds, was poured out. In this way, the dissolution of all narrow ties into a brotherhood of all humanity was made possible. The narrowly confined sense of ego that cannot yet say, “Whoever does not leave father, mother, wife, children, brother and sister, and even their own life, cannot be my disciple”—such egoism must flow from the wounds of the Redeemer. Through Christ’s flowing blood, the capacity for love was won, a love that overcomes blood brotherhood, tribe, and nation. Had we been able to collect the drops of blood at the cross, we would truly have possessed the substance that could transform people in the fullest sense. The aim is for human beings to find a connection with all other people, so that it is not only brothers and sisters who can love one another, but human beings who can love humanity. The physical blood that flowed from Christ’s wounds is the embodiment of the principle of redemption; this blood is a significant symbol of redemption.

Human beings are to rediscover the spirit in its full extent. They once possessed it, but only in a dull, nebulous form. Then it assumed the form through which people see the world today. But today people see only the earthly, only one side. This view cuts them off from spiritual life as if by a veil. Now the individual consciousness that made the human being an ego is to lead them back out into universal consciousness. That is why Christ’s blood was scattered from a narrow tribe into the wider world. The cross made this possible. From the cross, the blood flowed out into all humanity. At the same time,

however, the cross made the ego ever more concentrated and individual. All this was brought to us by Christianity.
GA097

GA094
Independence emerged at the point in physical evolution when a skeletal system first formed in the human being. The stability this gave humanity is connected with its predisposition toward spirituality. Looking to humanity's future makes it even clearer how important the formation of the skeleton was. How will the human race change—in its body, not its soul? It will become increasingly solidified. Just as an oyster controls its shell, human beings will control their bodies, their instruments, from outside. To understand this, you need only consider sleep, when the soul controls the physical organism from outside. In future ages, the soul will consciously govern the body as its instrument from outside. The formation of bones is therefore the foundation for something great and splendid. Hence the ancient religious injunctions: preserve your skeletal system; do not break your bones. The symbolic expression of this was the sacrifice instituted in Egypt to commemorate deliverance during the slaying of Egypt's firstborn (Exodus 12:1–51). A lamb was to be eaten as an outward sign, and the words are significant: "You shall not break any bone of it!" Thus, at the point where liberation through Manas begins, the importance of bone formation is emphatically indicated in the ritual prescription for the Passover lamb (Exodus 12:46). And in the case of the great Lamb, the representative of humanity, Christ Jesus, his legs were not broken, although this was customary for those crucified. "... that the scripture should be fulfilled: 'You shall not break a bone of him.'"

You can also see the significance of this naming in the fact that the one who is the spiritual representative of humanity's development in the great cosmic plan receives the name "Son of Man." His father is the "Holy Spirit," and his mother is the "Virgin Sophia."
GA094

GA265
Now, however, when the great Sun Spirit had descended to Earth and lived in the body of Jesus of Nazareth, Christ Jesus himself placed the seed of new life in the heart of the reborn Hiram Abiff. Through Christ himself he was raised to spiritual life and reborn in the disciple whom the Lord loved. The human ego was enlivened by the divine ego and raised to a higher existence. This disciple could then become the writer of the Gospel whose starting point is the human and divine ego. The development of the human ego through the post-Atlantean cultural epochs and into the future, until the end of the Earth's days, was revealed to him, as he depicted in the Apocalypse. His Gospel tells how Christ Jesus, in the last words spoken from the cross, entrusts this disciple to his mother, who was not his physical mother. As a son, he gives the human ego to the Earth-Mother after enlivening it with his powers, so that she may protect and nurture it. As a mother, he gives the Earth to this ego, so that the son may give the mother his powers. The human ego is to redeem the Earth, raising it through its powers into spiritual regions, fully conscious that without this Earth it could not have developed into what it is and is destined to become.

At the event on Golgotha, when blood flowed from the wounds of the great Redeemer, when the cosmic heart-blood permeated the Earth and its forces poured into the very center, the Earth became luminous; light radiated outward from within it.
When the Earth became the body of the great Sun Spirit, permeated by its spiritual powers, all beings on Earth were endowed with these powers as well. The seed was planted for the reunion of Sun and Earth. The physical body of Jesus of Nazareth was the mediator through whom the forces of the cosmos united with the Earth's aura. And when blood flowed from this body on Golgotha, the Earth

was once more received into the power of the Sun. Since then, this Christ-power has radiated outward from the Earth's center, while Christ-power streams from the Sun into the Earth. Human beings can experience this power, this light, within themselves as earthly beings when they recognize themselves as part of the Earth, which, as the physical body of Christ, is permeated by his being. Then the white light shining from the Earth's center shines back from within them.

A person can also experience Christ's power and light as something approaching from outside, illuminating and permeating them with higher life. It then surrounds and penetrates them, just as the Sun's rays stream into the Earth and enliven it.

The person feels spiritually united with this solar power, as though growing from the heart to unite with the great cosmic heart. As a higher being living in this spiritual Sun, the person recognizes their true self, united with it as an earthly human being is united with the Earth itself. Just as the solar forces illuminate and enliven the Earth, this higher being illuminates and enlivens the earthly human being with its powers.
GA265

GA103
The point now is that this event must have an effect in the true Christian: there must be something through which the true Christian gradually develops the potential for an astral body purified in the Christian sense.

Where does this power lie? It lies in the fact that Christ Jesus entrusted to the disciple whom he loved —the writer of the Gospel of John—the mission of faithfully recording, from his enlightenment, the events in Palestine, so that people could allow them to work upon them. If people allow what is written in the Gospel of John to work upon them sufficiently, their astral body is on the path to becoming a "Virgin Sophia," and it will then become receptive to the "Holy Spirit." Through the strength of the impulses emanating from the Gospel of John, it gradually becomes capable of feeling and later recognizing what is truly spiritual. This mission, this commission, was given by Christ Jesus to the writer of the Gospel of John. You need only read the Gospel to find it: at the cross stood Jesus' mother —the "Virgin Sophia" in the esoteric sense of Christianity—and from the cross Christ speaks to the disciple whom he loved:

"From now on, this is your mother!" And from that hour the disciple took her into his own home. (19:27)

That is, the power that was in my astral body and enabled it to become a vessel for the Holy Spirit—I transfer this power to you. You are to write down what this astral body was able to attain through its development! "And the disciple took her into his own home" means that he wrote the Gospel of John. The Gospel of John is the Gospel in which the writer concealed the forces for developing the "Virgin Sophia." At the cross he is given the mission of accepting her as his mother and becoming the true, authentic interpreter of the Messiah. In essence, this means: immerse yourselves fully in the meaning of the Gospel of John and understand it spiritually. It has the power to lead you to Christian catharsis; it has the power to give you the "Virgin Sophia." Then the Holy Spirit united with the Earth will also bestow enlightenment upon you—Photismos, in the Christian sense. What the most intimate disciples experienced at that time in Palestine was so powerful that from then on they at least possessed within themselves the potential to see in the spirit. The closest disciples had absorbed this potential. For, in the Christian sense, seeing in the spirit consists in transforming the astral body through the power of the

events in Palestine, so that what a person is to see need not be physically and sensorially present outside.
GA103

GA103
Two things are necessary for this: a person must prepare themselves through catharsis and enlightenment, and then freely open their inner being to the spiritual world. In this context of knowledge, we may compare the human being's inner aspect with the feminine and the outer aspect with the masculine. The inner being must be made receptive to the higher self. When it is receptive, the higher self flows into the human being from the spiritual world. For where is the human being's higher self? Is it inside the personal human being? No. On Saturn, Sun, and Moon, the higher self was poured out over the entire cosmos. At that time the ego of the cosmos was spread over humanity, and people must allow this ego to work upon them. It must work upon the inner being that has been prepared beforehand. In other words, the human inner being—its astral body—must be purified, refined, and ennobled through catharsis. Then it can expect the external spiritual element to flow into it and bring enlightenment. This happens when a person is sufficiently prepared, having subjected the astral body to catharsis and thereby developed inner organs of knowledge. When the astral body then immerses itself in the etheric and physical bodies, it is ready for enlightenment, or Photismos, to occur. What actually happens is that the astral body impresses its organs into the etheric body, enabling the person to perceive a spiritual world around them: the inner being, the astral body, receives what the etheric body can offer, what it draws from the entire cosmos—from the cosmic ego.

Christian esotericism called this purified, refined astral body—which, at the moment of enlightenment, contains none of the impure impressions of the physical world, but only the organs of cognition for the spiritual world—the "pure, chaste, wise Virgin Sophia." Through everything a person takes in during catharsis, the astral body is cleansed and refined into the "Virgin Sophia." The cosmic ego, the World-Ego, then comes to meet the Virgin Sophia and brings about enlightenment, giving the person spiritual light all around. This second element, which joins the "Virgin Sophia," was—and still is—called by Christian esotericism the "Holy Spirit." Thus, it is entirely correct in the Christian-esoteric sense to say that through initiation the Christian esotericist purifies and refines the astral body, transforms it into the "Virgin Sophia," and is illuminated—or, if you prefer, overshadowed—by the "Holy Spirit," the cosmic World-Ego. One who is thus enlightened, who has received the "Holy Spirit" in the Christian-esoteric sense, speaks thereafter in a different way. How? When speaking of Saturn, Sun, Moon, the various members of the human being, or the processes of world evolution, it is no longer a matter of personal opinion. Their own views are irrelevant. When such a person speaks of Saturn, Saturn speaks through them; when they speak of the Sun, the spiritual being of the Sun speaks through them. They are the instrument; their ego has receded—in other words, it has become impersonal for such moments—and the cosmic World-Ego uses them as an instrument through which to speak. Therefore, with genuine esoteric teachings arising from Christian esotericism, it is not right to speak of opinions or personal views. In the fullest sense of the word, these do not exist there. Someone who speaks of the world in the proper spirit of Christian esotericism does not think it important to tell people that there were two horses outside, that they liked one less and thought it lazy. What matters is describing the horses to others and reporting the facts. The task is to recount what has been observed in the spiritual world, excluding all personal opinion. Any system of spiritual-scientific teaching must simply relate the sequence of facts; it must have nothing to do with the opinions of the person recounting them.

We have thus learned the spiritual meaning of two concepts. We have learned about the "Virgin Sophia," the purified astral body, and about the "Holy Spirit," the cosmic World-Ego, which is received by the "Virgin Sophia" and can then speak through the astral body concerned.

There is something else to attain, a still higher stage: being able to help another person and give them the impulses needed to attain both. People in our evolutionary epoch can receive the “Virgin Sophia,” the purified astral body, and the “Holy Spirit,” enlightenment, in the manner described. Only Christ Jesus could give the Earth what was necessary for this. He implanted in the spiritual part of the Earth the powers that make possible the process described as Christian initiation.
GA103

GA148
Then, when Jesus’ body was taken down and placed in a tomb, a real observation was made of a natural event entering into human moral life. A whirlwind arose, and a fissure opened in the Earth to receive Jesus’ body, while the cloths were swept away from the corpse. It is a deeply moving observation that the arrangement of the cloths described in the Gospel of John can truly be seen by the beholder.

These two events—the darkening of the Earth, the earthquake, and the mighty whirlwind—show us at one point in the Earth’s evolution how natural events occurred simultaneously with spiritual events. Otherwise, something of this kind occurs only in living beings, as when a decision of the will and thought precede a movement of the hand. The Earth developed in such a way that in ordinary life we deal only with mechanical facts. Only at a special moment—and this is true of other events in the Earth’s history as well, but to the highest degree of this event—do we encounter the coincidence of a spiritual event with two physical events.
GA148

GA093a
Through connection with Christ, it is always possible to purify one’s astral body to such an extent that one can work it into the etheric body without harm to the world. When we consider this, the words “vicarious atoning death” take on a quite different meaning. This is what is meant by Christ’s atoning death. Previously, anyone seeking purification had to undergo death in the Mysteries. Now the One underwent it for all, so that this world-historical initiation took the place of the old initiation. Christianity has created many things in common that previously were not shared. Its effective power is expressed in the possibility of communion with Christ through inner vision, through true mysticism. This was also embedded in language. Ulfilas, the first Christian initiate in Europe, embedded it in the German language itself, so that the human being found the “I” in language. Other languages express this relation to the ego through a special verb form, such as Latin “amo,” but German adds the “I.” “Ich” is J.Ch. = Jesus Christ. This was deliberately placed in the German language; it is no coincidence. Initiates are the ones who created language. Just as Sanskrit has AUM for the Trinity, we have the sign “ICH” for the human being’s inner self. In this way a center was created through which the passions of the world can be transformed into rhythm. They must be brought into rhythm through the ego. This center is literally the Christ.
GA093a

GA112
Among all the facts we observe, one stands out as fundamental: death. A person should therefore say to themselves: the external things presented to our senses are, in truth, the Father-principle; they express the divine-spiritual element of the Father. Since death is woven into the entire sensory world, death belongs to the divine-spiritual Father-principle. Because human beings have developed as they have, the divine Father-principle is wrapped in many coverings—and finally in the covering of death. What must a person seek behind death, as behind everything sensory? The Father, the cosmic Father! Just as a person must learn to say of every thing, “In truth, it is the Father,” so they must learn to say, “Death is

the Father.” Why, then, does physical-sensory reality present us with a false image of the Father? Why is the image of the Father so distorted that it appears as the deceptive death? Because the Lucifer-Ahriman principle is mixed into all our life! So what would have to happen for humanity to be led from a false, deceptive, illusory view of death to a true understanding of it?

Humanity would have to be enlightened about death through facts. Something would have to happen that could teach people that what they had known and felt about death was untrue, and that the things they had done under the influence of their ideas about death were mistaken. An event had to occur that placed the true form of death before their eyes. The false form of death had to be erased and the true form presented.

This was Christ’s mission on Earth: through his deed, to replace the false form of death with its true form.

Death became this distorted image of the Father because Lucifer-Ahriman intervened in humanity’s evolution. Death was the consequence, the effect, of Lucifer-Ahriman’s influence. What, then, had the one who wished to remove this false form of death from the world to do?

An innocent person therefore had to suffer death, unite with death, and undergo it. By enduring death, he brought into human life the forces that would gradually enable people to recognize the true form of death—that is, to recognize that death as it appears in the sensory world is not the truth. On the contrary, this death had to occur for the sake of life in the spiritual world; through this death, the foundation for spiritual life was created.

Thus, Christ’s innocent death on Golgotha provided proof that people will gradually come to understand: death is the ever-living Father! Once we have the right view of death, once through the event on Golgotha we have learned that outward dying means nothing, and that Christ lived in the body of Jesus of Nazareth, with whom we can unite; once we recognize that although the image of death appears on the cross, it is only an outward event, and that Christ’s life in the etheric body is the same before and after this death—so that death cannot harm life—
once we have understood that here we see a death that does not extinguish life, but is itself life, then what hung on the cross becomes an enduring sign that death is truly the giver of life. Just as a plant grows from a seed, death is not a destroyer but a seed of life. It was sown
into our physical-sensory world so that this world would not fall out of life, but could be taken up into life. The refutation of death had to be demonstrated on the cross through this paradoxical death, an innocent death.
GA112

GA097
All ancient states were founded on the principle of blood relationship. The Ten Commandments of the Jews are tribal commandments. What characterized the Jewish people had not yet become characteristic of all humanity. Then the Son-Spirit appeared on Earth in Christ, and his blood flowed. Blood, which had previously created only narrow bonds, was poured out. In this way, the dissolution of all narrow ties into a brotherhood of all humanity was made possible. The narrowly confined sense of ego that cannot yet say, “Whoever does not leave father, mother, wife, children, brother and sister, and even their own life, cannot be my disciple”—such egoism must flow from the wounds of the Redeemer. Through Christ’s flowing blood, the capacity for love was won, a love that overcomes blood brotherhood, tribe, and nation. Had we been able to collect the drops of blood at the cross, we would truly have possessed the substance that could transform people in the fullest sense. The aim is for

human beings to find a connection with all other people, so that it is not only brothers and sisters who can love one another, but human beings who can love humanity. The physical blood that flowed from Christ's wounds is the embodiment of the principle of redemption; this blood is a significant symbol of redemption.

Human beings are to rediscover the spirit in its full extent. They once possessed it, but only in a dull, nebulous form. Then it assumed the form through which people see the world today. But today people see only the earthly, only one side. This view cuts them off from spiritual life as if by a veil. Now the individual consciousness that made the human being an ego is to lead them back out into universal consciousness. That is why Christ's blood was scattered from a narrow tribe into the wider world. The cross made this possible. From the cross, the blood flowed out into all humanity. At the same time, however, the cross made the ego ever more concentrated and individual. All this was brought to us by Christianity.
GA097

Chapter 20.

GA103
Human beings then have something more with which they can look into the spiritual world. There were such intimate disciples. The woman who anointed Christ Jesus in the village of Bethany had received, through the event in Palestine, a powerful capacity for spiritual vision. She was among those who first learned that what had lived in Jesus continued to exist after death—that he had risen. She had this ability. How did she acquire it? Through the opening of her inner sense organs. Are we told this? Yes. We are told that Mary Magdalene went to the tomb, that the body was gone, and that at the tomb she saw two spiritual figures. These figures are seen when a corpse has been there for some time: on one side the astral body, and on the other what gradually separates off as the etheric body and passes into the world ether. Apart from the physical body, two spiritual figures belonging to the spiritual world are present.

"Then the disciples went away again to their own homes. But Mary stood outside the tomb weeping. As she wept, she stooped to look into the tomb, and she saw two angels in white sitting there." (20:10–12)

She saw this because the power and force of the event in Palestine had made her clairvoyant. And she saw more: she saw the Risen One. Was it necessary for her to be clairvoyant in order to do so? Would you imagine that, if you had seen someone in physical form a few days ago and saw him again a few days later, you would fail to recognize him?

"When she had said this, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but she did not know that it was Jesus. Jesus said to her, 'Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you looking for?' She supposed him to be the gardener." (20:14–15)

To make this as clear as possible, we are told this not just once, but also at the next appearance of the Risen One, when Jesus appeared by the Sea of Galilee.

"When morning had come, Jesus stood on the shore; but the disciples did not know that it was Jesus." (21:4)

The esoteric disciples recognize him there. Those who had received the full power of the event in Palestine could enter into this experience and see that it was the risen Jesus, whom one could perceive in the spiritual world.
Although the disciples and Mary Magdalene also saw him, some among them were less gifted in developing clairvoyant power. Thomas, for example, was one of them. We are told that Thomas was not present the first time the disciples saw the Lord; he says that he must first put his hands into the wounds, that he must have physical contact with the Risen One. What happens? An attempt is made to help him too, so that he may become able to see spiritually. How does this happen? It happens in accordance with these words:

"Eight days later his disciples were again inside, and Thomas was with them. Jesus came, although the doors were locked, stood among them, and said, 'Peace be with you!' Then he said to Thomas, 'Put your finger here and see my hands; reach out your hand and put it into my side. Do not be unbelieving, but believe.'" (20:26–27)

You will see something if you do not rely only on outward sight, but permeate yourself with inner strength. ("Jesus said to him, 'Have you believed because you have seen me, Thomas? Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.'" (20:29).) This inner strength, which is meant to proceed from the event in Palestine, is called "faith." It is not something trivial, but an inner clairvoyant power. Permeate yourself with this inner strength, and you will no longer need to regard only what you see outwardly as real; blessed are those who can know what they do not see outwardly!
GA103

GA130
Jesus of Nazareth stood at the Jordan. His I-being separated from the physical body, the etheric or life body, and the astral body; the macrocosmic Being of Christ descended, took possession of these three bodies, and lived in them until April 3, 33, as we were able to establish. But this was a different kind of life. From the baptism onward, Christ's life in the body of Jesus of Nazareth was a slow process of dying. With each passing period during those three years, something of Jesus of Nazareth's sheaths, so to speak, died away. These sheaths slowly died, so that after three years the entire body was on the verge of becoming a corpse and was held together only by the power of the macrocosmic Being of Christ. Do not imagine that this body, a year and a half after John's baptism in the Jordan, was like any other body. An ordinary human soul would have felt it slipping away, because it could be held together only by the mighty macrocosmic Being of Christ. It was a continuous, slow dying lasting three years. The body had reached the point of disintegration when the Mystery of Golgotha took place. Then the men described in the account approached it with their peculiar substances, called spices, established a chemical connection between these substances and the body in which the macrocosmic Being of Christ had dwelt for three years, and laid it in the tomb. Only a little more was needed for the body to crumble to dust in the tomb, while the Spirit of Christ clothed itself in an etheric body condensed to the point of physical visibility. Thus the Risen Christ was enveloped in an etheric body condensed to physical visibility. He appeared to those to whom he could appear, but was not visible to everyone, since after the Resurrection he bore, in essence, only a condensed etheric body. What had been placed in the tomb crumbled to dust. According to the most recent occult investigations, an earthquake did indeed occur. It struck me forcibly, after discovering this through occult research, to find it indicated in Matthew's Gospel. The earth split open, the dust of the corpse fell into it and mingled with the substance of the earth. The earthquake shook the cloths into the arrangement described in the Gospel of John, where this is wonderfully depicted.

In this way we can understand the Resurrection occultly without coming into conflict with the Gospels. I have often pointed out that Mary Magdalene did not recognize Christ when he encountered her. Would anyone fail to recognize someone seen only a few days earlier, especially someone as important as Christ Jesus? If Mary Magdalene did not recognize him, he must have appeared to her in a different form. She recognizes him only when, so to speak, she hears him speak; then she becomes attentive.

All the details in the Gospels are entirely understandable from an occult perspective.
Someone might object that Thomas was asked by the Risen One to put his hands into the wounds. One might assume that the wounds were still there and that Christ came to the disciples in the same body that had dissolved into dust. No! Imagine that someone has a wound: the etheric body contracts especially at that place and develops a kind of scar. In this particularly contracted etheric body, from which the components for the new etheric body were taken—the body with which the Being of Christ clothed itself—the wounds were made visible as especially dense places, so that Thomas too could feel that something real was there.
GA130

GA349
It is reported that the women went out and what they saw at the tomb—interpret this sophistically if you wish! It is reported that Christ met the disciples at Emmaus, and so on; it is reported that Christ was seen.

Remember that I have told you that a human being consists not only of the material, physical body laid in the grave, but also of the etheric body, astral body, and I. I have described these in detail. The physical body of Jesus of Nazareth was indeed laid in the tomb. I have given much thought to this question, and it is extraordinarily significant that the Gospel itself says an earthquake occurred. The earthquake opened a fissure, and the earth received the body, so that it truly was no longer there. The disciples did not see the physical body, but the etheric, supersensible body. The women and disciples saw Christ in the etheric body—not Jesus of Nazareth any longer, but Christ, the transformed inner human being.
GA349

GA112
The Gospel also tells us that when a human being has advanced so far that what is perishable develops something imperishable, that person gains a higher vision. It also says that those who had already developed this higher vision could recognize Christ. This is stated clearly enough; people simply do not want to read what the Gospel actually says. Consider Christ's first appearance after death. It says:

"Mary stood outside the tomb weeping. As she wept, she stooped to look into the tomb and saw two angels in white sitting where the body of Jesus had lain, one at the head and the other at the feet. They said to her, 'Woman, why are you weeping?' She said to them, 'They have taken away my Lord, and I do not know where they have laid him.' Having said this, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but she did not know that it was Jesus. Jesus said to her, 'Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you looking for?' Supposing him to be the gardener, she said to him, 'Sir, if you have carried him away, tell me where you have laid him, and I will take him away.' Jesus said to her, 'Mary!' She turned and said to him in Hebrew, 'Rabbuni!'—which means, 'Teacher!'" (20:11–16)

Imagine this: you saw someone a few days ago, and you see him again a few days later. Could you fail to recognize him? Could you ask whether he was the gardener and where he had put the person, while you were looking at that very person? Yet you must suppose this of Mary—or of the woman called

Mary here—if you wish to maintain that every physical eye would have recognized Christ and seen him in the same way as before. Read the Gospels in their spiritual meaning.

First, the sacred power of the words had to enter the woman as a force. This was necessary! The echo of the words awakened within her, rekindling everything she had seen before. This enabled her spiritual eye to see the Risen One.

“On the first day of the week Mary Magdalene came to the tomb early, while it was still dark, and saw that the stone had been taken away. She ran to Simon Peter and the other disciple, whom Jesus loved, and said, ‘They have taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we do not know where they have laid him.’ The two disciples ran to the tomb together; the other disciple outran Peter and arrived first. He stooped to look in and saw the linen cloths lying there, but did not enter. Simon Peter arrived after him and went into the tomb. He saw the linen cloths lying there, and the cloth that had been on Jesus’ head, not with the linen cloths but rolled up separately. Then the other disciple, who had arrived first, also went in; he saw and believed. For they did not yet understand the Scripture, that he must rise from the dead. Then the disciples went home. Mary stood outside the tomb weeping. As she wept, she bent down to look into the tomb and saw two angels in white sitting where Jesus’ body had lain, one at the head and the other at the feet. They said to her, ‘Woman, why are you weeping?’ She said, ‘They have taken away my Lord, and I do not know where they have laid him.’ After saying this, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but did not recognize him. Jesus said, ‘Woman, why are you weeping? Whom are you looking for?’ Thinking he was the gardener, she said, ‘Sir, if you have carried him away, tell me where you have laid him, and I will take him away.’ Jesus said, ‘Mary!’ She turned and said to him in Hebrew, ‘Rabbuni!’—which means ‘Teacher.’ Jesus said to her, ‘Do not touch me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father!’”

Here a situation is described in such detail that we scarcely lack anything when forming a picture in our imagination—for example, we are told that one disciple runs faster than the other, and that the cloth that had covered the head was placed elsewhere. Every detail describes something that would make no sense if it did not refer to actual events. Another point has been emphasized before: we are told that Mary did not recognize Christ Jesus. How could someone fail, after three days, to recognize a person they had known before in the same form? We must therefore take into account that Christ appeared to Mary in a changed form; otherwise these words would make no sense.

We can therefore say two things. We must understand the Resurrection as the historical realization of the raising that had taken place in the sacred Mysteries in all ages—with this difference: in the Mysteries, the hierophant raised the individual mystery student; in the Gospels, however, we are shown that the one who raised Christ was the Being we call the Father, that the Father himself raised Christ. What had otherwise taken place on a smaller scale in the depths of the Mysteries was enacted once for all humanity by the divine spirits at Golgotha, and the Being called the Father himself acted as hierophant in raising Christ Jesus. Thus what had previously occurred on a smaller scale in the Mysteries was brought to its highest expression. That is the first point. The second is that specific details are interwoven with the elements that refer back to the Mysteries, so that even today we can reconstruct the situations from the Gospels down to their details.

One point is even more important. These words must have meaning: ‘For they did not yet understand the Scripture, that he must rise from the dead. Then the disciples went home.’ What had the disciples established up to that point? The account makes it perfectly clear that the linen cloths were there, but the body was no longer in the tomb. That was all they had established, and all they understood when they went home. Otherwise the words would make no sense. The more deeply you enter into the text,

the more you must say: the disciples at the tomb established that the linen cloths were there, but the body was gone; and they went home wondering where the body had gone and who had taken it out of the tomb.

The Gospels then lead us gradually from the conviction that the body is missing to the events through which the disciples actually become convinced of the Resurrection. How are they convinced? As the Gospels relate, Christ gradually appeared to them, so that they could say: He is here! This went so far that Thomas, called the doubter, could put his fingers into the wounds. In short, the Gospels show that the disciples were convinced of the Resurrection only when Christ subsequently appeared to them as the Risen One. His presence was the proof for them. If they had been asked what their faith essentially consisted of after gradually becoming convinced that Christ lived although he had died, they would have said: 'We have proof that Christ lives!'
GA131

GA115
Let us bring all this together, my dear friends, and from this point of view recall Christ's words when he sent his disciples into the world to proclaim his name and forgive sins in his name (John 20:23). Why forgive sins in his name? Because forgiveness of sins is connected with his name; sin can be erased and transformed into living life only if Christ can be united with what remains of us on earth—if, during our earthly existence, we have carried him within us, in the sense of Paul's words: 'Not I, but Christ in me.'
GA115

Chapter 21.

GA130
This passage is truly wonderful from an occult perspective. It is not inconsistent with the fact that we are dealing with an etheric body condensed to visibility by the power of Christ, and that the scene at Emmaus could then take place. The Gospel describes it not as ordinary eating, but as the immediate dissolution of what was eaten by the etheric body, through the powers of Christ, without the participation of the physical body (Luke 24:41–43).
GA130

GA103
This shows that we are dealing with the full reality and truth of the Resurrection, which can be fully recognized only by someone who first equips themselves with the inner power to look into the spiritual world.

This will help you understand the final chapter of the Gospel of John. It increasingly indicates how the most intimate disciples of Christ Jesus, through the event that unfolded before them, had attained the "Virgin Sophia." Yet when they first had to stand firm and truly behold a spiritual event, they were still dazzled and had to find their bearings. They did not know that this was the same one who had been with them before. We must grasp this with the subtlest concepts, for a crudely materialistic mind would say: 'Then the Resurrection is being called into question!' The miracle of the Resurrection must be taken quite literally, even in the sense of his words:

"I am with you always, to the end of the age!" (Matthew 28:20)

These lectures were intended only to offer a sample of how spiritual science can lead us into the Gospel of John; it is impossible to explain the entire Gospel. The Gospel itself says:

For this reason, we tried to bring together a wide variety of material that would help us understand more and more of the profound truths of the Gospel of John: how Jesus' physical mother is an outward revelation, an image of the "Virgin Sophia"; how the "Virgin Sophia" has a spiritual significance for the mystery student whom Christ loved; and how, for the other Evangelists who focus on physical descent, the physical father also plays a role, especially where the divine concept is expressed outwardly through the blood. We also considered what the "Holy Spirit" means for John: the Spirit through whom Christ was conceived in Jesus during those three years, symbolically indicated by the dove descending at John's baptism.

If we understand the "Holy Spirit" as the Father of Christ Jesus, who brought forth the Christ within the body of Jesus, then, when we consider the matter from all sides, we can readily see that the disciples who were less initiated could not give us as profound a picture of the events in Palestine as the disciple whom the Lord loved. When people today speak of the Synoptic Gospels as their sole authority, this only shows that they are unwilling to rise to an understanding of the true form of the Gospel of John. For everyone resembles the spirit they understand!
GA103

GA148
We see, then, my dear friends, that in the Being of Christ we are dealing with an entity that requires us to change completely all the concepts we have acquired about the succession of stages in human life. After the brief interval commonly called the period of purification or Kamaloka, a human being passes into the spiritual world to prepare for the next earthly life. Thus, after death, a person lives a spiritual life. From the event of Pentecost onward, the Being of Christ experienced something that for it meant what the passage into the spirit-land means for a human being: entry into the earthly sphere. Instead of entering Devachan, instead of entering a spiritual realm as a human being does after death, the Being of Christ made the sacrifice of establishing its heaven, as it were, on earth and seeking it there. Human beings leave the earth to exchange their dwelling place for heaven, to use the usual expression. Christ left heaven to exchange his dwelling place for the earth. Please consider this in the right light and reflect on what occurred through the Mystery of Golgotha, on the sacrifice made by the Being of Christ: leaving the spiritual spheres in order to live with the earth and with human beings on earth, and to carry human evolution forward through the impulse thereby given. This means that before John's baptism in the Jordan, this Being did not belong to the earthly sphere; it entered the earthly sphere from super-earthly realms. What was experienced between John's baptism and the event of Pentecost had to be experienced in order to transform the heavenly Being of Christ into the earthly Being of Christ.
GA148

GA100
The Gospels are nothing other than ancient instructions for initiation, of varying depths. What once took place under conditions of diminished consciousness occurred publicly in the Mystery of Golgotha. The death that had previously been overcome in the etheric body during initiation was now overcome in the physical body. The event at Golgotha is the initiation of the highest initiate, who was initiated by no one else.

The writer of the Gospel of John could therefore describe Christ's life only as the initiation code describes it. Whoever lives through the Gospel of John will awaken within themselves the power of vision. It is a book of vision, written to train the capacity for spiritual sight. Whoever lives through it

sentence by sentence will reach the great and powerful result of standing spiritually face to face with Christ. Conviction does not come easily to people; they must work their way toward the point where the realization dawns that Christ is a reality.

The Gospel of John is the path that leads to Christ. Its writer wished to give everyone an opportunity to understand him. Whoever develops the Spirit-Self within themselves out of the astral body will receive in the spirit the wisdom through which they can understand what Christ is. Christ himself indicated this: he hangs on the cross, and at his feet stand his mother and the initiated disciple whom he loves. The disciple is to bring humanity the wisdom and knowledge of the significance of Christ. Hence the reference to the Mother Sophia in the words: 'This is your mother; you are to love her.' The spiritualized mother of Jesus is the Gospel itself; she is the wisdom that leads people upward to the highest knowledge. The disciple has given us the Mother Sophia—that is, he has written the Gospel, which offers those who study it the possibility of coming to know Christianity and grasping the origin and goal of this great movement.

The Gospel of John contains the wisdom of "God in the human being," theosophy; the more humanity devotes itself to studying this document, the more wisdom and illumination will arise from it.

At the end, the writer of the Gospel of John says that Christ did many other things that are not included in the book: "There are also many other things that Jesus did; if they were written down one after another, I suppose the world itself could not contain the books that would have to be written" (John 21:25). We too must therefore say that even a long series of lectures would not suffice to explain everything written in the Gospel.
GA100